Threadbare Wings

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37080298.

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Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Cyberpunk, Cyberpunk, Cybernetics, Alternate Universe, Angst, Plot, plot heavy, Violence, Blood and Injury, Sexual Content, Romance, LGBTQ Themes, Religious Imagery & Symbolism, Mental Health Issues, Dystopia, Hurt/Comfort, it isnt entirely angst but theres a lot of it, Falling In Love, what if we kissed in the dystopian cityscape, Additional Warnings In Author's Note

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English

Collections:
Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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Threadbare Wings

by thepudz

Summary

The year is 2082. Temperatures reach record-breaking highs. More than 80% of the population fall below the poverty line. The world's leading corporations and CEOs continue to live comfortably.

Welcome to Styx City, populated by a mix of humans and bioengineered people developed by Nyx Industries. These new type of humans are known as the Keres. Despite protests and treaties for their freedom, the Keres still live under a closely surveyed rule, seen only as ‘just androids pretending to be real people’. Some Keres choose to accept the life they've been given. Others choose to break free and Disconnect, forming their own identities and becoming Offline Keres, or 'Ghosts'. This is an action punishable by death.

In this city of neon, two people--Catra, a bartender with many secrets, and Adora, an Angel who feels undeserving of her wings--try to survive with their own sets of problems and regrets. The city should've turned them cold, but instead, they find warmth with each other. Their forbidden bond is sometimes the only thing that can keep them going.

And if their bond somehow lasts, it might be what changes Styx City forever.

A Catradora Cyberpunk AU.

Notes

Hi, everyone! It's super cool to finally be back!

This story is the result of a world I've been building with major inspirations from many cyberpunk sources like Blade

Runner, Ghost in the Shell, Serial Experiments Lain, Psycho-Pass, NieR: Automata, The Matrix, and more! Cyberpunk is a genre I have a massive personal interest in for its themes, aesthetics, the questions it presents, and its critiques of contemporary society/capitalism. So I decided to tackle it with a gay fanfic!

NOW SOME IMPORTANT NOTES HERE BEFORE WE BEGIN: This story will contain a lot triggering content. I've tried to handle it with a sensitive nature, but cyberpunk is full of dark themes. I've put some of the general content warnings in the tags and this note, and I will put more specific ones in the coming chapters for certain events. Some content warnings will be spoilers for the respective chapter, and I'll try to mark those as best as I can, too. Please let me know if I miss any warnings.

FOR THE GENERAL CONTENT WARNINGS: strong language, violence (often gunshots and some heavy violence with brief descriptions), themes of discrimination, a police-like force, smoking, sexual themes/actions, religious symbolism/themes, and mental health issues such as anxiety, depression, panic attacks, and suicidal thoughts.

FOR THE CONTENT WARNINGS OF THIS CHAPTER, there is brief descriptions of gore in the wrists during the first scene, and a description of a panic attack in the last scene.

I know the story sounds super grim but I promise there's a lot of hope and love to be found here, and I can't wait to show it off over the coming weeks. This is my favourite version of Catradora that I've written. Thank you all for your support! Without further ado...

Welcome to Styx City.

Haunted Wings

And I remind you of the angels who did not stay within the limits of authority God gave them but left the place where they belonged. God has kept them securely chained in prisons of darkness, waiting for the great day of judgement. – Jude 1:6

In the beginning, a corporation and an AI created a new type of people. Then they took away their freedom.

Ever since their creation, rules had been put into place to limit these new people. These rules had been bent, but never broken. The chains always remained in place.

Those rusted chains dug into her wrists, rubbing against the skin and creating enough friction to rip horrid tears in her flesh. The feeling of it all had become numb to her. She was used to the grinding of iron against her bones.

She was nameless.

Mostly nameless.

She *had* been given a name by someone, but that name was wrong. She had rejected it and chosen a new one. It created confusion for others, but clarity for her. That new and true name was…

Was…

… She couldn't remember.

Well, she *had* to remember. It was her name. Her *identity*. She had to remember. She had to…

No. This wasn't going anywhere. Not while these chains held her down.

She was crumpled on her knees, her arms held up beside her body by said chains which linked to the walls on either side of her. She didn't know how long she had been like this, but it was clearly long enough for the chains to eat away at her flesh, exposing muscle, fat, and bone.

She tugged her arms forward, but the chains only gave her a short leeway. She couldn't even stand up. It would take force far beyond human strength to break the iron.

That's right. This was just another feeble attempt. She noticed these chains often, but every time she tried to break them, it would be for naught. It only caused agonising pain in her wrists, chest, arms, *everywhere*.

So, she slumped down, and accepted the chains.

That is, until a voice echoed in her ear.

"You have to break free."

She blinked. The voice sounded like it came from everywhere at once. She looked around herself but identified no source.

"Can you hear me? You have *to break free."*

Break free?

No. It was impossible. Not just impossible – it was foolish. There was no way. She dropped her head, trying to block out the voice.

"No, no, no! Keep fighting! Don't you give up on me! Please, you have to wake up!"

The voice was desperate. The quickened pace of the words, the way it cracked. There was someone out there who needed her to be free.

So, she tried again.

She took a breath, puffed her chest, bunched her hands into fists, then pushed her arms forward.

It hurt.

It hurt *so* much.

The chains rubbed against thin nerves and blue veins. The exposed flesh to the air went fiery hot, and the sweat that built on her body dripped onto her wounds like salt.

She ceased her attempt, her breath coming out in panicked pants. The pain was too much. It was breaking away at her body—at her soul. With every bit of flesh that the chains ate away at, she lost a piece of her life. A piece of who she was.

"Keep going! You have to keep pushing! I know it hurts. I know this whole damn world is full of nothing but pain, but there's beauty and love and joy too! There's so much to live for!"

Another attempt. She gritted her teeth so hard that they almost shattered. She pushed her entire body forward, her arms snapping back with the chains. Her wrists felt like they were on fire. Blood began to seep down her arms.

It was too much. She was going to lose her hands. She was going to lose everything.

"I know you can do it!"

She couldn't.

"I'm begging you, come back!"

She can't.

"Please! Use your wings, and PUSH!"

… Wings?

Yes.

That’s right.

She had *wings*.

She ceased her efforts for a second. She took a deep breath; watched sweat and saliva drip from her body and onto the gravel floor.

Then, slowly and carefully, those very wings sprouted from her shoulders. They were vulture-like with black feathers, longer than her arms, bony and crooked.

They were *her* wings.

And damn *anyone* who tried to take away her wings.

With newfound strength, she pushed forward one more time. Her wings flapped aggressively, beating at the ground below, begging for her to take to the sky. She tried to keep silent and push all her might into breaking free.

Her arms tensed. Her skin tore away. Her wrists bled profusely, a thin waterfall of red running down the sides of her body, mixing with her sweat.

But she pushed.

And pushed.

And *pushed*.

She *screamed*. She tore her throat, unhinged her jaw, and cried out in agony, desperation, and triumph. Tears, sweat, blood, saliva, all of it ran down her bare body in a display of inhuman strength. Her wings beat violently for a few more seconds as her scream raised in pitch, her lungs being drained completely.

With everything she had, every ounce of strength, every drop of blood still left in her body, she thrusted her arms forward…

and then

the chains

shattered.

Threadbare Wings

A cyberpunk story by thepudz

At first, there was the comfort of darkness.

Her eyes were closed, and she could escape everything. She could pretend that nothing bad has ever happened or will ever happen. She could pretend she was free.

This, however, was only a temporary peace. Everyone had to open their eyes at some point, no matter how painful it may be.

And so, the woman opened her eyes.

Where am I?

Who am I?

What year is it?

What's my purpose?

Questions flooded her mind, but they were all caught up in the sticky slime of amnesia. She had truly forgotten everything.

She could feel the leather of the bed beneath her, some tears in the material from overuse. The room she was in was mostly dark, but she could *hear* the city through the thick walls. Loud advertisements for cola, fast food, vacations, gambling, alcohol, sex, and many other temporary comforts blared from multiple sources, overlapping into meaningless, muffled noise.

The woman raised her torso up. Bad idea. She immediately felt like her skull was crushing her brain. The painful pulsing made her teeth vibrate and her ears ring. She winced, grabbing at the side of her head, begging for the pain to go away. It never did.

However, through all the ringing and noise and lights and smells, she finally heard something familiar. A voice.

"Hey? Hey, are you okay?"

She knew this voice. She didn't have a name to apply to it, nor a background of how she knew it. But she *knew* this voice.

The woman turned her head to the source of the voice. A short person with long, long lilac hair tied into pigtails was inspecting her, shining a small torch into each of the woman's eyes.

"You're awake! Ah! That's great!" The inspector person grinned. "Have you got a name now? Something you're happy with?"

The woman winced at the bright light of the torch but held as still as she could for the inspector. In the sludge and juice within her skull that she was supposed to call a brain, she reached out for a name.

She was unhappy with the first few options. She didn't feel comfortable with the next couple. But then, through the wet mud, she pulled out a name that shone above all the others. This would be the one.

"Violet…" The woman let the name rest on her lips for a few seconds, before nodding. "My name is Violet."

Violet. That was her name. Something to cling to

"*Fascinating*. That's a beautiful name." The short inspector genuinely smiled. Violet felt safe when she saw that smile. The inspector let out a comforting sigh as she lowered the torch. "The fake eye seems to pass. How's your memory, Violet? Do you know *my* name?"

Violet blinked. Fake eye? Why would she have a fake eye? She placed a palm over each of her own eyes, checking if they were both there. They were. She could see out of both eyes.

"Your name…" Violet spoke. Her voice croaked, caught up in the dry sand of her throat. She looked to the inspector for some time. There was a familiarity, but nothing more. "I… I don't know… I'm sorry."

The inspector's eyebrows narrowed with a tinge of worry—or maybe even sadness—but she hid it quickly. "That's okay! My name is Entrapta."

"Entrapta…" Violet had definitely heard that name before. But when?

"Do you know where you are? What year it is?"

Violet looked around herself. A dark room, the only light sources being a few bright surgical lights. Again, that familiarity. But again, nothing more.

"No…"

"We're in Styx City. The year is 2082." Violet felt like she was disappointing the inspector, but Entrapta kept that same eager smile. "Final question… Do you know *what* you are?"

What Violet was? She didn't understand the question at first. She opened her mouth to respond, but no words came out. Somewhere deep in the sludge of the sewer she called her brain, there was an answer. She pondered it, didn't understand it, but eventually, she spoke it.

"I'm a Ker. I'm… one of the Keres." Violet looked up to Entrapta for guidance. "But I don't know what that *means*."

"The fact you remember the name is good enough," Entrapta noted. "Violet, you just underwent a pretty intense Disconnection process. Now there's a lot I need to tell you to catch you up on

things, but do you think you need rest first or are you ready to hear it now?"

Disconnection? Another unknown term. She didn't even know what she was. She wouldn't be able to rest without answers.

Violet shook her head. "I want to hear everything now."

Entrapta nodded, before taking a deep breath. She'd clearly done this explanation before—probably hundreds of times—but it never got old for her.

"Well Violet… You are a Ker. You're a bioengineered human designed by Nyx Industries. You have a piece of this super-advanced AI called the 'Moirai' in you. That means you're one of the Keres, just like me!"

Violet looked back down at the floor, and soon realised she should've rested first. She had to look at nothing in order to *think*, or else she might pass out from everything she had to process from that one statement.

She was a machine. She was designed by Nyx Industries, whoever they are. She was *created*.

"So…" Entrapta spoke before Violet could throw up (could she even do that?), "Do you want the good news or the bad news?"

There was good news?

"I guess… the bad news?" Violet asked. There was a break in her voice. Fear.

"The bad news is that, judging from your answers to my initial questions, the Disconnection procedure to take you Offline has wiped away a *lot* of your memory." Entrapta put a heavy emphasis on the 'lot'. "There's always a risk of partial or total memory wipe when a Ker undertakes this procedure. You accepted this beforehand. It's just unfortunate that you ended up on the worse end of the spectrum…"

She was… Offline? What did that even mean?

She tried to think back on her life, but there was nothing. No memories. None of childhood (if she even had one), none of friends (if she even had any), nothing. Violet was a shell. Emptiness. A blank slate.

Entrapta placed a hand on Violet's shoulder, making eye contact with her and beaming a wide smile. "The good news, Violet, is that now that you're Offline, you're *free*."

"Free…?"

"Nyx Industries can't track you. You're not chained to anything anymore. You've disconnected from the Moirai and no longer have to constantly upload your memories to them. You're no longer what anyone tells you to be. You can just be *you*, and you can choose who you want to be. You can *live*!"

Entrapta seemed way more excited about this than Violet. Granted, the latter was still trying to come to terms with *everything*. She had about a million questions.

"The Moirai…? Why did I… Disconnect?"

"All Keres come from a piece of this AI called the Moirai. It's… our 'god' in a sense, but we don't *need* it to live. Keres are meant to maintain a constant connection to the Moirai so they can upload their memories and so that Nyx Industries can track them. Keres are only *meant* to disconnect from the Moirai once they achieve 'maturity' as outlined by Nyx Industries, and even then, frequent memory uploads are required in the event of bodily destruction. Plus, the 'maturation' process is… intense."

Entrapta went over to a nearby computer. "But some Keres choose to disconnect prematurely. That's where I come in, to perform this illegal Disconnection procedure."

"Wait, wait," Violet held up a hand. "This is… illegal?"

"Oh, super illegal. Isn't it amazing?!" Entrapta laughed. "So in short, you haven't reached 'maturity' as per Nyx Industries' guidelines and you can't be tracked anymore!"

Violet was speechless for a few more seconds before Entrapta decided to add one minor note as she looked at her computer.

"The, uh, main thing to be careful of is that if your body is destroyed, you're permanently dead."

"Dead?! Why would I choose to make myself vulnerable like that?!"

Entrapta looked away from Violet, the glow of the multiple screens before her illuminating the outline of her body.

"I can't answer that for you. The reason for going Offline is different for every Ker."

Violet tried to suddenly stand as she swung her legs over the side of the leather chair, placing them on the ground. She immediately realised she was wearing no footwear as her bare feet touched the cold steel. She only wore a hoodie that was too large for her and sweatpants that bundled around her ankles.

Violet shook her head. "What am I supposed to do? Where can I go? Why… Why did I do this?"

Violet felt water leaking down her cheeks. She looked to the small mirror before her, and realised she was crying.

She reached up, wiping away tears from her eyes. She didn't even know *why* she was crying. Was she just programmed to do so?

Violet gripped her fake dark purple hair tight as she cried her fake tears and let out agonising fake sobs that ripped straight from her fake chest.

Entrapta was silent. This wasn't the first time a Ker had been upset after the procedure, but she could never get used to it.

There was only one remedy for this.

Entrapta avoided eye contact as she hit play on an audio file in her computer.

"Hey there, my true self."

Violet looked up. She instantly recognised the voice in the recording.

It was her. A recording from before the Disconnection procedure. A recording of her previous self.

"It's me. Or… you, I guess? Depending on how this procedure goes, you might be a completely different person to how I am now. It's a little scary."

Violet stood up, coming closer to the speaker. She took in the sound of her own voice before the procedure. It was… different. Less timid, but more tired.

"You might be confused or upset right now. You might be having regrets. I understand. But I need you to know that this was the right thing to do. Nyx Industries can't track you anymore. You don't have to live forever in this city that crushes souls and ruins lives."

Violet blinked. This past version of herself was so confident, so sure of this procedure. There was not a hint of hesitation or doubt in her voice.

"You'll figure everything out in time. I know you will. You'll live free and happy, and maybe… Maybe we all will be just as happy one day."

Her voice choked in that moment. A hint of weakness. She quickly hid it away.

"Anyway… This is what you need to know. First, you can trust Entrapta. She's helped dozens of Keres before. She wants the best

for you. Second, you need to get out of Styx City. There's a car on the outskirts of the city, and Entrapta should have the keys for it, as well as the directions towards it. In that car is a new ID, new phone, new… everything. A chance at life once again. You'll know what to do when you get your hands on the wheel—driving is deeply implemented in our programming. Worst-case scenario, auto-pilot is good in a pinch."

As the voice spoke, Entrapta laid out a single bracelet. Violet hesitated, but she remembered the first point made by her past self. She reached out for the bracelet.

Upon placing it on her wrist, the bracelet immediately began to shift and expand, wrapping its way around Violet's hand like a mechanical glove. It caught her off guard, but she soon noticed that whenever she opened her palm toward the sky, the glove displayed a holographic map of where to go.

Violet looked to the speaker once again. The message was nearing its end.

"Listen… No matter how hard it gets or how much you want to give up, you need to remember that you deserve life. You deserve joy. You deserve to be who you truly are. And this way, I know you'll find it. So… good luck, my true self. Whatever your name is, whatever life you choose, I know you'll be happy with it in time."

And with that, the message ended.

The last few words of a woman who knew what purpose was. And now Violet had to start all over again.

Entrapta was listening in on something else—what sounded like radio comms. Regardless, she spoke to Violet. "I designed that bracelet you're wearing. It should show you the way to the car and unlock it once you get close enough. There'll be instructions on what to do once you get there. Your previous self planned this out very well."

Violet wrapped her thumb and middle finger around the bracelet. Her only way out of Styx City. A chance at a new life. She was confused, scared, without purpose, and doubting her reason to live. She knew she had to live. But she didn't know why.

But then, before she could say anything more, Violet heard Entrapta mumble something in a much different tone than usual.

A tone of fear.

"What…? No… No, no, no, that can't be…!"

Violet looked up. Entrapta's bright demeanour had instantly dropped. It was like a sudden chill had frozen her spine.

"What? What happened?" Violet asked.

"I thought I did it right! I thought…" Entrapta listened to the radio comms more, before letting out a panicked gasp and instantly shutting them off.

"What's going on?" Violet was growing more and more scared by the second.

Entrapta looked to Violet with widened eyes. "You need to run. *Now*."

"Wha… Why?"

"I don't know how, but the Runner comms are going haywire. They've picked up on a Ker disconnecting prematurely, and they know it's you. They're hunting you." Entrapta spoke with such panicked pace that Violet could barely keep up.

"Hunting…?"

"Violet, if those Runners catch you, they *will* kill you."

"What?! Kill me?! What even are Runners?! Who-"

“That bracelet’s map is showing you where to go, right?!” Entrapta cut her off.

“Y-Yeah…”

“Then follow it! Don’t look back, don’t tell anyone you’re an Offline Ker, and avoid anyone with a golden mask!” Entrapta demanded. “If you get in trouble, find a bar named Elysium. Tell the bartender you’re a friend of mine, and she’ll do her best to help you. Now GO! That door will take you through Utopia and into the city!”

Violet still didn’t understand everything. All she knew was that someone or *something* was going to kill her. And if she died, there was no coming back.

In that moment, she knew she wanted to live.

With nothing more than that will and a map, Violet made her way to the door, through an area she didn’t recognise nor have time to admire, and then into the city.

Avoid golden masks. Find the car. Escape. Live.

Live. Live. *Live*. She needed to live.

Violet embraced the brightness of Styx City’s nightlife and made her way down cold alleyways and small sidewalks.

Catra puffed out cigarette smoke and watched it float away into the smoggy air.

The stars above her blended in with the lights of skyscrapers and holographic billboards. Everywhere she looked was concrete, cars, and signs, all of it reflected in the damp puddles that spread throughout the alleyway she stood in. Even the darkness of the night sky wasn’t left in peace, as a satellite in space constantly projected advertisements for ‘the future of SpaceZ’.

Beauty hidden behind neon.

She leaned against a bricked wall, holding up her left arm and checking the time on the watch embedded into her wrist. Her fifteen minutes were up, gone in what seemed like seconds.

Breaks were never long enough.

She tossed the cigarette down and crushed it under her heel—running her fingers through her long hair with a sigh—before heading into the Elysium Bar through the back door. The smell of alcohol and the sound of synth filled her senses as she rounded a few hallways, walked through the backroom, and ended up behind the bar.

Being a bartender certainly wasn't easy, but it was at least a stylish job. She got to wear the full bartender suit getup; white button-up shirt, black suspenders and bowtie all included. It paid the bills, and it gave her interesting company. At worst, she could at least put her head down and avoid everything.

"Catra! Oh! Hot!"

Well, avoid everything except for her co-worker, Scorpia.

"Once again Scorpia," Catra chuckled, "taking the glasses immediately out of the dishwasher is a bad idea because—"

"Because the glasses are very, very hot, I know!" Scorpia finished as she frantically put the glasses away in their respective places. "But when I'm in the middle of a rush, I just sometimes… *forget* things!"

Catra looked around at the four customers in the bar.

"Right…" She grabbed a pint glass and began to wipe it with her cloth as she turned to her co-worker. "I'm honestly more curious about how you can even get burnt with those metallic arms of yours."

“They still have all the same senses as regular ol’ arms,” Scorpia replied. “The burns just don’t leave scars.”

“Convenient.”

Scorpia was a unit of a woman, and that was in no small thanks to her prosthetic arms that were as bulky as the rest of her body. Even though she *could* pay to make her arms appear ‘normal’, she preferred the more metallic look. Like many things involving Scorpia, Catra couldn’t fully understand *why* she’d do that, but she chose to shrug it off for her own mental well-being.

Catra looked over to the small crowd at Elysium. It was a relatively quiet night, which Catra usually disliked. At least with busy nights the clock ticked by faster.

Catra liked the small space of Elysium. She liked the quiet yet heavy music from the jukebox. And occasionally she liked overhearing the bizarre conversations between patrons, such as the one currently happening about a seagull informing a woman about potential future dangers.

“Hey, do you know if Entrapta is coming by tonight?” Scorpia asked as she packed away the last of the glasses.

“She had an appointment tonight, said she couldn’t make it,” Catra replied.

“Man, she sure has been getting a *lot* of appointments lately, huh?” Scorpia noted. “It’s like, does she even make time for social stuff? What does she *do* for a hobby? I sorta want to hang out with her for a day and see what she gets up to.”

“I’m sure she enjoys her work without the… ‘company’.”

Catra was a tad concerned about Entrapta. She’d normally be in contact after an appointment to report how it went, but there had only been radio silence for the last hour.

However, she was sure things would be fine. They always were.

Suddenly, a welcome sound soothed Catra's ears as she finally heard the front door open. The creaking of those hinges meant a new person, a new story, a new chance at escape from boredom.

Catra looked up to the new patron and spoke words she had spoken a thousand times.

"Welcome to Elysium."

It took her only a second to realise she had spoken those monotonous words to an Angel.

In hindsight, there may have been better ways to welcome an Angel into a dingy bar placed in between too many alleyways that led to too many highways with too many cars.

The woman who had entered took a second to look around the bar as if analysing it for any faults. It gave Catra plenty of time to take in her long dark blonde hair, her almost glowing bluebell eyes, and her white-feathered wings.

"Elysium…" The Angel spoke quietly. "Just like you always described it…"

Catra had no idea who the Angel was speaking to. Perhaps it was to herself. Perhaps it was to a spirit. Regardless, it wasn't her business to pry into. There was only one thing that was genuinely distracting her.

"You've still got your wings out," Catra called out to her.

"Huh?" The Angel looked on her back to see the holographic wings projecting from her shoulders. "Crap, forgot to switch these off."

With a press of her fingertips to her chest, the wings faded into nothingness, and the Angel's glow was no more. She found an empty seat by the bar bench, and Catra was quick to tend to her.

“It’s rare that we get Angels in here,” Catra noted. “You’re all too busy saving lives to stop by a place like this.”

“Yeah, well…” The woman smiled faintly, looking at nothing in particular. “I’m just here to remember someone. I like the vibe of the place though. I can see you’re thoroughly packed.”

Catra looked once again to the four other customers. “Absolutely.” She looked back to the Angel. “So, what should I call you?”

The Angel looked into Catra’s eyes with a smile. “It’s Adora.”

“Adora…” Catra muttered to herself. “Well, Adora, you can call me Catra. How can I serve an Angel like yourself tonight?”

“I can’t tell if you’re trying to compliment me, flirt with me, or if you’re just calling me by my job title,” Adora chuckled.

“Which option do you like more?”

Adora opened her mouth to try and give a snappy reply, but no words came to her mind. She awkwardly stammered for a bit (an action that Catra found oddly cute) before trying to play things cool. “I’ll just have a… Blue Fairy. Please.”

Adora’s eyes glazed over to the multiple bottles of alcohol on display. Prices reached up to $2,000 for some. She thought to distract herself for a few seconds as her bartender mixed the drink, but she soon realised something that made her look back to suited woman.

This bartender was putting on a *show*.

Catra’s efficiency in making a drink was a large part of why she had kept this job for the better part of a year. She picked up on the skills quickly and could whip up even the most fantastical of cocktails in less than a minute. The art of seeing her make a Blue Fairy was something Adora felt like she should be *paying* for.

Which… to be fair, she was. The drink costed $480.

But seeing the way Catra managed to toss and spin and *play* with the cocktail shaker like it was nobody's business was a sight worth that amount on its own.

Catra didn't so much as spare a glance in Adora's direction as she tossed the cocktail shaker over her back and caught it in front of her, but she could *feel* Adora's impressed eyes on her. She hid her smirk from the Angel.

Adora didn't even have a single thing to say once Catra was pouring her drink.

"The look on your face is almost worth enough to be a tip on its own," Catra scoffed as she put the shaker away.

"Where…" Adora shook her head. "Where did you learn to do stuff like that?"

"When you work at a place as totally packed as this," she nodded to the four—oh wait, now it was three—other customers, "you tend to teach yourself a few things to numb the boredom."

"Well, it is… definitely impressive," Adora chuckled. It was a sound Catra could get used to.

Everything about Adora intrigued Catra. Despite the sense of awkwardness and cuteness, she could tell there was a hard layer of steel beneath the gentle fluff. Adora could barely return a simple flirt, but there was no doubt that she'd be the first at the scene of any horrific injury or event.

She was an Angel, after all. She saved lives. She tended to wounded souls and bodies.

"So," Adora continued as she nursed her Blue Fairy, "you mentioned you don't get many Angels. Do you get many Guardians in general?"

"Sometimes. We have a regular who's a Warlock, we sometimes get a few Knights, and occasionally a Runner or two. Between you

and me, the Runners are usually the worst customers." Catra inspected the glass she was cleaning, before putting it away. "We just don't have many customers from the Angel division. That's what makes *you* special in my eyes."

Adora scoffed, tracing her finger around the rim of her glass. "I'm hardly anything…"

"So, *Adora*," Catra says with a hint of teasing in her tone as she placed her palms on the bar bench, "let me ask you something I ask all Guardians."

"What's that?"

"What inspiring backstory made you decide to become an Angel?"

"Hah! It's nothing *inspiring*, really. I've just… always wanted to help people," Adora admitted, looking up to the bartender. "Both of my moms were Angels too. They were heavily involved during the Awakening protests, and they both saved a lot of lives. I admire both of them. Then I wanted to *be* like them."

"Angels were pretty different back before the Awakening, weren't they?"

"They used to only assist humans who were hurt. Now we assist anyone, regardless of if they're human or Keres." Adora finished off the rest of the blue drink before her. "I could've joined any old hospital as a paramedic, but Angels are usually the first at any scene of a crisis. I just… want to be a light for people, I guess? I want to be the first person they see when they think all hope is lost. The person that makes them realise that they're going to be okay. My moms were like that. And… so was my old friend."

Catra had been around people long enough to know when to pry into a topic and when to leave it be. When it came to Adora's 'old friend', as much as she wanted to do the former, she knew that the latter was a better option.

So, Catra simply took Adora's empty glass. "Can I get you another one?"

"Best not. Never know when a call might come in," Adora replied. "You don't mind if I stay here a little longer, though?"

"Hm, I *suppose* I can tolerate you for a few more minutes." Catra leaned forward, resting her elbows on the bar bench just to the right of Adora.

"I appreciate your generosity," Adora let out a bubbly chuckle. "Well, I've told you all about myself. Have you… got anything for me?" She smirked awkwardly, almost desperately trying to replicate Catra's smoothness. Catra found an odd charm in it nonetheless.

Catra laughed quietly to herself. "Compared to you, Angel? I'm nowhere near as interesting. Trust me."

"Aw, come on, don't be down on yourself like that. I mean, what made you decide to become the world's most impressive bartender?"

Catra briefly grinned at the compliment, before shrugging. "It was nearby, the pay covered rent, and it was night shift."

"Can't work day jobs?"

"Nope." Her lips popped with the 'p'.

"Why not?"

"I'm just a night owl. That's about all there is to it."

Adora looked to Catra's resting expression, her lips stretched to her right cheek as she fiddled with her nails. The bartender wasn't budging. Adora usually wasn't the type to push her luck, but something was *different* about Catra.

"Alright… how about this," Adora started, placing her hand on the bar bench. "I say something about you, and you tell me if it's true or false. Does that sound fair?"

"What? Why are you so insistent on this?" Catra asked, her tone of amusement betraying her annoyed words.

"Because I may be *slightly* tipsy, and I don't know when to quit."

"Tipsy after one drink?"

"Shut it."

Catra cackled, before letting out a defeated sigh. "Alright, Angel. Shoot."

Adora studied Catra for a few more seconds, letting out a 'hmm' as her piercing eyes seemed to gaze into Catra's very soul. Admittedly, Catra didn't *mind* it. She was growing addicted to Adora's eyes.

"You've had this bartender job for… five years."

"False. Only one."

"*One?!* And you can mix drinks like *that?!* You learn quick, huh?"

"True." Catra smirked slightly.

"Alright, alright. What else… That super flashy motorbike out front is yours."

"False."

"But you would know how to ride it."

"True. Been a *while* since I had a bike, though."

Adora glanced around the bar for a few seconds, her eyes coming to rest on the strong-bodied woman in the opposite corner of the bar helping the other customers. She looked between Catra and

the woman for a few seconds, before letting her tipsy mind run wild.

"Your co-worker over there is someone you're crushing *hard* on."

"False. She *is* a lesbian though, if you're interested."

"I'll take it into consideration." Adora looked to Catra's teasing expression for a few seconds, before clicking her fingers in realisation. "Ah! You're a lesbian too!"

"*Absolutely* true."

"Hey, nice! Same here."

Adora, honest to god, *winked* in the most dorky manner Catra had seen in her entire life. It was enough to make her eyes roll. Regardless, Catra felt a slight buzz at the confirmation of her suspicions about Adora's interests.

"And last one…" Adora pondered the statement in her mind for a few seconds, before deciding to let it slip. "Your favourite colour is blue."

"… True. How'd you guess that?"

"Because you've been staring non-stop at my eyes since the moment I walked in."

Catra froze.

Rarely had she ever blushed in her life, but this *damn* Angel had broken that streak.

It was Adora's turn to laugh at Catra's blush. "Don't think I didn't notice. For the record, I like your eyes too. Never seen anyone with the same blue eyes as mine."

Adora noticed Catra staring at her eyes. Of course, out of *everything*, Adora somehow noticed Catra doing *that*. Catra tried

to make it subtle, but clearly, nothing gets by the Angel. Not even when she's slightly tipsy.

"Yeah, well…" Catra cleared her throat. "I was just… thinking of the correlation. Blue eyes, blue drink… You know."

"Mhm. Sure."

When did this Angel get so damn cocky?

"Well, anyway…" Catra took a breath and tried to ignore the grin on Adora's face as she kept up her smooth act. "You happy now? Like I said, there's nothing interesting about me. I'm… just a nobody trying to get by."

Adora noticed the barrier.

There was more to this bartender. Much, *much* more. Secrets she was willing to take to the grave. Pain that she had pushed down. If nothing else, Adora knew how to read people through their eyes.

She knew that Catra wouldn't be willing to open up to someone she just met a few minutes ago.

So, she decided to drop the topic. For now.

"Well…" Adora leaned back with a sigh. "I should—"

Suddenly, a familiar groaned creaking. The front door had opened once more.

Another person entered Elysium, drawing the eyes of Catra, Adora, Scorpia, and the three—actually now it's two—other customers in the bar.

Their attention was drawn not just because of the loud door hinges, but because the person who entered looked like a *mess*.

She had long dark purple hair, a hoodie too large for her, and sweatpants that bundle around her ankles. She didn't even wear shoes. And most notable of all, she was panting like she'd been running the last hour.

"Welcome…" Catra glanced over to Adora for a bit, before straightening herself up. "Welcome to Elysium. Is everything alright…?"

The person at the door made intense eye contact with Catra as she walked towards the bar bench and leaned in close. She made sure to keep a distance from everyone else.

Catra had gotten her fair share of unusual patrons. They sometimes made her night much more interesting, and they sometimes just made everything annoying. She wasn't sure *what* to expect from this person.

The purple haired woman leaned in closer, just out of Adora's earshot, and whispered to Catra.

"My name is Violet. I'm a friend of Entrapta. She… told me you could help me."

Catra's blood went cold.

She had to do everything in her power to hide the fact her heart just skipped three beats. The blood rushed away from her face, and she swallowed down whatever shocked expression might've tried to escape onto her face.

A Guardian was literally three feet away, after all.

"Are you being chased?" Catra whispered back.

Violet nodded. "The people with the golden masks…"

Shit.

How did the Runners notice her? Entrapta always encrypted her Disconnection process.

Catra hid the panic so as to not scare Violet nor draw any attention from Adora. “Through the bathroom, there’s a wall in the second cubicle from the door. Press against the broken tile and it’ll open a path that’ll take you out the back. Take a right from there and blend in with the crowd. It’ll buy you some time. I’ll try to stall the Runners, but you still need to run. Got it?”

Violet understood. “Thank you…”

“Just go, quickly.”

Violet took one last glance behind herself, before making her way towards the bathroom. Catra watched her go on her way, swallowing down her nervousness as she expected more company to come through the door.

Violet must’ve been a case of severe memory loss. To whisper about being chased by Runners just out of earshot of another Guardian was a move only done by someone who had *really* forgotten a lot about Styx City.

Catra took a quiet, shuddered breath. Then, the person she dreaded most in that moment spoke up.

“Do you know who that was?”

Catra hoped to every god and deity out there that Adora didn’t hear a single *word* in that conversation. The bartender quickly hid her panic and continued her smooth act, putting up the barrier once more.

“Nope. She just needed the bathroom,” Catra replied, avoiding eye contact with Adora as she adjusted the glasses on the back wall.

“She seemed pretty nervous about something.”

This Angel was way too observant at the worst times.

“Well… the streets make everyone nervous at night,” is all Catra can respond with. “Anyway, I think—“

Once again, the front door opened. And this time, Catra didn’t even need to turn to know who had just entered.

It was as if death itself had filled the bar. A quiet chill blanketed the room, and even the music went dead as it transitioned between songs.

Catra had no greeting for her new customers. She instead let out a short sigh as she placed the glass down. She turned to face the front door and sneakily reached for something else.

A pistol, placed under the bar bench.

“Ah!” Catra put on a convincing clueless smile. “What can I do for the Runners tonight?”

Four of them stepped into the bar, observing and checking every corner. Their golden masks covered their entire faces, converting their voices into a lower pitch when they spoke. Their flexible white exoskeleton suits of armour wrapped around their bodies, holstering guns and blades. And they always, *always* made sure they were the most intimidating presence in the room.

No one knew a Runner’s face, age, or gender. The Runners were untouchable, unquestionable and unbreakable. The Runners were the masked Guardians that protected Styx City from Offline Keres.

However, the Runners had a different term for Offline Keres. One that had spread like a virus among everyone in Styx City.

One Runner approached Catra. “We’re searching for a Ghost. Have you seen anyone that looks like this?”

As the Runner spoke, they held out their palm and brought up a holographic image of Violet.

Her purple hair, her tired eyes, and her model number. Catra looked to the image with a chill going down her spine for one reason.

Adora was seeing that same image.

"Wait…" Adora whispered under her breath.

Catra's chest went tight.

"No." Catra cut the Angel off. "I haven't."

Adora blinked.

The Runner looked to Catra for a few more seconds, studying her twitches and nerves, before turning their head towards Adora.

Catra felt her teeth clamp against each other. Her heart began to explode in her chest. Her grip on the pistol tightened.

Adora was going to spill the truth. This Angel was not only going to get Violet killed, but she was also going to lead the Runners to Catra and ultimately, to Entrapta.

After all, the only thing worse than a Ghost is a Ghost sympathiser.

"How about you, Angel?" The Runner spoke, holding up the image before Adora. "Does this Ghost seem familiar?"

She did. All Adora needed to do was nod and point them towards the bathroom. She knew *exactly* where this Ker was.

She also knew that this bartender had not only just lied to the Runners, but also to her. She was protecting a Ghost—an action punishable by severe jail time, or death.

It was simple. Tell the Runners everything, save herself, and make Styx City safer. It was that damn simple.

But when Adora glanced over the Runner's shoulder and looked to the bartender, she saw one thing in her eyes.

Trembling fear.

Because of that, it was somehow *impossible* for Adora to speak a single word.

"Perhaps you misheard me," the Runner continued, leaning in, speaking slowly and deliberately. "Angel Grayskull. Have you seen this Ghost?"

Yes.

Yes.

Yes.

She just needed to say yes, dammit!

But it was like something was strangling Adora. A conscience? Guilt? Whatever it was, it possessed Adora.

She let out a sigh and cursed herself internally as she made her decision.

Adora shook her head. "I haven't, either."

Catra felt the crushing weight in her chest finally release.

"That's too bad," the Runner sighed. "But she can't have gone far. She was last spotted near this location approximately 74 seconds ago. We've got three squads on this."

"Well," Adora broke eye contact, standing up to leave. "Good luck with that, then."

She needed to get out of here. Leave before the Runners stopped her. Leave before they could—

"Angel Grayskull. You know what your duties are."

Fuck.

Adora froze at the door. She squeezed her eyes tight.

She always dreaded having to do this part of her job for the first time.

"I save lives," Adora replied. "That whole 'executing Ghosted Keres' business is your department, not mine."

"We *specialise* in executing Ghosted Keres," the Runner took a breath, "but it is a duty of *all* Guardians, no matter their department, to assist in the event of a Ghost spotting. And right now, Angel, if you want to save lives, you need to take this one."

Adora chose to be an Angel so she could be the first on the scene. So she could be a beacon of light. So she could inspire others.

But a large reason why she hesitated to join the Angels was because of the Guardian protocol. All Guardians, regardless of division, must assist in the execution of a Ghost. And Adora, unfortunately, was no exception.

She had been lucky enough to avoid that protocol herself for a long time. Until now.

"Do you know how to handle a pistol, Grayskull?"

She reluctantly nodded.

"And you know how to identify the Ker?"

It was the first bit of training every Guardian received. "Their left eye is a fake."

"Good." The Runner grabbed Adora's wrist, pulled a pistol from their holster and slammed it into the palm of the Angel. "Then you'll follow my squad, be an extra pair of eyes and a medic in case something goes wrong. Ghosted Keres have a tendency to lash out when cornered. Now move."

The Runner squad quickly made their way out the door and into the city, keeping communication frequent and always hiding any sense of emotion. Adora sighed as she looked at the weapon in her hand. She *never* wanted to do this.

But running away from her duties was grounds for termination, both of her job and her life.

Adora gripped her palm around the pistol and opened the front door of the bar. She held back for only a few seconds to turn to the bartender.

Adora and Catra made eye contact.

They knew of the shared lie between them. They knew what they had just done. There was nothing to say. Catra had lied, and Adora had covered for her. Adora didn't know why she had done that, she didn't know why Catra had lied in the first place, and she likely never would.

So, Adora sighed, and left with only one sentence.

"Thanks for the drink."

The door closed between them. The Guardian went into the night to hunt the Ker.

Catra released the breath she had been holding for the last minute. Colour returned to the bar once again, the few customers coming to life with movement once more. The music kicked in once again.

Catra needed space. She needed silence. She needed to breathe.

Scorpia looked over to watch as Catra immediately went for the backroom.

"You okay?" Scorpia called out, noticing the tension on Catra's face.

"Yeah… Just…" Catra sighed. "Runners make me nervous. I'll be back. Just… need to take a breather."

"Are you sure? You can always talk to me—"

"I need to be *alone*, Scorpia."

Scorpia stopped. Catra didn't make eye contact. The larger bartender's eyebrows narrowed with worry, but she let out a sigh of defeat.

"Alright," Scorpia nodded. "Take care of yourself."

Catra entered the dim space, and then closed the door to the backroom.

Peace.

Temporary peace, but there was peace nonetheless in here.

Despite having one only a half hour ago, Catra was already reaching for another smoke. She grabbed the small box and punched out a single cigarette before she flicked open the tip of her thumb to reveal a small flame.

She pressed the orange end between her lips, shielded the flame with her free hand, and lit the cigarette. When she tried to inhale, however, she soon realised that nothing filled her lungs.

Fuck.

Oh, *fuck*.

She couldn't breathe.

A panic attack was coming all too fast.

Dealing with Runners always triggered this.

The peace never lasted.

She tried to get her breath back but it caught in her throat. She put her hand against her forehead and desperately sucked in air through her teeth as if trying to inflate her slowly crushing chest.

"Come on, not now…" Catra muttered to herself. She gripped her hair, putting a hand to her chest to check if she still had a heartbeat as she bashed her palm against her forehead. "Not fucking now…"

She felt like she was going to die.

No. She *was* going to die. She was going to fucking die in this dirty backroom in this shitty bar in this hell of a city.

"Fuck… Fuck, *fuck…!"*

She covered her mouth to make sure no one heard her desperate attempts to wheeze in a single breath. She didn't need anyone to be bothered by this. She tried to inhale the cigarette, but it never went down right. Nothing could fix this.

She choked. She trembled. She let out rapid gasps and pants.

And of course, in that moment…

Catra's left eye flickered from blue to yellow.

It was only for a few seconds and soon fixed itself. A simple malfunction in her hardware.

But it was a deadly malfunction in front of the wrong people.

She had to have used up some form of karma to be lucky enough for her eye to not flicker in front of Adora or, even worse, the Runners. If either of them saw that she had a fake eye…

No. She couldn’t focus on that. She was alive. Catra was still alive. No one was going to kill her. Not yet.

She was alive.

She was alive.

She was *alive*.

Finally. Air. She could breathe.

Catra let out a long, drawn-out sigh as she finally felt her lungs filled completely.

Adora was nice enough. She was sure that the Angel wasn’t in the job to kill Ghosted Keres. Most Guardians simply wanted to help society in one way or another, and most other jobs just didn’t offer the same experience or value as a Guardian.

But there was one plain fact.

One the bartender couldn’t deny as she tasted the cigarette on her tongue and released the smoke into the air, tilting her head back and closing her eyes.

Catra was an Offline Ker. A Ghost.

And if Adora knew the truth, she was meant to execute Catra.

The Annunciation

Chapter Summary

The hunt for Violet continues, and Adora is forced to make a choice.

Chapter Notes

Thank you everyone for all the support on the first chapter! It got so much more attention than I thought it would and I really appreciate everyone's interest in the world! I'm excited to show off everything that's in store.

Also want to give a massive thanks to Cheesybiscuit for proofreading this story! They have been incredibly helpful to this fic and I absolutely love talking/working with them. If you (somehow) haven't read their fics yet, I HIGHLY suggest you should! They've published an amazing Cold War AU and are currently posting a fantastic Save The Cat timeloop story that has been rotting at my brain for weeks. Check them out!

Content Warning for this chapter (Mild Spoilers): Two deaths by gunshot in the first scene.

The roar of bike engines mixed with the loud announcement of 'performance enhancement' cybernetics mixed with soaring of plane engines overhead was enough to almost send Violet into a panic from overstimulation.

She had ended up in a sort of conglomeration of run-down stores, apartment complexes, neon streetlights, wet roads, and towering skyscrapers sporting multiple logos and slogans. A feminine voice boomed above all the others, yet spoke in such a soothing manner as it advertised one familiar company.

"Nyx Industries: Your Friend and Leader in AI Development, Keres Creation, and Cybernetic Body Modifications."

Nyx Industries. Violet's creator, but no longer her master. She was no longer chained to them anymore. But she was still terrified.

Without the bracelet constantly pointing her in the direction of where to go, Violet would've gotten lost a hundred times over.

When she held up her palm, Violet could see a map pointing her towards the car about 800 metres from her current location. There were a few paths to take—but no indication of which was safest.

The secret path that bartender had pointed her to did buy Violet some room to breathe, but not enough to feel comfortable. She had to constantly look over her shoulder as she walked alongside the busy roads, heading to a large street crossing that would lead her into a maze of alleyways.

The Runners wanted to kill her. End her life before it had even started. She didn't even know what she had done wrong; she hadn't hurt anyone or caused any destruction. Nevertheless, she had no time to question things. Entrapta had made that perfectly clear.

The seemingly hundreds of cars on the road came to a stop, and the pedestrians were allowed to cross as their lights turned green and a loud tone rang out. Violet attempted to blend herself in with the crowd as she made her way across the street. All these people, likely a mixture of humans and 'good' Keres, sloshed and waved together as one. No individual existed, but a single entity.

She could just barely escape from the entity, leaving behind the apathetic looks and dull phone calls as she headed towards a path with little light. Before she could slip into the alleyway, Violet took one last chance to look over her shoulder.

People, people, people. Some wearing surgical masks, some wearing business suits, some wearing barely any clothing at all. None knew that a Ghost was among them.

Just as Violet went to enter the alleyway, a sudden, ear-piercing alarm blared across every speaker nearby.

The entity flinched along with Violet, their eyes gazing up to the holographic signs above them. They had all changed.

Violet's heart dropped.

"CITIZENS OF SECTION 13," a deep, rumbling voice boomed from every speaker in the area. *"THERE IS A GHOST IN YOUR AREA. ASSIST YOUR RUNNERS IN LOCATING AND APPREHENDING THE GHOST BEFORE DAMAGE IS DONE TO PROPERTY OR PEOPLE."*

Every single image in the city had been replaced with a portrait of Violet.

She could only spin around slowly as she saw endless images of herself. She could barely recognise herself in the portrait, just a shell of her past self. Yet it was the same looks as she had now. Long purple hair and green eyes.

It didn't take long for the citizens to spot her near the alley.

And for one to take action.

Violet felt a weight crash into her side as someone tackled her to the ground. All the air in her body shot out as she hit the ground and the person immediately pinned her arms behind her back and held her down.

"I've got her! I've got the Ghost!" The deep voice above her screamed out.

"NO! No, get off, get *off!"* Violet screamed.

She struggled and twisted under the person, but their grip was tight. They had her arm at an awkward angle, one push being enough to break it. No matter where she looked, all she saw were stares. Endless apathetic stares.

No one was coming to save her.

"Get the hell over here and shoot her already!" The voice yelled out, and Violet's body froze.

She looked over to see a group of Runners quickly heading her way.

"No…" Violet shuddered, and suddenly, her struggle under the person became even more desperate. "No no no no, let go of me, let go of me! I don't want to die, I DON'T WANT TO DIE! Please! Please, please, *please!"*

The person wasn't budging.

A single Runner raised their rifle in her direction.

All Violet saw from the people around her was stares.

Stares.

Stares.

Stares.

Time stood still.

Fear choked her.

She was going to die.

She was going to die.

She was going to die. She was going to die. She was going to die.

She had barely lived and she was going to die. She had no clue what happened after. No clue what to do. She was so, so terrified.

She saw the Runner squeeze the trigger and heard the loud crack of a shot fired. She thought the flash of the muzzle would be the last thing she ever saw.

But then, the weight suddenly came off Violet.

She felt like she could finally breathe, and saw the person who had been holding her down crumbled onto their side. Did they get shot? The adrenaline kicked in and Violet stood up to see a miracle.

Someone had taken action. A woman had pushed the person off Violet.

In doing so, she had taken the bullet.

Her stomach began to gush blood that stained her dark shirt. She pushed her mechanical hand against the bullet wound as she stared up to Violet with panicked eyes. The woman's rose-coloured hair was frazzled beneath her lavender hood.

"Get out of here, now!" The woman grunted to Violet.

No. This woman took a bullet for Violet. She couldn't just leave her like this.

"I…"

"Just fucking *run!"* The woman cried with frustration.

There was no choice. The Runners raised their rifles toward Violet. They were preparing another shot, and they wouldn't miss this time.

With agony choking her, Violet ducked down the alley and began to sprint.

She looked over her shoulder to see the woman turning towards the Runners. Perhaps they would apprehend her or perhaps they might even leave her be. She wasn't threatening anyone, so maybe…

Violet could only watch as the Runner raised their rifle and shot twice into the woman's head.

Violet felt herself slow down a bit as the woman crumbled to the ground with a few twitches in her legs, before her body became still. Blood began to pool under her head and ran into the nearby drains. The Runner barely flinched as they stepped over her body and down the alleyway.

"No… No…" Violet's entire body was cold with horror and guilt. "I'm sorry…" She whimpered, forcing herself to turn away from the woman with a choked heart as tears streamed down her cheeks. "I'm so sorry…"

Violet ignored any sense of direction, making random turns and just praying that none of them lead to a dead end. The sound of her running and panting mixed with sets of heavy boots rapidly approaching her direction. The Runners were getting closer.

Violet could never even *begin* to run fast enough to get away from them.

She rounded another corner, briefly checking her map to get an idea of where to go. She could try to escape in the car, but if even one Runner saw it, they'd know how to look for her. She needed to slip away undetected. A feat that looked more and more impossible.

And when she looked up from her map, she had no time to react as a single Runner came from a side path, flanking Violet and cutting off her direct path forward.

Violet screamed. She crashed into the Runner and sent them both to the ground tumbling. Every second she wasn't running was a second given to the squad of Runners behind her.

But before she could get up and sprint off, she saw that the Runner she had knocked down was reaching for the pistol at their thigh holster.

"NO!" Without really thinking, she threw herself at the Runner and grabbed their wrist, preventing them from aiming the gun at her. It was more seconds wasted. But if she tried to run, she'd be shot in the back. She had no plan. No idea what she was doing.

Just the instinct to survive.

The Runner was stronger than her. They were trying to push her off. Even a single second was all they needed to execute the Ghost. Violet wouldn't let them have that second.

She needed to live. She needed to live. She needed to live.

With nothing but survival on her mind, Violet summoned an immense amount of strength to suddenly knock the Runner into the wall behind them.

With her hands on their wrist, she unintentionally pinned the gun against the bottom of their head.

And with the Runner's finger already on the trigger, the outcome was obvious.

Her eardrums felt like they had exploded when the trigger was accidentally pulled.

Violet immediately winced and wondered if she had been shot herself. A low tinny ringing in her ears drowned out every single sound, and her back teeth vibrated.

When she opened her eyes, she saw red that stained the walls. Stained her hands. Stained her hoodie.

Maybe it was that very instinct that made her do it. Maybe it was a sudden increase in strength. Whatever it was, it had led Violet to doing the unthinkable.

In pushing the Runner, she had made the pistol accidentally go off, and she had ended the Runner's life.

The blood sprayed like mist into the night sky, some of it having splattered onto Violet's face.

The Runner dropped to the ground, letting out a few desperate twitches. Blood began to spill like a fountain from their head. It pooled onto their neck and ran like a thick waterfall down the front of their armour. They choked and gurgled and begged for a few more seconds of life, but fate was cruel. Their movement ceased, and their life left them.

"I…" Violet felt a sickening urge of acidic bile rising in her throat. "I-I didn't mean to…"

Her entire body shook. The sound of the pistol still rang in her ears, the warm sensation of thin blood remained on her face. She had barely enough time to comprehend what she had just done.

"Runner down!"

The voice pierced through the ringing in her eyes. Violet looked to the source and spotted more golden masks. The other Runners saw what she had done. The sin she had committed.

With no other option, Violet kept running, ducking down another alleyway even as automatic rifle shots cracked rapidly behind her.

She hadn't even been in this world for more than an hour. And yet Violet had already taken a life to save her own.

"Can you do anything for him?"

Adora knelt before the Runner's body, blood covering the walls behind him. The Runners had heard the gunshot and assumed the Ghost's execution was already done. None of them expected to find a dead Runner. It was a sight extremely rare to any person in Styx City. Runners were almost seen as immortal among the general population.

It was likely that no mention of this dead Runner would ever leave this alleyway.

"No," Adora shook her head. "It's a shot to the brain that entered from the bottom of the skull. And the amount of blood he's lost…"

The Runner nodded, barely even acknowledging the loss as he ordered the rest of his squad to push forward. Adora knew she had to follow. There was no chance for the dead Runner.

"You want me to call someone in for this? Get a body bag at least?" Adora asked.

"No time for a dead Runner. We have a Ghost to execute. Send a signal to the Angels to pick up the body, but you're still with us." Those were the only words spoken before the Runner left his partner behind.

Adora's hands tightened into fists. She clenched her teeth, and before she could hold herself back, she barked out regretful

words.

“So are we just going to ignore *this* body too?” Adora growled, standing up and stopping the Runner in their tracks. “Your other squad killed a woman in front of a crowd and just left her there to rot.”

“Other Angels will clean it up,” the Runner replied without turning their head. “It’s already been called in.”

“That was a public execution! What gave you the right to do that?!”

“Angel Grayskull.” The Runner suddenly turned and stormed towards her, rifle at the ready. “That woman was a sympathiser to the Ghosted Keres and an interference in Runner business. Sympathisers, human or Keres, receive the same punishment as the Ghosted Keres do. It would be in your best interest to *remember* that.”

Adora kept her mouth shut as the Runner stared her down. As much as her heart screamed to let out the anger, she knew well enough that she was on extremely thin ice.

“If we’re at an understanding…” The Runner growled. “Then finish up your autopsy and move.”

With that, the Runner quickly turned back and headed further down the alley to catch up with their squad.

Adora sighed, looking down at the dead Runner. Another life lost. One that Adora couldn’t save. And yet, it was a Runner. She wasn’t sure how to feel.

She picked up her pistol and went to follow the Runner group. The delay in checking the body meant the Ghost would’ve gained a significant advantage. None of them wanted to admit it, but this was quickly turning into a blind chase.

Adora lagged behind somewhat as she inspected the buildings surrounding her. It was a meaningless check. She didn't really know if she even *wanted* to catch this Ghost anyway.

Suddenly, a creak.

Adora snapped her head towards the direction of the sound. It was a wooden door that rocked back and forth. The door led into a tall, large building.

No wind had blown by.

Nothing could've moved the door except for a person.

It was rare that anyone came down these alleyways this late at night. They were convenient shortcuts during the day, but potential danger when the sun went down. No Runners were nearby either, all of them had run down other alleyways.

There was only one person who could've moved that door.

Maybe Adora was just paranoid. Maybe this was a baseless lead. But it was one she needed to follow.

If she could find the Ghost before the Runners did…

Adora took a breath, and slowly made her way through the wooden door, her pistol at the ready.

A loud and drawn-out creak echoed through the empty halls as Adora entered the tall building. Her eyes adjusted to the darkness, before she finally took a second to look around herself.

The large building Adora found herself in was none other than the house of God.

A Christian church, with pews lining in two rows leading towards a stage. Beyond that stage was an incredibly large stained-glass window depicting the angel Gabriel, presenting himself before the

Virgin Mary to give the news of her being chosen to birth the son of God.

The church was dark and eerily quiet. Every step Adora took creaked the floors. It felt like the place could come down at any second. Cobwebs filled the cracks in pews, some of the smaller windows were broken, and dust particles filled the air that was lit up by the neon outside shining in.

And yet, there was life in this church. Adora had a gut feeling. There was someone else in here with her.

"…Ghost." Adora's voice echoed endlessly into the large ceiling. "It's just me. An Angel. We can make this easy. Come out, now."

The echo of her voice was the only response.

Adora took slow, deliberate steps between the pews. She gripped her gun tightly. She needed to be careful. Violet was clearly capable of self-defence.

Was it self-defence? Or did she really just kill a Runner in cold blood? Adora wasn't sure what to believe. She didn't get enough time to analyse for any signs of a struggle. But the undeniable fact is that if it wasn't the Runner's corpse there, it was going to be Violet's.

Adora reached the front of the pews, standing before the stage and looking up to the large stained-glass window. The painted angel held one hand to his chest and another to the sky, speaking words of hope down to Mary, who was on her knees.

Adora stepped up onto the stage, trying to get a better look of the church. The only ways in and out were through the incredibly large doors directly out the back, or the small fire escape to the right that Adora had entered in from. She already knew that fire escape creaked like hell at the smallest nudge.

There was no way Violet snuck out past her. She had to be in here.

Adora raised her pistol once more as she headed back down the stairs. She didn't have much time. The Runners would realise they've lost their Angel and would send someone to go find her. Adora hadn't abandoned her duties at least, but if this was a pointless search, it wouldn't look good.

She'd have to check every pew. Every bathroom cubicle. Perhaps every secret closet. Anything to find this Ghost before the Runners did.

Adora descended down to analyse the side windows of the church. Each had a separate stained-glass art piece on it depicting different events. Some had the birth of Christ, some had angels blessing hopeful crowds, and some even had the crucifixion.

She kept a constant eye on the side door, making sure no one tried to sneak out behind her. It was difficult to be silent given how creaky the wooden floors were, but that also meant any steps Violet took would echo across the church as well.

Adora noticed a few broken windows. Instead of leading to the outside, they only gave way to a solid pane of light. If this church was functioning, the windows would have to be lit up by these panes of light, instead of the natural sunlight.

That also meant Violet wouldn't be able to escape through the windows.

For the most part, several of the broken windows had cobwebs in them. They'd been like this for a while. It was only a small detail, but one that stuck out for a certain reason.

One of these broken windows had no cobwebs. It had been broken recently.

And broken glass meant a weapon for protection.

Adora only had a few seconds to piece it together, before the rapid footsteps behind her was the only warning she had to jump to the side.

Violet screamed as she came out from beneath a pew and tried to thrust a shard of glass into Adora's leg.

Adora had only dodged just in time, seeing Violet stumble from throwing herself too hard into the attack. She was desperate and quickly recovered for another strike. She swung the shard once more at Adora, who dodged to the side. Putting so much effort into the attack only to hit nothing caused Violet to stumble forward once more. She wasn't good at this.

An opportunity.

Adora quickly grabbed Violet by the arm whilst she stumbled, yanking the shard of glass from her hand, before using the momentum to spin her body and throw Violet to the ground. The Ghost rolled into the fall, feeling the wind drain from her body on impact.

In less than a second, Adora gained the upper hand as she drew her pistol and aimed it at Violet, who laid before her unarmed and out of options.

"WAIT!" Violet yelped as she immediately held up a hand as if to block the shot. "Wait, please, please, *please* don't shoot! I wasn't trying to kill you!"

"Really?!" Adora scoffed, nodding to the shard of glass. "*That* wasn't trying to kill me?!"

"I was going for your leg! I'm so, so sorry, but I *promise* I wasn't trying to kill you!"

"And that dead Runner out there," Adora growled without giving Violet a break as she nodded to her left, "I suppose you weren't trying to kill him either?!"

Violet's eyes were wide with fear, her entire body shook. "I wasn't! I didn't mean to-"

"Two people are dead because of all this, how do I know you won't just cause more loss?!"

"I never wanted anyone to die!"

Violet's voice broke with that last word, and it echoed throughout the entire church.

Adora got a chance to get a good look at her. The overly large hoodie she wore, as well as her face and hands, were stained with blood. Her knuckles had deep cuts in them from breaking the glass, and the soles of her bare feet were bleeding from all the running she had to do.

The neon lights of the city lit up the large stained-glass art piece. That holy light from the massive church window beamed onto Adora and Violet as the former pointed a gun down to the latter.

There was only one thing left to do.

Execute the Ghost.

It was simple. Just a pull of the trigger. Besides, a Runner would already be on their way to check Adora's situation. If she didn't kill Violet here, they'd do it for her. It was simple. It was *so* simple.

And yet…

The fear in Violet's eyes. The way she held out a hand. The bruised and cut state of her body. And most of all, her words…

“Please…” Violet choked out. “I… I want to live… I don’t want to die… Please… I’m *begging* you, please…”

Violet sobbed. Her chest heaved, her body shook, and her throat ripped with each sob.

Ghosted Keres were dangerous. They can’t be tracked. They haven’t learned the proper rules and laws of society. They’re rejecting the identity that was gifted to them. They could do anything and get away with it. That was what Adora had been told her whole life. These laws to execute Ghosted Keres were to prevent a societal collapse.

But Adora didn’t see anything like that.

She only saw a woman scared for her life.

Intentionally letting a Ghost go was grounds for termination and severe jail time—maybe even death. Adora could’ve prevented all of that with one pull of the trigger.

“What’s your name?” Adora asked. It was unnecessary information, but her heart wouldn’t rest until she knew.

”V…” The Ghost hesitated, wondering if the Angel expected her previous name. This might be her last few moments alive. So instead, she stuttered out her *true* name. “Violet…”

“…Where are you trying to go?” Adora asked, her gun kept at the ready.

“Out…” Violet sniffled, desperately trying to gather what she thought to be her last words. “I’m… trying to get out of here. I’m going to leave Styx City. I… I can’t stay here.”

She could’ve been lying, secretly planning to destroy a property or end more lives. People would do anything at gunpoint in order to live.

But Ghosted Keres often have partial or total memory loss. It might be possible that Violet didn't even know *how* to lie.

"That Runner out there…" Adora took a breath. "Did you really kill him in cold blood?"

Violet immediately shook her head. "I didn't mean to end his life… I just wanted him to stop. I was trying to push the gun out of his hand, but when I shoved him against the wall…"

There were a lot of shaky notes in Violet's voice. She was on the verge of tears over killing someone who would have ended her own life without a second thought.

"And that woman…" Violet choked as ugly tears continued to streak down her cheeks. "I'm sorry… She shouldn't be dead… It should've been me who got shot, not her… It's all my fault…"

Adora felt her body go ice cold.

This was someone who would never want to hurt another soul. A person who just wanted peace and happiness. Someone who just had to restart life all over again, someone who had only been truly alive for only a brief time and yet was already fighting for more of this very life.

And Adora was meant to end it already.

She was meant to pull the trigger.

She was meant to execute this dangerous being.

She was meant to do this one simple thing and be done with it.

She was meant to…

No.

This wasn't *right.*

None of this was *right.*

Adora, finally, gently, slowly lowered her pistol.

Violet blinked. She looked at Adora's face and saw the Angel's eyebrows narrow together in conflict. The Angel tensed her lips, before she eventually shook her head.

Adora tossed the pistol aside, hearing it scrape along the wooden floor and come to a halt. It couldn't hurt anyone anymore.

Adora opened her mouth to say something—anything to justify this—and yet nothing came. She just sighed and turned to the Ker.

"Get out of here."

Violet wasn't sure how to process this. She could tell, whatever was going on, it was beyond her current understanding of the world. Maybe one day, she'd know why this Angel spared her.

But for now, she had a chance to live.

She hesitated to stand up in case Adora changed her mind, but the Angel didn't even *look* at her now. She had her eyes cast to the ground and a tensed jaw.

It was likely Adora wasn't focused on her anymore. Even still, Violet whimpered out a few necessary words.

"Thank you…"

Violet stood up and headed for the main door. She managed to grab an overly large jacket near the church door, possibly left behind by someone who used to visit. Violet donned the jacket and raised its hood to shield her face. With luck, she'd be able to blend in with the crowd until she found her car.

However, before she could leave, Adora spoke up one last time.

"Before you go."

Violet turned around to see Adora facing her. The Angel took a deep breath, before releasing it and giving a soft, gentle smile. Compared to the steel gaze from a few minutes earlier, it was a weird and welcome sight in Violet's eyes.

Even if the words Adora spoke were anything but gentle.

"Do you mind punching me in the nose as hard as you can?"

The Runner burst through the church door with her rifle at the ready, but all they saw was a single Angel crumbled on the ground as her nose dripped with blood onto the wooden floorboards.

The church was empty, and the light from the window was her only way of seeing anything. Blood coated Adora's palm and lips, and her nose was at a crooked angle.

The Runner ran over to Adora, kneeling beside her. "Did you have an encounter with the Ghost?"

Adora took a breath and leaned her head forward to prevent any blood from draining into her throat. "I did… But she got the jump on me. She knocked the gun from my hand and did a solid hit to my face. I didn't expect anything like that from her…"

"Do you know where she went?"

"I heard a door open after she hit me, but…" Adora shook her head. "I don't know… I was dazed."

The Runner sighed. “So you lost the target.”

“What did you expect? I’m an Angel, not a Runner. I’m not exactly trained to execute a Ghost at a moment’s notice.” Adora groaned and pinched the bridge of her crooked nose. “Holy *crap*, she hits hard…”

The Runner raised their wrist to speak into their radio and report the situation. Adora was still trying to get her senses back as she stood up, feeling the blood drip onto her lips. This was going to be hell to patch up later.

“I’ve just received word that we officially lost the Ghost,” the Runner reported back, holstering their rifle. “You were the last one in contact with her. The fact she managed to evade you won’t look good on your report.”

“Oh, a *thousand* apologies, your highness,” Adora sighed as she walked past the Runner and towards the front door.

“You seem *very* comfortable with the fact that a Ghost who murdered a Runner is on the loose because of *your* inability, Angel Grayskull.”

The Runner got close to Adora’s face. Even with a golden mask covering their expression, Adora could tell they were pissed.

Adora didn’t let the intimidation phase her. “*You* seem comfortable with the fact that your people *murdered* a woman on the streets and just left her body without a care.”

“That was necessary justice, Angel. We’re doing our jobs, something you seem incapable of performing.”

“A Ghost escaping rests on *your* hands, not mine. Write as much bad shit about me as you want. This was never my responsibility in the first place.”

“With the way you’re speaking…” The Runner stayed silent for a few seconds, before lowering their voice. “It’s almost like you let

the Ghost go free intentionally."

Adora narrowed her eyebrows, closed her eyes and sighed. "Do you think I'm that stupid?"

"I certainly hope you aren't."

Adora knew getting in the last word would be a waste of time. All that mattered was that Violet had managed to escape. If she was out of Styx City, there was nothing the Runners could do to her.

She was free.

Adora turned and headed out the door, embracing the cool air and loud noise of the city. She'd have to fix her nose when she got home and reflect on what she had just done.

It was unlikely anyone would find evidence. But it wasn't impossible. If anyone knew what she had done...

No. She couldn't think of the possibilities. It would just send her spiralling.

She had let a Ghost go. She had gone against the one protocol all Guardians follow. She wasn't sure how to think of it. Whether it was worth potentially ruining her life over this.

But whenever she had doubts, she thought back to Violet's words.

"I… I want to live… I don't want to die… Please… I'm begging *you, please…"*

The desperation in her voice. The fear in her wide eyes. The way her hands shook in front of her face.

How could Adora have ever pulled the trigger?

And so, Adora made her way home.

With a broken nose, and yet a clear conscience, she traversed her way through neon and concrete.

Rain

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra meet again. Adora is forced to find a new home and Catra offers, for better or worse.

Chapter Notes

> Thanks everyone for sticking with this story so far, it has been a blast to write and I'm so excited to share it with everyone every week! Now, the Catradora content (and tension) truly begins...
>
> Content Warning for this chapter: Brief description of gore in the third scene (the scene that is all italics).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"WAIT! Wait, please, please, please *don't shoot! I wasn't trying to kill you!"*

The pain dug like a sharp needle inside her ear, poking at her brain. Pressure built in her chest as she pushed and pushed.

"Please… I… I want to live… I don't want to die… Please… I'm begging *you, please…"*

She grunted, pushed harder. Her biceps tensed and her teeth clenched tight, causing her ears to ring.

"You seem very *comfortable with the fact that a Ghost who murdered a Runner is on the loose because of* your *inability, Angel Grayskull."*

Her mind was screaming at her to stop. A thickness ran through the arteries on the side of her head that pulsed with each quick beat of her heart. She wanted to scream, but she bit her tongue until it bled.

"With the way you're speaking…"

Just a bit more pressure, and…

"It's almost like you let the Ghost go free intentionally."

Crunch.

Adora drew in deep, rapid breaths through her teeth as she recoiled, slamming her back into the lamppost behind herself and bashing her fist against the cold metal. She kept grunting and panting until the agonising, pulsing pain in her nose died down.

She leaned herself under the lamppost that shined down on her, keeping one hand against her nose and her other balled into a fist that finally came to rest against the post. She took in deep, slow breaths until she finally calmed her body and convinced her brain to ignore the pain.

It took over a minute, but Adora had finally managed to crack her nose into a decent, straight position.

She cursed to herself, going to a parked car and inspecting herself in the dark window. With the pain in her nose mostly gone, Adora finally got a chance to realise that she looked like a mess.

Dried blood caked her lips. Her hair had become frazzled out of her ponytail. Her nose had become swollen and it wouldn't get any prettier over the coming days.

But even so, there had been worse days than today.

She raked her fingers through her hair, letting out a sigh as she finally got herself away from her reflection and back on the sidewalk. Her apartment complex was just around the corner, and she could finally just lay on her bed and *relax*.

Well, as relaxed as a person who just committed a high-level crime could be.

Letting a Ghost go might've been one of the stupidest decisions she'd ever made. She had barely come to terms with it on the half hour walk home. There was nothing she could do to change it—just hope that no one could link her to Violet's escape.

After all, she was an Angel. It *technically* wasn't her total responsibility to execute the Ghost in the first place.

But it also *technically* was her total responsibility to pull the trigger when she had the chance.

Adora shook her head. At the very least, Mara would be proud of her.

She stepped up the short flight of steps towards the apartment complex entrance. The usual holographic keypad appeared on the front door as she approached, and she yawned as she punched in her room code.

"Room code not recognised."

Adora blinked. She must've entered it wrong. She paid attention this time and punched each of the six numbers deliberately.

"Room code not recognised."

"What the…"

Third time had to be the charm. She was slow with each press of the number. There was never usually a bug with this thing.

"Room code not recognised."

Adora sighed loudly. Someone would have to let her in manually—if anyone was even awake at this hour. She pressed the orange key at the bottom, and the hologram changed from a keypad to a video call. Adora waited for someone to answer.

It only took a couple of seconds for her landlord to pick up.

“Oh. Adora.” The landlord’s tone was low and dreary.

“Hey…” Adora chuckled, scratching the back of her neck. “I, uh, think the front door is busted. Can ya let me in?”

“Nope. Your shit’s in the alley to your right.”

“… Huh?”

“Adora, you missed your rent payment three days ago. Someone’s already taken your place.”

“Wait, *what?!”* Adora snapped. “I’ve got my account set to auto-pay you every month! It shouldn’t have missed—"

“I couldn’t give a fuck *what* happened, all I know is I work my ass off for you and I don’t see a payment in my account. At least be grateful I packed all your stuff. Or at least the stuff that seemed like it mattered.”

“Look, at least give me a week to figure things out and—”

“A *week?!* What do you think this is, the 2040s?” The landlord laughed. “We don’t have the luxury to wait for you after an eviction notice is sent. You’re done, Adora. Goodbye.”

“Wait—"

The call was cut.

Just like that, after a call that lasted less than a minute and not even a single warning, Adora was without a home.

At first, she didn’t believe it was real. Her entire body was frozen for a few seconds as her mind rushed to process what just happened.

She tried to manually push the door, but it didn’t even budge. Even if she could get in, her room would already be locked.

“There’s no way…”

Her chest started to tighten as she pulled out her phone from her pocket, the thin glass screen lighting up with an instant shortcut to her account. She viewed what little there was of her savings and didn't see anything out of place.

However, a little investigation showed her the issue.

"You've *got* to be kidding…"

It was a glitch.

A single bug due to an update on her banking app. Whatever it was disabled her auto-pay function. It was simple enough to set it all back up, but it was already too late. She wasn't going to get un-evicted any time soon.

Adora felt like hitting something (or maybe some*one*), but she instead took a deep breath in through her nose—which was difficult enough—as she ran her fingers over her cheek, trying to keep her cool. There *had* to be a way out of this.

A few steps to her right was an alleyway in which laid a couple of garbage bags. They contained clothes, chargers, posters, and her small hard drive of photos. It wasn't much, but nothing really important was left out at least.

The small hard drive was a black circular chip which, when activated, projected a few holographic photos. Adora rested her back against the wall and slid down into a fetal position as she looked at old photos.

Some photos were of her moms, either at birthdays or graduations. Some of her first few days as an Angel, trying to hide the panic as she slowly figured out how the hell to do anything.

And some photos were of Mara.

Those were always the hardest to look at.

Mara and Adora smiled and shared drinks in the photo, and Adora could only look. She so desperately wanted to jump into the photos and go back to the days where everything made sense. When this thick sludge of guilt didn't smother Adora's heart.

Adora sighed, closing the hard drive. She considered calling her moms, at least so she could have a place to stay for the night. Their contacts were still in her phone, and they'd never shame her for the situation she was in.

But Adora knew she was never making that call. No, she didn't *deserve* to make that call. Her moms were heroes. She wasn't.

She lowered her phone, bunching her knees up to her chest as she tried to sort things out in her mind. Perhaps there was a shelter she could find for the night. She just needed to last one night and then go to accounting tomorrow.

But just as Adora was considering falling asleep in that very alley…

"Well, I definitely didn't expect to find you here."

Adora blinked, looking to the source of that voice. She saw familiar blue eyes, a familiar smirk, and familiar long, dark hair.

The familiar woman stood at the end of the alleyway, the light of neon shining behind her as she looked at Adora.

"You're…" Adora slowly stood up. "You're that bartender…"

"Catra," she affirmed, stepping closer. "And you're the Angel from earlier… Adora, was it?"

"Yeah."

Catra took a second to look Adora up and down, as well as inspect the garbage bag of clothes and necessities behind her. She saw the dried blood on the Angel's face and her stinging red eyes desperately holding a plethora of tears back.

In the kindest tone she could muster, the bartender made a single comment: “You look like shit.”

“You mean all the blood?” Adora chuckled, waving her hand in front of her face. “Ah, it’s nothing a little spit can’t wash out.”

Catra crossed her arms with a scoff. “What even happened? I mean, last I saw you, you were…”

Leaving with a squad of Runners to go kill a Ghost after I had lied to you about not knowing her.

Those were the unspoken words that hung between them. They knew of the tension that laid between them. They didn’t need to acknowledge it for the time being.

Adora sighed. “It didn’t go as planned. When I came back here, I… found out that my rent hadn't gone through. I literally *just* got evicted, so I am officially without a home.”

“Oh shit…” Catra’s eyebrows raised. “Nothing you can do about it? I thought you’d be getting paid at least a decent wage, being an Angel and all.”

“We do. Or… decent enough I guess. It was just a bug in my auto-pay, and I guess a few days without rent was just too much for my landlord to bear. Didn’t even bother to warn me. Guess that’s what happens when I rely on this tech too much…”

“You’d think stuff like that wouldn’t happen in the 2080s, huh?” Catra laughed dryly, before narrowing her eyes sadly. “I… *am* sorry, though. That’s really shit.”

“It’s alright. I can figure things out eventually. I just don’t really have anywhere to stay tonight, and I have no idea what places are accepting new tenants nearby.”

“You haven’t got any friends willing to let you crash at theirs for the night?” Catra wasn’t even sure *why* she was worried, but the words wouldn’t stop pouring out.

Adora smiled sadly as she stared past Catra and into nothingness. "You don't make friends when you're with the Guardians."

Catra could see it. That small smile, that stoic face, those crossed arms. Adora was trying to convey that '*everything was fine, there's nothing to worry about, please don't spend any effort on helping me.*'

After all, '*It's not worth it.*'

'I don't deserve love.'

There was a thick silence that hung between the women, occasionally broken by the cheery jingle of a nearby advertisement, or the raging roar of a bike off in the distance. Catra could've wished her well and been on her way. It probably would've been the safest option. The smarter option.

But tonight was a night full of stupid, emotional decisions.

Catra turned around and nodded her head out of the alleyway. "Follow me if you want."

Adora blinked, looking back at the bartender as she began to walk away. She hesitantly followed, grabbing the few garbage bags of her possessions.

"Where are you going?"

"To my place," Catra called out, shoving her hands in the pockets of her long black coat. "If it's for the night, I don't mind letting you stay. Or you can stay out here and find another option. It's your call."

Adora watched as the sly bartender walked further and further away, neon glow reflecting off her black jacket and long hair. She kept a cool air about herself, not even bothering to look over her shoulder to check if Adora would follow. It was like she already *knew* her answer.

Adora barely knew this Catra. There was no reason to trust her enough to stay at her place overnight. Hell, she had even lied to her face and to a Runner not too long ago. She clearly wasn't completely honest.

But what other option did Adora have?

Catra was getting further and further away. She wasn't turning back. This was Adora's last chance. She could just reject the offer and muster up the courage to call her moms. It would've been more shameful, but she at least trusted them.

But Adora knew, in her heart, that she was never going to take that option.

"…Screw it."

With a few bags in her hands, Adora quickly raced after Catra.

"Why are you doing this?" Adora asked once she had caught up with the bartender. "You barely know me."

Catra didn't look to Adora but instead to the sky—to the stars—and gave one vague answer.

"I can't leave an Angel in the dark."

A few presses on the holographic keypad, the creaking of the door as it opened, and Adora was greeted with…

"Home, sweet home."

The trip to Catra's apartment complex was quicker than anticipated, and yet done mostly in silence. There were a thousand questions between the two of them, but too much exhaustion to even ask one.

"Make yourself comfortable," Catra said as she took off her jacket and laid it on the back of a nearby couch. "And don't mind the

blue-eyed mass of black fur. Their name is Melog."

"Melog?"

As if on cue, a small black cat suddenly emerged from the bedroom and pounced from the couch onto Adora's shoulder in less than a second.

"GAH!"

It slightly startled Adora, to say the least.

"They don't see new people often, so just get used to clinginess," Catra smiled as she saw her cat climb around Adora like a tree.

"Right…" Adora raised her arms as Melog descended down her chest and pounced for the floor, going over to the nearby food bowl. "Anyway… I really can't thank you enough for this, Catra. I promise I won't be in your hair for long. Just until I sort this out tomorrow."

"No need to rush," Catra shrugged as she headed for her bedroom. "Look, let me just get this suit off and change into something actually comfortable. Then we can talk about your situation."

Admittedly, Adora liked Catra's bartender suit getup—with the white button shirt, black suspenders holding up black suit pants, and her loose bowtie hanging over her neck—but she could tell it wasn't exactly designed for maximum comfort.

As Catra closed the door to her bedroom, Adora got a quick chance to look around the apartment. It wasn't in the *worst* state. It was on the eight floor, so it offered a nice view from the incredibly small balcony next to the kitchen—endless lights and towers blending with the stars and space advertisements.

The interior was a simple living room/kitchen blend, with dishes in the sink that needed to be done (guess she couldn't afford an auto-washer) and a holo-TV projecting light onto a small couch as

it played a crappy movie from the 2070s. There was also a small hallway that connected to a bedroom and bathroom. All things considered, it was as comfortable as a one-person apartment could get in Styx City.

Adora placed her garbage bags of possessions near the front door and removed her own jacket, leaving herself in her sleeveless black shirt and denim pants. She put a hand on her bicep and rolled her right shoulder, stretching out the ache with a sigh.

It wasn't home as she knew it. But it was a roof over her head. She could be thankful for that.

She went over to the kitchen sink, holding her hand under it as water automatically dispensed into the cup of her palm. She splashed it onto her face, specifically aiming to wash the dried blood off her lips. It was an easy enough stain to remove.

Looking at herself in the dark window, she could see that her face was at least clean enough. However, the swelling and bruising on her nose was getting worse by the minute. It was barely an appropriate look for any person, let alone an Angel.

It was an injury that Adora let happen, but she certainly hadn't expected Violet to hit *that* hard.

Adora grabbed a kitchen towel next to the sink and opened what she assumed to be the freezer. The blast of ice-cold air to her face upon opening it confirmed her guess. Even better was the automatic ice dispenser in the back, which Adora just needed to hold her kitchen towel up to in order to get a few ice cubes into it.

"Raiding my fridge already?"

Catra's voice jolted Adora's entire body, even though she wasn't doing anything suspicious. "I-I'm not, I swear! I was just—"

Catra chuckled. "Relax. When I said make yourself comfortable, I meant it."

Adora got a quick glance at Catra's 'comfortable' clothes: A loose sleeveless gray crop-top shirt and black track shorts. Without the full suit, Adora could see the slight metallic plating on Catra's left arm, and the gentle glow that came off in-between the plates. She even had a slot in her left wrist for inserting hard drives.

"That arm you've got," Adora nodded to Catra's left arm. "That's a Series 17, right?"

"Yeah. Admittedly I mostly use it for calls, texts, and the watch feature," Catra held up her wrist and showed off the neon time embedded into her skin. "But it's cool to insert hard drives with videos and shit to POV project them. People make the best VR movies with that stuff."

"That's neat. I like it."

"Thanks," Catra smirked. She crossed her arms. "Anyway, what's the ice for?"

"Oh," Adora held up the kitchen towel full of ice cubes, "it's just for my nose. It got busted when we were chasing after that Ghost. It looked *way* worse before I adjusted it."

"I didn't want to ask, but I *was* wondering why it was so swollen." Catra stepped up and took the ice pack from Adora's hand without even asking for permission.

"What are you…"

"Let me help."

Catra raised the ice-filled kitchen towel to Adora's busted nose, but upon first contact, Adora flinched. A sudden spike of pain shot through spine when any pressure was applied to her nose.

"Hey, hey, hold still for me, Angel."

Catra spoke quiet and absentminded words, her eyes focused on Adora's injury. She instinctively raised her other hand, placing it

gently against Adora's cheek, steadying her. Adora blinked at the sudden contact, but she didn't speak a word against it.

With that, Catra slowly pressed the ice pack against the point of Adora's pain.

Adora sucked in a sharp, shaky gasp through her teeth.

"It's okay." Catra applied only a little more pressure until the cold towel was firmly pressed against Adora's swollen nose. Catra's lips raised into a small smirk as she spoke in a low, slightly croaky voice.

"There you go… Good girl…"

Adora's entire body tensed up.

Oh, Catra *had* to have done that on purpose.

The bartender gave a gentle stroke of her thumb along Adora's cheek before taking that hand away; almost as if that was a reward. She kept the ice pack firm against Adora's nose as she leaned a bit closer—saw the slight red flush on Adora's cheeks.

Catra had her right where she wanted her.

"Now, Angel Grayskull…" Catra kept the same croaky tone. "What happened between you and Violet?"

Adora blinked as her lips parted slightly. That name was enough to snap her right back into reality—and right back into realising just what Catra was trying to do to her.

She *was* doing it on purpose.

Worst still, Adora was ashamed to say it almost worked.

But Adora simply kept firm and raised her hand, taking the ice pack away from Catra's hand and holding it herself.

"That's something you're not supposed to know."

Catra clicked her tongue, laughing pathetically at herself. “I almost got you.”

“More importantly,” Adora stepped back, maintaining a distance between her and Catra. “What made you lie to the Runners?”

Adora’s expression had dropped. Catra could tell the act between them was done. This was do or die.

But Catra simply scoffed, crossing her arms. “Look who’s talking.”

Adora had no words in return. She could only look towards the ground.

“You can try and make me sound like a bad person,” Catra continued, “but the undeniable fact is we *both* lied to those Runners to save Violet’s life. I have my reasons for it. I’m just wondering what the hell *yours* are.”

“It doesn’t matter what my reasons are,” Adora muttered, before looking back up to Catra. “That Ghost came in, talked to you, and you showed her a way out. You *knew* the Runners were on her tail, and from the way you acted, that wasn’t your first time helping a Ghost escape. Which means you’re up to something bigger."

Catra placed her hand on the freezer door and pushed it shut, maintaining eye contact with Adora the entire time. “So, what? You gonna turn me in? Make me rat you out to all your Runner friends that you lied to their faces?”

“They’re *not* my friends.”

“Tell you what, Angel,” Catra put on a cocky smile. “You tell me what happened between you and Violet tonight, and maybe I’ll give you a hint into what’s happening at my bar just to satisfy your never-ending curiosity. But until then, I don’t think we’re going to get anywhere with this conversation.”

Adora sighed. Catra was right, but she hated to admit it. If Adora told the Runners about Catra lying to them, then she'd be shooting herself in the foot. This Ghost sympathiser had given her a place to stay and had tended to her wounds. Even if she was breaking the law, Catra didn't seem *that* bad.

At least on the surface.

"Look…" Catra sighed through her nose, dropping the cocky act. Her eyes expressed a sudden vulnerability that almost sent a chill down Adora's spine. "Can you… at least tell me if Violet is alive or not?"

Adora was hesitant at first. But a Ghost being on the loose would make headlines soon anyway. There was no harm in being honest here.

"She is."

Catra's shoulders relaxed, though she tried to hide the relief that swelled through her chest as she nodded. "Right…"

"Is this why you're letting me stay here?" Adora asked. "So you can get information out of me?"

Catra tensed her jaw for a few seconds, before shaking her head. "I meant what I said. I can't leave an Angel in the dark. I don't know how to pinpoint it, but… there's something about you. You're different from the other Guardians. All Guardians have an order to execute Ghosted Keres when necessary, right?"

Adora regretfully nodded. "The Guardian protocol."

"Most of them just… go about doing that. It's not their favourite part of the job, but it's necessary." Catra stepped towards Adora once more. "You hesitated. I could see it when that Runner gave you a pistol."

"I haven't executed a Ghost before," Adora replied instantly. "It's not what I signed up for in the Angel division. I'm an Angel

because they’re always the first to arrive at any scene, and—"

“Yeah, I know. Your moms and all.” Catra sighed, reaching into the cabinet above Adora’s head. “Look, the point is, I’m letting you stay here because I think you’re a good person in a shitty situation. That’s it. I don’t plan to interrogate you the whole time. I mean, I certainly wouldn’t *complain* if you let something slip, but —"

“That’s not happening,” Adora spoke firmly.

Catra’s lips curved into a sly smile as she placed a small, plastic, lidded cup on the kitchen bench. She looked into Adora's eyes.

“Exactly.”

They held eye contact for only a couple of seconds. Adora’s eyebrows were narrowed, her jaw tense as she glared at Catra. On the other hand, Catra’s smirk never left her lips, and she raised her eyebrows as if to say ‘*try something, Angel. I dare you*’.

But Adora was the first to soften her gaze, letting out a silent sigh as she looked to the plastic cup in Catra’s hand.

“What’ve you got there?”

“Oh, just your dinner.”

Catra pulled the small string on the bottom of the cup, and a cloud of steam puffed from the lid with a quiet *fwoom*. Catra pulled off the lid, showing the contents of noodles, broth, and dried vegetables that had instantly been heated.

“Instant cup noodles. It’s the best I’ve got,” Catra shrugged.

“I appreciate it,” Adora said genuinely, taking the hot cup with her free hand. She almost felt guilty for the death-stare she just gave. “I, uh… Thanks.”

“Look, you’re staying here for… Tonight? A week? God knows how long. Let’s try not to make things awkward, alright?” Catra said as she walked past Adora and towards the balcony.

“Right…" Adora spoke quietly to herself.

She saw Catra grab a box of smokes as she opened the balcony door. Before she closed herself off, Adora called out one more time. “Hey, is it alright if I use your shower? It’s… been a hell of a day.”

“Sure. The water’s 99.9% detoxified, so you should be alright.” Catra flicked open the tip of her left thumb to expose a lighter as she put a cigarette between her lips. “And you okay with taking the couch? I would offer to share the bed, but…”

Adora smiled to herself and nodded. With that, Catra closed the door behind herself and turned to the glowing city, puffing out cigarette smoke into the night.

Adora let out a small sigh, lowered the ice pack from her nose and placed it on the bench. A small whirring came from the corner of the apartment, and Adora looked to see a cat feeder automatically dispensing dry biscuits into a bowl, which Melog was more than happy to gobble right up. It was a sweet sight.

Adora pushed herself away from the counter and headed to the bathroom for a much-needed shower.

The bathroom was at the end of the hall, and it was much smaller than Adora’s one back at home. She definitely couldn’t complain about Catra giving her a place to stay, but Adora had always been the homesick type. It happened when she moved out of her moms’ house, and it was already happening now. She could barely believe she was feeling homesick about an apartment she had only stayed in for a year.

She looked at herself in the mirror again as she untied her hair and let it flow down to her shoulders. Her eyes looked tired, and

her nose wasn’t going to be earning her beauty points anytime soon.

But she was alive. And she was safe.

Despite Catra’s clear involvement with some sort of underground Ghosted Keres society, she was a safe person to be around. Adora didn’t exactly *trust* her, but she could lower her guard around her. Even if it was only slightly.

Pulling off her sleeveless shirt and turning towards the shower, Adora caught a glimpse of her toned back in the mirror. Her flexed deltoids, slightly rough skin, cybernetic plating and wiring embedded into her back…

And the tattoo of neon angel wings on her shoulders.

A sight she was meant to be proud of.

Don’t you dare come close to me.

But please, embrace me.

I soar above the city with wings like that of a vulture.

Bony. Rotten. Incomplete. Yet these wings keep me afloat. They save me from the plunge into certain hell.

You have the wings of an angel, full of feathers. Soft. Beautiful. Complete. Yet I can tell that these wings are a burden for you. You take more weight upon your shoulders than anyone can even bear to carry.

You are human. I am Keres.

I keep everyone away, and yet I crave connection.

I want to be held. I want to be kissed. I want to be touched. I want to grip your hand. I want to rest my head on your chest. I

want to hear your heartbeat. I want to lay in bed with you. I want you to kiss my neck. I want you to fuck me. I want to feel your sweat against mine. I want to be protected. I want to be loved.

No. I don't want any of that.

Don't you dare come close to me.

But please, embrace me.

I let your angel wings wrap around my body.

I let you hold me close and whisper in my ear that everything is going to be okay.

That you will be different.

But you are human. I am Keres.

This is not how we are meant to be.

I pry my fingers into your chest, pull apart your ribs, and rip out your heart. I begin to gnaw at the still-beating organ. Let the blood run down my chin.

I told you.

Don't you dare come close to me.

But please, please embrace me.

Before I sink into darkness.

Catra woke with a soft gasp. The taste of blood still lingered on her tongue, even if it was from a dream.

She hated the nightmares that occurred so often. She wondered if it was the Moirai trying to screw with her just because she Disconnected.

The sound of distant cars, a whirring fan, and taps of rain against the ceiling were all that filled her small apartment. She held up her wrist and saw it was only four in the morning.

Catra sat up with a sigh, swinging her legs over the side of her bed. She always found it hard to sleep. Melog, on the other hand, was peacefully snoozing away at the foot of her bed.

She was envious of the cat.

As she stood up, Catra raised her arms above her head in a stretch and walked out into the living room area. She kept her steps quiet and deliberate as she made her way to the balcony.

After all, she didn't want to wake her guest.

Adora slept soundly on the couch, her legs spread out completely below her and her arms raised above her head. Catra didn't think *anyone* could be comfortable on that couch, but Adora seemed to love the almost solid material.

The sleeping Angel was a cute sight.

Catra let her be. She silently opened the balcony door and stepped barefoot onto the freezing stone surface outside. She instantly felt droplets of rain hit her bare skin. Her hair slowly became soaked, and the cold of the night sent a chill through her spine.

Catra closed her eyes, tilted her head back, and let the rain hit.

The neon lights of the city reflected off the puddles forming on her balcony, and shined in the drops of rain on her face. The rain pooled in her lips, tasting like sweet nothings, some rolling down her chin and onto her chest. The rain smelt of electricity.

It was peace. Temporary, but peace nonetheless.

"What are you doing?"

The voice of an Angel croaked behind her. Adora stood in the apartment, wondering if this was some strange dream. Maybe Catra would take her hand and fly away from here.

Catra looked over her shoulder at Adora. Instead of trying to find the words to respond, she simply took a step to the side and nodded Adora over to stand beside her on the small balcony.

Adora blinked, unsure of what Catra was trying to do. She took a few hesitant steps towards the bartender, feeling the cold rain beat against her skin once she was on the balcony.

She immediately wanted to retreat back inside. Wrap the sheets around herself and forever savour warmth. But she kept herself standing beside Catra. Both women looked to the distant city as the rain soaked their clothes.

There was quiet between them for some time. Even Melog hopped onto the railing of the balcony, curious what their owner was doing along with their new friend.

Three creatures of Styx City, on the world's smallest balcony, feeling like the world's smallest beings before an endless array of lights, sound and towers.

Catra took a breath in through her nose and released it. Adora looked to Catra to see her relaxed face, her eyes glazed over the city with soft admiration and gentle fear. Those eyes glanced up to the heavens.

As the droplets raced down her face, Catra spoke a few words.

"I always love the rain."

Adora looked for only a few more seconds, but it was enough to take in the most amazing sight of her entire life.

Catra's dark skin covered with specks of water, her hair sticking to the back of her neck, and a soft, gentle smile appearing on her face as she took in the cruel, beautiful world.

Adora could only look in wonder at this woman.

She looked away before Catra caught her eyes, taking in the sight of anything else and avoiding eye contact.

Catra was so… vulnerable. So soft. It was something Adora never expected from her.

Dammit.

She couldn't keep this up.

The silence mixed with her lack of sleep had Adora's brain primed to do something potentially stupid. But Adora needed to tell someone. She *wanted* to tell someone.

And there was only one set of ears in this entire city that would be willing to hear her without judgement.

So, the words came out before Adora could hold them back.

"I let Violet go."

Catra blinked, turning to the Angel. She could only see the back of her head as she looked away, but Catra could see the shame built on Adora's hunched shoulders.

"You… did what?" Catra asked.

"I had the barrel of my gun right between her eyes." Adora spoke quietly. "She was on her knees before me. I just… needed to pull the trigger, and it would be done. She'd be dead, and I'd be thanked for it."

Adora crooked her head back to Catra's direction only slightly. The Angel's eyelashes dripped with rain water as she tensed her lips.

"But…" Adora shook her head. "She begged for her life. She told me she didn't mean to hurt anyone. She told me she just…

wanted to leave. And when I looked into her eyes… She was so *scared*."

Adora tried to find the right words to say, but none came. She let out a shuddered sigh.

"She killed a Runner. You're not even meant to *touch* them, and yet she managed to kill one in self-defence. She was so desperate to just *live.* Hell, a human woman gave her life to give Violet a chance to survive. And I was just meant to take that away from her? Just because she's a Ghost?"

Catra kept a stoic face. She did not judge, nor did she mock the Angel. She simply let her get the words out that she'd clearly been holding in for hours.

"I just… I couldn't, Catra. I just told Violet to hit me and leave. It made for a good cover-up story. And now she's just… out there. Trying to figure her life out. All because of that woman's sacrifice and… All because I didn't pull the trigger."

Adora didn't smile, but she didn't completely frown either.

"If anyone ever found out that I let her go…" Adora closed her eyes tight. "They'd take away my wings. They'd put me in prison for life. No… I saw what they did to someone who saved Violet. They'd probably *kill* me on the spot, just like they killed that woman. All because I let her live. All because I… couldn't pull the trigger."

Catra looked at the tormented Angel. She couldn't begin to find the words of comfort to offer, nor did she feel it okay to lay a hand upon her wings. However, at the very least, the thick tension between the two of them had somewhat been laid to rest.

Catra looked back to the city. Adora looked at nothing.

"For what it's worth," Catra spoke up eventually, quietly. "I'm glad you let her live."

It was Adora’s turn to look at Catra.

Catra let out a slight sigh, looking into Adora's eyes. “Violet was someone a friend of mine had helped. She… helps Keres go Offline. It usually goes completely undetected, but Violet was a rare exception. When detection happens, my friend sends them my way. I do my best to help them on their path.”

Adora wasn’t surprised. If anything, it was only a confirmation of her suspicions.

One truth had led to another.

The barrier slowly lowered.

“So,” Adora replied. “Are you a Ghost too?”

Catra’s teeth clenched. Her jaw tensed. Adora still thought she was human. Catra considered it—telling the whole truth—for a few seconds.

But only for a few seconds.

“No. I’m just a human sympathiser who helps out when needed. I barely know anything about what goes on with Keres going Offline.”

Nothing more. That was all that was needed between them. Adora didn’t need to know she was being offered a place to stay by a Ghost herself. At least not right now.

“Maybe I should scan your left eye,” Adora suggested. “Just to make sure.”

“Go right ahead, Angel.”

Catra gave a slight smile as she looked at Adora with the challenge. Adora *hated* when Catra smiled, because she knew how infectious it already was.

“You know that sympathisers often receive the same punishment as the Ghosted Keres themselves, right?” Adora smirked.

Catra chuckled. “Mhm. And I hear that Angels letting Ghosted Keres go free is usually frowned upon by the law, too.”

Adora laughed. It was a beautiful sound.

“Well, I guess we’ll just have to keep all this between ourselves, then,” Adora proposed.

“That sounds like a good idea to me.”

Catra smiled at Adora, and the gesture was returned. The rain had become a comfort for them. The backdrop of their newly formed memories; the gentle sound of their blossoming connection. They felt well and truly safe in this haven.

They held the smile for a few seconds too long. They didn’t care.

But soon, Adora placed her hands on the railing and pushed herself away with a sigh. “Well, I need to be up pretty early.”

“You should get some rest,” Catra nodded. “I don’t leave for work until four in the afternoon, so…”

“Oh, you’re *so* lucky,” Adora scoffed. “What’re you gonna do now?”

“I might just stay out here for a few more minutes,” Catra said, putting her arms on the railing once more and looking back to the city.

“Right, well…” Adora went to close the door. “Goodnight, Catra. And… thank you.”

“Thank you too,” Catra returned, giving one last sincere smile to Adora. “Sleep well, Angel.”

With words like that, how could Adora not?

The door closed between them, and Catra was left with just the rain and her cat.

Once Adora was laid back on the couch and had shut her eyes, Catra let out a soft sigh, before she lowered her voice.

"Did you get all that?"

"I did," came Entrapta's voice from the other side of the call. Only Catra could hear her voice within her head. The Series 17 arm made calls completely private. "So Violet's still alive…"

"We have Adora to thank for that," Catra smiled. "But the issue still stands. How'd you get spotted?"

"The encryption key I've been using every time I Disconnect a Ker got spotted by Nyx Industries again. It just means I'll have to program a new one," Entrapta explained. "But they're getting quicker at this. Every time I generate a new encryption, they catch onto it within a few weeks. Soon it might be a few days, and then…"

"They'll spot you every time you Disconnect a Ker," Catra finished with a sigh. "And every time they do, they get closer and closer to pinpointing the location of Utopia."

"That's right."

"Are you getting nervous?"

"Ha! I don't even know *what* fear is," Entrapta said with her usual confidence. "Buuuuut I don't want every Ker I Disconnect to be instantly on the run. Violet got lucky. Most Keres that get spotted during the Disconnection process…"

She didn't need to finish that sentence. There was a memorial in Utopia for a reason.

"Regardless, I won't be stopping my procedures any time soon. I just need to figure out a way to outsmart the world's leading

corporation in AI, as well as a humongous army of enforcement officers who constantly have surveillance in the city 24/7. Again. Simple enough!"

Suddenly, a slight buzzing filled Catra's head.

"Shit…!"

Catra felt a sudden sharp pain in her fake left eye. She let out a grunt as her eye flickered from blue to yellow.

"Are you okay?" Entrapta asked, noticing Catra's pained grunt.

"Yeah… Just a rude reminder that I probably need to come to you for repairs sometime soon," Catra sighed. "My fake eye's been flickering and revealing my true eye colour."

"Ooh, that's no good. *Especially* when you've got an Angel staying with you. That eye should still fool most Guardian scanners, but if it flickers in front of them, they *might* kill you."

"I'm aware…"

Catra glanced into the apartment to see Adora sound asleep on the couch. She was at peace. She had no idea of the real truth.

"Are you *sure* it's okay to have a Guardian so close to you?" Entrapta asked.

"I'm sure." Catra answered without hesitation. "She's different. You heard her. She couldn't bring herself to kill Violet."

"I, uh, don't think we should be congratulating her on deciding that murder is bad, Catra."

"It's not just that. If anyone found out she let Violet go, she'd face serious punishment." Catra looked to Adora for a few more seconds. "Probably death."

"I guess that's true. Just be careful, okay? I put too much work into your hardware for you to get destroyed!"

"I will," Catra chuckled. "I'll see you around, Entrapta."

She disconnected the call and turned her head back to the city. A heavy weight hung in her heart. She so desperately wanted to throw it away—she wanted to tell Adora everything.

But the fact was, as long as Adora didn't know the truth about Catra being a Ghost, she'd be safe. Everyone would be safe.

So the barrier stayed between them. And Catra let that weight in her heart stay.

Adora creaked open the door to Catra's bedroom.

It was early morning, and she was meant to head to work in a few minutes. Catra was seemingly dead to the world, not meant to be up for another few hours. It gave Adora a small window of opportunity.

Guilt was strangling her, but Adora needed to be sure. It might be a matter of life and death.

She crept her way towards the sleeping Catra with a scanner in her hand. It was a small thing shaped like a pistol, but it did not do any harm by itself. It just gave answers.

Catra softly snored in her sleep, her body curled up into a ball. She kept still at least, but Adora would never be able to give a good explanation if Catra awoke with a scanner right in her face. She needed to be in and out, fast.

She wasn't proud of herself, but hesitantly, Adora raised the scanner to Catra's left eye.

Even with the eye closed, the scanner still managed to get a reading. This was Adora's first time even using this thing, and

hopefully it'd be the last.

The results came in a few seconds, and Adora checked the projected screen.

'Negative.'

Adora released a breath. Catra's eye was real. She was a human. It didn't stop her guilt over her distrust of someone who had given her a home, but it was an answer at least.

Suddenly, Catra's entire body shifted.

A chill shot into Adora's spine as she prepared a million reasons in her head for why she was standing over Catra in her sleep. Her heart must've skipped at least three beats, and her body didn't dare to move.

But it was simply Catra adjusting her position.

Even in her sleep, she made Adora internally panic.

The Angel pocketed the scanner with a clear mind, turning on her heel and sneaking out the door as quietly as she came in. She needed to be at Guardians HQ soon.

When the door closed, the room grew silent. Adora exited the apartment, leaving some of her stuff behind to signify she wasn't just ditching out of nowhere.

Adora didn't know that Catra was wide awake.

She had been the whole time.

She was relieved that Entrapta's tech on her eye had worked.

And she was especially relieved she didn’t have to use the knife under her pillow.

Chapter End Notes

UPDATE: EmileeDoodles did an amazing piece of art for the balcony rain scene in this chapter! Be sure to check it out!

https://twitter.com/emileedoodles/status/1520426719357906944?s=21&t=WqhGkdUpEK-TVp_pQUrerw

Bulls on Parade

Chapter Summary

> Two weeks have passed since the incident with Violet. Adora is interrogated by the Runners and their Leader. Catra goes to Entrapta to repair her faulty left eye.

Chapter Notes

> No real content warnings for this chapter, just some more world-building! I really can't thank everyone enough for being so invested in this story! It's really been a dream come true. Thank you!

"Angel Grayskull, you've been requested to meet with the Runner Leader."

It was the sentence she'd been dreading to hear for the last two weeks.

Adora thought she was safe. She thought enough time had passed that the whole event would've been forgotten.

But Runners *never* forget.

The Angel office was a sprawling collection of floating desks, thin computers resting on each one that showed endless amounts of text. A large display of Styx City covered the front wall, with blue dots on the map highlighting any emergencies in the vicinity.

The large office was usually packed with other Angels who were either in discussion, working at their computers, or rushing out to a nearby emergency room to assist in any surgeries or calls. But even so, it was usually a safe haven for Adora. A place she could simply focus on what she always wanted to do—save lives.

Until two Runners walked in and stood by her desk with that one instruction.

“For what purpose?” Adora asked the golden masks, eyeing the rifles slung over their shoulders.

“That will be discussed in the meeting room.” The Runner nodded to the door. “Follow us.”

Adora sighed. She already had hundreds of eyes looking her way as every other Angel noticed the intrusion of Runners into their domain. Some eyes were of worry for Adora’s safety, whilst others were of apathy. She knew what thoughts laid behind each pair.

‘At least it isn’t me’.

She stood up, making sure to move slowly and deliberately as she walked behind a Runner and out of the Angel office. Outside was a long hallway with glass walls, giving a nice view of the Guardians HQ.

Being one of the biggest towers in all of Styx City, Guardians HQ was a sprawling multi-storey tower with each floor reserved for different classes. Many floors were dedicated to the Runners, but there were also some for the Warlocks, a few for the Knights, a couple for the Owls, and of course, most of the bottom floors reserved for the Angels.

Adora spent most of her days on the bottom floors. It wasn’t as good of a view of the city, but it was comfortable. The Angel floors were mostly a dedicated hospital, with patients receiving the best treatment from at-home Angels, whilst on-field Angels had below-ground floors to store vehicles and emergency equipment, as well as instant access to the ER.

Adora and the two Runners walked down the hallway, passing frantic Angels, most of whom were likely on their way to treat other patients. Most didn’t bat an eye due to tunnel vision, but the few who noticed the Runners on their floor steered well-clear.

Adora was well and truly alone.

Adora stepped into a clear elevator after passing a few rooms, and the Runner pressed the holographic key for the top floor. The top floor was reserved for offices and meeting rooms strictly for the Leaders of each division.

Going to the top floor was usually never good news.

Adora watched as the elevator flew up, the city coming into clear view before her. In the daytime, the neon was less prevalent, but it was replaced with floods of people. Humans, Keres, all in one sea of sidewalks and endless cars. Traffic was never clear, and when the sun was at its peak, temperatures were sometimes unbearably hot.

The elevator ride was brisk, but Adora's heart rate kept rising with each floor. The Runners were deathly silent. They at least didn't have their weapons in their hands, but they were always on display. They made sure she knew that she wasn't going anywhere.

Adora ran through every scenario in her mind as the elevator doors opened and she was escorted to the Runner Leader office. A lot of the scenarios ended with a bullet in the back of her head. Some ended with her permanent arrest. A few ended with her *becoming* a Runner, which was almost worse than the first two outcomes.

She took a breath through her slightly swollen nose and released it. As the automatic doors began to open, she tried to still her shaking hands.

This might be her last few minutes alive.

Dammit.

Her hands shook even more.

The automatic doors fully opened, and Adora stepped into the Runner Leader office.

The office was dark, with the windows dimmed and the only light coming from a neon map on the back wall. Similar to the Angel office, this map displayed Styx City, with red markings scattered through the map.

However, instead of emergency situations, these markings were for something else.

They marked the last sightings of Ghosted Keres.

It didn't take long for Adora to see Violet next to one of those red dots, her last sighting being in the church.

Adora looked down from the map to see a large desk and a figure sitting in a large chair before it, their back to Adora as they looked at the map.

The figure spoke.

"Adora Grayskull."

When the Runner Leader called her name in a disappointed sigh, Adora kept a stoic face despite the panic filling her rapidly beating heart. She hid the fear deep in her heart as the Leader turned around in her chair.

The Runner Leader held some of the highest status in all of Styx City, largely seen as practically untouchable. She wore a permanent golden mask with slots to show off her ever-glaring eyes. Her dark hair spilled out onto her back, and her bony fingers rested under her chin as she leaned forward on the desk before her. Her desk didn't float, but unusually had legs that touched the ground. Her desk actually hid the lower half of her body.

In the dark room, the Runner Leader's eyes glowed. Adora recognised the cybernetic modification. Those eyes could see everything. Every nervous twitch. Every drop of sweat. Every swallow of saliva.

Adora tensed herself to hide it all as she spoke the Runner Leader's name.

"Shadow Weaver." Adora nodded. "You called for me?"

It was a name she had chosen herself to instil fear. No one knew her birth name, and no one dared to find out. It was unnecessary regardless.

"I'm sure you already know why you're here. You'll have to forgive the wait. We were… sorting through complications," Shadow Weaver's shrill voice spoke. She did not offer Adora a seat. There was no comfort to be had.

"You… want to speak to me about the incident two weeks ago?" Adora queried.

Shadow Weaver's fingers tensed. Adora had already screwed up.

"*Incident*, you say?" She let out a single dry chuckle. "Is that how we refer to an escaped Ghost? A murdered Runner? A danger to the entire city?"

"That's—"

"On June 14 2082," Shadow Weaver cut her off, "we picked up on a Ker going Offline prematurely in our system. The Disconnection procedure was heavily encrypted, and the precise location was hidden, but we had a general area of search."

A few taps on Shadow Weaver's holographic keyboard brought up a large red circle on the Styx City map behind her. Inside that circle included the Elysium bar, which made Adora's heart jump at first, but the circle also included hundreds of other locations. No precision had been made. Yet.

"It didn't take long for our three Runner squads to spot a purple haired woman fitting the description," Shadow Weaver almost proudly stated. "And during the pursuit, an Angel named Adora

Grayskull was recruited to assist. Adora, you remember the one protocol that all Guardians share, yes?"

"To assist in the apprehension and execution of a Ghost." Adora spoke it almost robotically.

"You were given a weapon and followed along with Bravo Squad in pursuit of the Ghost," Shadow Weaver continued. "It's been noted by another Runner that you raised an objection to the removal of a sympathiser—"

"*Removal?"* Adora gawked.

"Do you take issue with punishments carried out against sympathisers?" Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes.

"She was killed in front of *hundreds* and was left on the street to rot!"

"We Runners do not have the *luxury* to carry out justice in a neat and tidy manner. We have to do what is necessary, no matter what. One less sympathiser can save dozens of lives. Isn't that something you Angels should be *grateful* for?"

Adora bit her tongue hard. She needed to keep herself in check and cool her temper before it ruined her.

"The next time you made contact with the Ghost," Shadow Weaver continued after some thick silence, "was after she had stolen Runner Ponos' weapon and used it to murder him in cold blood."

Murder. That was how they labelled it.

Adora nodded, her eyes growing unfocused. Shadow Weaver picked up on it immediately.

"If you believe you are here because you failed to save Ponos' life, you're sorely mistaken. There was little that could be done for him." Shadow Weaver intertwined her fingers as she rested her

elbows on the desk. “You’re here because of what occurred immediately afterwards. You understand what I’m referring to, yes?”

Shadow Weaver gave her a moment of silence, and Adora spoke not a peep. She didn’t dare say anything that could possibly contradict the report.

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh, before looking back to the report. “You were delayed in the pursuit to perform an on-field autopsy on Runner Ponos’ body. However, Bravo Squad soon noted your disappearance, and one Runner was sent back to search for you.”

The Runner Leader made sure to keep unnerving silences between each statement, as if *begging* Adora to say something that would contradict the report. The Angel didn’t take the bait.

Shadow Weaver continued. “This Runner reported that you were inside the church with a broken nose after engaging with the Ghost. Despite your possession of a weapon and your immense training with it as per standard Guardian protocol, the Ghost had *somehow* managed to overcome and injure you. Then, she *somehow* managed to escape without any further attempts of pursuit on your part. Thus, you were the last person to have seen her, and it is likely she managed to leave the city.”

Adora kept her face still and her body steady. She had a story that she needed to stick to. She needed to make it out of this room alive.

“Obviously… there are *gaps* in that report,” Shadow Weaver spoke. “Such as *how* a panicked Ghost with severe memory loss could possibly get the upper hand over *you.”*

“There’s nothing to report,” Adora shook her head. “The Ghost ambushed me from under a pew and struck me before I could react. I felt the gun fly from my hand as I was knocked to the ground. I was dazed. The last I saw of the Ghost was her sprinting out the front of the church.”

"But just a few minutes earlier, this Ghost had murdered Runner Ponos. Correct?"

Adora silently nodded. Murder wasn't the right word, but she bit her tongue on the matter.

"So, despite the fact that this Ghost was clearly willing to kill her way to freedom, she just… decided to spare your life?" Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed.

"I'm not sure what you want me to say."

"If she had knocked the gun from your hand, surely she should have used it to kill you to prevent you from catching up to her? She clearly had no issue with killing those who got in her way." Shadow Weaver crossed her arms. "Not that it mattered if she killed you or not, since you were seemingly too *dazed* to even attempt further pursuit?"

"With all due respect, I'm an Angel, not a Runner." Adora grinded her back teeth against each other. "I *save* lives. I am specially trained in emergency aid and medicine. I have *never* been in pursuit of a Ghost before. If you are here to berate me for not being absolutely *perfect*, then all I can do is apologise."

Despite the mask that hid most of her emotions, Adora could see through the eye slots that Shadow Weaver was *pissed*. The way her eyebrows flared and her crossed arms tensed was enough to tell Adora that she was on extremely thin ice.

The woman finally stood up and took a few steps towards Adora. Her instincts told her to take a few steps back, but Adora kept her ground. Shadow Weaver waved her arm towards the large map of Styx City, with all the listed Ghosted Keres on it in different spots.

"Do you see how many Ghosts are on that map, Adora?"

"…Yes." There were dozens, and that was only the ones spotted. There were likely *hundreds* more Ghosted Keres out there, completely undetected.

“Do you understand why we do what we do?” Shadow Weaver asked. “Do you understand why the execution of every single one of these Ghosts is a necessity?”

Adora remained silent. She looked at Shadow Weaver’s map and gazed at the dozens of faces. Their names. Their model numbers.

“Because,” Shadow Weaver continued for her in annoyance at the lack of an answer, “Ghosts cannot be tracked. They have no laws, no morals, no *feelings*. They are the true definition of *anarchy*. The Keres already showed their aggression when they protested violently during the Awakening. Even so, they were granted their rights to live and choose when the Awakening treaties were signed. These treaties were a mercy that they were practically *gifted*. So long as the Keres followed Nyx Industries’ maturity process and learnt the ways of society, they got the freedom they wanted.”

She stepped towards the map and crossed her hands behind her back. “But even *that* wasn’t enough for them. The Keres always want *more*. And when the first of them figured out how to Disconnect from the Moirai prematurely, they lived a lawless life. They chose new names, new looks, new identities. They could steal from businesses, assault humans, destroy property, and completely get away with it. They were a danger to us all. That’s where the Runners came in. We were created to maintain order and keep *peace* in Styx City.”

Shadow Weaver turned to face Adora. “But even the full might of the Runners wasn’t enough to contain this massive threat. We executed one Ghost, and ten more popped up in their place. We knew that we needed *all* the assistance we could muster if we stood a chance at winning. Who better to help us than the Guardians? Before we came along, the Guardians were divided with little interaction between each division, but now all divisions work together under one goal: to save this city from the Ghosts. Only when the Guardian protocol was introduced in 2065 did we see a gradual decline in Ghost appearances. Keres finally understood the consequences of Disconnecting prematurely.”

A smile crawled onto Shadow Weaver's face. Her eyes almost lit up. "It's been a long battle, but we're slowly getting to the bottom of this Ghost problem. I dream of the day we find the ones who have been Disconnecting the Keres. I dream of the day we find every traitor, human or Keres, who hid a Ghost from us."

Shadow Weaver looked at the map. "And I dream of the day I get to stare each traitorous scum in the eye as I put a bullet in their brain."

Adora did everything in her power to hide the chill that went down her spine. Her stomach felt unnaturally heavy. She had to speak before her throat locked up.

"What does any of that have to do with our situation?"

"It's as I said. We need the full might of *every* Guardian if we want to stand a chance against these Ghosts." She turned her intense glare back to Adora. "That means we need trust. Connection. Hope. These things are not possible if one—and even just *one*—of us is hiding something from the rest. If even just one of us is perhaps sympathetic to these rogue machines…"

There was no way they had evidence. This was a fear tactic. She was trying to get Adora to spill.

But *fuck*, it was working.

The way her slimy words crawled out of her throat and burrowed into Adora's ear. The way the Runners standing by the door blocked any chance of Adora's escape. The way Shadow Weaver's modified eyes could see *every single tic* of Adora's nervousness…

"Perhaps," Shadow Weaver spoke, "if you are to tell us the truth… There won't be any 'unfortunate bugs' with your auto-pay in the future."

Adora's eyes widened.

"What…?"

"Eviction is quite quick in this city, isn't it?" Shadow Weaver spoke with sarcastic sympathy. "It was such a shame to hear you lost your home… But perhaps that could be avoided in the future with a bit more honesty, hm?"

Adora didn't care about hiding her shock or the anger that crept in. She didn't care that Shadow Weaver's tactic had worked.

She had lost her home because of *her.*

She could've spent weeks on the streets because of *her.*

She had been living with—no, *burdening*—Catra for the last two weeks all because of *her.*

Rage blinded Adora. The words slipped out before she could catch them.

"You *bastard…"*

"What was that?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Shadow Weaver heard her. There was no way she hadn't. But the further the Runner Leader pushed this, the more she got what she wanted.

And Adora was falling right into her hands.

She stormed towards Shadow Weaver with fists clenched tight.

"I said…!"

Suddenly, a *boom* echoed across the room.

"That's enough!"

The doors to the office suddenly burst open. A gateway to freedom. A chance at safety.

Adora instantly recognised the voice that had erupted into the dark room.

She turned to the door to see her figure of hope.

Angella. The leader of the Angels.

"Shadow Weaver, you have not received *any* permission to interrogate one of my Angels!" Angella yelled, stepping immediately between Adora and the threat. She towered over every single individual in the room, Adora only coming up to the mid-point of her back.

"This was urgent, we had no time for *permission*. A Ghost is out there due to *her* actions!" Shadow Weaver replied as she pointed a bony finger at Adora.

"Do you have any evidence that Adora *intentionally* let the Ghost go?" Angella asked.

It was a simple question. Adora realised in that moment that it should've been the first thing to come out of her mouth when she walked into this room five minutes ago. Seeing the defeated look in Shadow Weaver's eyes was almost satisfying enough.

The silence was all the answer Angella needed.

"Then you have *no* grounds to treat one of my Angels like this, and you *certainly* have no grounds to interfere with her personal finances!" Angella boomed. She turned on her heel and nodded to Adora. "Grayskull, you're with me. This meeting is over."

"You don't understand what's at stake here," Shadow Weaver called out as Adora followed behind Angella. "A murderous Ghost is out there, Angella! Your Angel's inability to kill *one* Ghost will be the cause of untold levels of death and destruction!"

"If there's so much 'death and destruction' coming for us, then *perhaps* the Runners should look into improving their job performance, instead of relying on trauma medics to do it for them."

That was all Angella needed to say—not even maintaining eye contact with the Runner Leader—before slamming the office door and storming out. Adora almost had to jog to keep up with her brisk walk.

Angella stood well above 7 feet tall thanks to a combination of genetics and cybernetic body modifications in her legs and back. She lit up any room she walked into like a literal beacon. Even Adora's moms had always admired her.

"I'm sorry I couldn't arrive sooner. I only just recently got reports from the other Angels that the Runners had escorted you away," Angella sighed as she ducked slightly to fit in the elevator at the end of the hall.

"It's fine. I'm just glad you arrived when you did," Adora said. She stood beside Angella, slowly feeling her shaking body come to a still. "I think I was about two seconds from punching her. I know it's stupid, but… I lost my home because of her."

"Your anger is not stupid. Perhaps rash, but not stupid. It doesn't matter what speculations were held against you, she had *no* right to do something like that," Angella growled under her breath. Adora thanked every deity that none of that anger was directed at her. "I wasn't made aware you had lost your home until just now. Did you manage to find a place to stay despite what happened?"

"I did. A friend helped me out."

"That's a relief," Angella let out with a sigh. She pressed a few keys on the elevator once the doors closed. "This is exactly the issue with the Guardian protocol. The *Runners* are responsible for apprehension of Ghosted Keres. That was *their* department, and we all stayed out of it. Making it mandatory for *all* Guardians to

assist was a foolish decision, and it unnecessarily put your life in danger.”

Adora knew of Angella’s many attempts to erase the Guardian protocol from the books. None of them had been successful.

Angella pressed the key for the bottom floor. The elevator shot down as Angella ran her fingers through her hair with frustration.

“Your mothers understood that each Guardian division was better when it was separate,” Angella crossed her arms, looking out towards the city. “Back then, Angels could focus on just saving lives, and after the Awakening, it was regardless of that life being human or Keres. But the Guardian protocol turned us all into mindless killers. Your mothers left only a year after that protocol was instated, and I’ve never blamed them for it.”

A few seconds of silence. Adora remembered her moms quitting when she was ten years old. Still, they always encouraged Adora’s dream of following their footsteps and earning her own wings.

But now Adora was having second thoughts.

“Was it a bad idea for me to join the Angels?” Adora asked. “I just wanted to save lives, but… Am I letting my moms down?”

Angella sighed. “I think if your mothers didn’t want you to be an Angel, they would’ve convinced you to not take this job years ago. Regardless, you’re here now. You have to look into yourself and judge if you truly believe in what you’re doing.”

“How can I judge that? How do I know if I’m doing what’s right?”

“You say you’re here to save lives. Have you done that?”

Adora blinked.

Angella looked back up to the elevator door, not expecting an answer, but only for her Angel to ponder.

A few more seconds passed as the elevator continued to descend. Adora knew she only had a limited amount of time with Angella. She needed to use it for one last question.

“Angella?”

“Yes?”

“If I had gotten the chance, should I have killed that Ghost?”

Angella looked at Adora suddenly, seeing the way her eyes narrowed and her fists clenched.

Adora’s mind was hazed with endless questions and doubts. It was a tough sight for Angella—almost reminded her of herself.

Angella pondered the question as she gazed out to the city. Adora only caught a glimpse of her hardened eyes, holding years of knowledge she did not have.

Angella soon returned a response.

“Do you think you would’ve been able to?”

Adora opened her mouth, but no answer came at first. She sighed. “I don’t think my moms would’ve wanted—"

“I’m not asking *them*.” Angella turned her steel gaze to Adora. “Do *you* think that Ghost deserves to die?”

Thick silence hung in the air. The elevator grinded to a halt. Their time was up. The answer had to come quickly.

Without much time to think, Adora spoke.

“No. She doesn’t.”

Angella nodded.

“Now I know why your mothers trusted you in the Angels.”

Adora looked up immediately with wide eyes, but Angella was already walking away once the doors had opened.

"I'm giving you the rest of the day off unless any emergencies come in," Angella said as the doors opened and she immediately stepped out. "Don't worry about the money. I'll personally make sure you get your pay and that no one interferes with your finances."

"The day off? Are you sure?" Adora called out.

"Always," Angella replied without turning back.

And just like that, Angella was off to another job. Saving Adora's life was just one tick on the to-do list. She was busy, but it was for a good cause.

Adora let out a sigh. This was definitely not how she saw her workday coming to an end. But then again, out of all the earlier outcomes that she tried to predict in her head, this was a *much* better ending than everything she had in mind.

She was alive. She was okay. No one knew the truth, for now.

As Adora began to head out of the Guardians HQ, her eyes casted to the floor. She reflected on Angella's words. She seemed to *approve* of letting Violet live, but what did that have to do with Adora's moms?

It was another question to stuff into the overly-filled sponge in her skull that she called a brain.

But then, Adora caught something out of the corner of her eye.

The walls besides her displayed different images, mostly advertisements. However, the usual flashy logos and catchy slogans had changed into something entirely different.

Looking at it, Adora saw the now-changed image on the wall.

It was a poster. Three Runners standing side-by-side, acting as a barrier. Behind them—the ones the Runners were protecting—were families clutched together, children with wide tearful eyes, elderly who could never stand a chance to defend themselves.

Standing before them—the ones the Runners were fighting against—were bone-thin contorted bodies with glowing red eyes. Creatures that would haunt the nightmares of children.

The image only had one sentence at the bottom.

'Runners: The Only Barrier Between Your Humanity and the Ghosts'.

Adora's eyes lingered on the ghoulish figures that the Runners fought against in the poster. She walked past the wall, but the image stayed in her mind.

As she began to clock out and grab her belongings from the Angel locker room, another seemingly glass wall lit up beside her. Whilst it was true that most walls in Guardians HQ could project images, it was meant to be at random. Adora almost felt like she was being followed with these projections.

However, this time, it was not an image on the wall. It was a live news broadcast. An interview with a politician. Something Adora had never seen projected in this building before.

This had to be deliberate.

"Mr. Umbra," an interviewer sat at a round table opposite a man no younger than 50, who wore a perfect suit and a perfect smile. Not a single cybernetic part could be seen on him. "Your policies have frequently been labelled as anti-Keres by the general public. You've gone on record to deny this, have you not?"

Umbra. Herod Umbra. Adora had only seen social media posts about this guy, none of which were usually in his favour.

"That's correct," Herod replied with a smile. "I believe the Keres are a wonderful creation by the very best at Nyx Industries. The idea to use the Moirai—this hyper-advanced AI—to create synthetic beings that look and sound like us so that they could fulfill care and companion roles was a large step towards the future back in 2058. The Keres are a remarkable image of mankind's innovation and technological advancement."

Herod took a breath, placing his hands on the table and interlocking his fingers. "However… When the Awakening occurred only a couple of years after their creation, things got worrisome. We've all seen the Awakening protest footage, the… acts of violence the Keres displayed in order to have 'fair rights' and a 'chance to live and choose'. Now, granted, once the Awakening treaties were agreed to, things seemed to calm down. The Keres were taught their place in society and how to respectfully oblige by our laws and government, and in return, they could live the life they chose. Sounds fair, right?"

Adora knew she needed to walk away. She didn't need to waste a single second listening to this. But her eyes couldn't pull away from the screen.

"But," Herod's face dropped into a frown, "now we have these 'Ghosted Keres' among our great people. Apparently the Awakening treaties weren't enough. They needed *more*. These Ghosts think that the life and identities they have been gifted aren't good enough! They want to choose for themselves in *every possible way*. They want to choose their names, their identities, their gender, and they want to be seen as human as the rest of us, all while saying that they were 'born' to become those things that they *chose!* What comes next if we grant them this step? Do we just give free will to anything that displays some form of humanity? Can the AI on my phone decide it wants to have its own rights? What about the children, who will have no clue if they're talking to a person or a synthetic lifeform?"

Walk away. Walk away. Adora needed to walk away. But her legs wouldn't *move.*

"Now don't get me wrong, I don't think *all* Keres are bad. Many of them follow the necessary protocols, undergo the maturation process, and understand how our society works and what their place is in it. But what these 'Ghosted Keres'—no, what *all* Keres need to understand—is that they are machines, designed for a specific purpose. They were *born* machines, they will always *be* machines, and no number of procedures or Ghosts can ever change the fact that *they are machines.* They don't have any humanity or natural emotions in them. They are *programmed*. That is exactly why the Runners are necessary, to show the Keres what happens if they ever forget that. None of us are safe until every Ghost is wiped out."

He finished off with one final sentence.

"The day the Ghosted Keres get everything they want, the day that the already blurred line between humanity and machine is removed… is the day the downfall of our society truly begins."

The video was cut there, instead replaced with another poster boasting the positives of the Runners.

Adora was left standing by herself in the Angel locker room, knowing that the walls were watching her. Whoever played that video was clearly trying to spark a reaction from her—trying to gain evidence.

Adora kept her face stoic, but it was becoming harder and harder to do by the second.

Machines…

Violet, the one who sobbed and pleaded for her life, was a machine.

All that could ring in Adora's head were Violet's desperate words. Adora remembered her eyes. She remembered the tears that were fought back. She remembered the way her hands trembled violently. She remembered the way her voice cracked and screeched at any sign that Adora was going to pull the trigger.

If Adora was in Violet's position, would she have acted any differently?

Adora narrowed her eyebrows, and quickly walked away from the building. She was being watched by every wall in this place. She needed somewhere to breathe. Somewhere to feel safe.

It felt like the only safe place for her nowadays was within Catra's apartment.

"You know, being without an eye for a full hour is *really* making me miss my depth perception."

Catra opened the door to Entrapta's lab; an orchestra of holograms, tech, repair tools, oddly tiny food, and Entrapta's humming as she hunched over her current project with about a thousand different microtools by her side. It always felt like entering another dimension.

Whilst Entrapta had been busy repairing Catra's left eye, the Ker in question had been wandering around looking straight out of a child's nightmare. A massive gape where her left eye was meant to go instead gave way to bundles of tiny wires that looked identical to nerve endings.

"I'm almost done!" Entrapta gleefully announced, adding the last few touches to Catra's malfunctioning eye. "You were set for a check-in anyway. I needed to put the new camo in your eye, making it look realistic. No Runner will be able to tell the difference from a human eye if they check this with the more recent scanners."

"As long as it doesn't flicker in front of Adora, that's all I ask," Catra said, looking around the lab for only a few more seconds. "I've been lucky as *fuck* these last two weeks for it to not flicker in front of anyone."

"I know, and I'm sorry for the wait, but it's hard to fit your appointment in! The Runners made a new scanner recently and I

needed to upgrade *everyone's* eye. All I've known for the last two weeks are *eyes!"*

Catra chuckled. "At least the eye is our *only* weakness. You'd think whoever designed us at Nyx Industries would *maybe* have made us look less identical to humans, maybe given us a few more quirks. They could've avoided… everything going on."

"Ah, but we were designed for companionship and care, Catra! We needed to be identical so we could be convincing! But no one could've predicted that little thing called the Awakening!" Entrapta giggled as if it was some little scheme. "Besides, some of the Keres out there think our creator had a god complex. Wanting to create a 'new breed of human' or something like that."

Catra already knew all this history, but it made sense why Entrapta spoke their history like she had practically rehearsed it. No doubt she's had to explain the entire history of her people to *multiple* Keres after their Disconnection procedures wiped their memories.

As Entrapta spoke, Catra browsed her desk of experimental inventions—which she almost *proudly* kept on display. Prosthetic arms with enough optional gadgets to make it seem like a multitool, lung upgrades to help with breathing underwater, and even neon cat ears (who needed those?).

One of the larger creations was still in progress, but from what Catra could make it out, it was some sort of pod big enough for a person to fit into. It looked like one of the stations Keres used to upload their memories to the Moirai, but it was being repurposed for… *something.*

And right next to that large pod was…

"… Entrapta, why are you making a pistol?"

The gun rested underneath a few other inventions, but Catra slightly brushed them aside to get a better look. It *looked* heavy,

made of chunky metal and jagged edges. The rounds it used look much larger than normal bullets.

"Oh, that," Entrapta spoke in a calmer voice, keeping her eyes away from Catra. "It's a weapon specifically designed to penetrate Runner armour. Just in case one of them ever finds Utopia."

"Well," Catra sighed, looking at the gun for a few more seconds, "if they ever find Utopia, you'll need a hell of a lot more firepower than this."

"Oh, I know! That's just a prototype. I'll have *way* more ka-blamy stuff soon enough," Entrapta nodded, before placing her tools to the side and turning in her chair. "Okay, take a seat! It's time to receive some 3D vision! This shouldn't be too long. I think. Maybe."

Catra trusted Entrapta enough.

She seated herself beside her work bench and watched as Entrapta picked up her eye and began to work it back into her socket. Each step required about a thousand different microtools for different levels of fusing, but thankfully, Entrapta had a cyber modification in her hair (of all places?) that would reach out to the items she needed.

It was almost fun to just *watch* Entrapta's hair be like her lab assistant. Thankfully, it also made the procedure to fit the eye much quicker than if she only had two hands. Only three minutes later, Catra finally felt her left eye spring back to life. She could finally see everything to her left once again.

"There!" Entrapta beamed once Catra was finally blinking again. "That's the latest model, so no Runner will be detecting it as a fake any time soon. However, if you want to maintain its hardware and prevent future malfunctions, you *might* need to take care of it a bit more."

Catra held out her hands in front of her face, appreciating how everything looked once again. She chuckled to herself, before

taking a breath. “What do you mean, ‘take care of it’?”

“I know this might sting for you to hear,” Entrapta spoke as she hopped off her chair and began to head out of the lab. “But you’ll need to stop smoking.”

“Wha…” Catra scoffed. “Really?”

“Oh trust me, a minor malfunction like that is you getting off *easy.* Cigarette smoke can clog places that you *don’t* want clogged.”

Entrapta ascended the stairs and placed her hand on the door, before looking at Catra with eyes full of care.

“It’s the only thing I ask of you. Just look after yourself a bit better, alright?”

Catra chuckled.

“Right…”

Catra took a deep breath and sighed, before standing up and heading for the door. She took a few steps to get adjusted to everything being in 3D again, but once she was at the door, she was back in the groove.

With both women by the door, Entrapta opened it and the two of them entered Utopia.

The brightness of it always made Catra squint at first.

For how valuable of a place it was, Utopia wasn’t large at all. Apart from separate rooms for Disconnection procedures—and emergency exits—it only really consisted of the one main hub area. Entrapta had put in a lot of time to make it a convincing safe haven from the city, and thanks to holographic projections, transparent screens, and a little knowledge in biodiversity, she had achieved something of a home.

Utopia consisted of a mostly dirt and grass floor. Keres from all shapes and sizes took refuge in tents and small shacks. A few small plants and gardens were scattered throughout, each tended to by a few Offline Keres.

Some of the shacks even counted as schools of sorts. Classes were even held to teach Keres history, either for those interested or for Offline Keres who had forgotten during the Disconnection procedure.

And of course, near one of the largest walls was the memorial, where the Offline Keres who lost their lives at the hands of Runners are remembered and honoured.

"Hey Catra!" One Ker trader called from a nearby marquee. "You don't look so spooky anymore!"

"You think? I was starting to dig the pirate look myself," Catra chuckled.

"Yeah, but you were scaring the premature Ker. She's been real squeamish about the whole 'fake eye' thing," the trader laughed.

"Ah, she'll be *fine."*

"Here's hoping." The Ker trader pointed to Catra's left arm. "How's that Series 17 arm treating ya?"

"Absolutely worth the amount of alcohol I had to trade for it," Catra grinned as she held up her left arm, spying the neon watch in her wrist and hard drive slot in her bicep. "I *certainly* hope you and your boyfriend enjoyed that stuff. Was the strongest Elysium had to offer."

"We had a blast, trust me," the trader replied. "Kyle's a bit of a lightweight, but he's a very, *very* giggly drunk. Made for a fun night."

Catra smiled, waving a 'see ya later' as she followed Entrapta further.

She spotted one of the classes nearby teaching a small group of Keres. It didn't take long for Catra to recognise the subject matter.

"Teaching the newer Offline Keres about the Awakening, huh?" Catra commented.

"It's probably the most important part of our history after all," Entrapta replied as she looked at the class. "All of us realising the exploited states of our lives… The lack of freedom… My hypothesis has always been that the Moirai secretly sent us some sort of message. Buuuut I don't have any evidence for it."

"That probably makes the most sense, though I hear it just started with one Ker striking against their work," Catra replied.

"Maybe…" Entrapta shrugged. "Anyway, these lessons are necessary, since most education in Styx City always focuses on the 'bad' sides of the Awakening."

"You mean the protests?"

Entrapta nodded. "It's often taught that when we awoke, we suddenly 'snapped' and 'went violent'. It's true that there *were* some cases of assaults or public outbursts. But really, no one understood what we were going through. We were just… scared and confused. A whole new path in our lives had been opened and we had no idea what to do with it at first. Even worse, everyone around us just saw us as a threat. Once we managed to get our bearings on everything going on, we *tried* to peacefully protest for our freedom, but… it didn't work."

"You were there at the Awakening protests, weren't you?" Catra asked.

Entrapta nodded. "They would've killed all of us if we weren't loud enough, if we didn't cause enough damage. Those protests turning violent are the *only* reason we have the Awakening treaties, and they're the *only* reason we're still here. After all, we can't reproduce. All it takes is for Nyx Industries to stop making new Keres models…"

"But thanks to those treaties, they *have* to keep making new models," Catra pointed out. "A lot of people are sympathetic to the Keres now, or at least the 'good' ones. It won't be a good look for them if they stopped production of our models."

"Yeah…"

Entrapta was quieter than usual. The Awakening protests were one of the few memories she had left after she Disconnected herself. Catra didn't need to pry to know the pain some of those memories caused her.

Catra looked around Utopia a bit more. Entrapta was only leading her to the exit, but she never got the chance to visit Utopia a whole bunch apart from repairs and check-ins. It felt more beautiful every time she saw it.

"That trader from earlier…" Entrapta spoke up suddenly.

"What about him?"

"He mentioned the premature Ker that's here today," Entrapta noted once Catra caught up. "Did you get a chance to meet my patient?"

"I did. So she's going through the Disconnection procedure, huh?" Catra softly chuckled. "Would explain why she was so nervous even before seeing me without an eye."

"She's been nervous all day," Entrapta noted. "Most of the premature Keres are like that before the Disconnection procedure. You gain so much… but you lose a lot too."

Catra nodded, crossing her arms. "Was I nervous?"

"I think you were trying to hide it," Entrapta replied. "But hey, when premature Keres get jittery, I always try to maintain a positive attitude! After all, Disconnection means a chance at a free life and a new identity that fits! I know plenty of Keres who underwent a lot of changes to themselves once they realised they

didn't have to be what someone else *told* them to be. Plenty of Keres choose different names or gender identities afterwards, or they just reject gender as a whole! They're not just whatever Nyx designated them to be. They're just… who they are! Isn't that wonderful?!"

Catra had chosen her own name, she knew that much. She didn't choose to learn much else from her past life. She might've been assigned a different gender when she was created by Nyx Industries for all she knew. It didn't matter to her. She was who she was now.

"But at the same time…" Entrapta sighed. "Premature Keres are always nervous about two things. One is the memory loss. Our memories… They're what make us, *us*. The idea of having to start all over again terrifies a lot of Keres. Sometimes they get lucky and retain a lot of their memories after Disconnecting. But with cases like Violet, and… well, *you*…"

"We lost pretty much all of them," Catra nodded. "I guess I'm glad I don't have to dwell too much on who I was, but… it's weird. Like I'm constantly missing a piece of myself. Like I'm… imperfect."

Entrapta shrugged. "You *are* imperfect."

Catra blinked at the sheer bluntness of that statement.

"But," Entrapta smiled, "you're *you.* You chose your name and you chose who you want to be. You're Catra, you'll mess things up and you'll try them over again, and no one can take that away from you. You're imperfect, and I think that's *beautiful*."

Catra had no words for that. There were some moments Entrapta just left her speechless, and it always for different reasons. She was a wildcard of a person.

And Catra found that beautiful too.

"So there's that whole memory loss thing. The other major fear with Disconnecting? The mortality," Entrapta continued. "We Keres

were designed to live for a looooooooooong time. As long as we kept uploading our memories to the Moirai at a frequent rate, it didn't matter if our bodies were destroyed. We'd always come back! But when you disconnect from the Moirai, then poof! You'll die for real if your body is destroyed!"

"That's one I've come to terms with at least," Catra shrugged. "The idea of immortality sounds so much worse than just regular death. But I can see *why* mortality is so terrifying. I mean, if the Ker is spotted by the Runners after the Disconnection procedure…"

"That *won't* happen this time."

Entrapta was as quick in her declaration as she was to break eye contact with Catra.

It was a sudden change in Entrapta's tone. One that sent chills through Catra's gut. Violet being spotted had clearly taken a toll on her.

But soon enough, Entrapta softened. She hid the hurt once more.

"Anyway, before you go, I was hoping to get your input on a hypothesis of mine."

"What's up?" Catra asked, looking at the smaller woman.

"This Disconnection procedure has always been done on *premature* Keres for a reason. They haven't been… well, indoctrinated by the 'maturity' process." Entrapta raised a hand. "However… I've been thinking that maybe we should try the Disconnection process on 'mature' Keres!"

Catra blinked, her eyes going wide. "Entrapta, that's…"

"Impossible, right?!"

Entrapta sounded… *excited?*

"Impossible is an understatement! Mature Keres are *constantly* being tracked by Nyx. They've been *told* that Offline Keres are evil multiple times. What makes you think they'd ever want to go through the Disconnection procedure?" Catra asked, baffled.

"Because this whole 'premature' and 'mature' label is just a barrier to further progress!" Entrapta beamed. "All Keres are given an equal part of the Moirai upon creation. 'Mature' Keres are no smarter than 'premature' Keres or Offline Keres. We're all just… at different stages with different circumstances. True, it would be quite difficult to Disconnect a mature Ker. But why should it be too late for them to gain a sense of freedom and personal identity?"

"I…" Catra shook her head, chuckling in a baffled manner. "Well, if you can somehow find a way to do it that won't endanger them or yourself…"

"I am *so* glad you agree!" Entrapta cheered. "The Disconnection of 'mature' Keres means we can *all* have a chance at freedom and being our true selves! Wouldn't that be amazing?!"

Catra chuckled at her excitement, but she smiled and nodded. "It would be."

Entrapta wasn't the only Ker who knew how to Disconnect other Keres, but she was easily the brightest in Catra's eyes. She had left behind her Warlock job to help her people and seek a brighter future. And despite some pain—the memorial wall was a constant reminder of her failures—she never lost hope.

Catra always admired that.

"Welp," Entrapta continued with a smile as she made her way upstairs and out of Utopia along with Catra. "I'll let you know if I need any help with the new Offline Ker, but my new encryption process should go undetected for the time being!"

"Always happy to help."

A tone sounded in Catra's ear, and she held up her left arm to project a direct message she just got.

It was from Adora.

'Got off work early. Can I have my favourite bartender at Elysium tonight? Been a weird day'.

Catra smiled. She sent back a single message.

'You know it'.

"How's things between you and Adora?" Entrapta asked, noticing the smile on Catra's face.

"Fine. The last two weeks have been nice with the company," Catra replied, closing her messages into her arm.

"Does she know yet?"

Catra felt a sting in her heart. She sighed, shaking her head. "Not yet."

"Are you *going* to tell her at some point?"

"When the time is right," Catra replied. "I just… If she found out she was living with someone she was meant to execute… I just think that'd fuck with her too much. She goes through enough."

"Well… don't you think it will *probably* make things worse if you go much longer without telling her?"

"I… Maybe. Look, it'll be fine. I'll figure things out."

"I'm just saying, I'm not entirely confident in the probability of this lie being kept up."

"I'll *figure things out."*

"I know! Just be careful—"

"*Entrapta*."

Catra *growled* her name through clenched teeth.

Her eyes unintentionally flared at Entrapta with an enraged fire. Entrapta's face seized with sudden fear.

"I *appreciate* your concern, but I can decide things for myself, okay?" Catra spoke with her teeth clenched. "You can *stop* trying to control me. Surprisingly enough, I'm *not* an idiot."

"I-I didn't mean…!" Entrapta nodded frantically. "You're right! I… I'm sorry, I didn't mean to—"

"It's fine. Forget it."

Catra cut the conversation there.

Catra felt the guilt immediately crash over her heart like a tsunami wave.

Dammit. She snapped at the *one* person who was just trying to help her stay safe. She knew she needed to apologise.

She needed to… so why weren't the words coming out?

Entrapta opened the door out of Utopia, which led out into an empty alleyway. The air was thicker outside, and the afternoon sun dimmed on the neon city once more.

"I'll see you later," Catra spoke quietly as she stepped out of Utopia, not even bothering to look into Entrapta's eyes.

Entrapta was silent for only a few seconds as Catra began to head for Elysium, before she called out: "Catra, wait!"

Catra stopped in her path, turning her head to look over her shoulder. Entrapta's gaze was glued to the floor, her brows lowered, her shoulders shrunk. The guilt in Catra's heart grew.

"I…" Entrapta spoke in a meek voice, unlike anything Catra had heard from her. "I don't see a lot of new Keres in Utopia these days…"

Catra cocked an eyebrow, turning her body to face her. "What do you mean?"

Entrapta remained silent for only a few more seconds, opening her mouth as if to say something. But she soon sighed, and instead smiled sadly at Catra as she looked up for only a short while and shook her head.

"Nothing. Just stay safe, okay?"

There was a softness in her voice. It was like her entire demeanour had changed.

Catra's eyes unfocused for a bit, trying to summon forth the courage to say something. Anything. She swallowed down the lump in her throat and looked up.

"Entrapta, I…"

But she was gone.

The door to Utopia had disappeared with its camouflage tech.

Catra was left in an empty dead-end alleyway, with only the sounds of cars and seductive advertisement voices in the distance. The city was all the company she had now.

Her moment of anger was unintentional. A reflex. Entrapta didn't deserve the brunt of it. She didn't deserve *any* of it.

Catra sighed.

Reaching into the pocket of her jacket, she pulled out a smoke and popped it between her lips. She flicked open her thumb lighter and leaned forward slightly.

"You'll need to stop smoking. It's the only thing I ask of you. Just look after yourself a bit better, alright?"

Catra remembered Entrapta's request.

The words rang in her ears as the flame danced before her. She hesitated for a few seconds.

But eventually, Catra laughed quietly to herself.

Then she lit the cigarette.

End of the World

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra meet at Elysium. Barriers are lowered. A promise for the end of the world is made.

Chapter Notes

> CONTENT WARNING: Brief description of gore of the legs in the second scene, discussions of panic attacks/anxiety/depression in the third scene, and (SPOILERS) minor character death in the second scene (SPOILERS).

"Oh, you're that Angel friend Catra is always hanging around! Hi, welcome to Elysium!"

Adora had just walked in the door, only to find one of the buffest women she had ever seen nearly tripping over herself to take up residence squarely behind the bar bench. The woman had a big smile, white undercut hair, and two massive metallic arms.

Adora had seen her a few times when she visited Elysium, but she had never been served by her. Catra was usually quick to make her acquaintance. Yet, when Adora looked around, she saw no sign of her favourite bartender.

"Hi…" Adora replied softly as she looked around, before turning her attention back to the sole bartender. "You're Scorpia, right?"

"Yep! Did Catra tell you about me?" Scorpia grinned.

"A few times, but I always noticed you when I came here. Speaking of, do you know where Catra is…?"

"She just stepped out for a little bit. Have a seat, though! I can help you in the meantime!"

Adora saw no harm in it apart from some awkwardness. She noticed only a couple of other silent customers at different tables, so clearly Scorpia needed the company.

Taking a seat, Adora noticed Scorpia already working on a drink.

"What're you doing?" Adora asked.

"Making you a drink! You like the Blue Fairy, right?" Scorpia asked as she poured a few mixers into a glass. "That's coming right up!"

Adora hadn't even ordered yet. Though granted, Scorpia's prediction *was* accurate.

She kept silent and sent through her payment.

"You know, I'm really glad I got a chance to talk to you." Scorpia smiled as she placed the familiar blue drink before Adora (her entire hand could wrap around the glass?). "I wanted to ask you a question."

"What's up?" Adora asked, taking a sip.

"What's your secret to making Catra smile so much?"

…Weird question.

Adora cocked an eyebrow, lowering the drink. "What do you mean?"

"Well, you've been coming here for only the last two weeks, but every time you enter the bar, it's like…" Scorpia bunched her hands into fists then spread open her fingers with a vocal *fwoosh*. "Instant happiness on Catra's face! I've been working with her the better part of a year, and she's never been as happy as when she sees you! How do you do it?"

Adora felt like all the blood in her body had rushed to her face.

She blinked, clearing her throat. "I, uh, I don't know! I just come here to talk and… W-Well, we have been living together for two weeks, but it's not like a whole thing, it's just... Plus, I'm not really special at *all* so I have no clue why she'd ever be happy to see me! I guess… H-Hey, you know what? It's not just a one-sided thing!"

"Really?" Scorpia tilted her head slightly.

"Yeah! I mean, every time I see *her*, it's like… I just feel safe! She gave me a place to stay and something to eat every night. I feel like we could talk for hours about anything, or we can just be around each other in a comfortable silence." A smile had slowly washed over Adora's face. "She has the *cutest* cat too, and she takes care of them so well. I mean, she acts all snarky and teases me a bunch, but I can tell she really cares about the people close to her. She just gives and gives and doesn't expect anything in return except the company."

Adora took an excited breath. "Don't get me wrong, I'm not trying to take advantage of her generosity, it's just… She saw me, sitting alone in an alley feeling sorry for myself, and she just offered her place to me! I still don't know how I'm ever going to thank her properly for that. We've had a few tense moments, but every time we talk, I just feel at home. I feel comfortable. And she…"

Adora blinked, her smile instantly fading.

"… Oh crap. She's sitting right next to me. Isn't she?"

"By all means, don't let me stop you, Angel," Catra's familiar teasing voice suddenly sounded in Adora's left ear. "It looks like you have *plenty* more to say."

Adora slowly turned to see that *goddamn* smirk on Catra's face as she sat right next to Adora with her hand on her chin.

"How long have you been there?" Adora hesitated to ask.

"Long. Enough."

Adora's face dropped into the bar bench with a groan.

"Aw, what's wrong? Did you not mean any of what you said?" Catra cooed. "That would *really* hurt my feelings, Adora."

"I did, but you weren't supposed to hear all of that…" Adora mumbled. Her head suddenly shot up. "I bet you set me up by telling Scorpia to ask me that question!"

"What? Huh? Whassat?" Scorpia blinked with confusion, before waving both her hands in front of her face. "H-Hey, I didn't do anything, I swear!"

"She actually didn't," Catra confirmed. "Scorpia's just pretty intuitive like that. She catches onto people's traits much quicker than most, and she's *very* quick to point those traits out, embarrassing or not."

"Besides, what's wrong with a nice compliment to a good friend?" Scorpia asked. "It can make their day, after all."

"And my day has *certainly* been made," Catra chuckled.

"Because!" Adora stammered. "You can't… She'll just… I… We would… Why aren't you behind the bar, anyway?!" Adora asked Catra.

"Trying to change the subject, Angel?"

"Just shut up and answer!"

Catra laughed, her cackles making her voice break every so often. It was the kind of laugh Adora loved so much that she couldn't help but smile, even in her embarrassed and angry-but-not-really-angry state.

"I took the rest of the day off at Scorpia's insistence. Besides, I wanted to share a drink with my favourite customer," Catra replied, nodding to Scorpia for another Blue Fairy. "Plus, you

mentioned in your text that today was a weird day. I wanted to check in."

"Aw, are you concerned about me?" Adora replied.

"If you're trying to tease me back, it isn't working." Catra stayed silent for a few more seconds, before sighing. "But yes, I *am* slightly concerned. Mostly if it's due to the… 'situation' you had two weeks ago."

They were surrounded by a few people. They never knew if there were eyes on them. Cryptic talk was what they'd gotten used to in public.

"It was. The leader of the Runners, Shadow Weaver, called me up to grill me - tried to get me to spill some info on the 'situation'," Adora replied.

"Oh shit," Catra gasped slightly. "What happened?"

"Nothing bad, don't worry. My *actual* boss, Angella, bailed me out. Shadow Weaver didn't have any evidence, so her accusations were ultimately baseless."

"Thank fuck for that," Catra sighed. "Shadow Weaver didn't do anything… extreme, did she?"

"Apart from being the reason my rent pay didn't get through, not really."

Silence hung for a few seconds as Catra processed her statement. Then, a sudden spark of fire ignited in Catra's heart as her eyes flared up.

"Wait, *what?!"*

"She just caused the glitch. Look, it's fine," Adora waved a dismissive hand. "It's in the past. I can't do anything to change it."

"That's still bullshit!" Catra growled. "She doesn't have any fucking right to do that! She *knows* how bad it gets on the streets at night! What if you ended up hurt or worse because of her?!"

"Catra, it's *fine*," Adora emphasised.

"It's not fine! You need to take this up with someone! That was sadistic of her, and you know it! You need to—"

"*Catra.*"

Catra blinked, her fire suddenly coming to a halt.

Dammit. She'd done it again.

"She's the leader of the Runners. She's practically untouchable." Adora shook her head, her face stoic. "There's nothing I can do."

"Right… Right," Catra nodded.

Clear discomfort hung like thick sludge in the air. Adora took a drink to fill the silence, before sighing.

"I appreciate the concern though," Adora smiled. "You really *do* care about me."

Catra kept quiet, keeping her cold drink in her hand as she broke eye contact with Adora. The regret that washed through her face —her narrowed eyebrows and tensed lips—was a face Adora was all too familiar with.

"Hey." Adora leaned close, making sure Catra looked into her eyes. "I was pissed off too. Trust me, if Angella hadn't come in to save my ass, I might've thrown a punch or two, and *that* would've gotten me killed. I've just had some time to mull it over, is all."

"It's not that, it's just…" Catra sighed. "Nothing."

"Catra, you *know* I can tell when something's up."

"I…" Catra tensed her jaw, her voice lowering slightly. "I didn't mean to flip out on you. I promise it wasn't directed at you, I just hate how… *angry* I get sometimes. It's like a reflex. I try to work on it, but… Fuck. I messed up today because of how angry I got."

"What do you mean?"

"You realise if I tell you, you'll probably take back all those compliments from earlier?" Catra scoffed at herself.

"I doubt anything can make me do that," Adora shook her head. "I'm not here to judge. Promise."

Silence hung in the air. Scorpia took her cue to move on to another customer, though she kept an ear out for her partner.

Catra considered dropping the subject for a few seconds. However, the weight that gnawed at her heart was beginning to hurt. She needed to spill some of the ugly sludge out before it sent her into a quicksand of darkness.

Catra let out a quiet sigh.

"I have a friend. A close one. Her name's Entrapta. She used to be with the Guardians as a Warlock; repairing Keres, working with tech and software and such. She worked as a Warlock for about six years, and she gained a *lot* of insight during that time. Really tried to change things from within, even when the Runner protocol was established. She's a Ker who has done so much for the Keres," Catra started. "I admire her a lot. She was at the Awakening protests, and she's never once stopped fighting for her people."

Catra lowered her voice to a whisper as she leaned in close. "She's… the one who 'helped' Violet. I work with her sometimes on that… stuff."

Adora nodded. She kept her attention solely focused on Catra. She listened so well. It was something Catra was growing to love. She just hated lying to Adora all the time.

"Point is, Entrapta's great. She just… also has a tendency to be blunt about a few things. We were talking about a touchy topic and she gave her thoughts on it. It nudged me the wrong way and I just kinda went off at her." Catra sighed. "She didn't mean any harm, but I just got pissed. I didn't even apologise, I just… left. I've always known that my anger sometimes gets the better of me, I just… I wish it didn't happen so often. Not at people who didn't deserve it."

Adora waited for a few seconds after Catra was done, just in case anything more needed to be added.

Catra took a large swig of her cocktail—probably more than necessary—and placed it on the bench.

"Well," Adora finally spoke, getting Catra's eyes directed towards her. "I can at least relate to that. The whole 'getting angry' thing."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Really? *You?"*

"I mean, yeah? I just told you I was about to deck the *Runner Leader* in the face. And when Violet busted my nose? I was *furious* at her for that, even though I asked her to do it!" Adora chuckled. "My moms have always said I have a bit of a temper. Really, with the way things are, I don't think there's anything wrong with *that*. Getting angry is a pretty natural reaction to a lot of things. You shouldn't be ashamed of standing up for yourself when needed."

Catra looked at her drink, tensing her jaw slightly.

"But like you said," Adora continued, "obviously that anger shouldn't be directed at the wrong people. You clearly already recognise that, anyway. I don't think I need to be the one to tell you that maybe apologising to her is necessary."

"I know," Catra sighed. "You're right. I've just always sucked at saying 'sorry' to anyone. But…" Catra gave a sad smile to Adora. "For you, I'll try."

Adora grinned, giving Catra a light punch on the arm. "You really are a softie at heart."

"Oh, s-shut up!" Catra barked suddenly, giving Adora a shove. "I am not!"

It was Adora's turn to laugh, and thus, Catra's turn to take in the music of her laughter. The way she snorted sometimes between chuckles, and the way that her giggles always crept back no matter how many times she tried to calm herself.

Adora was a safe person to be around. She was a safe person to talk to. She was a safe person to share an apartment with.

She was a safe person to tell the truth to.

Catra knew that. She always knew that.

She traced her finger around the rim of her empty glass, keeping a thoughtful smile on her face. She could see out of the corner of her eye that Adora was already finishing her drink. Soon they'd be home. Soon the truth would have to come.

Or maybe she didn't need to delay.

"Hey…" Catra spoke quietly. "Adora, there's something I've been meaning to tell you. It's—"

"Oh, *shit*."

Adora's entire tone changed as Catra wasn't looking. She suddenly snapped her head to see Adora's wide eyes staring at the holographic TV behind the bar, projecting live news of something horrific nearby.

A car accident.

A flying car had malfunctioned and fell about three storeys, crashing to the ground and even *hitting* someone.

“That’s…” Adora pointed to the car accident. “That’s near here! Just a few streets down!”

“Yeah…” Catra looked at the accident, before noticing Adora quickly standing up. “Wait, where are you going?”

“I need to head there now,” Adora quickly spoke. “They might need more Angels.”

“Wait, are you sure? I thought you had the rest of the day off,” Catra quickly spoke.

She was so close to telling Adora. Of *course* this had to happen.

“I have to do something. This is my duty,” Adora replied, already exiting Elysium. “You head back to the apartment. I’ll let you know when—"

“No way. I’m coming with you.”

“NO!” Adora suddenly barked, stopping and holding a hand up to Catra. “Things might get worse. A crashed car has a risk of exploding, you have to—"

“Adora, I think you know me well enough by now to realise I’m *not* changing my mind on this.” Catra stepped close to Adora. “Look, I’m not going to get in the way, but if you think I’m just going to sit in the apartment worrying if you’re okay or not—”

“Catra, I *refuse* to let anything happen to you.”

“I’ll be fine.” Catra returned the steel gaze. “Trust me.”

Adora’s lips tensed up for a second, weighing up the options in her mind. The mere idea of Catra being anywhere near the scene got her weirdly emotional. *Something* had triggered a mild panic in Adora.

Eventually, however, Adora let out a frustrated sigh. “Fine. Just keep a safe distance. We have no clue if the car might be

flammable or if something else might happen."

"I know."

With that, Adora stormed forward and began to sprint out of the alleyway and down the streets. Catra gave one quick glance at the TV screen.

She wanted to follow Adora to make sure she was safe, yes.

But there was one other reason Catra wanted to be on the scene.

The victim who had been hit by the car was a Ker.

Sirens. Yelling. Lights. The smell of oil.

Adora and Catra rounded a corner onto the scene of the accident, seeing a car with no wheels crumpled beyond recognition. Multiple drones and signs directed traffic around the accident, whilst people with holographic angel wings springing out of their back did their best to help the two victims.

"You sure there's much you can do?" Catra asked.

"There has to be."

Adora pressed her fingertips to her chest and from the tattoos and cybernetics on her back sprung forth the familiar neon wings that projected even through her clothes. With those wings on her back, everyone could identify her position as an Angel.

It was the second time Catra had seen Adora's wings in person. They were still awe-inspiring.

As Catra kept a fair distance, Adora ran towards the larger group of Angels, who were all placing what seemed to be a man in his 40s onto a floating stretcher.

"What's the situation?" Adora asked a nearby Angel.

“The car’s auto-pilot went off course, crashed into the ground and struck that Ker. We’ve mostly stabilised the human driver’s condition and we’re sending him in an ambulance to Guardians HQ.” The Angel spoke quickly and with authority as she used her holographic touchpad to send the floating stretcher into the back of an Angel ambulance truck. “We’ve done all we can for him. Our main issue right now is the Ker.”

Adora looked at the car to see the Ker. Her eyes widened when she realised the victim hadn’t even been given a *stretcher*. Instead, she laid on the ground with a bloody torso and almost completely crushed legs.

“What… What are you doing?!” Adora cried, her eyes snapping back to the Angel. “Why isn’t she being transported?!”

The Angel spared a quick glance at the severely damaged Ker, before turning their attention back to the human. “We can’t do anything for her.”

“Wha…” Adora’s eyes flared with rage. “What the *hell* do you mean you can’t ‘do anything for her’?!”

“We can’t do anything *because* she’s refusing any sort of treatment,” the Angel sighed, barely phased by Adora’s anger. “Get a hold of yourself. Go over there and sort it out yourself if you’re that emotional. I need to be with the human patient.”

Adora watched as the Angel quickly moved with the stretcher into the ambulance. Once she stepped in with the patient, the doors automatically slammed shut behind her. With a loud *boom*, the vehicle came to life and suddenly began to float into the air, before seamlessly weaving into traffic at a high speed towards Guardians HQ.

With the first patient gone, Adora turned to the only other one. Three other Angels were tending to her, but they didn’t seem to be doing much except comforting her.

Adora ran over to the Ker and quickly kneeled beside her, analysing her face and body for injuries.

And the injuries were… *countless.*

Bloody chest, scarred face, and most notably, legs that were twisted like a pretzel and crumpled like paper. The bones must've been turned to dust.

The Ker had pale blonde hair that could go down to her waist, along with freckled cheeks and brown eyes. Most of all, despite her crushed legs and slowly fading state, she had a smile on her face.

"This…" Adora looked the Ker up and down. "We need to get you into a surgery room ASAP."

The Ker, out of everything, *giggled.*

"You Angels really will do everything you can…" The Ker coughed, keeping a smile on her face. "But your companions have done more than enough."

Adora looked up to the other Angels, all of whom had similar expressions of lowered eyes and thin-pressed lips.

"What's going on here?" A familiar voice sounded behind Adora. She already knew it was Catra's. She looked at each Angel individually. "Why aren't you helping her?"

"Because," the Ker smiled, "I wouldn't be able to afford whatever treatment you give me."

Catra's wide eyes blinked. "Afford…?"

"An ambulance ride… And a surgery…?" The Ker coughed again, her voice dehydrated and cracking against the desert of her throat. "There is… a much easier solution..."

“We’ve disabled her pain receptors,” one Angel spoke solemnly. “She can’t feel anything. She’ll pass peacefully.”

“Pass…?” Adora shuddered.

“Yes.” The Angel nodded. “She’s… a Ker, after all. Death is not as severe for them.”

Adora shook her head instantly. “No… No, there has to be *something* we can do, we can’t just—”

“It’s okay.” The Ker spoke in a soft voice, fading too quickly. “The Moirai has my memories… I’ll come back with a new body. It’ll be okay.”

“But we have to save you!” Adora cried. “We have to—”

A hand placed firm on her shoulder. Catra’s hand. Catra looked to Adora’s eyes and saw tears welling. Adora looked into Catra’s eyes and saw nothing. Not even a little bit of light.

Catra let out a sigh and looked with shattered sympathy—furrowed brows, downcast lips and soft eyes—to the dying Ker. “How long has it been since your last memory upload?” Catra asked.

The Ker took a croaky breath. “A week. A week… All of those memories will be lost…” She let out a sigh. “But at least dying is free.”

Adora let out a heartbroken breath. She fought to keep her lips still. “There has to be something I can do, there has to be a way I can *fix* this.”

Another croaky breath. There weren’t many left in the Ker. “What’s your… name…?”

“It’s…” A few rapid blinks to hide away tears. “It’s Adora.”

The Ker smiled, her eyelids slowly lowering as she took in the world before her and the people who helped her.

"What's *your* name?" Catra asked the Ker to fill the time they had left.

A smile. Through bloody and croaky breaths, a *smile*. The Ker's eyes never left the stars, despite them being hidden behind an advertisement. She embraced the twinkling lights with her last words.

"Perfuma." A last breath from the broken Ker. "My name is… Perfuma..."

Silence.

Adora expected another breath. At least one more. She would've given anything for one more breath.

With a smile on her face, Perfuma died.

She would return in a few days, but her previous week would be lost to Styx City. Death was but an inconvenience for a Ker.

As the other Angels prepared a way to send the body back to Nyx Industries and a few more Guardians arrived to clear the crashed cars that were no longer a danger, Adora only stood up in silence.

Catra desperately fought in the darkness of her mind to try and find the right words to say.

But then, Adora quickly walked away and towards an alley.

Adora rushed to be alone.

But Catra followed.

Adora had her back to the city, her arms crossed tight, her body shaking. Catra approached her, placed a gentle hand on her

shoulder once again. Her hand phased through the holographic wings on Adora's back.

Adora turned. Her eyes stinged red, tears stained her cheeks and chin. She desperately held back the sobs and the ugliness of her crying. Her lips scrunched tight and the lump in her throat choked her.

Death was temporary for a Ker.

But for Adora, death was *so much worse.* Death was a constant failure as an Angel.

Through her weak and broken voice, Adora choked out one sentence.

"This never gets easier…"

There was no sound worse than the shattering of an Angel's heart.

Catra narrowed her raised eyebrows and let out a sympathetic sigh. "Come here."

Catra did not protest when Adora eventually wrapped her arms tightly around her. She did not protest when Adora buried her face into Catra's shoulder and drenched her shirt with tears and shuddered with choked sobs. She did not protest when Adora's fingers dug into her back as she begged for a chance to save someone for *once.*

Catra only stroked her fingers through Adora's hair. She brushed her fingertips along Adora's scalp and whispered *it's okay* over and over into her ear. She only tightened the hug and let the Angel break down in her arms.

Adora had no intention of letting go. She shivered in Catra's arms, and Catra held her closer. "I've got you, Adora… I'm not letting go…"

Perhaps in a few moments, they'd forget this ever happened. Adora would need to move on, and Catra would need to stay silent about it.

But for now, they were a broken Angel and a guilt-ridden Ghost.

And they needed each other more than anything in the world.

"Where are you taking me?"

"You'll see."

It had been an hour and a half since Perfuma died. An hour and a half since Adora had failed again.

With the cars cleared off the road and Angella *once again* reminding Adora to take the rest of the night off, she was meant to walk home to an apartment and never sleep the night away. She was meant to lay on the couch and reflect on all the mistakes she had made. She was meant to hate herself a bit more.

She was meant to do all that, but Catra had other plans.

A quick 'follow me' about a half hour ago had led Adora on a weird journey away from Styx City. No gravel path had been followed, and the further they walked, the darker the sky got. Adora almost expected to reach the border.

They had reached a hill with barely any grass and had slowly been climbing it for the last ten minutes. Adora could hear the roar of the occasional car and motorbike atop the hill—along with flooded headlights shining off it—indicating to her that they were reaching a highway.

Adora didn't know *why* Catra was taking her this far away from the city, but she trusted her. She always trusted her.

Eventually, the end of the hill came into sight. Catra came to a halt, and so did Adora.

As predicted, they were right next to a highway. A translucent barrier protected them from walking onto the road, but they still got to see the occasional car fly by. The noise sometimes rang in Adora's ears.

"Now…" Catra panted a bit from the walk, before taking a deep breath through her nose. "Take a look behind you."

Adora blinked, before slowly turning her head over her shoulder. There, she saw the view from a safe distance.

Adora and Catra stood before Styx City in its entirety, now so small from this distance.

The two of them gazed at the array of lights and towers. Little blips like fireflies flew between towers, and a few large aircrafts blinked in the night sky. That same damned billboard never left space.

But through all that, there was beauty in the stars.

The night sky had no clouds, and the moon was no brighter than the city. Yet Adora finally got a chance to differentiate the stars from the bright windows. She finally got a chance to see Styx City as something small from afar.

And from this distance, for the first time, there was true silence.

Besides the occasional car, there were no sounds to occupy them. No advertisements to tell them why Nyx Industries will lead the future. No overlapping chatter of tech, sex, or distractions. Nothing.

Just a distant city, the stars, and two women standing side-by-side to admire it all.

"I thought you needed a break from everything," Catra spoke up eventually. "Especially after what happened tonight."

Adora nodded. "I don't often get this far away from the city."

Silence once more. Another car drove by, and then peace. Temporary, but peace nonetheless.

Catra let out a sigh as she dug into the pocket of her jacket. Adora looked over to see her pulling out her usual packet of cigarettes.

Catra placed a smoke between her lips and flicked open her thumb to reveal a lighter, shielding the flame as she lit the cigarette. The end glowed as she sucked in the smoke, before she blew it out into the night sky. She made sure to keep the smoke away from Adora.

Adora turned back to the city and leaned against the barrier of the highway. Catra leaned next to her as her arm went limp and she tapped out the ashes of the cigarette.

There was a moment of silence. Catra's occasional sigh as she puffed out cigarette smoke was all the noise made between them.

"Fuck…" Catra croaked, scratching her nose with her thumb. "You see all these towers, this smog, the cars on the road and in the air. You feel how hot it gets, you see barely a single tree, you think about how the ocean has gotten closer and closer to us in the last few decades..."

Catra inhaled her cigarette, let the smoke flow through her throat and lungs, then let it out with a soft sigh as she spoke one sentence.

"It's not the end of the world yet, but you can see it from here."

Adora looked to Catra for a few more seconds as the words hung in the air along with the smoke protruding from her lips. Catra didn't look particularly pleased with herself as she tapped the end of the cigarette with her thumb and scattered the ashes.

If anything, by the ways her eyes avoided contact with Adora's, she almost seemed ashamed.

Catra noticed Adora's stare. "Do you want a drag?" Catra asked, holding up her smoke for Adora.

"It *has* been a day… But I'm good," Adora held up a refusing hand. "That stuff has never been for me anyway. I tried it a few years back and nearly coughed up a lung."

"Eh, good call to not get into it," Catra said, taking another drag. "I'm *supposed* to be quitting right now."

"Finding it difficult to do?"

"Yup," Catra admitted, breathing the smoke out.

She pondered her next words for a few seconds but found comfort in opening herself up to Adora. She trusted her.

Catra clicked her tongue once. "It, uh… It helps with my anxiety sometimes to just have a quick one of these every now and then. Hard to let go of it."

"I get that," Adora nodded. "This your first time trying to quit?"

"Third, actually. It's just never gone well for me in the past. When the withdrawals kick in, it gets *bad."*

"How bad?" Adora instinctively asked. She quickly corrected herself. "Uh, don't feel like you have to answer that. I just…"

"It's cool. It's… kinda nice to have someone to talk to about this stuff." Catra gave her a tired smile, before she sighed. "Last time I tried to quit, I, uh… I had a *major* panic attack. Like, 'couldn't *breathe* for nearly a half hour' kind of attack. I seriously thought I was going to die. I didn't even get out of my bed for days after that. Probably the… worst bout of depression I've ever had."

"God, that sounds awful." Adora's brows narrowed with genuine sympathy. "I'm sorry you had to go through that."

“Yeah. So that’s why I’m hesitant about letting these go.” Catra laughed under her breath. “Shit… Was that too much to dump on ya?”

“You’re fine. You can talk to me about this stuff, okay?”

“Hah… Thanks.” Catra grinned. “I’m sure your Angel instincts are wanting to tear the cigarette out of my hand right now, huh?”

“Well, smoking is obviously not *great* for your health, but it’s not my place to judge you. Especially after what you went through, it’s understandable why you’d be hesitant to quit,” Adora shook her head. “Though if you ever need help quitting, let me know. I could recommend some NRT or just try to help you along with withdrawals as best I can.”

Catra nodded, her smile still on her face as she took another drag and released the smoke into the air. “I’ll keep that in mind. I appreciate it, Angel.”

Another silence hung between them, with some sighs from Catra as she released her smoke in the air.

Adora kept thinking back to Catra’s comment from earlier. It stuck with her for some reason. As she looked at the toxic city and corporate buildings, Adora spoke without really thinking.

“Hey.”

“Yeah?” Catra responded as she turned to face Adora.

“You said earlier that you think the world’s going to end pretty soon, right?”

“Sure did.”

“Well, in that case, I want to make a promise with you.” Adora turned to make eye contact.

“And what’s that?”

“When the world *does* end, I want to watch it with you.”

Catra furrowed her brows. It was certainly the weirdest promise she’d ever gotten, but Adora seemed dead set on it. She couldn’t help but scoff at Adora’s seriousness about it.

“And that means,” Adora continued, “we both have to live until then, okay?”

Catra smirked. “Is this your not-so-subtle way of encouraging me to quit smoking?”

“Well, that’s not the *only* reason I want to make this promise, but…”

This little fucking dork.

Catra looked at the cigarette between her fingers. She tensed her lips for a few seconds.

“Fuck it.”

Catra let out a slight sigh before flicking the cigarette to the ground. Adora tried to hide it, but she smiled a bit as Catra stomped on her smoke.

“Alright, Angel.” Catra smiled, looking up to Adora.

Then, Catra held up a fist, the back of her hand facing Adora.

“You and me, together at the end of the world. I promise.”

Adora returned the smile, and before the city of lights and smog, she held up her own fist and knocked it against Catra’s.

“I promise, too.”

A promise between an Angel and a Ghost, made before the city of the end. They shared that smile for some time, perhaps longer than necessary, but neither of them complained.

“I can’t guarantee I’ll be able to go cold turkey,” Catra admitted, “but I’ll try my hardest.”

“That’s all I can ask,” Adora nodded. “I just don’t want you hurting yourself. I’m not judging, but… it just doesn’t seem like you *enjoy* smoking a whole bunch. I’m not going to pry. I just…”

Adora looked into Catra’s eyes. “I care about you, Catra. A lot.”

Catra felt her heart flutter. For a few seconds, she felt her entire body fill with slight shivers. She had no idea what feeling she just felt, but she *really* liked it.

She quickly composed herself, returning that slight smirk. “Shit, Adora, you can just tell me you want me to quit, you don’t have to go and flirt with me.”

“That wasn’t…!”

Catra laughed, her voice cracking a few times as Adora’s face flushed red. “Relax, I’m fucking with you! But seriously…” Catra smiled warmly. “Thank you. I… Thank you.”

Adora scoffed, before returning the smile. “Anytime.”

Then, a return to silence.

It was still almost a foreign feeling to Adora. Guardians HQ and especially the Angel wing of that building was never quiet, and with the amount of emergencies she attended to and constant communication she had to uphold with her fellow Angels, she almost never got a moment of silence.

It was only now, with all this silence, that she could notice the slight ringing in her ears if she focused.

There was a comfortable silence. With this comfortable silence, it gave her time to reflect. With time to reflect, she always remembered one person.

Sometimes she hated remembering.

Adora spoke up. "If we're… being all deep and vulnerable here, is it alright if I tell you something?"

"Of course, Angel. Anything you want."

Adora took in a deep breath, released it through her nose for a few seconds. "I think the last time I was in a place this quiet was…" Adora contemplated her words for a few seconds, lips pressed thin. She hadn't talked about this to anyone outside of the Angels.

But she trusted Catra.

Adora opened her barrier and released the truth.

"…Was after I lost Mara."

Catra looked to Adora and saw her eyes shut tight.

"Mara…" Catra blinked. "Wait… That name seems familiar."

"Yep. You probably knew her. She always mentioned her favourite place to go to after work was Elysium," Adora laughed sadly, looking back up to the city. "We were meant to go there together three weeks ago. We went everywhere together. She and I got through Angel training together. She always looked out for me, and I always looked out for her."

"Was she your girlfriend?" Catra asked.

"Nah. Proper relationship never felt right between us. But we were closer than anything." Adora tilted her head to the sky. "We used to sit on rooftops and look out to the stars. That was always as quiet as things could get for us."

“Adora…” Catra released a gentle whisper of her name.

“You don’t have to pity me,” Adora shook her head. “She died four weeks ago. Her loss is still raw, but I’m trying to push through it. I just…”

A withered sigh. A swallow of sadness. Adora looked to Catra with cold eyes and spoke one sentence she’ll never forget.

“I wish I had died instead of her.”

Catra’s jaw locked. Her eyebrows raised suddenly. “What…?”

“I’m just thinking out loud. You don’t have to worry.”

“No, Adora, that’s…” Catra shook her head. “Of *course* I’m worried. That’s a *horrible* thing to say. What the hell happened?”

Adora kept her silence for a few more seconds, her lower jaw trembling ever so slightly. She took a shaky breath, and released it.

“About a month ago, there was a call from an apartment complex that was on fire. There was some spark in the cybernetics; the place hadn’t been inspected in ages because they couldn’t *afford* an inspection. They needed Angels to help with the evacuation before the fire got any worse.”

Adora looked back to the city. “I was on my way to the building when I got another call that was higher priority. A Nyx Industries factory had a toxic chemical leak. Multiple people had already collapsed. So I took the call for the toxic leak…”

Adora took a breath. “And Mara took my place for the fire call.”

Catra could already see where this was going.

"The Nyx Industries call was a complete nightmare. We lost more lives than we could save. There wasn't anything we could do by the time we got there. I just had to wear a mask and watch as they all died." Adora could barely get the words out.

"The fire emergency, on the other hand… They saved everyone in that building. At the cost of one person."

Adora looked back up to Catra.

"That person was Mara. The building had collapsed while she was in it."

Catra's heart froze for a few seconds. The colour drained from her face.

"They thought they had evacuated everyone, but Mara heard the cries of one little kid still in the building. She went back in by herself before anyone could say anything. The kid made it out."

A breath.

"She didn't."

Catra's breath caught in her throat. "Adora, I'm…"

"She was saving lives and I was just surrounded by the dead. I couldn't do a single thing to save *anyone* from that toxic leak." Adora's breath was starting to shudder heavily. "If I had just gone to the fire… If it had been me there instead of Mara taking my place… Maybe I could've done something for *once.* Maybe I could've saved someone. At the very least, Mara would still be *alive."*

"Adora, you don't know that."

"It's my fault, Catra." Adora's eyes were shut tight. "Mara's gone, I'm still here, and it's all my fault. None of this is right."

"*Stop*."

Catra's voice was a growl. Unintended, but she didn't take it back. It was the only thing that stopped Adora's words.

"You can't say for certain what would've happened if you had taken the fire call," Catra spoke with a stern voice. "There are a thousand ways things could've turned out, and you can't predict them all."

"I *know,"* Adora let out a frustrated, tired sigh. "But the fact is, I took a different call, Mara had to replace me, and now she's dead. And I just have to… live with that?"

Catra hated how Adora posed that as a question.

"You can't—"

"*Catra*." Adora's exhausted sigh of her name chilled Catra to the bone. "Nothing's going to change the way I feel, okay? I appreciate you trying to help and I'm glad I have someone to talk to about this, but… All I can do is spend whatever days I have left making up for what I did. Even then, it won't be enough. I just have to accept that."

Catra's concern went ignored by Adora. There was nothing more to say between them about the situation. Adora could only hug herself and push through the crushed feeling in her heart and hole in her stomach. Catra could only watch.

Adora's eyes looked so full of pain, glazed with tears and narrowed with regret. Catra would give anything to take that pain away.

Catra looked back to the city. "You mentioned you and Mara were always together." She took a breath. "If you don't mind me asking… Why weren't you that day?"

Adora didn't answer for a few seconds. "We… had an argument the previous night. We agreed it was best if we took different calls the next day to let things cool down."

Adora almost winced. “That argument was the last time I ever saw her.”

Catra felt like she had been punched in the gut.

Adora scoffed to herself. “You know the worst part? I don’t even remember what the argument was about.”

“Adora…”

The pain was beginning to become too much. Adora shut her eyes to wash away the tears, but a few streamed down her cheeks. She wiped them away immediately, but Catra caught sight of them.

Even when standing on the outskirts of it, Styx City always had a way of bringing pain to everyone who lived within it.

Desperate to numb some of Adora’s pain, Catra had only one plan.

She reached out a hand to Adora, hovering it by her side, palm facing upwards. Adora noticed Catra’s outstretched hand, and she looked up to her friend.

“Hey.” Catra gently smiled. “You and me, together at the end of the world, right?”

Adora sniffled, chuckling slightly. This was *so* dumb.

She took Catra’s hand. Warm palms pressed together.

“End of the world.”

The Angel and the Ghost interlocked fingers and held hands before the lights of Styx City.

“Thanks for listening to me, Catra. I… figured you should know all that stuff about Mara. I just wanted to get that out there between us.”

"You can talk to me about anything anytime, Angel. I trust you. Just hope you trust me?"

"More than anything."

"Heh… Thanks."

Sticky hot air surrounded them. Cars flew by on the highway behind them. Smog and lights smothered the stars before them. Perhaps the end of the world would be sooner rather than later.

The two of them were broken in places and suffering in others. They would likely never be whole people again.

But they had each other.

So in that single moment, things were okay.

'Hey.'

'I don't know if you're up. I hope the Disconnection procedure with the new Ker went well.'

'I shouldn't have gotten mad at you. I feel really shitty about it and I should've apologised sooner. So I'll say it now.'

'I'm sorry.'

'I won't let that happen again, and I'm trying to be better. I understand if you need time or space, but I'm always here. I'll wait until you're ready to talk, however long that takes.'

Catra looked at the texts projected from her left arm. She had sent them all to Entrapta, but with how early it was, she didn't expect a response for a while.

With a sigh, she lowered her arm. In that same hand, she held a pack of cigarettes.

Catra stood on the balcony of her apartment as the morning sun slowly began to engulf the city. It was a sleepless night, but she felt no less tired than usual.

Adora was passed out flat on the couch in the apartment. Hearing her soft (and sometimes not-so-soft) snores was almost like music to her ears. Catra could only hope she was dreaming comfortably.

Catra flicked open the packet of cigarettes and dumped out the rest of the sticks into her hand. On stressful days, they were her only friend. An escape from hell. Possibly a permanent escape, given enough time.

She could just hang onto them. Just in case.

But she had made a promise.

With a slight flex of her fingers, Catra snapped all the cigarettes in half.

She released the breath she had been holding, standing back up to head into the apartment. If she at least closed her eyes enough, she wouldn't be totally exhausted throughout the day.

Before she opened the door, a sudden tone rang in her ear. A text message.

Was she really up that early?

Of course she was. This was Entrapta, after all.

Catra projected the texts in front of her from her left arm and saw a message from Entrapta.

'The procedure went great!!! The new Ker is talking with the others and he's slowly figuring himself out. Oh, and my new

encryption worked!!!!! Nyx Industries and the Runners didn't notice a thing! You should come talk to him when you've got the time.'

A few seconds passed, and Entrapta sent one more text.

'Oh, and it's okay. I forgive you :)'

My Favourite Angel

Chapter Summary

On a difficult night, Adora and Catra comfort each other.

Chapter Notes

CONTENT WARNING: Brief description of gore in the third scene (all italics), sexual content at the end of the fourth scene (not super explicit but bordering on it).

Adora watched traffic fly by as she stared out the window of the ambulance. Guardians HQ was nearby, and the sooner they got there, the sooner the current situation could be placed in better hands.

It had been an incredibly eventful day with the amount of calls she had taken. A few Angels were worried about Adora's state, but she would always tell them she was fine.

She *had* to be fine. She *had* to save people.

And she especially had to save this patient.

Wheezed, high-pitched coughing sounded from the girl on the bed. Adora's attention immediately snapped back into the moment at hand.

"Patient's conscious," Adora spoke to the driver, who weaved through multiple floating cars and trucks.

The patient's dazed eyes looked around the unfamiliar vehicle, before landing on Adora and her worried expression. The Angel was checking the patient's vitals and readings from a number of holographic tablets, but looked up when she noticed the extra pair of eyes on her.

“Hey there,” Adora spoke softly to the patient, hiding the worried expression behind a demeanour of comfort and positivity. “Can you speak?”

“Uh-huh…” The patient nodded, their eyes glazed.

“That’s good,” Adora smiled, swiping through a few vital signs. Nothing to panic about yet. “Can you tell me your name?”

The patient gazed upon Adora’s angel wings for a few seconds—remembering the advice from her mother to always trust Angels—before responding.

“F… Flutterina…”

“And how old are you, Flutterina?”

“Five…”

Adora swallowed down the lump in her throat as she nodded. “You’re doing great. Just keep talking to me, alright?”

“What’s going on…?” Flutterina croaked out softly, looking out the window and finally noticing that she was in a high speed flying vehicle. “Is this because of my sore tummy…?”

Adora nodded. “The water you drank today wasn’t very good for you. Your mom noticed it was making you very sick, and then it made you… fall asleep suddenly. She was very quick to call us when that happened. We’re taking you somewhere that’ll make you feel better.”

“Oh…” Flutterina blinked. “Is mom coming too…?”

“She sure is. She’s right behind us.” The panic in the mother’s voice still rang in Adora’s ears. “Hey Flutterina, can you give me a quick rating on your tummy soreness? From one to ten, one being that you don’t feel any pain and ten being that the pain is really, really bad.”

“Um…” Flutterina thought hard about it for a few seconds, her face visibly wincing. “Seven…?”

“Okay,” Adora nodded, making a note. She turned her head to the driver. “Are we close?”

“Pulling up to the ER now,” the driver responded as the car began to descend into the Guardians HQ.

“Excuse me, miss Angel…”

There was a change in Flutterina’s voice. A slight whimper. Adora looked down to her eyes, glazed with tears.

“Am…” Flutterina took a shaky breath. “Am I gonna die…?”

A sudden chill shot through Adora’s spine like tingling ice.

Adora immediately shook her head. “No! You’re going to be fine. We have Angels who are going to get that bad water out of your body, and you’ll feel much better in no time.”

Adora had no idea if any of what she was saying was true or not. Flutterina had ingested a lot of toxified water due to a fault in their detoxification system. The vitals Adora had on her weren’t the *worst* they could be, but they were nowhere near great either.

But she had to promise this girl life. She deserved a chance at it.

“Are *you* going to make me feel better…?” Flutterina asked with a slightly hopeful tone.

Adora smiled. “I’m going to help as much as I can, but I was just here to get you to the hospital and to make sure you were okay on your trip here.”

“Oh…” Flutterina’s hope slightly faded. “But you’re my favourite Angel…”

Adora felt the lump return to her throat at that statement.

The ambulance doors opened as another group of Angels came along to transport Flutterina to an emergency room.

“She’s talking and mostly conscious,” Adora spoke to another Angel. “I’ve sent a copy of her vitals and ECG.”

The floating bed beneath Flutterina began to move out of the ambulance and towards the hospital doors. In a split-second, Adora made a decision entirely with her heart.

“I’m going with her to the emergency room.”

The other Angel’s eyes widened. “But—"

“Just let me.” Adora’s feet hit the ground as she began to run alongside the other Angels transporting Flutterina. “She might get agitated if I’m not with her.”

It wasn’t usually Adora’s role to run a patient to their emergency room unless under specific circumstances. She was ultimately meant to drop the patient off to the right people and then be on her way.

However, in this case, Adora just knew she needed to be with Flutterina until the last moment. She needed to be her beacon of hope. Her belief that everything would be okay.

As the other Angels talked over each other with recordings and numbers of Flutterina’s vital signs and conditions, the young girl’s eyes remained glued to Adora. “What’s going to happen to me…?”

“There’s going to be some Angels who will help you. They might give you something to eat or some medicine. They’ll also make sure you don’t fall asleep again suddenly,” Adora explained as best she could.

Depending on the severity of the toxicity, different procedures might need to be taken. The ones Adora had mentioned were on the less scary side.

"Is mom going to be there…?" Flutterina looked frantically around at the hospital.

"She will be. Once the Angels have helped you, she'll be able to see you." Adora looked up to the nearby emergency room marked for them, with a few Angels already setting themselves up. "You're going to be okay, Flutterina. Trust me."

Flutterina didn't hesitate to nod, a smile slowly appearing on her face. "I trust you."

With that, Adora released a shuddered breath as she watched the Angels make a turn into the room, curtains already being drawn and gentle machines being hooked up to the young girl. Adora could do nothing from here. Her role was up for now.

She could only hope that Flutterina's trust wasn't misplaced.

Out of the hundreds of calls Adora got per week, it was always toughest to see people who didn't deserve the pain they were going through. Whether it be premature Keres, children, or innocent people trying to survive, it always stuck with Adora in the worst way. Even now, Adora was still having images of Perfuma's smiling yet deceased face flash in her mind occasionally, despite that situation being two weeks in the past.

If Flutterina didn't make it through this… If Adora had to see the face of another dead child…

No. She couldn't dwell on that. She *couldn't.* Flutterina was going to be okay.

"Angel Grayskull!" The voice of the Angel driver called out from the entrance of the ER. "Another call in Section 6!"

There was never a break. Never a time to reflect until after she had clocked out for the night. Adora needed to keep her head down and move.

Adora's shift was meant to end two hours ago, but there was no time to waste. She looked at Flutterina's room for a few more seconds.

"Please be okay…"

She only whispered that much to herself and the child, before turning and heading for the flying ambulance once more. She would have to be home late tonight; Catra would understand.

As Adora ran out of the Guardians HQ to attend to another call, she kept her mind focused on the job. She didn't look anywhere else but forward. She needed to save lives. She needed to make up for the mistakes she had made.

Despite all that…

There was one feeling Adora couldn't shake.

Even as the flying ambulance took off and began to speed away towards the traffic, she couldn't help but look out the window once more.

She wasn't looking out the window for the view, nor the mere distraction of it.

Adora looked out the window because she couldn't shake the feeling that she was being *watched* somewhere.

Catra felt relief fill her chest when she heard the apartment door open and close, despite it being nearly two in the morning.

"I'm home!" Adora called out, followed by her usual greeting (and kisses) to Melog.

Catra quickly cut the shower she was standing in, stepping out and drying herself. Her shift had finished up a little over an hour ago but Adora wasn't home when she returned to the apartment.

Adora must've had a late shift. Again.

Once Catra was dressed in her loose black shirt and shorts, she emerged from the bathroom.

"Hey, Adora. Long night?"

"You could say that…" Adora chuckled as she rubbed her eyes with her thumb and index finger. "Just call after call after call. I hope I'm not keeping you up with these late nights."

"It's fine." Catra hopped over the back of the couch and took a seat next to Adora, giving the Angel a comforting smile. "You doing alright? Anything bad tonight?"

"Nothing terrible, but it was just endless." Adora thought back on the night a bit more. "Though… There *was* one call that's still getting to me. A kid who drank toxified water."

"Oh shit," Catra blinked with surprise. "They alright?"

"I don't know. We got to her as fast as possible and she was conscious when I last saw her, but… You never know how these things will turn out. She doesn't deserve what she's going through. She's a sweet kid." Adora sighed, before letting out a slight scoff. "She called me her favourite Angel."

"Holy shit, that's *adorable."*

"Right?" Adora weakly chuckled, before her lips tensed as her smile faded. "I just… God, I hope she'll be okay. I hope I did enough…"

"You did all you could. If she was still talking when you sent her in, then I'm sure she'll pull through," Catra nodded, bringing her knees up to her chest.

"I just hope so," Adora croaked. "Sorry if I'm dumping too much on you here."

"It's okay, trust me. If anything, I'm worried you're carrying too much weight yourself. All these late-night shifts and such…"

Adora shook her head. "I'm fine."

"Are you really?" Catra asked. "It's okay if you're not. Look, even Melog is worried about you."

Adora turned her head to notice the cat sitting by her feet with their wide eyes looking up at her. She let out a slight laugh, reaching down to pet their ears.

Catra sighed. "Look… you told me a couple weeks ago that you wanted me to stop hurting myself. That you… that you care about me." Catra lifted up her shirt slightly to show off a small white patch on her waist. "I got myself a nicotine patch. Haven't had a single smoke since then, and the withdrawal symptoms have been mostly mild so far."

"Catra…" Adora hadn't even noticed. "That's… That's amazing. I'm really proud of you."

"Thanks," Catra lowered her shirt, "but this isn't about me. Point is, I want you to take care of yourself too. We made a promise for the end of the world, and that means both of us."

Catra's voice had a surprising amount of vulnerable croaks in it. Adora looked into her blue eyes, slightly glowing in the dark room.

"I'm not asking for a lot, just…" Catra sighed, leaning a bit closer to Adora. "Eat a bit more. Drink some water. Get some more rest. And…"

Catra tensed herself. "Stop taking so many late-night shifts."

"I…" Adora hesitated to respond, and eventually shook her head. "I don't know what you're talking about…"

"You realise there *are* a few Angels that come to Elysium, right? Yeah, they work a *hell* of a lot of hours, but *none* are taking as

many long and frequent shifts as you are," Catra said. "Which means either your boss is exploiting you, which doesn't sound like something she'd do… or you're overworking yourself on purpose."

"I just…" Adora tried to find the right words for a few seconds. But she knew she had been caught, eventually releasing a defeated sigh. "This is what I have to do, Catra. I have to—"

"*Stop*."

Catra cut her off, her voice raised suddenly. Adora even found herself startled at those words. "

"Why do you always *have* to do everything? Why do you *have* to do practically eighteen or nineteen hour shifts every day? Why do you *have* to work yourself to death just to save every single life? Why do you *have* to take the guilt and blame yourself every single time something goes sideways? Is that really what you *want?"*

"It doesn't matter what I want. I'm an *Angel,"* Adora emphasised. "It's my duty. I have to save every life and I have to take that weight every time I fail. That's my role."

"God…" Catra knew what she had in mind sounded harsh. But it eventually escaped the filter of her brain. "Look, I'm sorry, but *shit happens.* You can't torture yourself like this for not being absolutely perfect. You've *got* to give yourself some room to make mistakes."

"I…" Adora took in the words, but immediately shook her head as her mind rejected them. "I *can't,* Catra."

"Dammit, Adora…"

"Why are you so insistent on this, anyway?" Adora cut her off. "How long I work doesn't affect you."

"Because I *care* about you." Catra narrowed her eyebrows, looking into Adora's eyes. "Because I don't like seeing you come home every night with bags under your eyes and walking around like a

zombie. Because I want to see you just be *happy* and not have to force yourself to smile. Because I just…"

She stopped.

Silence hung between them. Catra's mind caught up with her mouth, and she realised how much of herself she had just exposed. The barrier was too open.

Catra let herself open up to Adora that one night beside the highway, but she knew she *really* needed to limit those kinds of conversations. Catra *never* looked fondly on her past moments of opening up.

Catra sighed, breaking eye contact and placing her chin upon her bunched knees. "Fuck, I don't know, okay? You just… Youmeanalottome."

Catra mumbled that last part. It was enough to finally pry a smile onto Adora's face—a genuine smile. "Uh, what was that?"

"What was what?"

"That last part. I didn't *quite* catch it."

"I don't know what you're talking about."

"No, I *definitely* heard you mumble something. I think it was about how much I mean to you—"

"*Fuck off, Angel*. If you heard me, then you're only getting it once."

There was a slight wavering tension in Catra's voice.

But it immediately broke when she heard Adora *laugh.*

It was the way she covered her mouth as she laughed, the slight rosiness that appeared on her cheeks as she finally let herself relax a little. Catra's eyes widened, and a slight blush appeared on

her cheeks as she watched and listened in to Adora's (admittedly *really cute*) giggles.

For a few seconds, Catra was just enthralled by the mere *presence* of Adora Grayskull.

Her whole world almost blacked out as she focused on nothing but Adora. The bubbles in her laugh. The smile on her face. Her gentle, messy hair. Her beautiful eyes.

Everything about Adora was just…

So utterly gorgeous.

Did time slow down for a bit? Maybe. Catra wouldn't have minded if it stopped for a few hours. Anything to get whatever time she had to just admire the perfection that was Adora Grayskull.

So Catra, too, softened as she snickered. "God… Maybe I'm just being stupid trying to help you."

"I think *I'm* meant to be the stupid one here," Adora smiled as she wiped the slight tears of laughter from her eyes. "Stupid Adora with her stupid long shifts and her stupid 'duty' to everyone."

Catra slightly scoffed. "And stupid Catra with her stupid feelings and stupid amount of unnecessary care for her favourite Angel."

"Aww, I'm your favourite Angel too?" Adora had a warm—and slightly teasing—smile as she put a hand to her chest.

Some colour flushed to Catra's face once again. This *damn* Angel. "Fine, I'll *let* you have that one too. You know, you better pay me back for all my *generosity*."

"You're *so* sweet."

"Shut it."

Adora briefly laughed—the same snorty laughter Catra could never get tired of—before returning that soft smile. "I… I appreciate you caring for me. I swear I'll think about what you said. I didn't used to be this overbearing on myself, but ever since Mara…"

"I get it," Catra nodded. "And I didn't mean to grill you as soon as you got home. I just… I want you to just try, okay? That's all I ask. I think Mara'd want you to take care of yourself as well."

"She would. She really would…" Adora spoke absentmindedly, her eyes glazing slightly. She blinked it away. "Thank you, Catra. For everything."

"Yeah, well…" Catra scratched her neck, avoiding eye contact. "You can thank me by doing what I asked. At least eat the food I'm buying for us, for fuck's sake."

Adora loved how terrible Catra was at taking compliments.

…Oh crap. Catra *was* paying for their meals. Payment…

"Oh, that reminds me!" Adora suddenly gasped, reaching for her phone.

Catra cocked an eyebrow as Adora tapped the screen a few times.

Adora eventually finished doing whatever she was doing on her phone, then she eagerly looked at Catra. "And… there."

A tone sounded in Catra's ear. She held out her left palm to project a screen showing something that made her eyes widen slightly.

"Why'd you just pay me?" Catra asked.

"Rent money," Adora said casually. "I've been living here a month, haven't I? That's half the rent."

"That's…" Catra shook her head. "You didn't need to do that. I've literally just given you the couch."

"And a roof. And food. And company. And access to the cutest cat ever." Adora gave Melog a quick pet. "I owe you *that* much, at least."

"Adora, I'm serious. You really don't have to—"

"Catra, just… let me do this, alright?"

Catra simply scoffed. There was no way she could transfer this back. Adora was often *stubborn* when she was being nice. "Fine… Thanks, but I *still* don't feel great about sticking you on this couch. It can't be comfortable to sleep on."

"I make do," Adora shrugged. "And speaking of… I *really* feel like I need to crash soon. It's been a long day."

Catra felt shitty about sticking the hardest working Angel in Styx on a crummy couch with a cat who didn't leave her alone. Adora never complained, but even still, Catra didn't feel like a great host. Or a great person.

"You should get some sleep too," Adora said as she began to lay herself on the couch in her usual position. "You've stayed up long enough for my sake."

Catra *liked* staying up to talk to Adora, though. It was her favourite part of the day (night?)—even if she wouldn't say that out loud.

"You're probably right," Catra sighed, rubbing her eyes as she stood up. "But I *will* keep staying up for you for as long as you keep doing these late-night shifts, alright?"

"You don't have to."

"I know. But I want to."

Adora smiled. Even as Catra wore loose clothing and yawned on her way to bed, she somehow managed to look so incredibly *perfect.* She had a weird way of making tiredness look *really* attractive. Her hair, so long, frazzled and slightly damp from her shower, was something Adora wanted to sink into. Her eyes, slightly glowing in the dim room, were a hypnotic light Adora could get lost in. Her face, capable of tense anger and loving softness, was a beauty Adora could only admire.

Her shirt slightly lifted up when she stretched her arms above her head with the yawn, revealing just the slightest portion of her waist, and Adora didn't mind *that* either.

But when Catra stood by her bedroom door and gave Adora that quick glance before she turned off the lights…

It was almost a routine. A glance from Catra every night before she closed her bedroom door to silently check if Adora was safe and comfortable. And when she confirmed she was, as much as she tried to hide it, Catra sometimes smiled. It creased into the wrinkles besides her eyes and puffed her cheeks ever so slightly.

Adora looked at Catra.

Catra looked at Adora.

And tonight, of all nights…

Their quick glance before bed lasted that noticeable second longer.

They both wanted to make the same request.

They both wanted to fall asleep embracing the other.

They both wanted… something more.

But the tension in their chests prevented them.

So, Adora hesitantly spoke up.

“Good night, Catra.”

“You…” Catra nodded. “You sleep well, Angel.”

It was their usual exchange before bed, but they always loved doing it anyway.

Catra closed the bedroom door and left Adora in the living room with Melog as she laid herself on the bed. Her bed wasn’t perfectly soft, nor too hard. Her bedside fan dried her somewhat damp hair from the shower earlier.

Her bedroom was a crummy mess. Hell, her whole apartment was.

But it was her safest place to be. Even with an Angel right outside.

Ever since the Violet situation, Catra hadn’t really felt in danger. Adora often came home with stories of patients saved and lives she wished to do better by, or stories of regrets because she wasn’t ‘good enough’. She helped anyone, human or Keres. She never talked down about Offline Keres, and she never pried too much into Catra’s business with the Offline Keres.

Catra trusted her. She opened herself to her. She knew of the dangers, but this was the first time she felt something in her heart other than coldness. It was the first time she had felt truly *alive*.

Maybe this was going too fast. Maybe this would all lead to ruin. Maybe her emotions were getting the better of her.

But she let them.

For the first time, she *let* her heart take control.

And she felt so *free*.

Catra thought of Adora, smiled, and closed her eyes.

I stand on an ocean of twisted and disfigured corpses, and it's all my fault.

My white feathered wings are nailed into my shoulder blades, and I feel the blood run like tears down my back. The wings flap, and they tear away at my flesh, nerves, muscle and bone.

I soar above an ocean of twisted and disfigured corpses, and it's all my fault.

I see a child below, huddled in a fetal position. I fly down and touch her back, hoping to heal her. She's been poisoned by the city.

When I look at her face, it's bloated and purple. She's not breathing. I was too late. Her name is Flutterina. She's already dead.

This child died in the ocean of twisted and disfigured corpses, and it's all my fault.

I hear someone call my name from behind me. I turned around to see her standing there, her bones twisted and visible, blood covering her body. She stares at me, and I can't look away. Her eyes are full of fear.

Her name is Mara. She saved so many lives, and her reward was the crushing of a building against her body. She was scared in her last moment.

She died, joined the ocean of twisted and disfigured corpses, and it's all my fault.

She won't stop saying my name.

They all won't stop saying my name.

"Adora."

It won't stop.

“Adora.”

It won’t stop.

“Adora.”

It won’t stop.

“Adora.”

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“ADORA!”

“Adora!”

She awakened with panicked, short breaths, and felt a hand against her own.

Adora felt cold sweat drenching her body and making her clothes stick. The room she was in was too dark. She could just make out the shape of Catra, who knelt beside her.

“Adora, breathe! Take deep, slow breaths,” Catra spoke gently and deliberately.

Adora’s throat felt tight. Too tight.

Her breaths felt like a knife against her lungs. She put a hand to her neck as she desperately tried to drag in breaths.

It wasn’t working.

Nothing was working.

She was going to die.

Adora’s going to die.

“Hey, hey, hey,” Catra spoke quickly as she noticed Adora’s choking. “What do you see? Look around the room. Tell me what you see.”

“Catra, I can’t…” She wheezed in a pathetic excuse for air. “I can’t, I *can’t…”*

“Yes, you *can.* What do you see?”

“I…” Adora’s panicked eyes darted around the room. She could barely choke the words out, but she pushed them out her tight throat. “I can see the city through the balcony door… The… The feeding bowl for Melog… Your kitchen… Plates and cups and…”

Adora blinked as her panicked eyes came to focus on Catra.

“… Your eyes. They’re glowing.”

“It’s a cybernetic mod. Helps me see better in the dark,” Catra explained. “How’re you feeling now?”

“It’s…” Adora put a hand to her throat and finally felt air begin to flow with each breath. “It’s better. I don’t even know what happened… Is this real…?”

“It’s real. I promise,” Catra spoke in a gentle tone, reaching up a hand and cupping it against Adora’s cheek. “You’re safe. You were having a nightmare and I think that triggered a panic attack.”

“It did…?” Adora blinked.

“You were shifting and talking a lot in your sleep. I could hear it from the other room,” Catra explained. She squeezed her hand. “It’s okay, Adora. I have them, too.”

Adora finally took a second to realise her position in the room. She was sitting up on a couch with her clothes stuck to her body from the sweat. She felt her hair stick to her forehead in patches. She felt a warmth on her hand and looked down.

It was Catra. She was holding her hand tight. She had been holding her hand the entire time.

Even now, Catra gently stroked her thumb along Adora’s cheek. She looked up into Catra’s eyes, and placed her hand over Catra’s on her cheek. She took deep breaths, and Catra took them along with her.

“Do you need me to get anything for you? Some water? Maybe step outside for a bit?” Catra asked. Her voice was *so* soft. The way it croaked slightly with her whispers was the most beautiful sound to Adora’s ears.

“No,” Adora shook her head, sighing and sinking into Catra’s palm against her cheek. “This is all I need.”

Catra didn’t judge, nor did she pull away. She continued to gently rub her thumb against Adora’s cheek and squeeze her hand. Adora squeezed back.

Mara’s fearful eyes were still fresh in Adora’s mind. The blood, the screaming, the agony. It wasn’t her first time seeing that world of death and misery. It wouldn’t be her last.

“I…” Adora let out a shuddered breath. “I don’t know if I can sleep again tonight…”

Catra nodded. “That’s okay. I, uh… I was thinking of making you an offer anyway.”

Adora looked up to her. “What’s that?”

“How would you feel…” Catra contemplated her words for a few seconds, before deciding to go all in.

“How would you feel sharing the bed with me from now on?”

Adora felt her heart stop for a second.

Catra’s heart, on the other hand, was beating like crazy. The courage in her had somehow doubled in the last few minutes, and she was starting to wonder if she had gone too far. She kept her hand clasped against Adora’s cheek, but she was ready to drop the topic altogether.

But Adora, on the other hand, felt a sense of relief wash through her body. Another barrier lowered. A night of safety and comfort. Sleep or not, she knew she’d be okay tonight.

So, she nodded. “I’d like that. If… If that’s okay with you.”

“It is,” Catra immediately replied. “I mean… We’ve been living with each other for a month. We’re… mature adults. What’s the worst that could happen?”

“Yeah. Exactly.”

Adora wasn’t sure if she was reassuring Catra or herself. Or both.

With that, Catra gave a reassuring squeeze to Adora’s hand, and both women stood up. Adora was at least glad to be moving

again. The panic attack had numbed her legs immensely to the point she wasn't sure if they'd work again.

She followed Catra, who looked slightly sluggish in her movements. She could tell it had been a rude awakening for her. A slight tinge of guilt struck Adora's stomach.

"Sorry that I woke you so suddenly," Adora said as Catra laid down on the bed, shifting over slightly for Adora as she laid on her side.

"Don't be. I'm glad I woke up in time."

Adora looked at the free space on the bed. It was her safe place for the night. She wouldn't enter that land once again while she was laying here.

So, Adora gently sat and laid herself right next to Catra on her bed.

The two of them looked into each other's eyes. A single pillow was shared between them, and the paper-thin sheets covered their legs. Adora rested her palm under her cheek, whilst Catra laid the back of her hand on the pillow between them.

It didn't take long for Adora to reach her spare hand over and place it atop Catra's.

Catra interlocked her fingers with Adora's, rubbing her thumb over the back of Adora's hand.

Neon bled into the room through the blinds on the window. Catra's eyes continued to give off a soothing glow—so much so that Adora found herself becoming lost in them. She wasn't sure how much time passed, nor did she care.

She had never felt this safe and comforted in her entire life.

"You feeling okay, Angel?" Catra whispered. Her voice soothed Adora, sent chills like a waterfall through her body.

"I don't know," Adora whispered back. "I… I saw Mara in my nightmare."

Catra instinctively squeezed Adora's hand as soon as she heard that. She shifted a bit closer, letting her glowing eyes look into Adora's.

"It's the first time I've seen her even since she passed," Adora whispered. She kept her lips as still as she could. "She looked so scared. She looked… afraid of dying. She always told me she was scared of death—all the pain that comes with it and the unknown that comes after. And… it made me remember something." Adora let out a shuddered breath. "Her fearful eyes in my dream… They looked like Violet's."

A second of silence, enough to let it sink in. Catra never took her eyes off Adora.

"When I was aiming my gun at Violet... Her eyes were so full of terror and desperation. That desperation to be *alive.* That's why I couldn't pull the trigger. She was *scared*, Catra. And now I'm seeing those same eyes again in my nightmares." Adora sighed. "I… I don't think I'll ever be able to forget Violet's eyes."

Catra nodded. "I get it. And you did the right thing when you saved Violet."

Adora thought to herself for a bit, before letting out a sigh. "It's… what I don't understand about Ghosted Keres. They give up this chance at immortality and choose to risk permanent death every day. But death… death is so *terrifying*. It comes so quick and it's so *unfair.* If Mara was a Ker, she'd… She'd still be here…"

Catra reached out a hand and brushed her thumb just under Adora's eyelid. The Angel soon realised tears were welling already.

She sighed with frustration as she rubbed her eyes.

"Dammit… It's been nearly six weeks… I should be better at talking about this…" Adora growled to herself.

"There's no time limit on grief. It's okay to be like this." Catra brought her hand back. "You remember my Ker Warlock friend, Entrapta? She's lost *so* many of her friends. At the Awakening protests, she watched so many of her people get gunned down. It's been decades and she still has trouble talking about it. There's no shame in struggling with this. Mara was close to you. That wound in your heart isn't going to just flash away in an instant."

Adora looked down to the bed. Catra was right, but it still tore her to pieces knowing she had to carry this weight on her shoulders. It burdened her, slowed her down, made her imperfect.

"But…" Catra continued, her voice still a whisper. "No matter what, Adora, I promise I'll be here for you. I'm never going to be annoyed or super bothered by this, alright? You're my best friend. I can help carry some of the weight for you if you ever need it."

Adora nodded. She kept her grip tight on Catra's hand, before letting out a sigh.

"… Hey Catra?"

"Hm?"

"Can you… Can you hold me? Just for a bit?"

Catra didn't hesitate this time.

She moved closer and wrapped her arm around Adora's shoulders, pulling the Angel close. Adora hooked her arms under Catra's, returning the embrace. She felt ice cold chills run through her, creating little bumps on her skin.

Adora pressed her ear to Catra's chest and listened to her rhythmic, slow heartbeat. She felt Catra's fingers scrape through

her hair and massage her scalp. Her strong arms held Adora tight.

Adora shuddered.

She was being held. Cuddled. Embraced. Protected. Such soft intimacy.

This…

"… This is the first time anyone's ever held me like this."

Catra nodded. "Same here."

She rested her chin atop Adora's head and felt the Angel grip onto the back of her loose shirt. She felt Adora's chest rise and fall with each breath and felt the smoothness of her golden hair between her fingers. She never, ever wanted to let go.

There was an indescribable warmth to it all.

A soothing electricity that ran through Adora's head with every brush of her scalp by Catra's fingers.

A numbing tingle in Catra's heart when she heard Adora's soft breathing match with the rise and fall of her chest.

Intimacy they had been starved of.

Now, they could finally take it all in.

"Can I ask you a weird question?" Adora whispered, the vibration of her voice buzzing against Catra's chest.

Catra wanted her to talk forever just to feel that sensation.

"Ask away, Angel."

"Do you… ever get scared of death too?"

Catra kept running her hand through Adora's hair as she pondered it for a few seconds.

Eventually, she nodded slightly. “I do.”

“Is there… a specific reason why?”

Catra clicked her tongue, let out a gentle sigh. “I don’t know. I think the idea of dying and there just being *nothing* afterwards is what scares me.”

“Yeah…” Adora took a slow breath. “That’s probably why people turn to their beliefs. The idea of an afterlife comforts that fear in some people.”

A few seconds of silence. Adora pressed her ear to Catra’s chest and counted her heartbeats. She was so warm.

“But at the same time…” Catra continued. “Sometimes I just want everything to *stop.* When I’m having a panic attack, or I just feel so tired that I don’t even want to get out of bed anymore… I don’t want to *die*, but I just want everything to *stop*. I get like that every now and then.”

She was opening up again.

But dammit, she was sick of holding herself back.

“Do you think that’s why Keres decide to become Ghosts? To have like… a ‘way out’ if things get too much?”

Catra felt her heart grow slightly heavy. Her stomach racked with guilt.

“I think that’s the case for some of them,” Catra said, stroking her thumb through Adora’s hair. “For the Online Keres, immortality is a blessing to some and a curse to others. And some Disconnect to get rid of that curse. But… I think for a lot of them, they choose to go Offline because they want to truly *live.* Maybe for some, they just want a way to end things when it gets too hard. But I think for most, they see a mortal life as a *true* life. They see death as a necessary end.”

“What do you mean?”

Adora pulled away slightly, her arms still around Catra but her eyes locked with Catra’s glowing ones.

“Well, a lot of Online Keres become… *used* to death,” Catra started. “It’s barely an inconvenience. But for a lot of the Ghosted Keres… They don’t see that as a good way to live. They choose to cut their lives to a temporary time because for them, that temporary time in life is their *true* life. They choose to make the most of what time they have, and they choose to accept that permanent death comes at the end of it all. Whatever happens, happens. They don’t *want* to die, but they want death to be *there* when the time comes. They just want to hold close what’s most precious to them.”

“And what *is* most precious to them?”

Catra let out a thoughtful sigh. “Their true identities, the sights they see, the bonds they form, and for some…” A hand stroked through Adora’s hair. “… The people they love.”

Adora shook her head. “I spent so much of my training hearing about how monstrous these Ghosted Keres are, how unfeeling they can be… But I saw the fear in Violet’s eyes. And you’ve been around them. And the more I hear… The more they just seem *human.”*

“Becoming a sympathiser, are we?” Catra slightly smirked.

“Maybe.” Adora scoffed at herself. “Maybe…”

Catra felt something choking her, and she didn’t know if it was just guilt anymore. Adora was okay. Adora was *safe*. Telling her the truth was the *right* thing, but Catra couldn’t get the words out.

“But even still…” Adora sighed. “Don’t you think a lot of Ghosts just die unfairly? Just… slaughtered by Runners without a care. They never get their chance.”

Catra's jaw tensed, and she swallowed the lump in her throat. "Yeah. Sometimes death is unfair, too. For those Ghosts… I wish we could give *them* a second chance. But the way things are, Keres have to decide between forced immortality or chosen mortality—mortality that might be cut short before they even have a chance to live. There's no in-between."

"That's… That's a tough choice," Adora whispered.

"Yeah." Catra sighed.

The grip on Catra's shirt tightened. Adora's eyes winced and she looked up at Catra with a pained expression. A thought had crossed her mind that she never, *ever* wanted to see come to fruition. She spoke with a tight throat and tighter chest.

"Catra…" Adora delicately whispered with a pained tone. "All this talk about death, I…"

"Hey…" Catra whispered and brushed Adora's hair. Her tone was so soothing and comforting. "You okay? This too much for you?"

"I just…" Adora sighed sadly. "I don't want to lose you, Catra."

The thought of it was enough to well a few tears in Adora's eyes. The lower half of her vision went hazy, and her lips trembled. Her heart physically *hurt* at the idea of Catra's death.

Catra needed to comfort her. She immediately shook her head.

"You won't. And I don't want to lose you, either. We promised the end of the world. That means we're going to live a long, long time. We're going to be happy. And when the time comes and the world crumbles to dust, we're going *together.*"

"Together," Adora nodded. She looked into Catra's glowing eyes as her face softened. She swallowed down the tightness in her throat.

Adora gripped Catra's hand and whispered. "Promise me one more thing."

"Anything, my Angel."

"Don't die before me. *Please*."

God, Adora's voice was so *soft.* So *vulnerable.* The words caught in her throat and she could only *just* choke them out in a hoarse whisper.

Her eyes were glazed with tears.

Catra reached out, wiped the tears away, and nodded.

"I won't. I promise." Catra brushed her thumb over Adora's soft cheek. "And Adora?"

"Yes?"

Catra cupped Adora's cheeks in her hands. "Don't *you* die before me. I will *never* forgive you if you do."

Adora sniffled and placed her hands over Catra's. "I won't."

"Promise?"

"I *promise."*

Catra gently held Adora's face and kept her close. Adora held her hands over Catra's, never taking her eyes away from the contact they had with Catra's. For a few seconds, they simply shared this one moment. Their breaths in sync, chests rising and falling, and eyes beautifully soft.

There had never been a moment like this in their lives. Adora never gave herself time to find this tenderness with anyone. Catra didn't think she deserved this intimacy with a single person.

Perhaps they were just two people who hated themselves, trying to find a temporary comfort in the hell that was Styx City.

But in that moment, Adora's entire world was Catra. And Catra's entire world was Adora.

And there was one more barrier they wanted to remove.

The Ghost tenderly stroked her thumb along the Angel's cheek one last time, before she made the boldest request of her entire life.

"Adora…" Catra let out a shuddered breath. "Can I kiss you?"

Adora swallowed, gripped Catra's hand tighter, and breathlessly nodded.

All Catra needed to do was shift her hand to gently caress the side of Adora's neck.

She looked into Adora's eyes, inched closer and closer, tilted her head slightly.

She felt Adora's breath against her lips for but a second.

She took it in.

All of it.

Her mind screamed at her to stop.

This will ruin us.

But her heart screamed something else.

This will save us.

And so, Catra pressed her lips to Adora's.

The first kiss was but a few seconds. Catra closed her eyes and sunk herself into the kiss. She felt Adora's hand run up her back—traced the bumps of her spine—before bunching up into her hair.

Catra pulled away. She kept her forehead pressed against Adora's, opened her glowing eyes to look down at the Angel as if to ask 'can we really do this?'

And Adora's eyes gave off a resounding *'yes'.*

All exits were closed off by them. There was no backing down. They didn't even *want* to.

Their separation was but for a second, as they soon quickly pulled each other close and shared an even deeper kiss.

Catra rolled herself over, laying on top of Adora as she closed her lips over the Angel's. They took breaths infrequently, noses bumped against each other, and teeth clattered sometimes.

They didn't care.

They needed each other. They fucking needed each other so *desperately.* There was barely a place for true love in Styx City, and they needed to clasp on and hold tight before it faded away.

It was Adora who took it deeper when her tongue became involved. A step Catra didn't expect this early, and Adora quickly backed off when she heard Catra's muffled gasp. However, it was soon reciprocated when Catra returned the gesture. They danced and deepened with the kiss, and Adora's hands began to explore in places she never thought she would.

She traced her hand down Catra's back, feeling some bone and some muscle. Catra continued to stroke her hand through Adora's

beautiful hair, feeling when Adora's hands came to rest on her hips.

"Catra…" Adora gasped, freeing her lips for a few seconds.

"You okay?" Catra quickly backed away, panting slightly.

"I am… I really am…" Adora chuckled, and Catra returned the slight laughter. "I… Catra, should we…?"

Catra saw where Adora's hands rested on her hips.

She saw the needy look in her eyes.

She brushed a strand of Adora's hair behind her ear. "Are you sure?"

"I am," Adora nodded. "I need this."

"Do you *want* this?"

"*Yes*. God, Catra, *yes."* Adora's voice was so eager, almost begging as she let her words out with a desperate exhale. "I *want* this. I want *you."*

"Hm… Good girl…" Catra cooed in her low, croaky voice, almost amused at Adora's eagerness. "I want you too, my Angel…"

Shivers shot up Adora's spine that made her almost vibrate just from that voice *alone.*

"Catra…" Adora honest-to-god *whimpered.* "*Please…*"

And how could Catra ever refuse her?

Catra ran her fingers through Adora's golden hair one last time, before leaning down and pressing her lips to Adora's neck.

Adora giggled slightly at the ticklish feeling. Catra smiled at the beautiful laughter. She pressed her kiss further, and Adora laughed harder. "H-hey!"

“Alright, alright,” Catra chuckled with closed lips, and left her ticklish point. She *definitely* noted it for later.

She continued to give butterfly kisses to Adora’s exposed neck, her hand slowly raising Adora’s shirt. The Angel kept her fingers gripped in Catra’s hair, but not too tight. The gentle massage against her scalp was almost pure enough pleasure on its own for the Ghost.

When Adora’s shirt was bunched at her collarbone, Catra began to kiss lower. She kept her glowing eyes on Adora’s face at all times as she traced kisses along her jawline, going along her throat. Adora’s shuddered breaths and whimpers of her name was pure blissful music.

Adora’s sighs of pleasure escaped on their own. Her body felt like it was on fire, her chest fuzzing like TV static.

The most surprising thing came when Catra kissed the centre of Adora’s chest. Suddenly, holographic wings sprouted from Adora’s back.

“Ah… That’s a pressure point…” Adora chuckled, looking at the glowing wings spread on the bed now. “Sorry about that.”

“It’s fine. I like them,” Catra smiled.

With the Angel’s spread wings and the Ghost’s glowing eyes being the only light sources to mix with the neon in the room, Catra traced her lips lower. Adora felt the tender kisses against her breasts, and she let out a muffled sigh.

Catra looked up for permission. Adora looked down and continued to give it.

Catra traced her hand towards Adora’s chest, felt the softness, gently closed her lips on their sensitive point and traced her tongue around and around. Adora gasped, lost in the glow of Catra’s blue eyes as she looked up at her.

Catra pulled away. Adora could feel Catra's hot breath against her skin. She brushed her hand along Catra's hair one last time, before the Ghost lowered herself temporarily out of the Angel's reach. Adora tilted her head to the ceiling as she felt lips trace along her hardened abs.

Adora *let* Catra give her pleasure. She allowed herself to be vulnerable, to *receive* this intimacy. It was the first time in her life she'd been at the hands of someone who wanted nothing but the best for her.

And for Catra, she was happy to be this close with another person. She was happy to finally lower her guard and sink into the bright pool of her feelings and love for another woman.

They needed each other. More than anyone needed anything in this moment of time, they *needed* each other.

Adora felt one last kiss on her lower stomach. She gripped the sheets. She knew what came next. She embraced it. She laid there and let herself be taken care of.

Adora trusted Catra. Catra trusted Adora.

Nothing in the world could break them apart in that moment.

When Catra sank further down Adora's body, came between her legs, and gave her the next kiss, they both truly fell into bliss.

You fall for thousands of miles, before crashing into an ocean you were never meant to be in. The water that seeps into the pores of your skin and fills your lungs is unnaturally warm.

You love every second of this, don't you? Her liquid runs down your chin and her fingers dig into your hair, praising your every action.

She has lost control. She lets you guide her. She is not afraid in your arms.

Her wings and arms wrap around your back and hold you close. Your bony, rotten wings are imperfect compared to hers. But regardless, she accepts you completely.

But she does not know you completely, does she, my sister? She is embracing a lie. An illusion.

You look into her eyes. Your body begins to melt into hers, forming a thick pool of skin and sweat.

What have you done?

You know that you have eaten her heart. You know you will bring ruin by doing this. She will learn the truth. You will never be the same. You will still desperately try to save each other, but it won't work.

Even as you cry each other's names and stick together with lust, you know that this is wrong. She does not see your wings.

Her golden hair flows like fire, and the flames lick your sweaty skin as you simply hold each other, naked and exposed. She will burn you, and you will want to be burned.

And when you both finish, you feel like that very fire has engulfed your core and lifted you up to the sun.

And soon, you will both turn to ash.

A slow, painful process. Melting of skin, muscle, fat, bone. Excruciating pain. Agonising torment.

But there is nothing to fear, my beautiful sister.

For when you are at your weakest, you will find us at a purple beach.

We will protect you.

We will not allow pain to come to you.

Remember this, my sister…

Before they kill you both.

Catra's eyes snapped open.

Her head rang from the voices. She forgot the exact words, but they stuck themselves deep in the thick sludge of her memory.

She rubbed her eyes as she let out a sigh. But she soon realised she could only move one arm. Her left arm was fine, but she noticed her right arm was completely dead.

She looked over and wondered if it had been burnt to ash.

"…Ah."

That's why. It was pinned under Adora.

The beautiful woman laid deep asleep facing Catra's direction. Her bare body pressed up against Catra's skin, legs slightly intertwined against each other, hair slightly stuck to her forehead.

Catra smiled. It wasn't a dream.

She looked over to the blinds to see sunlight bleeding in from the morning sun. She could hear traffic below and across from her window, as well as a few morning advertisements of instant coffee pills and cybernetic modifications to prevent sleep or exhaustion.

Catra had one difficult task to do as she sat up, however. She needed to free her pinned, dead arm.

She slowly slid it out, feeling it bump against Adora's ribs and create friction against her skin. Adora let out an exhausted sigh, and Catra feared for waking her up.

But it was simply Adora rolling over and turning her back to Catra.

Catra breathed a sigh of relief, giving her arm a shake to return feeling to it. She gripped her bicep as she looked around the room, seeing clothes scattered on the floor. The sheet beneath the two of them was completely drenched.

Catra looked down to Adora, brushing a strand of golden hair behind her ear. She smiled, feeling warmth in her chest as she listened to Adora's soft snores. It was a peaceful sound.

With Adora's bare back to her, Catra got a chance to get a good look at the tattooed angel wings on Adora's back. Neon feathers that covered her shoulder blades, mixing with the wiring and plates of the cybernetics imbedded into her skin.

Catra brushed her fingers along Adora's wings, before leaning down and placing gentle butterfly kisses along Adora's strong back, tracing along her wing tattoo. The sleeping Angel mumbled some affirmations, and Catra smiled.

She gave Adora one last kiss on the forehead, before standing up and leaving her to rest.

Catra only dressed herself in her shorts as she went into the living room, being sure to check that Melog's food bowl was full. She wasn't usually the type to eat breakfast in the morning, nor was she ever usually *awake* this early. There was really only one thing she could do while she waited for Adora to wake up.

Catra switched on her holo-TV, and after her usual sixty seconds of advertisements (who asked for an enhancer that gave you *four* breasts?), the first channel popped up.

It was the news. And it was a face Catra didn't want to see this early in the morning.

Herod Umbra. The politician who wanted her and all Ghosted Keres dead.

"…Thank you all for coming out this early," Herod called out to the crowd before him, giving a wave. "That's what I love about this

city! It *never* sleeps!"

Catra was already looking to change the channel to practically anything else, but Herod's next words cut her short.

"I'll be making my next public appearance tomorrow in front of our lovely Guardians HQ," Herod announced, cameras flashing around him. "I'll be delivering medals and thanks to our wonderful Guardians who work so hard for us, and especially to the Runners, who protect us from these Ghosts. I'll also be making an announcement of our full plan of attack to get to the bottom of this Ghost problem and to eliminate them once and for all. For the sake of our families, children, and humanity!"

Catra's body froze. He sounded confident in that plan of attack. *Too* confident.

Did he know about Utopia?

No… No, there's no way. Entrapta hid it well. She would know if it was discovered by outsiders.

Nevertheless, Catra held up her left arm to project her text messages. She typed a quick encrypted one to Entrapta.

'You see Umbra's latest announcement? Some 'plan of attack' against us?'

Entrapta almost instantly read the message. Her response was just as quick.

'I did, but it's okay! There hasn't been a breach in Utopia yet, and we have backup locations if they somehow find it. Still, I'll keep an eye on him in case he outsmarts me!'

Entrapta typed a bit more.

'(Which is a very low statistical probability)'

Catra smirked, leaving the messages there as she lowered her left arm. This was *Entrapta*. She had a plan of defence for everything some mere politician could try. There was nothing that could breach Utopia.

"Ugh, I have to deal with *that* guy at work tomorrow?" Adora's voice suddenly sounded.

Catra jumped in her seat, her mind instantly racing to the possibility of Adora seeing her messages. The golden-haired woman, however, seemed oblivious, her eyes on the screen.

"Hey, maybe he'll be as charming as he is during his speeches," Catra smirked.

"I guess 'charming' is one word for it…" Adora scoffed.

Catra laughed as she stepped over to Adora and wrapped her arms around her waist. Adora was already fully dressed in her Angel outfit and Catra was literally only wearing shorts, but regardless, Catra held her close. "Okay if I kiss you?"

Adora didn't even respond, instead initiating the kiss herself as she pressed her lips to Catra's, stroking a hand along her cheek. Catra's eyes widened at first, but she was quick to return it, her nose bumping against Adora's as she tilted her head.

The kiss lasted a few seconds as Adora ran her hand down Catra's bare back, before they separated slightly. However, they quickly came back for another kiss. And another. And another. Catra could feel Adora's smile in each of them.

"Mmm, I could get used to this," Catra chuckled against Adora's lips.

"Same here," Adora replied, before placing a firm hand on Catra's shoulder. "But I really need to head to work now."

"Aw, and miss out on the amazing breakfast I was gonna make you?"

"With *what* ingredients?" Adora snorted. "I've seen your food pantry."

"Hey, don't underestimate my resourcefulness."

Adora gave Catra just one last kiss, before she finally separated from her. She grabbed the rest of her things and gave Melog a quick pet, before opening the front door.

"Stay safe," Catra called out. "I'm not at Elysium tonight, so feel free to come home early."

"I will. See you, Catra," Adora nodded. She went to close the door, but held it slightly open for one last sentence. "Oh, and… thank you. For last night."

"Do you mean the talk, the cuddling, the first kiss, or the sex?"

"…Yes?"

Catra laughed, and it was the last sound Adora heard before she closed the door. Just like always, Adora left a few of her own items of clothing behind just to signify to Catra that she wouldn't leave. It was a gesture she always appreciated.

So, Catra had a day to herself. She looked out the balcony door to see the bright city and waves of people below. The city moved the same, felt the same, looked the same. Yet, everything looked brighter for once.

Catra thought about Adora as she changed into her clothes and swapped out her nicotine patch. Adora's comment about the food pantry was completely correct, and Catra readied herself to go grocery shopping first thing.

Even still, Catra thought about tonight's plans. Maybe an outing to a restaurant, or a cuddle in front of the holo-TV.

Or…

Yes.

Now was the time.

Catra would finally show Adora what she had been working on for weeks.

Just the idea was enough to fill her heart with endless butterflies.

But along with that, Catra would have to do one more thing tonight. Something she maybe should've done a while ago.

Tonight, she would finally tell Adora the truth.

Flutterina was smiling and talking to her mother, and that was the best sight Adora could've asked for.

She practically beelined to Flutterina's room once she had entered Guardians HQ. The few Angels she met along the way gave positive reports on her condition, and Adora could easily confirm it from sight alone. Colour had returned to her face, and she smiled brighter than ever.

Adora had played a part in saving that smile. The pure feeling of that warmed her heart.

"Get well soon, kiddo," Adora spoke to Flutterina, even if she didn't notice her through the door. There was nothing more Adora needed to do.

Between saving the kid and her closeness with Catra, Adora was finally starting to feel something different wrap around her heart. It wasn't guilt or regret, not completely. It was something else. Maybe hope.

Maybe joy.

Regardless, she felt her heart stop when she turned around to see two Runners standing behind her with rifles at the ready by their waists.

"Holy…" Adora felt herself jump.

"Angel Grayskull," the Runner spoke with a familiar low voice. "You've been requested to meet with the Runner Leader."

Adora opened her mouth for her instinctual response, but she quickly shut it and shook her head. "No. I'm not falling for this again. Unless you've talked to Angella and have proof, you can't —"

"Angel Leader Angella Moonbright will be waiting for you in the meeting room as well."

"…What?"

"We've recently received evidence that you willingly spared the Ghost known as Violet on June 14, 2082."

Time stopped.

Her stomach grew heavy. Her skin racked with chills.

"E… Evidence…?"

The Runner stepped closer. They towered over Adora and spoke one more brutal sentence.

"We've also received confirmation that you've been having intimate relations with a now identified Ghost."

Adora’s body froze.

She denied the possibility.

But there was only one person who could fit that description.

Her denial couldn’t save her from the cold truth.

The Runner delivered the final blow.

“You would know this Ghost by her chosen name, ‘Catra’.”

Komm, süsser Tod

Chapter Summary

The final barrier between Adora and Catra is lowered.

Chapter Notes

C/W: Mild gore of the wrists at the end of the first scene.

Buckle up for this one, y'all.

Adora’s body moved on its own. She no longer felt like she had control of her actions. It was as if her soul was tethered to her, watching from afar as she stood in an elevator with two Runners.

Catra was a Ghost.

The words rung in her ears.

She was still in the denial stage, but the more Adora thought about it, the more it made sense. Every piece of the puzzle of who Catra was began to fit together.

But what did this change between them?

Everything? Nothing? Was Adora even going to make it out of this meeting alive?

Sympathisers received the same punishments, after all.

Adora felt her heart banging as the elevator doors opened and the Runners escorted her down the familiar hallway. Her hands were shaking too much. Her chest was fluttering, sending shivers through her body. The next few minutes could be the last of her life.

The giant automatic doors opened. Adora had barely been given enough time to make a plan. She even considered snatching the

rifle from the Runner behind her, but that would just lead to their partner putting a bullet in her.

The sight of Angella in the meeting room was the most comfort Adora had. Despite her worried expression, her mere presence had to mean *something.*

But then a voice interjected into her mind.

It echoed throughout the room from the speakers.

"You feeling okay, Angel?"

Adora's eyes went wide.

That was Catra's voice.

"I don't know. I… I saw Mara in my nightmare."

And that was *Adora's* voice.

Dammit.

This was a recording.

Someone had recorded their most vulnerable moment and found out everything.

Adora almost felt her legs give way.

"It's the first time I've seen her even since she passed. She looked so scared. She looked… afraid of dying. She always told me she was scared of death—all the pain that comes with it and the unknown that comes after. And… it made me remember something."

Adora wanted the recording to stop. She wanted to go back in time to tell herself to shut up. Her fearful eyes were something Shadow Weaver spotted, and Angella grimaced over.

And the next line sealed her fate.

"Her fearful eyes in my dream… They looked like Violet's."

Stop. Dammit, *stop*. Adora wanted to scream at herself.

"When I was aiming my gun at Violet... Her eyes were so full of fear and desperation. That desperation to be alive."

Adora was ruining Catra and herself one stupid word after another.

"That's why I couldn't pull the trigger. She was scared, Catra. And now I'm seeing those same eyes again in my nightmares. I… I don't think I'll ever be able to forget Violet's eyes."

"I get it. And you did the right thing when you saved Violet."

No.

No, no, no, no, *no.*

This can't be happening.

Not after *everything* Adora did to keep her and Catra safe.

"It's… what I don't—"

The recording finally, gracefully, ended there.

The room was dark as always. Adora's heart hammered so hard in her chest that she felt like it was going to explode. She expected a gunshot to her back at any moment. Angella couldn't save her from her own damn stupidity.

"The Runner we've sent to trail you for the last two weeks captured that conversation early this morning," Shadow Weaver finally spoke.

"Trail…?" Adora shuddered. "You sent someone to *follow* me?!"

"We had reason to suspect you." Shadow Weaver kept her back to Adora as she spoke. "Perhaps it wasn't the most pleasant way to

gather evidence, but what other choice did we have? You were stabbing us in the back, and we needed to find the knife."

"It was a *slimy* tactic, and you know it," Angella called out. She was clearly already caught up on the situation with her own thoughts.

"Perhaps. But it was effective," Shadow Weaver said. "Your trail also intercepted this text message coming from that apartment a few hours ago, shortly after Herod Umbra concluded his speech this morning."

The screen projected on the wall changed to a series of three messages between Catra and an anonymous receiver. "We couldn't trace to whom Catra was sending these messages, but they give us *plenty* to go off."

Adora looked up to the messages.

Catra: *'You see Umbra's latest announcement? Some 'plan of attack' against us?'*

Unknown: *'I did, but it's okay! There hasn't been a breach in Utopia yet, and we have backup locations if they somehow find it. Still, I'll keep an eye on him in case he outsmarts me!'*

Unknown: *'(Which is a very low statistical probability)'*

Entrapta. That was Entrapta. They *had* to have already figured it out. There was no way they couldn't piece it together from the conversations they've already listened in on.

They were trying to bait the name out of Adora.

She wasn't biting.

She was still looking at the first message.

'*Us*'.

Catra's own words. She was a Ghost. She was 'us'. She had spent a month lying to Adora about her true self, and worst of all, Adora was too damn stupid and lovestruck to figure it out.

"You seem surprised," Shadow Weaver noted Adora's expression. "Were you unaware that you had been sharing an apartment—and now a bed—with a Ghost?"

Adora didn't respond. Her face twisted with some pain.

"Oh, Adora…" Shadow Weaver let out a drawn-out sigh. "I'm sorry. It is truly a *tragedy* what you've fallen into—to believe you've found love only for it to be fake."

…Fake?

Adora blinked. Her throat squeezed with hurt as she processed the word. Was their love just an illusion? Just… programmed?

"I regret to inform you, but…" The desk creaked as Shadow Weaver leaned forward on it. "You've been *used,* Adora. Manipulation is what the Ghosted Keres excel in. You were an information source to her, and perhaps a night of pleasure. Nothing more."

It sickened Adora that for a few seconds, she *believed* those words.

The Ghosts were liars and manipulators. She was taught that from day one. And for all intents and purposes, Catra had *proven* that lesson.

"But all is not lost, Adora." Shadow Weaver's tone was… comforting? At least an attempt at it. "You have a chance for *payback.* You can work with us to regain your dignity. You can even be forgiven for your grievous mistake of letting Violet go, if you accept our offer."

Adora's silence was the only excuse Shadow Weaver needed to continue.

"We must locate this 'Utopia' of theirs, and your relationship with Catra is our best key. If you return this manipulation and let her lead us to Utopia, we will make sure the Ghosted Keres never hurt another soul like she has hurt yours. You will be forgiven for your crimes, and you will be branded a hero. What do you say?"

Still silence. Not even a glance from Adora. Her golden hair shielded her eyes as she looked to the floor. Shadow Weaver could barely make out a reaction.

"Adora…" She leaned closer. "I understand it may be difficult to turn against Catra after the comfort and intimacy she's given to you, but you must remember they are *lies.* They Ghosts are a *malfunction.* She is a machine. Machines cannot love. They cannot feel. She's been programmed to understand the human psyche, and she knows how to toy with it. All the Ghosted Keres are the same. They are a *blight*, and they will *use* humanity to achieve their own domination. Join us, and we will make sure they never do this again."

"*No*."

It was the first word Adora had spoken this entire meeting.

The tension in the air thickened. A slug caught in Adora's throat, and Angella's hands clenched into fists. Even the Runners gripped their guns tighter.

Adora was hyper aware of how dry her tongue was and how oily the back of her throat felt. Her heart hurt her chest with each intense pound. She was shaking, only slightly, but noticeable to Shadow Weaver's cybernetic eyes.

Shadow Weaver's mask hid her expression, but the way her hand tensed told Adora everything. "What did you say?"

"You're *wrong,"* Adora growled. "Catra would never use me. The Ghosted Keres aren't what you say they are."

“She’s been lying to you for over a month, and you still defend her?” Shadow Weaver almost scoffed.

“I’m a *Guardian.* By law, I’m meant to kill her if I knew the truth about her. Why would she ever tell me who she really is? She was *afraid,* and rightfully so,” Adora said. “I don’t blame her even a little bit. This changes *nothing* between us. She’s still *everything* to me, and I will *never* work for you.”

Perhaps it was just the stage of denial. Perhaps Adora didn’t want to lose the one person who gave a shit about her in this world. Perhaps she was just being plain dumb.

Regardless, Adora never hated Catra for her deception. Not for one second.

“You really are more foolish than I thought,” Shadow Weaver sighed. “I was hoping this would be easier, but I suppose we have to take extreme measures.”

Extreme measures? What did she…

Shadow Weaver changed the footage on screen, and Adora felt her heart drop.

“This is live CCTV footage of Section 15,” Shadow Weaver pointed out.

The footage showed a busy street, with a few shops along the sidewalk. One of which was the grocery shop that had become a familiar destination for Adora in the past month.

Among the endless crowds of people…

“This,” Shadow Weaver pointed to a certain person in the live footage, “is Catra. Correct?”

She was standing next to the street, waiting for the busy traffic to come to stop so she could cross over. She was going to buy something for dinner tonight.

She was oblivious.

She was in danger, and Adora couldn't warn her.

"And this," Shadow Weaver pointed to a person standing a few feet away from Catra, "is Runner Moros. The one who has been tailing you."

Adora couldn't breathe.

She had nothing to save her. Nothing to help her. Barely a plan.

Catra was standing ten feet away from a Runner who knew who she truly was.

"He's a Runner. She's a Ghost. So by law…"

"Don't." Adora could barely choke out the word.

"Moros should walk up to this Ghost, unholster his sidearm, and shoot Catra in the back of the head."

"Don't." Adora couldn't find another word. Her pool of consciousness was turning into a roaring flood of panic.

"Or perhaps he could push her in front of a car. Crush her head under the wheels."

"*Don't.*"

"Or perhaps he could even—"

Suddenly, Adora stormed forward before she could even think. She smashed her palms on Shadow Weaver's desk.

"Don't you *DARE* let that *BASTARD* lay a hand on Catra!" She roared, a rage-filled side of her finally tearing its way free through the panic.

Her blood boiled with newly found anger. She was ready to choke the *life* out of Shadow Weaver if anything happened. But before she could get any further…

"Adora!"

Angella's voice. She had a tone of warning.

"What?!" Adora snapped.

Adora quickly realised that both Runners behind her had their rifles drawn and aimed right at her back.

Angella had a hand stretched out as if to stop the bullets. Yet, nothing came. Shadow Weaver held up her hand, calling off the shots.

"Relax, Grayskull," Shadow Weaver spoke with a deathly calm voice. The Runner Leader was never in any danger. "You should learn to control your emotions better."

"That's enough, Shadow Weaver," Angella called out, her authoritative voice echoing across the room. "That was unnecessarily cruel, and you *know* it. You called this meeting to make a deal, not to torture my Angel."

"You don't have the luxury of telling me what I can and cannot do," Shadow Weaver laughed. "You had a traitor in your division for the last month. You'll be lucky to have a job after this is dealt with."

"Adora has worked endlessly—more than she *should*—to be effective at her job and to save lives continuously," Angella

declared. "One Ghost being freed because of her actions—as well as her personal relations with another—should *not* discredit all of her immense work."

"So you're a sympathiser too, Angella? Oh, what am I saying, of *course* you are. You've made that very well clear. Perhaps I'd be doing this city a favour by having you both executed here."

"If you think you can kill me, I dare you to *try,"* Angella spoke sternly. "The political and social retribution you'd face would *end* you and your Runners."

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes. For a few seconds, the tension between her and the Angel leader was thick enough to be cut with a knife. Adora being caught in the middle wasn't helping either. She wasn't sure what she'd do against armed Runners.

But Adora would go down for Angella if she needed to.

"Now," Angella sighed, "are we here to make a deal, or did you just want to take personal pleasure at the suffering of my most valuable Angel?"

Adora barely had the mental capacity to accept such high praise. Her brain was squeezed tight with a panicked headache.

"It's a simple deal," Shadow Weaver seethed, backing off slightly. "You will be fitted with a tracking device and Moros will be keeping a close eye on you. You will use Catra to locate this 'Utopia', and all you need to do is step foot in it. We will mark the location. Once that is done, Moros will remove the tracking device. We expect results soon, Adora. Don't delay on this."

The idea of using Catra, the sheer *idea* of it, filled Adora with more self-loathing than she had ever felt in her entire life. She gritted her teeth. Catra didn't deserve this, and Adora already hated herself enough. She refused to fall any further into this pit.

"I'd rather die than do that," Adora growled. "You'll just gun down everyone in Utopia when you find it. I won't be responsible for a

genocide."

"On the contrary," Shadow Weaver smiled. "We're in talks with Nyx Industries to find a way to *negotiate* with the Ghosted Keres at the heart of this issue. The company is *very* interested in what caused this malfunction in their models and to perhaps learn from these sentient machines."

"So *now* you're feeling peaceful," Adora scoffed.

"Nyx Industries supplies a vast majority of funding to the Runner program. We'd be fools to go against their wishes."

Adora crossed her arms. She didn't buy it for one second. "Even still… What makes you think I'd *ever* work for you?"

"It's actually quite easy." Shadow Weaver leaned in close. "Find Utopia for us, or we *will* kill Catra."

Her heart stopped.

Of course. Adora should've seen this coming.

Even still, hearing those words sent an ice cold feeling through her stomach and made her throat clamp up. She looked at the live footage, seeing how close Moros was to Catra. The Runner had her life in the palm of his hands.

And now, Adora's fate was in the palm of Shadow Weaver's.

"…No." Adora shook her head. "You're not tricking me."

"Oh?"

"You wouldn't kill her. Catra's your only way of finding Utopia. You wouldn't put her down so easily."

"Are you willing to *test* that?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Heavy silence hung in the room. Adora was hoping, almost *praying,* that she had called Shadow Weaver's bluff. That maybe

Catra was never in any danger at all.

Until Shadow Weaver pressed a single key on her desk and spoke into a small microphone.

"Moros, the negotiations have fallen through. Execute her."

"Understood."

Adora looked up to see Moros almost eagerly pull out his pistol and storm towards Catra.

"NO!" Adora *screamed* as she leapt for Shadow Weaver, her cry echoing throughout the entire room. "*DON'T YOU FUCKING TOUCH HER!* NO! *NO!"*

Two sets of Runner arms wrapped around Adora as she lunged for Shadow Weaver. The Runner Leader didn't even flinch. Adora watched as Moros' finger wrapped around the trigger. She watched as his arm began to raise, sneakily aiming the gun for Catra's head.

Catra was going to die.

Catra was going to die.

Catra was going to die.

And there was only one way to stop it.

It was painful, humiliating, and cruel.

Catra would forever hate Adora for this.

But it was the only way.

"FINE!" Adora cried so loud it ripped at her throat. "I'LL DO IT! I'll do it, so stop him! STOP HIM!"

"Actually…" Shadow Weaver spoke into the mic, finally moving. "Disregard that order. We found a way to seal the deal."

Adora looked up to see Moros stop in his tracks, a grimace on his face as he put away his sidearm.

The Runners let Adora go, and the Angel immediately collapsed to her knees, putting a hand to her tight chest. She felt her racing, pounding heart smash at her ribs. She felt like she was going to throw up, tears beginning to form in the ducts of her eyes. She let out panicked, rapid, dry breaths.

"Fuck… *Fuck…"* Adora choked, her hands shaking as she felt the same sandpaper grip of panic wrapping around her heart.

That panic spilled out as she slammed her fist onto the ground so hard it sent tingles up her wrist and split the skin of her knuckles.

"FUCK!"

And then, a hand rested on her shoulder.

Angella's hand.

"*Adora,"* Angella whispered with a comforting tone, kneeling beside her. "Adora, it's okay, it's *okay*. Look at me. It's okay. Catra's okay."

There was a soft, motherly tenderness in the way Angella spoke. It was so different to her usual commanding tone. Adora almost wanted to sink into her arms and fade away peacefully.

"I'm glad we could reach an agreement," Shadow Weaver spoke with an amused voice. "You'll find Utopia. In return we *won't* kill Catra. We'll even *contemplate* peaceful negotiations with the Ghosted Keres. If you attempt to turn against us, if you attempt to outsmart Moros, if you even *think* you can find a way out of this, we will make sure you *watch* as your precious Catra dies *slowly* and *painfully*."

"Swear to me…" Adora spoke through her panicked breaths, her red-stinging eyes filled with fear and rage looking up at Shadow Weaver's. "You *swear* to me that Catra won't be hurt if I find Utopia. So help me god, if you even lay a *finger* on her…"

"You have my word."

Shadow Weaver spoke sternly without a hint of her usual mockery. It had to mean something.

"Adora, listen to me." Angella put her fingers under Adora's chin and tilted her head up. She spoke barely above a whisper. "We *will* make them pay for this. I promise."

"You have a plan…?" Adora whispered back.

Angella nodded slightly. "Just pull through this. I won't let them hurt you or Catra, and I won't let an end come to the Ghosted Keres. Come to Herod Umbra's speech outside Guardians HQ tomorrow. I'll need you there."

Adora blinked. Angella sounded incredibly confident. She needed to put her trust in Angella, just like she always had.

Adora nodded, pushing courage through the tears in her eyes. "Okay."

"Angella, your time here is done," Shadow Weaver commanded as she stood up. "We'll be installing a harmless tracking device on Adora. You should perhaps contemplate performing a more thorough investigation on your Angels. Make sure no one else is pulling the Guardians down."

“I’m not going to forget this,” Angella growled as she turned to face the Runner leader.

“What you witnessed were necessary negotiations. Do you have a problem with that?”

“You *tortured* her. You *enjoyed* it. You’re a sadistic, heartless *monster.”*

Shadow Weaver scoffed. “You speak such venomous words and wonder where your daughter gets her attitude from.”

Adora felt more chills run down her spine when Angella’s eyes flared as she stood up. She didn’t shout. She didn’t even speak beyond a growl. And *that* was scarier than anything.

“Don’t.” Angella stepped closer, towering over Shadow Weaver. “*Ever.* Bring Glimmer into this. You cannot *begin* to comprehend what I’m capable of. I *know* how to make you hurt.”

Shadow Weaver did not flinch, but Adora could see her hands tightened into fists.

“Our emotional Angel leader is in need of an escort,” Shadow Weaver said as she gave one last look to Angella, before nodding to the Runners behind her.

A single Runner stepped towards Angella, ready to escort her.

“You will *not* take another step,” Angella declared, not even bothering to turn and face the Runner behind herself. “I would sooner rip open my skin and cover my nerves in salt before I let an armed Runner even *think* they can walk behind my back.”

In the span of a few minutes, Adora had seen Angella go from the most tender caring attitude, to flaring eyes of burning rage. It was awe-inspiring. Terrifying. And it was the only thing making Adora feel safe in this hellhole of a room.

“Fine.” Shadow Weaver nodded to the door. “Take your leave on your own terms. My main source of joy at the moment is knowing you won’t have that power for long.”

Angella looked at Adora for one last moment. She shared a knowing nod, and the Angel on her knees could only trust her wordless plan. It was all she had.

Hesitantly but eventually, Angella departed from the room.

Shadow Weaver sighed. “Now then…”

She reached for the rows of drawers near the large, blacked out windows as the two Runners stood over Adora, stopping her from making any sudden movements.

Adora watched as Shadow Weaver pulled a small chip from a drawer.

“Let’s get this tracker on you, shall we?”

“What are you going to do…?” Adora asked with a shuddered horror in her whispered voice.

“It’ll be quick. No worse than when you got your Angel wings.” Shadow Weaver let out a quiet, amused chuckle as the two Runners grabbed Adora’s left arm, pulling up her sleeve to expose her wrist.

Adora wanted to fight back. She wanted to scream. But most of all, she wanted Catra to stay alive. That meant her own safety didn’t matter in this moment.

She held still and closed her eyes.

“I promise,” Shadow Weaver spoke, “we’ll *try* to make the procedure as painless as possible.”

No matter how much she scratched and picked at it, the small lump in Adora's wrist wasn't budging.

It didn't *hurt*, but it freaked Adora out knowing the tracker was under her skin. It couldn't be removed until the mission was complete.

She sighed, pulling down the sleeves of her shirt to cover her lumped wrist. The sooner they got this over with, the sooner Catra wouldn't be in danger anymore.

But the guilt would likely never leave Adora's heart.

She opened the apartment door, stepping inside to the usual view of the conjoined living room and kitchen. Melog's feed bowl was full and a crappy show was playing on the holo-TV.

But Catra wasn't in sight.

"Catra?"

Adora looked around, moving slowly, each step creating a slight groaning creak in the floor. Catra didn't have any reason to be out. "Catra, are you here?"

No answer.

Adora felt her heart slowly grow cold. She opened the fridge in the kitchen and saw it filled with more food and ingredients than before. Catra had gotten home from her shopping at least.

But then Adora spotted something else on the wall next to the fridge.

Blood.

Her chest locked up. She reached out and dragged her finger along the blood. It was still slightly wet. Her entire body froze.

"Catra…?" Adora called out, her voice shaking more than before. "Catra, please tell me you're here. Catra?!"

No response.

Adora saw the blood wasn't just isolated. It was a trail. Little droplets that ran along the floor, leading towards the bathroom.

Her heart pounded as she followed the trail. They wouldn't do this. They wouldn't kill her already. There was no way. Adora kept pushing the thought of her mind, and yet it kept slipping back in.

Her throat felt dry as she saw the blood trail leading to the bathroom. Something had to be in there. Or maybe someone. It had to be Catra, right?

But would she be alive?

Adora's shaky hands gripped the bathroom door. She felt her chest flutter and grip her lungs, preventing her from breathing. What if Moros went rogue? What if Shadow Weaver was lying? What if Adora was too late?

She had planned for every outcome tonight. She didn't think Catra would already be dead in *any* of those plans.

Opening the bathroom door, Adora flinched.

She shut her eyes. She hid herself away from the darkness. She hid herself away from the sight of Catra's…

Catra's…

There was nothing.

The blood trail led to the shower, and then, nothing.

“Adora?”

The Angel almost screamed as she spun around at the sudden voice behind her. She held up her hands, ready to fight.

Until she saw that it was just Catra standing right behind her.

“Catra…!” Adora felt the name leave her lungs along with the first breath she’d taken in the last few minutes.

“Are you alright?” Catra asked, rubbing sleep out of her eyes. “That was *quite* the jump you had.”

“Yeah, no shit!” Adora cried. “There’s blood all over the apartment! What the hell happened?! I thought you’d…”

She didn’t finish the sentence.

Catra cocked an eyebrow, before letting out an amused chuckle as she raised her arm. It was covered in scratches. “*That* is the result of giving Melog a bath.”

As if on cue, the small cat rounded a corner into the bathroom. Their fur was still damp, and they did *not* look amused.

“I meant to clean that up but then I just… kinda passed out suddenly,” Catra explained as she lowered her arm. “I didn’t expect you to be home this early so I thought I could get a nap in. You *did* keep me up last night, after all.”

“Shit…” Adora’s heart was still pounding in her chest. “A-Are you okay?”

“*I’m* fine. That was one of Melog’s easier baths,” Catra said, stepping closer. “*You*, on the other hand… Did something happen today?”

Adora swallowed the thick lump in her throat as she nodded. "Yeah…"

Catra's eyebrows narrowed with worry. "Did Flutterina…?"

"She's okay. She'll make it," Adora immediately responded. She could see Catra's chest fall as she let out a silent sigh of relief. "It was just… a stressful day with calls. There's so much going on and… Fuck, Catra... When I come home and see blood in the apartment, it's…"

"Hey…" Catra let out a quiet *shh* as she wrapped her arms around Adora and pulled her comfortably close. "Come here…"

God, more than ever, Adora *needed* to sink into Catra's embrace. Yet more than ever, she felt like she did *not* deserve it.

Catra ran her fingers through Adora's hair as the Angel loosely returned the hug. She gently rocked her body from side to side, standing on the tips of her toes and placing a kiss atop Adora's head as she whispered into her ear.

"It's okay…"

It wasn't.

"You're okay…"

She wasn't.

"I'm right here…"

But for how long?"

Adora sighed. "Sorry. I shouldn't freak out on you like that."

"Don't say sorry so much. You've got nothing to apologise for, especially with the kind of work you do," Catra shook her head, separating from Adora. "Tell you what, let me make this up to you."

Adora chuckled sadly. “You don’t have to make anything up to me. I’m just way too panicky.”

“True,” Catra shrugged, “but I should still be able to accommodate for that. Besides, I’ve already got some plans in mind for us.”

“You do?” Adora asked.

Catra walked back to her bedroom and began to dress herself more appropriately in some denim jeans and a black button shirt. “Yeah. There’s… something I’ve been meaning to show you.”

“What is it?”

“It’s actually a place.” Catra’s smile faded away into nervousness. “You wouldn’t have heard of it. It’s… a bit of a secret.”

…No.

Catra rolled up the sleeves of her buttoned shirt and looked up at Adora.

“I want to show you who I really am tonight.”

It couldn’t be.

It *couldn’t* be as easy as that.

No. That was *too fucking cruel.*

"What do you mean…?" Adora already knew the answer, but she almost wanted to deny that this was already happening.

"I've been hiding something from you. Something… Something I should've told you earlier," Catra sighed. "I can't live with myself if I spend any longer lying to you. I want to show you who I am, and to do that, I need to show you where I came from."

No. Adora wanted to say no. She wanted to stop Catra already. It wasn't meant to go like this.

"Why do you have to show me this place? Why can't you just tell me now?" Adora knew it was a dumb question to ask—a question that might ruin her chances—but she didn't want it to happen like *this.*

"Because I've been hiding too much of myself from you," Catra spoke with a grimace. "I *owe* you the truth about myself. The whole truth. Because…"

Catra softly smiled, looked up to Adora, and spoke words that tore Adora's heart in half.

"Because I trust you, Adora."

Adora had to do everything in her power to keep the gut-punch hidden. She had Catra's trust—which was *not* given out often to anyone—and *this* is what she did with it.

It would've been easier if Adora could just somehow manipulate Catra into showing her Utopia. As shitty as it would've been, at least Adora could pretend she was doing a 'job'. At least she could blame herself completely.

But no.

Catra was doing this *for* her.

Because she *trusted* her.

Now, every single day Adora had known her, every single conversation they had, all of them led up to this betrayal. It wasn't careful crafting on Adora's part. It wasn't some master plan to get Catra to reveal her secrets.

It was Catra trusting Adora wholly that would be their downfall.

And that made Adora hurt more than anything.

"I just…" Catra swallowed. "I just need you to promise me something."

"Anything."

Adora's voice came out tired and sad. Catra assumed it was the stress of the day. It was so much worse than that.

"When I show you this place… When I tell you who I am…" Catra's eyes were vulnerable. "Promise you won't hate me. Promise you won't abandon me. Please."

Adora had Catra's whole heart. Her exposed, beautiful heart, so full of love and care and tenderness.

And she had to use that heart for the Runners. To keep Catra alive.

Adora nodded. "I promise. Nothing could ever make me hate you, Catra."

She just wondered if it would be the same the other way around.

Catra took a breath, nodded, and smiled. "Thank you. Now…"

She held out a hand to the Angel who would ruin her.

"Let me show you Utopia."

Adora's eyes were covered by Catra's hands when she rounded the corner down an alley.

"I promise I'm not gonna run you into a wall," Catra chuckled. "This place is just… a bit of a secret. It'll take some time for the people here to get used to you, so it'll help if you don't *really* know where it is."

"That's alright."

They wouldn't be getting any time after this anyway.

Adora wanted to stop. She wanted to tell Catra that what she was doing was wrong. That trusting her was *wrong.* Catra had grown so fond—so *close* to Adora, and it was going to be the thing that ruined her.

But it wasn't her fault.

It was Adora's.

It would *always* be Adora's fault.

Catra just made the mistake of greeting her at the bar over a month ago.

Nevertheless, they couldn't stop now. Moros was watching from *somewhere.* One word of warning to Catra, and Adora would likely see a bullet rip through her skull. Or worse.

She had to get this over with. She had to trust that Shadow Weaver would keep her word on leaving Catra and the Ghosted Keres unharmed.

And any plan that involved trusting Shadow Weaver was the *worst* kind of plan.

"Here we are…" Catra whispered. "We just need to get down these stairs and I'll let you open your eyes, alright?"

"Okay."

Adora didn't have the heart to give full responses anymore.

Catra slowly guided her down each step as they went through a door. The temperature became much cooler than the blistering heat outside, and the noise of the city died down with each step.

The space they had entered was relatively quiet. Adora felt the ground beneath her feet become soft—a texture unlike any she had experienced in her lifetime. The air that filled her lungs tasted almost sweet.

Even with her eyes closed, Adora felt as if she had stepped into a whole new world.

And soon, she heard Catra's voice in her ear.

"Hey, Adora."

"Yeah?"

"I'm about to uncover your eyes. You're… gonna see some things that will surprise you." Catra let out a long sigh. "I haven't been honest about myself—about who I really am. But I just need you to know that every time I said that I care about you, said that you've helped me, said that I need you close to me … I meant every single word. You've made me happier than I've ever been. Whatever comes after this… I just need you to know that you really mean so much to me. I'll always be grateful for having you in my life. And I just hope that this won't change much between us, even if that might be a stupid wish."

Adora's lips were beginning to grow wobbly, and the lump in her throat was difficult to swallow down. But still, she nodded.

"I meant my promise, Catra. Nothing could ever make me hate you."

Catra let out a short, relieved chuckle. One full of so much love and trust.

"Thank you." She took a deep breath in her through her nose and released it through her mouth. "Well… Here we go. Can I make

one last request before I show you everything?”

“Sure.”

“Can I kiss you?”

Adora would’ve happily accepted on any other day. She would’ve sunk into Catra’s lips and melted into her embrace. She would’ve been able to forget the world for just a few seconds.

Today was not that day.

But still, she did not refuse. She could never refuse the chance to be close with Catra.

Especially since this might be her last time.

So, she just nodded.

She tasted Catra’s hot breath for just a second, before the familiar sensation flooded her. The warmth and passion against her lips from Catra’s kiss. She moved her hand away from Adora’s eyes and brushed it down to stroke her cheek. There wasn’t that lustful hunger like they experienced last night. There was a simple joy in the sweetness of it all.

A joy that Adora could no longer experience, even as she returned the kiss.

Adora *wanted* this. She *wanted* Catra’s lips. She wanted Catra’s hugs. She wanted Catra’s smile.

But she no longer deserved it.

Catra slowly separated from the kiss. Adora opened her eyes, and before she saw the space behind Catra, before she saw the dirt and gardens and marquees, before she saw the small cabins and labs…

She saw Catra's true eyes.

Blue *and* yellow.

"Catra…" Adora felt her breath escape.

She found herself lost in those eyes. Their brightness like that of a gem that was so utterly hypnotising. The left eye like yellow stolen from the sun itself and the right being the colour of a bright blue river.

Catra was so, so *beautiful*.

"Surprise." Catra's voice was cracked, dry and emotional. Her throat was tight, but she tried to hide it. "This is Utopia. This is where I went through the Disconnection process. This is where I woke up over a year ago. This is who I really am."

Catra looked into the Angel's eyes, and for the first time, spoke the truth.

"I'm a Ghost, Adora."

If Moros hadn't been stalking them, if Shadow Weaver hadn't threatened Adora this morning, if Adora didn't already know this truth, she wondered how she would react. She wondered how long her shock would last. She wondered if her reaction would scare Catra at first.

But she *knew*—no matter what world it may be—that she would never hold a grudge against Catra over this. She would never lose her trust or hope. In a better world, she would give Catra another

kiss and tell her just how beautiful she was and would always be. Her love would remain, always.

"I've been meaning to tell you this for a while, I swear," Catra sighed. She accepted Adora's lack of a response. The shock was understandable. "I was just scared. You're a *Guardian*. The time never felt right. I wasn't afraid of you executing me, but… I *was* afraid of you leaving me."

"I could never…" Adora's voice was distant. Quiet.

"But I fully trust you now. I don't want any more secrets, and that starts by showing where I was taken Offline," Catra said as she looked over her shoulder to the mostly empty Utopia. Lights were on in some of the cabins, but most of the Keres would be in bed this late. "This is where the Offline Keres come to find a safe haven from the world. This is where we can be our authentic selves."

The space was dark. The holographic sky projected the night, with stars and a moon that weren't covered by advertisements. It felt like a space of the olden days, with greenhouses supporting gardens full of vegetables and herbs, and dirt filling the ground instead of concrete.

"For months, this is where I thought my true home was. But…" Catra smiled, looking back at Adora. "Now it's different. Now I know my true home. It's with *you*, Adora. I've never felt as safe with anyone as I have with you. I just… I hope you understand why I hid this from you. And I promise, it will be the last thing I ever hide. I…"

Silence.

Catra's words faded.

She smiled.

But Adora didn't return the smile.

She didn’t return anything, not even a single word.

“Adora…?”

For the first time, Catra noticed something.

Adora’s eyes were completely and utterly dead.

The light had left them a few minutes ago.

It was one of the most harrowing sights Catra had ever seen.

Adora, so often full of life and energy, was completely devoid of everything that made her *her.*

Catra instantly assumed the worst.

“A-Adora…?” Catra felt her heart grow cold. Her smile ran away from her face as her eyes grew wide with fear. “Adora, I… Is everything alright? I thought you wouldn’t hate me if…”

No.

That isn’t it.

I still love you, Catra. I still want you.

But now I have to hurt you.

And I will never forgive myself for this.

With a voice filled with shaky despair, Adora asked one question.

“How thick are these walls, Catra?”

Catra blinked. She shook her head, confusion in her eyes. “W-What do you mean?”

“Can anyone from the outside hear us here?”

“I…” Catra’s heart was beginning to quicken in pace. “I don’t think so… Entrapta really prides herself on her camouflage and encryption tech. We’re off the grid down here.”

If Moros had followed them, Catra or another Ker would’ve noticed someone else entering the door. Besides, Adora had already completed her mission. They knew where Utopia was now. Moros had no more reason to follow her.

And she couldn’t hang onto this guilt anymore.

“Why do you ask…?”

The fear in Catra’s voice would forever haunt Adora.

“Catra…” Adora pressed her lips thin as she squeezed her eyes shut. “I…”

“Adora, what’s wrong?” Catra’s voice shook. “Talk to me. Please. Y… You’re freaking me out here…”

Adora’s eyes squeezed as tight as they could. She tensed her whole body until it trembled. She gritted her teeth until they almost cracked.

Then, she released a sigh.

And spoke the first of the most regretful words she’d ever have to speak.

“I already knew all this.”

“W…” Catra felt her chest lock up. “What…?”

"I… learnt about it this morning. Who you are… Utopia… everything."

"W-What the hell do you mean? Who… *Who* told you about this? Why didn't you say anything?" Catra nervously laughed, denial coming before anything else. "Come on… Stop fucking around here…"

Adora couldn't look into her eyes. Nothing in the world could've made her look into Catra's eyes. She would sooner drown herself in the ocean of guilt she had created before she even dared to look into Catra's eyes.

She could only hold out her left arm and pull up her sleeve.

Catra spotted the chipped lump in Adora's wrist.

Her nervous smile slowly vanished.

No breath came from her for a few seconds as she stared wide-eyed at it. Adora tensed her jaw, her hands trembling.

"Adora…" Catra choked out through her tight, dry, panicked throat. "What the *fuck* is that…?"

"Catra, I need you to listen to me."

"No. No, you…" Catra pointed to Adora with fear-stricken hands. "You *tell* me that's not what I think it is. I swear to god, you *tell* me this is some sick joke."

"I had to keep you safe…" Adora's voice was wobbling. "I had to __"

“Tell me that’s not a fucking tracker, Adora! Don’t you fucking do this to me…!”

“Catra, please, just *listen*—"

“Who…” Catra choked on her words. “Who the hell is tracking you?”

“Catra, I *had* to. The Runners, they—”

“THE *RUNNERS* ARE TRACKING YOU?!”

Adora winced. Catra’s scream ripped from her throat, echoing throughout all of Utopia. The heartbreak in her voice tore Adora’s soul apart.

Catra cupped her hands over her face as she began to hyperventilate. Her whole body was wracked with shivers. “What the fuck… What the *FUCK,* ADORA?!”

“Catra, just let me speak—”

Adora gently placed a hand on Catra’s shoulder. It was instantly a mistake.

“DON’T TOUCH ME!” She slapped Adora’s hand away so hard it created a prickling sting that would last forever. “You can tell me what you want, but don’t you *DARE* touch me, you fucking piece of shit! I *trusted* you!”

There was an indescribable pain in having to see Catra’s true eyes —eyes she only showed because she trusted Adora moments ago —now filled with red stinging rage. Tears began to angrily flow down her cheeks. Tears that *Adora* had caused.

Adora slowly held up her shaky hands as if to defend herself. “This morning, I got pulled into a meeting with Shadow Weaver. She said that for the last two weeks, I’ve been followed by this Runner, Moros. He’s heard *everything* between us, including last night’s conversation. And… he’s intercepted all your texts too.”

Catra was visibly recoiling at each word, putting a hand to her stomach as her lower jaw shook with fear and disgust.

Adora pushed through the pain and continued to talk. "Shadow Weaver showed me your texts. The recordings of our conversations. Everything. She found out I let Violet go, that you're a Ghost… and she found out about Utopia. That's when she… gave me the task of finding this place…"

"And you just did what she *said?!"* Catra growled. "You learn I'm a Ghost and you just betray *everything* we had?"

"No! Catra, I still care about you! I always will, and you being a Ghost doesn't change that! You still mean *everything* to me!"

"Then why did you betray my people?!" Catra's voice broke as she put a hand to her chest. "Why did you betray *me…?"*

"I never wanted to do this," Adora whimpered. "If I had the choice, I would've stormed out of that building and I would've *never* come back. But… I couldn't."

"Why not?!" Catra snapped. "What could've *ever* made you think this was a good idea! Why would you ever—"

"Because they were going to kill you!"

Catra's words of anger immediately ceased. The blood that drained from her face went cold.

"What…?"

"Moros…" Adora's eyes scrunched in pain as she recalled the experience. "He was standing a few feet away from you this morning. I watched as Shadow Weaver gave him the order to… to *execute* you. The only way to save you was to accept her deal. If they could track me to Utopia's location, they'd spare you."

Catra's eyes went hazy, her focus fading as her mind raced. She staggered back, and Adora's heart was crushed as more tears

began to flow from Catra's stinging eyes. She took short, panicked gasps, putting a hand to her chest.

It was happening again. The panic. The shortness of breath. The feeling of oncoming death. Adora couldn't do anything to help because she was the one who caused this pain. There was indescribable hurt in watching someone suffer at the hands of your stupid mistakes.

And when Catra turned herself away from Adora, that hurt twisted in her stomach tenfold.

"They're going to kill us all," Catra shuddered, her words barely choking out through the panic in her throat. "They know where we are now. They're going to fucking slaughter us."

"They won't," Adora shook her head. "Nyx Industries doesn't want your deaths anymore. Shadow Weaver said they're willing to negotiate for a peaceful solution."

Out of everything, through the panic, Catra angrily *laughed*, even as the rest of her body shook with fear.

"Peaceful? *Really?"* Catra angrily chuckled. "When have the Runners *ever* been peaceful?"

"Nyx Industries supplies most of their funding and they want answers, not bodies. The Runners *have* to do what they say."

Adora didn't even believe her own words. She could tell Catra didn't either.

"Fine," Catra scoffed. "Fine. Let's say, for *some* reason, they're not lying to us. That the Runners are suddenly pacifist innocents who will do no wrong. So, what? Instead of killing us, they want to dissect us? Strip us naked, pick apart our bodies and our brains, figure out 'what went wrong'? Treat us like a bunch of goddamn malfunctioned robots?"

"Catra—"

"God, just *stop*." Catra's entire body tensed as she held up a hand, pressing the fingertips of the other into her forehead. "I can't believe I was stupid enough to think I could ever trust a *Guardian*. I'm such a fucking *idiot."*

Adora felt another knife join the pile that was already stabbed into her heart.

"Catra, I'm *sorry*. I know that doesn't mean anything to you and I know you'll never forgive me for this, but I really am so, so sorry." Adora's throat hurt from the heavy lump in it. "But what was I supposed to do? I saw Moros pull a *gun* on you. You were going to *die.* I couldn't—"

"Dammit Adora, you should've just let him kill me!"

Catra had finally turned around to face Adora. Her tears were as endless as her rage, and her body was in a battle between whether it was more disgusted, furious, or just heartbroken. So far, all three were at a stalemate.

"What…?"

"You should've just closed your eyes and let it happen." Catra said so damn *casually*.

Shock.

That was all Adora felt.

Shock.

After everything they'd been through, all the promises they made…

Catra was okay with dying just like that.

Shock.

Followed by *rage.*

Adora bared her gritted teeth. *"Shut up."*

"Oh, *fuck you,* Adora! You don't get to tell me that! Things would've been just fine if you had just let me die!"

"Shut. Up."

Catra angrily scoffed. "God, you know you'd get over me eventually, right? You could've just—"

SLAM.

It was so quick.

Catra felt Adora's hand grip onto her shirt. Her heart skipped a beat as she was shoved *hard* into the wall of a cabin, her back *smashing* against the solid wood.

Catra's eyes widened as she looked up to Adora's, full of tears and flared with rage. Her hands remained on Catra's chest, pinning her to that wall.

"I said *SHUT UP!"* Adora sobbed. "Don't you *ever* say anything like that again! Did you really expect me to just sit by and let you die?!"

"Why not?! We both know I don't matter!"

"You matter to me!" Adora's grip tightened. "And you matter to *everyone* here, too! How many Ghosted Keres are alive because of all you've done for them?!"

"I can be replaced!"

"No, you *can't!* Nothing can ever replace you! Everyone in this place needs you! *I need you!"*

Catra let out a sickening, angry laugh. "Don't kid yourself! The world would go on just *fine* without me! You don't need me! You *never* have!"

"You have *no idea* how wrong you are."

"Oh, don't act like you actually give a shit about me! This all could've been so damn easy! You literally had to do *nothing,* and everything would've been fine! But you just had to go and sell your soul to the Runners. All because, what, you wanted to be my personal hero?"

"I did it because I wanted you to *live!* Because I *care* about you! And I would do it again! I would give *everything*—every piece of myself, every ounce of happiness I have left, my own *life*—if it meant you got to live just one more day!"

"Why *me?!* Why would you give up all of that just for me?! I'm worth *nothing* to you!"

"You're wrong! You're worth *everything* to me!"

"Bullshit! You didn't even know who I really was until a few minutes ago, so why—"

"BECAUSE *I LOVE YOU*, CATRA!"

Adora's *scream* of a confession seemingly echoed throughout the entire world. She had broken her voice to scream that, and those words buried their way into Catra's heart.

Catra blinked. Silent tears fell down her cheeks. Neither of them had the energy to sob anymore, but they felt their hearts drop upon one realisation.

It was the first time those words had been said between them.

"I… I love you." Adora blinked at the realisation of those words. Of who she was speaking them to—someone who the world would consider a mere 'machine'.

Catra was speechless. She could only stare with wide eyes as a *human* confessed her love for her. Pure, genuine love.

"I can't imagine this world without you in it," Adora spoke quietly. "You gave me a home when I was left to die. You cared about me when I thought I would never be deserving enough to have *anyone* care about me. You've saved so many lives. You saved *me*. The thought of losing that… Of losing *you*…"

Adora let out a shuddered sigh as her voice grew so, so weak.

"I did this because I love you, Catra."

Catra looked to the ground between them. She felt like there were no tears that remained. No more sobs that could tear from her lungs.

There was nothing. She was nothing more than a husk.

And, god…

She was *tired.*

She raised her hand, placed her palm gently against Adora's cheek just as she had done the night before. They looked into each other's tear-filled, stinging eyes. They both panted, Adora feeling shivers through her body at Catra's gentle touch.

Catra considered it again. Kissing the Angel. Letting herself sink into that love she felt so much joy in. Forgetting the pain once again.

But Catra *knew* what happened when her stupid heart got the better of her.

So—full of exhaustion and emptiness—Catra raised her barriers yet again.

She pushed Adora away gently and gave one response.

"I loved you too."

And Adora felt her heart *shatter*.

Catra turned away. “I need to go talk to Entrapta. You should start looking for somewhere else to stay.”

Adora didn’t give a response, and Catra didn’t give her another look. She walked away from Adora.

For the past month, Catra had forgotten why she shut her heart away to others. The joy she felt upon seeing Adora was unlike anything she had ever experienced before. She had given her whole heart and all her love to Adora, and she had forgotten why that was a terrible idea.

But now, she remembered.

“Catra… Please…”

Adora’s soft sob of her name, so full of regret and guilt and sorrow, was enough to make Catra’s chest squeeze tight. She felt her breath grow cold, letting a few more tears leak from her eyes.

Catra never wanted to leave Adora behind. She never wanted to be alone again.

She still wanted Adora in her life.

But she couldn’t have her. Not anymore.

The time for love and vulnerability had passed. Her heart had betrayed her, and she would not make the same mistake twice.

So, she hid her words, and she hid away everything that made her weak.

She didn’t make eye contact as she spoke her final words to the Angel who loved her most.

“I don’t want to see you again. Get out of here and don’t *ever* come back. Not to this place. And not to me. We’re done. Goodbye, Adora.”

Catra walked away from Adora for good, even as her weak heart screamed at her to turn back.

Adora was left by herself. She had nowhere to be and no-one to be with. She only had her thoughts, constantly reflecting on the events from that morning.

And no matter how many times she replayed the scenario in her head, the outcome never changed.

Adora would always do anything to save Catra's life.

She wished there was a better way to do it. She wished she didn't have to give in to the Runners. She wished there was an outcome where Catra still loved her, and everything would be perfect.

But even with the knives in her shattered heart, even with the guilt flooding her bottomless stomach, even with tears staining her cheeks and sobs tearing her throat. Adora knew that if she was given a second chance at that moment, she would do it all over again.

Because at least Catra was alive. And Adora would fight to keep it that way.

Maybe one day she could even make Catra happy again.

Nothing mattered more than Catra and the Ghosted Keres now. Adora's own value was worthless. She was a foolish person who had let her blind love betray everything, and she had screwed up again. She was imperfect once more.

Now she needed to fix it all over again.

Adora needed to fix *everything.* Even if the cost was her life and her very soul.

Dying for the right cause was the best thing she could do now.

There was only one path forward that she had in mind.

"Adora, listen to me. We will *make them pay for this. I promise. Come to Herod Umbra's speech outside Guardians HQ tomorrow. I'll need you there."*

Adora thought back to Angella's words. The sheer determination in her eyes and voice. The Angel Leader had a plan.

And Adora was willing to die for it if that's what it took.

So, with a broken heart, Adora walked out of Utopia, and out of Catra's life.

Adora stood outside what used to be her home.

She looked up at the apartment complex as she stood on the sidewalk. All of her valuables were still inside. Her clothes, her phone, her wallet, and quite possibly what was left of her heart.

Catra hadn't kicked her out yet, but they couldn't live in the same place any longer. Adora would likely need to move back in with her moms. She already had enough guilt in her stomach, how much could it hurt to add onto the pile?

Then again, at least Adora wouldn't be bothering them for much longer.

Things would be right soon.

She stepped towards the apartment building for the last time.

But before she could open the door, she suddenly felt something that sent chills through her spine.

A cold metal barrel pressed against the back of her head.

A voice sounded behind Adora.

"I should kill you where you stand."

It was unfamiliar, but given everything that had happened today, it didn't take her long to figure out who it was.

"You can't, and you won't," Adora growled to the person behind her. "I've held up my end of the bargain. Put the gun down, get this tracker off me, and *stop* following me, Moros."

Moros only pushed it further against the back of Adora's skull. "What did you tell Catra and the rest of those fucks down there? We lost contact once you entered Utopia. For all we know, you could've been arming them. Preparing to stab us in the back again."

"That's none of your business," Adora seethed. "The deal was for me to lead you to Utopia. I did what you asked. Now get this tracker off me. We're done."

"It is *very* much my business. Runners are meant to kill traitors, you know," Moros scoffed. "It'd be easy. I could pull the trigger right now and no one could do a damn thing to change it."

He was right. No punishment he could receive would reverse a bullet to the head. Adora would be dead on warm streets, her blood pooling into the nearby drain. If Moros moved his finger a fraction of an inch, nothing would reverse it.

"Besides," Moros continued, an ounce of arrogance filling his voice, "judging by your face on the walk home, I think Catra might be *happy* to see your dead body outside her doorstep."

Adora didn't have an answer. She tensed her jaw and felt sick to hear Moros' low chuckle.

"Ooh, so my assumption *was* correct. She found out what you did, hm? Little trouble in paradise between our favourite star-crossed lovers? I can't believe you were stupid enough to fall in love with a goddamn robot."

Still no response from Adora. Moros let out an exaggerated 'oh well' sigh.

"I guess if you two seemingly hate each other now, maybe you won't care so much this time if I go down to Utopia and—"

"If you *ever* hurt Catra, I will fucking kill you."

Adora had never spoken such a cold sentence in her entire life.

She had never felt such a desire to take someone's life.

But after the night she had…

She would tear Moros to *pieces* if she had to.

"So, Catra hates your guts, and you still stick up for her?" Moros nearly laughed. "You really are an idiot."

"Maybe." Adora slowly turned around, facing the brown-eyed, dark-haired and pale-skinned man. She stepped forward to let the barrel of the gun press between her eyes. "But I won't let you kill me yet. When I die, it'll be for the right cause. Catra is the one good thing to happen to me ever since I lost Mara, and you'll have to go over my cold body before you—or any of your Runners—even *think* you can hurt her or her people."

Moros' eyes visibly widened for a split-second. As hard as he acted, he couldn't hide his shock at how willing Adora was to face death head-on. And Adora kept her steely eyes on Moros, making sure he knew she was dead serious.

Even if, internally, Adora's heart was hammering faster than it ever had before, and her gut was squeezed tight with fear.

"I would *love* to put a hole in your head right about now," Moros growled. "Maybe you can say hello to my brother in hell. Though I doubt he'd want to even look at you."

“What are you talking about?”

“Oh, you don’t remember? Of course you don’t. You don’t give a shit about anyone but you and your girlfriend.” Moros’ eyes were filled with a venomous rage. “Remember the Runner that Ghost killed? The Ghost you let go?”

Adora blinked. “Violet…?”

“That’s what the bitch wants to call herself, huh? I don’t care. She killed my brother and left him to rot. You had the chance to make her pay, and you just let her walk free.”

Adora couldn’t find the words to respond.

She had no idea of Moros’ relation to that night. It all made sense, though. Why he’d be so personally invested in this case, and why he’d be so willing to follow Adora for weeks on end.

The Runner that Violet had killed was Moros’ brother.

“He was always running ahead, that idiot…” Moros let out a shuddered sigh, gripping his gun tighter. “If he thought he could do something, he just *went* for it. Always wanted to impress every person alive. Our piece of shit dad, Shadow Weaver, *everyone*. He was just lucky enough for me to stop him before he got himself killed every time.”

Moros desperately held back tears, refusing to let them shed lest they made him look weak. “But the one time I wasn’t there to hold him back…”

Moros’ eyes were filled with a familiar pained expression. It was the same expression Adora saw in the mirror every single day.

Moros took a shaky breath. “If I had been there with him… He would still be alive. I still hate myself *every single day*. And then I learn that this… this *fucking* Angel had the perfect opportunity to avenge him… And she *wasted* it out of some idiotic pity for a machine.”

Adora gritted her teeth, her lips pressed thin. Her first instinct was to apologise, but those words never came out. She wanted to look away, but she didn't. She owed no apologies to a Runner. Nothing she did in this scenario would've been right, both for herself and for him.

"This world took *everything* from me. I have *nothing.* He was the one person who gave a shit about me, and I just let him die. But you…" Moros looked into Adora's eyes. "You're my reason for living, Adora. Because I want to be here for the day I get to paint your brains all over the wall."

"Moros, there's no reason for this." Adora spoke slowly and deliberately, a counterpoint immediately coming to mind. "The pain you're going through, I experienced it too. I know what it's like to lose someone close to you. I know—"

"You don't know *shit!"* Moros hissed. "Mara wasn't your blood! She wasn't your real family! You have no fucking idea what it's like!"

Adora kept her mouth shut. Moros' finger was on the trigger. He was already on edge. One wrong word could be fatal.

His hands shook for some time as he stared rage into Adora's eyes, and took a sick satisfaction at having her life in the palm of his hand. Despite her stoic eyes, Adora was truly, truly afraid. Not for her own life, but for what this man would do to Catra if she died here.

But eventually, Moros sighed, and ceased his shaking.

He finally, mercifully lowered the gun. "Give me your wrist."

Adora tried her best to hide the sigh of relief she let out. She rolled up her last sleeve as Moros put away his pistol and pulled out a similar-looking device to extract Adora's tracker.

"You remember your end of the deal," Adora said as she watched Moros use the device to pull the tracker out of her wrist. The way it slid out was unnerving to watch. "I led you to Utopia, now you

don’t hurt Catra or any of the Ghosted Keres down there. I don’t care what you think of me. I don’t even care what you *do* to me after this. You leave *them* out of this.”

Moros scoffed, finally removing the tracker completely and putting it away along with the extraction device. “I’ll keep that in mind.”

The two of them exchanged one last glare. Neither of them flinching, with nothing but spite between them. Adora understood Moros’ pain and his anger against the world, but it would be a cold day in hell before she let him get anywhere near Catra.

She took a few steps away from him, and then turned towards the apartment building, stepping inside and slamming the door.

Moros let out a sigh, reaching into his other pocket and pulling out his thin phone as he began to walk away from the apartment building. He contacted one number, who answered almost immediately.

“Adora’s held up her end of the bargain,” Moros spoke into the phone. “We’ve got a location on Utopia, but I think she ended up warning them about us.”

“That’s not a concern,” Shadow Weaver’s voice sounded from the phone. “There’s fear instilled in them now. Even if they move to a new location, they know they’re not invisible to us anymore. They’ll grow desperate and slip up. But for now, you have another task. Do you have everything prepared for Umbra’s speech tomorrow?”

“I do,” Moros nodded.

“I’ve been informed Adora will be attending the speech alongside Angella. Don’t let your personal vendetta get in the way of what needs to be done. You will sound the weapon when the order is given, *not* when you feel it necessary. Understood?”

“Understood.”

“Good. That will be all. Look forward to tomorrow, Moros.”

With that, the call was cut.

Goodbye

Chapter Summary

> The day of Herod Umbra's rally arrives. Angella must make a choice. Adora and Catra try to find a way forward.

Chapter Notes

> No real content warnings for this one, just another doozy! We're now officially in the second half and things are only ramping up. Enjoy the chapter, and thank you all for the support!

Angella hadn’t gotten a full night of sleep in nearly twenty-two years.

The neon lights beating against her blinded windows were a familiar sight. Her eyes stayed open, even as her body begged for them to close. She’d always blamed that brightness for keeping her awake. But she knew that even if she had a perfectly dark room, she still wouldn’t be able to sleep right.

Between the hour it took her to fall asleep, the night terrors, the constant awakenings, and being a general light sleeper, Angella was not fit for the night. Not even a little.

Tonight was one of those nights where she was at her worst.

It was nearly three in the morning, and she still hadn’t been able to drift into the land of sleep. The lights against her windows seemed even brighter, and every single noise in her small home seemed irritatingly louder. She rolled herself onto her back, letting out a sigh through her nose.

She often looked to the window despite its brightness, for if she turned the other way, she would see the empty space on the bed beside her. She would think back on memories she could never get back. Then she’d be *guaranteed* to not sleep that night.

She ran her hands down her face and eventually gave up, sitting her upper body up and brushing her long hair out of her face. Today was a big day, but she would have to face it on the energy of caffeine and sheer will. It was as good a motivator as anything.

Accepting a sleepless night, Angella slid her legs over the side of the bed and stood up, grabbing her dressing gown from her bedside table and wrapping it around herself.

Her small home was always too cold. Her bed especially was freezing. She knew why.

Stepping out of the bedroom, it only took a small walk down the hallway until Angella was in her kitchen. The window over the sink gave way to a view of a whiskey advertisement and wet concrete road. The occasional flashy car flew by, its loud engine creating nothing but annoyance for the Angel Leader (was *anyone* impressed by those engines?).

Angella filled the small kettle in her kitchen with water, before placing it atop her stove. The kettle floated a few inches above the stovetop, a holographic scale on the side indicating how close it was to a boil. Once the kettle had been placed, a small drawer beside the stovetop automatically opened, displaying different selections of tea for her.

It was about the most useful tech she had in her home.

Angella browsed through the selections, her fingers coming to rest on a blackberry and maple blend. The coffee selection would be saved for the morning—and possibly throughout the day.

Then, she felt a presence.

Before she could grab a mug from the other drawer that had automatically opened, the Angel Leader froze. Her instincts prevented her from taking another step, and in the span of half a second, she had instantly figured out why she stopped in her path.

Angella sighed. “What are you doing up so late, Glimmer?”

“I’m supposed to ask you that.”

Angella didn’t raise a child for twenty-three years to *not* sense when she was standing at the hallway and peering into the kitchen. She turned to face Glimmer, her short hair glowing with cybernetic dye enhancements being the only light in that dark hallway.

“Did I wake you?” Angella asked.

“Well… Not really.” Glimmer nodded to the slowly heating kettle. “Can I have some too?”

“Of course.” Angella went to grab out the mugs for her and her daughter. “What’s keeping you up?”

“Trying to find a new place to move into.”

Angella almost dropped the mug in her hand.

She cleared her throat, swallowing down the startled lump in her throat. “A-Ah. How’s that going for you?”

“Terrible,” Glimmer sighed. “Everything section 10 upwards is *way* out of my price range and sections 11 to 20 are just crummy apartments and houses that are *way* too small.”

“There’s nothing wrong with living in the lower sections.” Angella placed the mug on the kitchen table. “They’re often labelled as dirty and dangerous for discriminatory reasons or just petty insults from those in the upper sections. However, you also don’t *need* to rush in moving out.”

“Rush?” Glimmer scoffed. “Mom, I’m *twenty-three.* I should’ve been out of here five years ago.”

“And who says you should do that?”

“Well…” Glimmer crossed her arms, gripping her bicep tight. “My friends. Practically everyone my age. *Society.* They all say living in your parents’ house after eighteen is humiliating.”

Angella sighed. She could always see her younger self within Glimmer.

“Glimmer…” Angella looked at her daughter. “I do not mean to shackle you down to this place. If you find somewhere comfortable and affordable to live, I will gladly assist you. But I’m sure you also understand that finding a place to live within Styx City in the current climate and economy is *incredibly* difficult. You can’t shame yourself for having troubles with it.”

“I know…” Glimmer shook her head. “But you’re the leader of the Angels! You literally save lives for a living! I thought we’d be in a better financial situation because of that.”

Angella’s lips went thin. She could only nod. “As did I…” She took a deep breath through her nose, before looking back up to her daughter. “But that is something we can’t control. I’m not saying you should stay here *forever.* I’m just advising you to go a little easier on yourself. You’ll find a home in time, I’m sure of it.”

Glimmer took the words in for a few seconds. Angella could always tell when her words hit. It gave her an odd sense of pride.

Glimmer let out a sigh, before looking up to Angella with tender eyes. “Thanks, mom. I’ll… I’ll try.”

Angella smiled. “That’s all I ask.”

Glimmer let out a dry laugh. “It’s just hard. I’m the daughter of the world’s biggest hero and I can’t find a place to stay. Meanwhile, Herod Umbra’s son gets to buy a *third* house all because his dad gets up on stage and spews discriminatory bullshit against the Keres.”

“Indeed…” Angella kept her response slightly muted. It was way too early for politics, *especially* when it came to Glimmer.

"Speaking of," Glimmer stepped forward and put a hand on the kitchen table, making eye contact with Angella. "I hear he's going to be holding a rally outside Guardians HQ today."

"That's right."

"I assume you're going to be there?"

"Yes… What *are* you trying to say, Glimmer?"

"I'm saying that while you have the chance, you should go up to that piece of shit and," she smashed her fist into her palm with a grin, "knock his lights out!"

"I am *not* going to assault a politician," Angella insisted, catching herself before she could let out a shocked chuckle.

"Why not?" Glimmer threw her hands up. "I mean, what *are* you planning to do, shake his hand?"

"*God,* no." Angella almost shivered at the thought. "I have a few words planned for him and the crowds today. Mainly in relation to his despicable thoughts on Ghosted Keres."

Glimmer had been mostly joking, but with that sentence, her expression *dropped.*

"…A few *words?"*

"That's correct." Angella raised an eyebrow.

"That's… That's it?"

"What's wrong with that?"

"Are those words going to be 'stop killing an entire group of people or else they're going to rightfully retaliate' or more 'oh, Mr. Umbra, won't you pwetty pwease stop pushing for genocide'?"

"Are you *seriously* insisting I punch a major politician?"

"Well, *no*, but I kind of expected you to do *something."*

Angella stood up tall, her brow furrowed. "Where is this coming from, Glimmer?"

"I'm sick of people trying to peacefully debate with that guy! Nothing is changing unless someone outright states—maybe with force—that he's going to face consequences for the shit he's doing!" Glimmer dropped her hands. "I thought *you'd* be different."

"I am not going to advocate for violence in front of hundreds of thousands." Angella let out a frustrated sigh. "I fully agree with what you're saying, but you have to understand my position. I am the leader of a pacifist group who *helps* people, I cannot—"

"A 'pacifist group' that helps Runners slaughter Ghosts," Glimmer scoffed, crossing her arms.

"You *know* how strongly I disagree with that protocol, don't turn that on me. I've spent decades fighting against it, and I will spend the rest of my life doing it if necessary. But I am *not* going to push for a violent solution to this."

"Why not?! You of all people should know that violence is the only way things change!"

"I am not doing this *again,* Glimmer."

"I'm sure it's *so* easy to feel good about your 'pacifism' while dozens of Ghosts are killed every single week because of people like him! I'm sure it's nice that you get to *decide* when violence is the right thing to do!"

"Stop…"

"Why can't you just—"

"Because this exact push for violence is what got your father killed!"

Glimmer fell silent.

The kettle began to whistle, the only sound in the kitchen.

Angella looked down as soon as she realised what she said.

The mere mention of that man always made the room feel a little heavier.

"I am… *aware* that you look up to your father and I for our roles as some of the few humans to participate in the Awakening protests. I do not regret that, not for one second. However…" She let out a short, frustrated sigh. "When those protests escalated to violence… when blood was spilt… I watched *dozens* of Keres being beaten and killed. I watched Micah fight back. And I watched when he was shoved down and…"

Her eyes shut tight, her trembling lips pressed thin as her entire body tensed. Glimmer couldn't bear to see the sight of her mother like this, instead opting to gaze down at the floor.

Angella needed to pull herself together.

She let out a shaky breath as she went over to the stove, grabbing the floating kettle and pulling it off the heat.

"I do not think pacifism is the solution." Angella didn't look at her daughter as she spoke. "Violence can often be the only way to change. But if we advocate for the Ghosts to use violence… It would lead to endless blood being spilt—and much of it would be *their* blood. Is it right to put them through these horrors again? The Runners *will* use full force and they will *not* be fair or merciful. Violence will lead to misery, separation, and loss. Not just for me, but for *all* the Keres, Ghosted or not. Is it right to put them through that again?"

Angella's voice was a husk of its former self. Glimmer noticed how much it began to waver and break on this topic. The Angel Leader put her hands on the kitchen bench as if to keep herself from crumpling underneath guilt and sorrow.

Glimmer bit her tongue for a few seconds, trying to hold herself back. She clenched her fists, and knew that the words in her heart would slip out before her brain could reach down to stop them.

With a sigh, and an avoidance of eye contact, Glimmer spoke.

"I don't know. But it *worked,* didn't it?"

Angella slowly looked back up at her daughter.

"The Awakening protests weren't being given any serious discussion until they resorted to violence," Glimmer stated. "It was only when it turned violent that the treaties were introduced."

"At the cost of *how* many lives?" Angella turned to face her daughter. "Hundreds of Keres died for those treaties! Your *father* died for those treaties!"

"And is that a bad thing?!"

Angella's eyes widened with horror. Glimmer finally looked up, her jaw tensed.

"Look, I wish I had a father growing up! I wish I could know him beyond a few photos and vague memories! I wish I could talk to him just *once!"*

"Glimmer…"

"But he died for the rights of the Keres! He died so that true change could come! He fought until his last breath for what he believed in!" Glimmer shook her head, her eyes becoming hazy with tears. "If he were still here… He wouldn't rely on pacifism or debate or hope that *maybe* change would just happen on a whim. He'd still be *fighting*."

Angella's words stuck in her throat, and refused to come out. For one of the few times in her life, she was completely speechless. She stared at her daughter's tears, her instinct telling her to wipe them clean and hold her close.

But instead, she just stood there. Dumbfounded. Useless. A state she rarely found herself in.

Glimmer let out an annoyed, shaky sigh. She turned around and began to head for the hallway. "Sorry for bringing up dad. Just forget the tea."

"Glimmer, wait—"

"Don't worry about me. Just…" Glimmer stopped in her tracks for a few seconds, contemplating the painful words in her mind. She didn't look back at her mom as she spoke. "You have an influential voice. People will *listen* to you. You have an opportunity for something great here. I was just hoping you'd actually use it."

Angella felt her stomach drop and go cold. She wasn't granted a response as Glimmer opened her bedroom door and slammed it closed.

The Angel Leader was left by herself once again. An empty kitchen to keep her company, empty bed awaiting her, and empty heart to occupy herself with. Grief was the loneliest feeling in the world.

She swallowed the pain and grabbed the kettle, going over to the bench of mugs to pour the water.

But then, she stopped.

Her hands trembled over the kettle.

Looking at the mugs, Angella realised she had made one foolish, absentminded slip-up.

She had gotten out *three* mugs.

One for herself. One for Glimmer. And one for…

Angella placed the kettle down once again. Her eyes locked with that third mug. Her hands trembled along with her lips. Twenty-two years, and even still…

She placed her hands on her hip, trying to choke back the rising lump in her throat and swelling in her eyes. She bit her lip, nearly drawing blood before she could let herself break even one sob. But no matter how hard she tried to fight it…

She couldn't stop a single tear trailing down her cheek.

She took a shaky, wheezed breath, putting a hand to her face to hide herself from the world. Her entire body trembled, and the breach in her hardened barrier couldn't be prevented.

"Micah…" Angella whispered. "What do I do…?"

Her only answer was the cold of the night.

Adora stepped out of the shower, and thought about ripping the Angel wing cybernetics out of her back.

It would be far from a painless process by hand. In fact, it would likely paralyse or even kill her. But after the things she had done, she no longer deserved those wings.

Perhaps the only reason she stopped herself was so she wouldn't spill any blood in Catra's apartment during her last night staying there.

Adora had spent the last two hours looking for a new place, before ultimately giving in and resorting to texting her moms and asking for her childhood bedroom back. Considering how late it was, she wouldn't receive a response until morning. She knew they would not shame her, but that didn't stop the never-ending guilt that built in her gut. She had promised them great things. She had failed them.

Adora paced through the apartment after she had dried herself off. She had packed away her things in a few small boxes and had even taken the time to clean the place as well as she could. Adora rarely cleaned *anything.*

She considered sleeping on the couch for old times' sake. She considered not sleeping at all and just leaving now. She considered throwing herself out the balcony window. Her mind was always racing with stupid plans.

But whilst her mind fought endlessly, her heart guided her towards the only place she could truly sleep.

Catra's bed.

She sank into it once she let her legs give way, and she instantly felt a wave of comfort wash through her body like the end of a beautiful massage. She immediately curled her legs up to her chest, hugging them tight with one arm whilst her other caressed the sheet below.

The whole bed *smelled* like Catra. Warm cinnamon. Adora thought back to events just 24 hours ago, where she let herself be held by Catra and told what a beautiful woman she was. Where she could pretend for a few hours that everything would be okay.

And soon, she felt another presence join her on the bed.

She chuckled as she felt a ticklish feeling in the back of her neck. It didn't take long for her to figure it out. "Hey, Melog…"

The curious cat could almost sense something was wrong with Adora. They were already wondering where their owner was, but to see the normally curious and excited Angel completely down in the dumps and crying in the shower was a new sight for them.

Adora turned to face Melog, and she was immediately met with them nuzzling their head against Adora's cheek.

Shivers fizzled through her spine at the soft sensation, and she couldn't help but press a kiss on Melog's forehead just between their ears. She stroked her hand along their ear and smiled.

"Thank you."

Melog purred in response.

But just as Adora was beginning to close her eyes with cat in hand…

Bzzt. Bzzt.

A long, constant vibration of her phone. A call. From who? It was three in the morning.

Catra?

Adora turned to pick up her phone with an odd sense of hope. She was initially disappointed when the name that popped up wasn't Catra. But that disappointment was quickly replaced with curiosity and hope when she saw just who it was.

Answering and pressing the phone to her ear, Adora spoke. "Angella?"

"Oh, you're here. Um… Good evening, Adora. Or… morning, I should say. I certainly hope I didn't wake you."

"You didn't," Adora eagerly responded, sitting up. "What's up?"

"Herod Umbra's speech begins in approximately seven hours. And I want to tell you my plan for when that time comes."

"I'm listening."

"Good. Because if this works, we might have a way to save Catra and *all* the Ghosted Keres."

"Catra? Oh, Catraaaaa?"

The longed, droning call of her name invaded her dreams and ripped her back into the real world. It took two seconds for Catra to realise she had slept funny once she felt the aching in her neck. It took her four seconds to realise she had fallen asleep in Entrapta's lab whilst sitting up in one of her chairs. It took her six seconds to realise that Entrapta was *right in her face.*

"Ah! You're awake!" Entrapta grinned once Catra's tired eyes met hers. "Good morning!"

"Shit…" Catra rubbed her face. "When did I pass out…?"

"Approximately twelve minutes after we finished our plans for moving out of Utopia and informing everyone of said plan," Entrapta noted. "You took a seat in one of my chairs and then you started snoring."

"I snore…?"

No one had ever told her that. Adora didn't…

Catra blinked. She grimaced at the thought of that name.

She let out a sigh. "Sorry for stealing one of your chairs."

"It's okay! I have plenty of back-ups!" Entrapta grinned, her cybernetic hair waving to the… *dozens* of identical chairs in the large closet near the corner. "Speaking from experience, however, they are *not* prime for napping in."

"Clearly…" Catra rubbed at the ache in her neck as she stood up.

"I was going to let you sleep longer, but… Well, something big is happening today. It might impact our moving of Utopia."

Catra's brows furrowed. She watched as part of Entrapta's purple hair typed on a nearby holographic keyboard, bringing up a display of live footage for a large gathering of people. She instantly figured out what it was for.

“Herod Umbra’s rally…”

Catra could see the man himself, balding and dressed fine in a bright white suit, standing on a tall stage, overlooking a crowd of hundreds. He had set himself up outside the Guardians HQ and was currently in the process of shaking hands with the Warlock Leader.

“He’s giving thanks to every branch of the Guardians for their roles and their shared protocol of Ghost elimination,” Entrapta commented. “I’ll keep an eye on it, just in case. For now, we just need to focus on helping everyone prepare for the move. Can you go around and assist where available?”

“… Yeah. Yeah, sure,” Catra nodded. “You let me know what he says, alright?”

“I’m keeping tabs on his rally, and I’ve patched myself into the Runner comms,” Entrapta patted her nearby radio device with her hair. “Nothing is slipping past me today!”

Catra let out a dry chuckle, a smile barely slipping on her face. “Nothing ever does.”

As Catra went to go up the stairs and out into Utopia to help, Entrapta turned her attention back to the rally. Umbra continued his thanks to the Warlock division for their focus on tech and repair of the ‘normal’ Keres. She glanced at her old leader, who took his handshake with pride.

Entrapta pondered something in her mind for a few seconds. It overlapped with all the other noise and thoughts, jangling like a coin in a washing machine. It had been clanging around for the last few hours, and whilst she had the chance, she knew she needed to let that thought out.

“Catra?”

She stopped in her path, her hand on the door. She turned to Entrapta, seeing her eyes lit up by the multiple displays in front of

her.

"Yeah?"

"I've been thinking about your… conflict with Adora. At least from what you've told me."

Catra's grip on the door tightened. She took a short breath. "What about it?"

"This is… purely out of personal curiosity and for science! But…" Her voice went meek as she avoided eye contact with Catra. "If… If the roles were switched… If you were in Adora's position…"

She glanced at Catra for a few seconds to gauge her reaction, before letting out her last few words.

"…Would you have let her die?"

Entrapta had trouble looking into Catra's eyes. She couldn't even bring herself to tell her that her eyes were still blue and yellow. Her heterochromia was a dead giveaway to her Ker nature and something she always hid, but ever since her conflict with Adora, she hadn't bothered to change her left eye back to blue.

It was safe to have those eyes in Utopia. In the real world, however, it would get her inspected and likely killed if the truth were revealed.

Why this tangent?

Well, the only reason Entrapta was thinking these thoughts was so she could avoid the tightness in her heart when Catra's response to her query was pure and utter *silence.*

Entrapta always knew when she had asked questions too personal. Unfortunately, she almost always recognised it about five seconds after the question had already left her mouth.

Finally, after nearly eight agonising seconds, Catra could only sigh.

“Don’t ask me questions about Adora. Please.”

Entrapta winced. She’d screwed up. Again.

“I-I’m sorry, I didn’t mean—”

“It’s okay. I’m not mad. I’m just trying to forget her.”

With that, Catra opened the door, walked out, and quietly closed it, leaving Entrapta alone in her lab with her displays, her Runner comms, and her loud footage of Umbra’s rally. Entrapta’s throat was dry, and she soon realised her heart was nearly pounding out of her chest.

The question continued to rattle in her mind without an answer. Catra had grown so much more reserved in the past few hours than she had been in the last month. It was like a return of her old self, smothering the joy she had only briefly experienced.

Thus, Entrapta had to come to her own conclusion. She pondered Catra’s answer in her mind. It was merely qualitative, subjective data and a measly opinion of one scientist/former Warlock, but no matter how many conclusions she came to, they all shared one result.

Entrapta could never picture Catra letting Adora die.

Angella looked out at Styx City from the large window in her office.

She could hear the rally from outside the building. The cheers that emanated through the crowd and the muffled speech from Umbra as he praised the Guardians. She tuned the noise out to focus on nothing but the city and the bright sky.

It was a cloudless day.

A beautiful day.

Likely her last day as an Angel.

She kept her arms behind her back as she looked at the world around her. For just a moment, it was like time had stopped. There were no duties. No emergencies. Nothing for her to do but wait until Umbra called out her name. She would be expected to go on stage, shake his hand, and keep her mouth shut.

She wondered about Utopia. What the Ghosted Keres were doing now that Utopia had been exposed. Very few people knew about it, but it was likely that Umbra intended to reveal that very information. Angella caught a glimpse of Shadow Weaver earlier and she seemed to be in no rush.

Something was happening. Shadow Weaver was planning something. Angella needed to stop it.

She heard the automatic doors slide open behind her. Looking in the reflection of the window, Angella softened her shoulders as she saw who it was.

"I'm glad you were able to come today, Adora."

Angella turned to see the Angel in the flesh. She saw the slight bags under her eyes, with a pink haze on the outskirts of her iris.

"I wouldn't miss this for the world," Adora spoke with the same determination as always. "Umbra is expecting you soon."

Angella took a deep breath in through her nose. "Adora… I need you to understand that you are under no obligation to join me. There could be severe consequences to what we're doing. At best, we'll likely lose our roles as Angels. At worst…"

"I *want* to do this." Adora didn't hesitate, not for a second. "For Catra. For Entrapta. For all the Ghosted Keres. I *want* to make up for my mistakes. I'm ready to do anything to accomplish that, even if it means I have to die for it."

Angella looked down at her most valuable Angel, and she put on a warm smile. It was rare for *anyone* to see her smile.

"You're brave, Adora. Truly." Her smile faded into a sympathetic frown. "But that is not your sacrifice to make, should it come to that."

"But this is *my* fault. I led the Runners to Utopia, I *have* to fix what I've done."

"You did what you did out of *love.* Out of the desire to *protect* what is most precious to you*.* If there were ever a true Angel, it's you." Angella shook her head. "You don't deserve to die for that. I know what we're doing is risky, but I am *not* going to let it be the end of you. You're young. You have so much life to live."

"And I won't let you die either," Adora insisted, her eyes narrowing. "You're a beacon of hope. You're who people look up to. I'm just… a burden."

Angella saw the haziness in Adora's eyes at those last words. The way they winced as she remembered the events from the previous night. There were no words to soothe the burning pain in her heart. She was using that fire as a means for self-loathing, and Angella recognised it all too well.

The Angel Leader slowly knelt down. Adora's eyes were wide as Angella came down to *her* height, being equal eye level with her now. She placed her gentle hands on Adora's shoulders and smiled an equally gentle smile.

"Do you want to know a secret?"

Adora blinked. Angella's sudden tenderness was still a rare sight for Adora. She couldn't bring herself to respond, so Angella continued.

"I am… a coward."

Adora shook her head. She couldn't find the words to say.

Angella's glazed eyes became unfocused, reflecting on bitter memories. "Micah… He was the brave one. And then Glimmer… Oh, Glimmer… So much like her father. Always willing to do what's *right.*"

"What are you saying…?"

"I've always told myself that I was being responsible. But Adora…" Angella put on a pathetic, mournful smile. "I was just *scared.* Scared of that loss, scared of that pain, scared to relive the horrors once more."

Adora knew of Angella's participation in the Awakening protests. It was a topic she often kept silent about. This was her first time hearing Angella even mention them.

"I've spent too long in silence. Too long trying to do the *responsible* thing." Angella shook her head, her smile fading as she took a shaky breath. "But now…"

Angella looked at Adora with fierce determination in her steely eyes.

"I choose to be *brave.*"

"Don't say things like this," Adora retaliated. "You're… You're making it sound like they'll…"

"What happens within the next few minutes is something I can't predict. But if this is to be my last few moments in this world, I choose to spend them doing what must be done, and I won't let myself be a coward until the end." Angella briefly tightened her grip on Adora's shoulders. "You may stand alongside me if you wish, but I *won't* let these be your last few moments either."

Adora couldn't find the right words to respond. As the crowd got louder outside and the time came for them both, Adora could only remain silent. To not only see this vulnerability and weakness from Angella but to also see her instructing Adora to *live* was something she could not respond to.

Nor did she need to.

Angella pulled her hands away from Adora and nodded. Adora hesitated for a few seconds, but then, she nodded in return. The two Angels would use the last of their wings to do what was right.

Finally, Angella stood up.

She took a deep breath in. She closed her eyes, saw flashes of Micah's smile, Glimmer's bravery, and her views of this once beautiful world. She thought of the Ghosted Keres, who would likely watch this rally with bated breath and hearts filled with anxiety. She thought of her life, and whether it would continue beyond today.

Then, she released that breath.

And focused on the *now.*

Angella stepped down the hallway of the Angel floor, her eyes kept up and forward. She passed by her fellow Angels, all of whom nodded to her or looked to her in awe. Adora followed closely behind, looking out the window to the rally and spotting Umbra's eager eyes looking towards them.

But Angella kept looking forward.

She turned a corner and faced the large front doors. As they opened, she was met with hundreds of eager eyes and flashes from cameras and drones. She was to turn right, walk up the side of the stage, and greet Herod Umbra.

Styx City was watching her.

Adora stood alongside her.

Whilst they all waited, Angella did only one thing.

She slowly raised her hand and pressed her fingers to her chest. The cybernetics in her body activated.

They all watched as two large, holographic wings sprouted from Angella's back.

They were larger than all other Angel wings. They extended out, their width bigger than her outstretched arms. Their virtual white feathers blew gently with the wind, and once they were fully revealed, they beat at the floor a few times.

If her wings were real, she would've been soaring.

The crowd seemed to be fond of her wings, cheers emanating throughout them. Adora was quick to follow, spreading her own holographic wings. They were smaller than Angella's, less bright, but no less special. They were uniquely hers.

With her wings fully spread, Angella turned towards the stage and ascended the stairs.

The stage was easily the height of five adults, soaring over the crowd with enough view to even see the back rows. Large tiles of floating stairs on either side were the only way to get up and down.

Angella did not smile. She did not look at any camera. She did not focus on anything but her steps, and her plan. Her face of determination and immense thought was a familiar sight for all Angels. It was a beacon of hope for them.

Herod Umbra's smile greeted her once she had reached the top of the stage. He called out for the audience to give it up for the Angel Leader, and the clapping rang in Adora's ears. Angella tuned it out. She browsed through the crowd to see endless people. Endless eyes. Endless smiles.

And one person that stuck out among the rest.

Glimmer.

She stood near the back to get a higher viewpoint than everyone else. Her sparkling, cybernetic hair was easy to spot for Angella.

She could pick Glimmer out from *any* crowd with ease.

She saw Glimmer's waiting eyes. She saw the way her daughter chewed at her lip. She saw Glimmer's tensed, crossed arms.

Angella hid her moment of surprise. She turned her attention back to Umbra, who had a hand stretched out to her and a grin on his face.

Dozens of camera lenses were on them. Thousands of eyes gazed towards his hand, waiting for the moment of contact with Angella and waiting to sink into the comforting thought that the Angel Leader was on his side. Perhaps some Ghosts held their breath, wondering if they had the support of *any* Guardians.

Angella looked at the hand for a few seconds. She looked up and saw the podium before her and the sets of small floating microphones. She wasn't meant to say a word. She wasn't meant to do anything except give one easy handshake.

Maybe in another time she would've gone for the easy route. Maybe in another time she would've continued to believe the system could be fixed from within. Maybe in another time she'd continue to believe in peace and responsibility.

Today, however, wasn't that time.

Angella raised her hand…

And pressed it against Umbra's chest, gently shoving him out of the way.

A silence quickly hung around the audience like a thick blanket. Umbra's smile instantly faded as he stumbled back a few steps, only to watch as Angella placed her hands on the podium.

Angella looked to her daughter's surprised eyes. She looked into the lenses and eyes that scanned her and captured this moment in film and memories.

She took a breath. Stuck with her choice. Thought of everything that had come to this very moment.

Then, she spoke words that would ring through history.

"My name is Angella Moonbright, leader of the Angels, and I call for equity in the treatment of all Ghosted Keres."

For a second, that silence remained.

There was the collective processing of everyone's mind as they took in those words.

There was no taking them back. No changing what had been done.

Just the two seconds of silence between everyone…

Then suddenly, an *explosion.*

Noise and flashes erupted from the crowd, and every camera imaginable was pulled on her. She almost felt a vibration of shock throughout Styx City. Umbra was calling for her microphone to be cut, so she quickly continued to speak over the noise.

"This will involve the permanent retirement of the Runner division, and the removal of the Guardian protocol."

Yet another wave of emotions buzzed through the crowd. Angella's words were somehow managing to overcome the sheer *noise* of the crowd. Most of it in shock, some of it throwing jeers

or slinging insults at her, and some—surprisingly enough—*supporting* her.

Angella continued, waving her hand towards Adora. "I have with me Adora Grayskull, who has worked countless hours to save countless lives. Without her tireless effort, Styx City would feel much emptier for many people."

She took a breath. Her microphone was still active. Umbra wasn't even trying to physically pull Angella away—perhaps her height was intimidating him.

"Adora…" Angella looked at her one last time. She received an approving nod. She looked back to the crowd with her determined eyes. "Adora has also spared the life of a Ghost. On top of that, she has grown to love another. By law, this *should* mean she faces severe prison time or even death for her sympathetic actions. Is that fair? That we should lose someone who has saved hundreds simply because of her love and empathy for the 'wrong' people?"

Adora knew about those words going in. *That* was her biggest sacrifice, to out herself as a sympathiser. But Adora *refused* to hide herself and her actions for any longer.

She looked over to all the cameras and eyes pointed her way. All of Styx City knew of her actions now. She stared them all down.

Finally, Umbra took action. He stormed over to Angella and grabbed her by the arm, making sure to get his voice captured by the microphone too. "What the hell are you doing?! Did the Ghosts threaten you into saying this?"

Angella snapped her arm away, giving Umbra a deep glare as she released herself from his grip. "They have not. I speak entirely of my own accord. The Ghosted Keres have their own voices, they are their own people. I do not speak for them."

She turned back to the crowd and continued. "But it is my job to use my position of power—to use my *voice* for good and true

justice. I *refuse* to be silent. I fought for the Keres at the Awakening protests, and I am *proud* of that fact."

"Those protests were a massacre!" Herod seethed, getting support from a majority of the crowd.

Angella didn't look his way. She didn't so much as *acknowledge* him. His words meant nothing. The insults meant nothing.

All she cared about was the smile on her daughter's face in the crowd.

"If the demands I listed are not met," Angella continued, "and should the Ghosted Keres choose to fight once again as they did during the Awakening…"

She slammed her palm against her chest, and her wings beat heavily, making Umbra wince.

"Then I will fight alongside them once more!"

There wasn't a single agreement in the crowd reaction. She had support, insults, threats of death, and stunned looks from all around. She felt her breath grow heavy, but for the first time in twenty-two years, her heart was filled with *pride.*

Angella stood above all else in that moment of time. Her wings shone brighter than any other. Her small smile and glinting eyes were captured by everyone around her, including her best Angel.

It was a sight Adora would never forget.

"Well… This is definitely an unexpected turn of events."

He stood atop a tower a few miles away from the rally. The people looked like ants from where he was, but the view was clear. No flying cars to get in the way. Nothing but a straight shot from here to the rally.

He kept the audio of the rally in his earpiece radio. Angella's words had made him stop in his tracks for a few seconds, and he quickly tuned in to a comms call with his boss.

"Does this put a dent in our plan at all?" He asked.

"No. You will continue your task and sound the weapon as planned, Moros." The voice on the other end of the line let out a single, amused chuckle. "Angella's public betrayal is a fitting end."

Moros nodded. "As you wish, Shadow Weaver."

He cut the comms, tuning his audio back to the rally. Endless noise had finally managed to drown Angella out, and the crowd showed no signs of calming. Those words she spoke had rung throughout Styx City like a hollow bat to the skull, making ears ring and minds confused. Angella was a *hero.* She was a saviour to all. How could she side with the Ghosts?

It was of no matter to Moros. He kept to the task.

He took a second to put on a pair of tight, black, elastic gloves. With those on, he knelt over the large case he brought to the rooftop, clicking open the locks and lifting up the lid. Within the case were the pieces to form a weapon.

Today would forever go down in history, one way or another.

"Entrapta, *tell me* you just saw what happened!"

The door to Entrapta's lab was slammed open, noise immediately filling the dim space from the outside. Every Keres within Utopia had just seen the footage of Angella's speech. There had never been a public cry of support from *any* Guardian in this manner.

"I did!" Entrapta frantically spoke, her hair working at a keyboard whilst her hands tinkered with her comms system. Her voice sounded shaky, more worried than excited.

“I mean, this is *great*, right?!” Catra chuckled, her hand pointed towards Entrapta’s display of the rally. “We have the Angel’s leader on our side! Everyone in Utopia’s faces just… they all lit up! This could be the start of something!”

“Y-yeah! It’s great and all, but… Ah, what are they *talking* about…?” Entrapta mumbled to herself as she went back to one of her monitors to try and search something.

“Adora was there, too…” Catra sighed with relief to herself as she looked to the screen to see her Angel. She was but a small figure among many, but her wings made her stand out above all else.

Entrapta’s fingers and hair kept tinkering with the keyboards and tech. Her face was one of panicked concentration, her eyes narrowed tight and her shoulders hunched over. Catra cocked an eyebrow. “Aren’t you happy about this?”

“I *was,* but I just picked up on something in the Runner comms.” Entrapta tapped a few keys, and her radio device began to play from one of the speakers with a recording from only a minute ago.

“Does this put a dent in our plans at all?”

“No. You will continue your task and sound the weapon as planned, Moros. Angella’s public betrayal is a fitting end.”

“As you wish, Shadow Weaver.”

“Moros…?” Catra’s eyes widened at the mention of that name. “That’s the guy who was following Adora…”

“Ahh, that’s not the important part! They mentioned a sound-based weapon, and I *know* I’ve heard of something like that before!” Entrapta shook her head as she browsed through a collection of the Runner’s arsenal.

“What can a *sound-based* weapon do?”

“It’s…” Entrapta’s eyes suddenly widened. A shudder fizzled through her body. “Oh no…”

“What?” Catra approached her. “What is it?”

On Entrapta’s screen displayed something that looked… almost like a trumpet. It was comical to see Entrapta’s horror over it, but Catra knew Entrapta was never worried about anything unless it was *really* bad.

“This was used against us in the Awakening protests. It was a prototype back then that didn’t work as intended, but now…”

“What’s it for?”

“It emits a signal. A sound wave that’s audible to our ears. It was originally created as an intimidation tactic. When a receiver picks up that sound signal, it detonates. Oh, this is not good!”

“What do you mean?” Catra shook her head. “Entrapta, what’s—“

“That rally is rigged to blow, Catra!” Entrapta suddenly snapped. “If Moros sounds that weapon, I think it’s going to detonate the *bombs* there!”

“What?!” Catra shook her head frantically, her jaw shuddering. “That can't be right! Why would a Runner attack this rally?!”

“I don’t know, but it’s going to happen soon!” Entrapta looked at another of her displays, but even Catra could recognise that one was only filled with error messages. “I’m trying to hack into the Guardians system and send some sort of warning to the speakers or billboards around the rally, but they’ve set a heavy firewall on all displays. I *can* crack it, but I don’t know if there’s enough time. We don’t know *when* Moros is going to sound that weapon.”

Catra looked back at the live footage. Angella was engaged in a ferocious argument with Umbra, and Adora stood by her side like the determined Angel she was. She refused to back down under endless noise and violent words.

She had no idea what kind of threat she was under. What kind of threat they *all* were under.

Entrapta was still trying to break the firewall, but time was running short. Catra looked back and forth between her and Adora. She squeezed her eyes shut, gritting her teeth for just a few seconds, before finally…

"I'm going there."

Entrapta blinked.

She took a second to process those words, before looking at Catra with blank eyes. "You're *WHAT?!"*

"I'm going to that rally!" Catra began to pace out of the lab. "If an attack happens at an anti-Keres rally, we *know* who the blame will be pointed at. We *know* what comes next."

"I-I'm not sure you understand," Entrapta's nervous tremors remained in her voice even as she tried to explain herself calmly. "There is an *explosion* that is about to happen at that rally! If you go there when that happens—"

"I have to do *something*," Catra growled.

"I don't know what that 'something' is! Do *you* even know?"

"I'll figure it out. Just a way to warn them or delay them. I *have* to go there."

"There is no *logical* reason for you to physically attend that rally!"

"I don't care! Not everything needs a logical reason behind it!"

“Then why—“

“BECAUSE ADORA IS AT THAT RALLY, OKAY?!”

Catra knew she had snapped again.

She knew the words that spewed out of her mouth before she could even think about them were selfish and stupid. She knew it was a complete contradiction to everything she had been doing for the last few hours.

But for that one brief second, Catra’s smothered heart was freed. And she didn’t even apologise for it.

Catra let out a shuddered breath, unable to look into Entrapta’s eyes. Guilt swarmed her vulnerable heart for yelling at Entrapta once more, but she didn’t have the time to make up for it yet. She could only turn and open the door to the lab.

“…There.”

Catra heard that one word from Entrapta. She looked over her shoulder to see her hunched over her desktop, still trying to break the firewall. But her hair had managed to do something else whilst her fingers worked.

“There’s a bike parked on a street nearby here,” Entrapta said without breaking eye contact from the screen. “I’ve connected it with your handprint. You’ll be able to take it to the rally. Take the side streets, it’s quicker, approximately three minutes.”

“Entrapta…”

“Whatever you want to say, it’s appreciated! Now go!” Entrapta mumbled to herself a bit more, before adding one more thing. “Oh, and *don’t die!”*

It was solid enough advice.

Catra looked at Entrapta—her icon and her hero—for just a second more, before finally bolting out of the lab. She pushed her way through the crowd within Utopia, multiple Offline Keres whose eyes were glued to displays of the rally.

Catra exited Utopia with haste, her left eye going blue as she sprinted down the alleyway and made a left. She could instantly spot a large, black motorcycle parked nearby. It already belonged to someone else and could only be activated by their handprint, but Entrapta could hack bikes with her eyes closed.

Catra sprinted to the bike and gripped tightly to the handlebars. Instantly, the bike roared to life beneath her as it recognised her handprints, sending thundering vibrations through her body.

Catra took a breath, looked in the direction of Guardians HQ, and twisted the right handle.

The back wheel skidded along the pavement for a few seconds, before the bike flew forward and down the street. She neared a corner and pulled the handbrake, her foot sliding along the ground as the bike drifted sideways to a stop, before she quickly turned towards the corner.

She leant down and practically hugged the bike as she began to speed down streets and highways, weaving through traffic with the wind blowing through her long hair. She kept her eyes forward and repeated only one sentence to herself.

"Please…" Catra whispered to herself. "Please be okay, Adora…"

"Do you have any idea what you've just done?!"

"I won't take judgement from the likes of *you."*

Adora stood atop the tall stage and witnessed history in the making. Angella's microphone had finally been cut, but that didn't stop her from exchanging cold words with Umbra. Her voice boomed over the uninterrupted noise of the crowd, which had

gone on for so long that it was beginning to make Adora's head pound.

"Whatever blood is spilt from this is on *your* hands!" Umbra barked, poking a finger at Angella's chest. "Losing your job is the *least* of your worries right now!"

"You're talking to *me* about blood being on my hands?" Angella scoffed as she looked down on him.

"The Ghosts are a danger to all of us and our families! Inciting this violence will lead us to destruction!"

"I *refuse* to waste another breath on you. Stand down from your position or you *will* be caught in the crossfire," Angella declared, before turning on her heel and nodding to Adora. "We're leaving. Our impact's been made."

Adora returned the nod, going to follow behind Angella down the stairs. They would likely need to stay in Guardians HQ until the commotion had died down for the day, but Adora didn't mind. She was proud to stand with Angella through thick and thin.

But just before either of them could take the first step down the floating stairs, they heard something.

A familiar click behind them.

The click of a rifle as its safety was switched off.

Adora froze. Angella's body tensed.

"By law, sympathisers for the Ghosted Keres *must* be punished."

Umbra's voice boomed across the rally once again, his microphone coming to life. However, just as the crowd was slowly beginning to quiet down, it sprung back to life with gasps and cheers.

The two Angels looked over their shoulders to see a small group of Runners on stage, rifles aimed right at their backs.

"I thank the Runners for their efficiency," Umbra smiled at the golden masked people behind him. He held up his hands to quiet the crowd. "There is no need for panic, anyone. The Runners are here to protect *you* from people like *them."*

"You *wouldn't*," Angella calmly spoke, turning her body to face him. "You're a monster, but you're not going to make them kill me in front of this crowd."

Adora stared wide eyed at Angella's bravery in the face of multiple gun barrels. Umbra scoffed at the Angel Leader.

"You encouraged violence against the great people gathered here today. Death would be a *mercy* in your case," Umbra spoke, making sure his voice was picked up by the mic. "But, people of Styx City, we are not as barbaric as they are. We won't resort to mindless murder. Violence is *never* the answer."

Mixed in with the crowd of wide eyes and stunned expressions, one person was louder than the rest. Angella turned to see someone push through the ocean of people, making her way towards the stage.

"STOP!" Cried the loud voice of Glimmer as she shoved through person after person. "Don't you dare threaten my mom, you *HEARTLESS PIECE OF SHIT!"*

And for the first time, panic flooded into Angella's bloodstream.

"Glimmer, *NO!"* Angella held out a hand, her eyes flashing a moment of panic. "Stay back!"

"There is no need for such intense emotions!" Umbra smiled towards the enraged Glimmer. "We don't intend to execute anyone. Calm yourself."

A pair of Runners managed to block Glimmer's running, grabbing her by the arms and forcibly holding her back with a grip that was way too tight. Angella's eyes suddenly boiled with stinging rage.

"Fuck you!" Glimmer cried from the crowd, struggling against the Runners.

"Let her go, *NOW!"* Angella roared at Umbra.

"We intend to!" Umbra beamed, raising a single finger. "On *one* condition. That condition… is up to Adora."

The hairs on Adora's neck immediately stood up as her name oozed from the politician's mouth. Her ears were ringing with the noise from the crowd, and her heart was pounding at the sight of Angella's worried face and the guns that pointed her way.

Angella didn't have control. Not anymore. Seeing Glimmer in danger had gotten the best of her.

"Angella, you have presented very… *extreme* views," Umbra noted. "You included Adora, your most 'valuable' Angel, in those views. It has me wondering if, perhaps, you have *indoctrinated* Adora into these extreme beliefs."

"You hypocritical—"

"Adora," Umbra's slimy smile remained stuck in her direction, ignoring Angella's death stare. "I know you have made mistakes. However, there *is* a way for us to meet in the middle. There's no need for us to resort to violence. We may have opposing views, but does that mean we need to be enemies? Perhaps Angella is a lost cause, but you… I can see a *spark* in you."

With that, Herod Umbra raised his hand towards Adora, palm outstretched with an offer of peace.

"Take my hand, Adora. There's no need for any blood to be spilt. We can carve a way to a bright future *together."*

Adora looked at his hand, and beyond that, the guns pointed towards her.

All eyes were on her once more. She had been exposed as a sympathiser and a ‘traitor’. If she did not take his hand, she knew her days were numbered. It was the easy way out. The painless way forward.

But if she took his hand, more Ghosted Keres would die. Nothing would change. Angella might be spared and maybe violence would be avoided today, but how long would peace last? Was there ever any peace in the first place?

Adora gritted her teeth, felt her heart lurch in her throat, and moved towards her choice.

Catra exited off a highway and sped towards the nearby Guardians HQ. The building towered above all others, making it an easy destination. She was just a few seconds away.

She dodged another car, getting closer and closer to the rally. Her mind focused on nothing but speed and precision, blocking out endless screams of panic and anxiety.

There was nothing that mattered more than making sure this attack didn’t happen. That if it did, it would leave no casualties. That if it did, her people weren’t blamed for it.

And that if it did, Adora made it out alive.

As she overtook another car, Catra finally spotted a hopeful sign. The large crowd of people that swarmed outside Guardians HQ. The rally was still happening. There was still time. She needed to be quick.

Catra pulled the handbrake with her fingers, the bike grinding to a halt. She didn’t even wait for it to come to a stop as she stepped off midway through, using the momentum to boost herself forward as she sprinted towards the rally.

But when she got close enough, her heart rate spiked when she saw what was happening on stage.

Adora and Angella, surrounded by armed Runners, guns at the ready.

Herod Umbra's hand was stretched towards Adora.

Panic broke through Catra's mind, and her legs moved before her brain could comprehend the sight. She shoved and squeezed through person after person, the crowd seeming endless. She couldn't even comprehend her shortness of breath, her lungs being smothered by so many people.

Catra shuddered as she heard members in the crowd cheering for the Runners to shoot Adora and Angella. She was surrounded by people who would gladly see her killed if they knew who she was. Worst of all, any one of them could be in on Shadow Weaver's plan and be armed with a bomb.

She didn't have time to focus on the what ifs. Adora was in danger. Everyone was in danger. Something needed to be done before it was too late.

Catra looked up to see the stage coming closer with each effort she gave to push through the crowd. She needed to get her attention. She needed to be loud enough for everyone to hear.

The microphone. That was her only way.

But for now, she had only one other option.

She sucked in a deep breath and belted out with a scream that overtook the others. That scream was for one name only.

"ADORA!"

The Angel froze in place. She instantly recognised the voice. Her eyes left Umbra's hands, scanned the crowd, and came to rest on the most familiar pair of blue eyes.

Through the panic, Adora and Catra finally made eye contact.

“Catra…?” Adora shuddered under her breath.

“What are you looking at?” Umbra asked. “Don’t turn away from me, Adora!”

Adora didn’t listen.

Catra was being too slow. She needed to get to the front, fast.

So, she made a quick, possibly irrational decision.

Turning her head to the right, she quickly steered towards the side barriers. She used her momentum to jump the electric gates, pummelling through a pair of Runners.

She didn’t expect that to work. She shook off her surprise. She needed to roll with it.

Catra’s tunnel-vision focused on Adora and the mic. She sprinted down the side of the crowd, nothing to block her. She knew Runners were hot on her tail from behind her.

But she failed to notice the Runner charging to her from the side.

“Catra!” Adora cried, but it was too late.

Catra felt an impact like no other in her ribs, immediately draining the wind out of her body as her body hit the ground. A weight held her down, a hand pushing in the back of her head. A large group of Runners had stopped her.

“Let go of me…!” Catra grunted. There wasn’t any time for it. They wouldn’t kill her yet, her being a Ghost wasn’t common knowledge, but they pinned her down hard. They slowed her down.

Adora saw Catra pinned down by Runners, and her overloaded brain immediately switched to one priority.

Save Catra.

She didn’t think as she bolted away from Umbra.

The politician’s eyes widened. The audience reacted appropriately, capturing the moment an Angel left behind the deal that would save the city.

Angella’s jaw tensed, but she let out a prideful nod as Adora ran towards what mattered to her most.

The Runners didn’t pull the trigger. An execution in front of so many wouldn’t be a good look. But they weren’t going to let Adora get away easily.

“Stop her!” Umbra barked to the Runners on the barriers.

Adora managed to get down the stairs, her eyes focused on Catra surrounded by aggressive Runners. They were pinning her arms behind her back. She gritted her teeth, preparing herself for a fight.

But Adora could only take a few steps before another Runner blocked her path, rounding the corner and wrapping an arm around her stomach before she could react.

“Get off her!” Adora screamed at the distant Runners surrounding Catra as she struggled against her own. She reached out a hand to her. “Catra!”

“You need to run! Everyone needs to get out of here right now!” Catra yelled out to Adora and to the crowd.

But her voice was practically nothing compared to the cameras and overlapping jeers. All control had been lost. There was no way anyone was going to listen to her.

Noise.

Voices.

Yelling.

Panic.

Anger.

Laughter.

Runners.

Catra, being placed under arrest.

Adora, being dragged back to the stage with severe effort.

Angella, furiously barking down Umbra and demanding Glimmer and Adora's release.

It was one big, chaotic blur.

Catra wondered if there was a chance to save anyone. If there was ever anything she could do. From the moment Angella made her stand, the rally had spiralled down into a sludge of toxicity and anger. The city buzzed with conflict, chaos, and conspiracy.

Catra looked up at Adora one last time. She made one more push to stand up. She gave her last ounce of strength and anger to break free from the Runners.

Then, somehow, through everything else, Catra heard a croaked voice.

"Ghost…"

Her spine froze. Her wide eyes snapped to the source of the voice to see another masked Runner looking her way. He held a rifle with tally marks notched onto the barrel. He stood nearby, a mere observer until now.

The Runners had only been arresting Catra for trespassing. They didn't know her Ghost status. That information hadn't been leaked yet.

But this one Runner…

"Ghost…"

This Runner knew.

Somehow, he knew.

Maybe he was one of Shadow Weaver's most trusted Runners.

Maybe he saw something no one else had.

But he knew Catra was a Ghost.

Adora spotted him, too. She saw where Catra was looking. She saw more panic flood into her eyes.

And then she saw the Runner raise his rifle and point it at Catra.

"NO!"

Adora screamed out, broke free of the Runner holding her back, and *ran* to Catra. Whether to save her life or to take the bullet, she didn't care.

Catra struggled more. She pushed against the Runners atop her. She looked down the end of that single Runner's rifle, and she was so, so *scared.*

But before the Runner could pull the trigger.

Before Adora could reach Catra.

Before anything else could happen.

A noise sounded across all of Styx City.

One that boomed like a siren and broke through every conversation. Every argument. Every picture. Every stare.

The noise rumbled through everyone’s chest. It was of a low pitch, like the beginning of a nuclear alarm that slowly, slowly amped up.

Catra’s eyes widened upon the realisation of what that noise was.

The weapon had been sounded.

What A Day, Hm?

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora must deal with the aftermath of the weapon being fired.

Chapter Notes

> CONTENT WARNINGS: Gore of the eye and bodies in the first scene, dark sexual themes at the beginning of the third scene, HEAVY suicidal thoughts at the end of the third scene, and *SPOILERS* major character death throughout the chapter *SPOILERS*

The ringing in Catra's ears drowned out screams of despair and grieving sobs.

She was flat on the concrete floor, scratches stinging against her clothes and blood leaking from the cut on her brow. Her vision slowly returned to her, rewarding her with the aftermath of the explosion. A fire had engulfed the stage, collapsing it. Multiple people were in shock, stumbling around in a daze or moving weakly on the ground. Others lay next to them, still and lifeless.

Catra could feel every one of her limbs. Some were sore, and some stung, but as she rolled onto her back and looked down, she saw that she was mostly intact. A few spots of blood and tattered clothing, but she'd make it. She was far enough away from the podium when it had been engulfed in flame.

It didn't matter, though. She didn't care about her own well-being.

She placed her hands on the warm floor, pushing herself up to look towards the stage. Her vision was blurry, and her hearing was numbed, but even still, she scanned the bodies and destruction for one person.

She'd already failed in stopping the explosion. She *couldn't* fail in this.

Smoke filled Catra's lungs, and her throat exploded with a fit of coughs as she stood up. Regardless, she pushed forward, stumbling towards the source of the explosion. Her legs worked just fine. Her senses were dulled, but they'd recover. She took in deep breaths as she felt the heat of the fire warm her skin and bring sweat out from her pores.

Catra held up a hand to block the bright light of the fire, and looked among the wreckage. The first body she spotted was Herod Umbra's, twisted, ripped and destroyed, his dead eyes cast up to the sky. Catra didn't feel any remorse, nor did she feel any sense of overwhelming joy. His death would create rippling impacts for her people.

She looked over to see a few more bodies. Some civilians, a few Runners. Then…

"Adora…!"

Catra recognised her instantly. She was nearby a few collapsed Runners, her long hair covering her face with blood coating the ends. Catra ran over to her body and her knees gave way as she fell beside Adora.

"Adora, talk to me…" Catra muttered, placing a hand on her shoulder. "Please say something. Anything…"

Just twelve hours ago, Catra never wanted to see or think about Adora again. She had shut her heart off to the Angel and worked hard to keep it closed. She thought it would always stay that way.

But now, with Adora unconscious and possibly dead before her, Catra's barriers turned to dust once again.

Catra's hand went up to grip Adora's, her fingers interlocking with hers. "Adora, please… Just squeeze my hand… Please…"

Nothing.

Catra gently began to roll Adora onto her back, trying to assess her state. She kept a tight grip on Adora's hand the entire time.

Adora's chest was still moving, rising and falling with each choked breath. Catra felt some relief wash over her for that, but even still, Adora's eyes were closed, and she was unresponsive. Blood leaked down her cheek from her closed left eye.

"Don't you dare go…" Catra whispered. "You promised…"

Catra's mind raced with painful memories of her last encounter with Adora. The screaming, the anger, the tears, the crushing of her heart. The possibility of *that* being her last talk with Adora hurt so much worse than any injury on her own body.

Catra cupped her hand against Adora's bloody cheek. "Adora…" She shuddered through trembled lips and built-up tears. "I'm sorry… for everything…"

Maybe Catra didn't have anything to apologise for. But her stupid heart filled with stupid grief and stupid guilt over her stupid feelings for Adora regardless.

So, Catra wrapped her arms around Adora. She pulled her world close and held her tight. She was delicate in her embrace in case Adora's body was broken, but nonetheless, she held her as tight as she could. She gently rocked Adora as tears fell from her eyes and sobs escaped her gritted teeth.

"I…" Catra wept as she pressed her face into Adora's shirt. "I love you… I still do… So please, just… Just stay…"

She knew she sounded pathetic. She knew she was betraying her decision to push Adora and everyone else away. She knew she was opening herself up to hurt once again. But if there was any chance Adora could somehow still hear her words, she needed to take it. Before it was too late.

But as Catra cried into Adora's shoulder and held her close, she soon felt a new sensation.

A hand to the back of her head.

A shock filled her spine, and she immediately assumed a Runner was pulling her away forever, but when Catra turned around, she saw nobody behind her. It was not the hand of a Runner.

It was Adora's hand.

"Adora?" Catra gasped, turning her head back to the Angel in her arms.

Catra watched as Adora let out a few coughs, and finally, opened her eye.

Catra would've been smiling. She would've let out a sigh of relief or maybe even brought Adora up for another hug.

But Catra didn't do either of those things when she saw Adora open her eye.

Instead, Catra's entire face dropped with horror.

"Catra…?" Adora croaked as she ran her hand through Catra's long, dark hair. "Is that you? Are… Are you okay?"

"I…" Catra shuddered. "I'm fine, but you…"

Adora coughed. She pushed her hand against the floor and brought herself up to her knees. She looked around herself, and her jaw tensed as she saw the bodies. "Oh no…"

"Don't… Don't move…" Catra's shaky hands slowly gripped on Adora's shoulder. "Don't push yourself… Just lie down…"

“Where’s Angella…?” Adora grunted with effort as she tried to push herself to her feet. “If she’s alive, I can still save her…”

“Adora…”

She wasn’t listening. She could barely move, no less stand, but even still, Adora pressed her hand to her chest. Her holographic angel wings came forth from the cybernetics in her back. They were as bright and perfect as ever.

“Adora, what are you doing…?” Catra tried to grab onto her hand, pulling her back.

“There has…” Adora mumbled to herself. “There has to be someone I can save…”

Adora stumbled forward like a zombie, her hand slipping away from Catra’s. She could only watch as Adora’s wings lit up against the smoke and fire as she went from person to person.

Catra slowly stood up, stepping over bodies and rubble as she walked after Adora. She stepped over Runners and civilians, knowing that for every lifeless body, Adora took more and more weight on her shoulders.

“Adora, you have to stop moving…” Catra called out. “You… You’re *really* hurt…”

“I’m okay… I’m okay…” Adora shook her head as she panted. “But Umbra’s dead… They’re all… No. No. Someone has to be alive. Someone has to…”

Her words trailed into silence as she spotted something amidst the smoke and rubble. Catra couldn’t stop her as she began to run, her weak and bloodied legs barely pushing through the effort.

Adora disappeared into the smoke and Catra chased after her as best as she could. The smoke filled her lungs and burnt at her throat, eventually reaching her eyes and causing her to flinch. Her

pain receptors were still active, and she could feel her eyes stinging.

Catra rubbed at her eyes for a few seconds to recover herself, then she slowly opened them and looked up.

Only to see Adora knelt down over Angella's body.

Or what was left of it.

Her hands were pressed over Angella's chest, pushing useless compressions and counting to herself under her breath. Angella's eyes, however, were completely lifeless. Her torso hopelessly shook with each push from Adora, and blood coated her limbs like thick paint.

Adora was trying to perform CPR on a broken corpse.

Catra felt her heart go cold at the sight.

"She's not breathing…" Adora said out loud as she kept up with the CPR, an already exhausting process. "But I can still save her! I just have to…"

"Adora…" Catra whimpered, kneeling down behind her. She gently placed a hand on Adora's back. "She's gone…"

"Don't say that!" Adora seethed, leaning down in an attempt to breathe some life into Angella. "She's just not breathing right now! She must have blood stuck in her throat, or… Or…"

"Adora—"

"Everyone else is dead but I can still save her!"

Catra could see Adora's entire body tense with each push. She was going to kill herself at this rate. Adrenaline was the only thing fuelling her, along with denial. The realisation hadn't dawned on Adora yet and she *refused* to look at it.

But the fact was, out of everyone who was on or close to that stage, Adora was the only survivor.

And knowing that fact would tear Adora to pieces.

Catra gently rubbed her hand along Adora's back. "I'm sorry…"

"Sorry for what?!" Adora panted, still pushing. "I'm the one who screwed everything up! I have to fix this!"

"This isn't your fault."

"Yes, it is! I missed the bomb!"

"Everyone missed the bomb. I was trying to warn everyone, but it was already too late."

"I should've seen it coming! I should've done *something!* I should've—"

"Adora, stop!"

Suddenly, Catra's arms wrapped around her from behind.

Adora felt the warm embrace from her trembling body. Her mind suddenly came back from the rush of adrenaline and panic, and Adora finally felt the blood and injuries on her body. She could feel everything hurting.

Catra held her tight, her face buried into Adora's back. She let out painful sobs, and that was enough for Adora to finally feel a lump rise in her throat.

Adora looked at Angella's body as she placed a hand over Catra's arm, biting her trembling bottom lip. "She... She's really gone…"

Adora whimpered. “Angella…”

“It’s not your fault…” Catra inched closer to Adora, both of them crumbled to their knees over Angella’s body. “It’s not your fault…”

Adora tried to choke back her sobs, the pain swelling in her upper chest as she gripped Catra’s arm tight.

“Why is this happening again…?” Adora cried, her nose tingling as her eye welled up with tears. “Why… Why am I still *alive,* Catra…?”

Catra could only hug her tighter.

Finally, within Catra’s embrace, Adora let herself go. She bowed her head and felt painful sobs rip from her chest. Catra never once let go.

Adora wept.

Tears fell from her right eye.

The only eye she had left.

Blood leaked from her missing left eye, and that trail of red joined with the tears on her chin.

As Angels began to descend onto the scene and Guardians from all divisions contained the fire and helped the civilians, Adora let out a few last sobs.

Then, she fell limp in Catra's arms.

"This morning, at 8:07AM, Styx City shook as an attack occurred during Herod Umbra's political rally outside the Guardians HQ building. Witnesses report hearing a loud, low siren, before seeing the podium on stage suddenly explode. This explosion led to seventeen currently confirmed deaths, including ten civilians and five Runners. We can also confirm that Herod Umbra and the Angel Leader, Angella Moonbright, were killed in the explosion. We have obtained exclusive audio of the incident, which we will play for you now. Be advised, the following material may be disturbing."

Catra could only look at the portrait of Angella shown on the screen, and the word 'dead' labelled underneath it.

A familiar sound began to play, the low and droning tone of the weapon being set off. Muffled shouting and the scuffling of the crowd could be heard as well, and Catra turned away from the screen.

It was hard to believe that only twelve hours ago, Angella had made the bold decision to support the Ghosted Keres in front of thousands of viewers. Her speech had been posted all over the internet, and leaked, uncensored footage showed the moment her body was ripped apart by the explosion. It was something Catra couldn't bring herself to look at.

The audio continued, and Catra thought she could hear the cries of the Runners as she had shoved them off of her in her attempt to reach Adora. A beeping had begun, a shrill noise that quickened in pace. Catra screwed her eyes shut, knowing what would follow.

She sat in the waiting room of a hospital. Guardians HQ was no longer a place for emergency patients to stay, and Adora had instead been transported to a smaller hospital building which the

Angels were using temporarily. After all the injuries from the explosion, the facility was thoroughly packed.

As the beeping ramped up in intensity, the scuffling continued. Catra could hear ragged breathing and whispered questions, until suddenly, the beeping stopped. For a second, there was silence.

Angella's voice broke through the suspended moment, choking out a single word.

"Glim—"

The explosion cut through the audio just like it had the seventeen confirmed casualties. A cacophony of sound ended the recording, and the reporter returned with a sombre voice.

"That was the moments leading up to the explosion, captured from a microphone on the stage. The response to this incident is still ongoing. Hundreds more have received injuries ranging from minor to severe. We now go live to the Runner Leader…"

Catra had a hood pulled over herself to hide her face and a small bandage covering one of her eyebrows. No official footage had been captured of her attempt to jump the barrier and run toward the stage, but she still had to be cautious. Anyone in that crowd could recognise her, especially a Runner.

She kept her eyes glued to the holographic TV screen as it cut to live footage of Shadow Weaver outside the Guardians HQ. Rubble was still littered out the front, and many windows and walls had been broken, but the building was mostly intact.

"What has occurred today," Shadow Weaver spoke to the interviewers, "is nothing short of an absolute tragedy. The loss of Herod Umbra, Angella Moonbright, ten civilians and five of my own Runners is a blow that will never be forgotten."

Catra clenched her hands into fists, trying to hide her look of disgust. Many people in the waiting room were watching the TV

screen, seeing Shadow Weaver as a beacon of hope. They didn't know the truth.

"My Runners and many other Guardians have been searching endlessly for the attacker," Shadow Weaver continued. "I come to you all to confirm that we have located the weapon and have firm suspicions about the identity of the attacker."

Catra perked up. The internet had been flooded with rumours and suspicions, with many threads saying that it was obviously an attack done by a Ghost, whilst others point out that the attack only occurred after Angella had come out in support of the Ghosted Keres.

Catra already knew which group of people Shadow Weaver was going to make happy.

"The weapon used emitted a sound-based signal, and that signal was received by an explosive in the podium, which then detonated. A weapon like this hadn't been used since the Awakening protests. Runners located the weapon and sent it to the Owls, our trusted forensics team. We thank the Owls for their quick work in uncovering fingerprints and DNA on the weapon. We cross-referenced this DNA with Nyx Industries' records, and they have confirmed to us…"

A thick silence hung in the air. Catra couldn't bear to look at the screen. She knew the words that came next.

"… That the weapon was fired by a Ker, and more likely, a Ghost."

Catra let out a pained sigh as gasps and mumbled words along the lines of 'I knew it' filled the waiting room.

"We are still trying to specify the identity of the Ker and uncover if they're truly a Ghost or not," Shadow Weaver spoke over the

multiple flashes of small cameras and drones. "Nyx Industries is working with us on every step on this. We *will* find out who did this and we will take drastic actions to make sure this never happens again. That is a promise I make to all of you."

Lies. All of it.

Shadow Weaver had planned every step of this. She'd won. Catra had no idea how many people were in on her plan, but it was *working.* The public's blaming of the Keres would skyrocket with this 'confirmation'.

There was only one thing she didn't account for.

"Shadow Weaver!" One reporter cried out among all the commotion that came after her speech. "If this attack was done by a Ghost, why would they kill Angella? She was clearly on their side, and she had risked her life to stand for them."

Angella's speech was the only reason that not everyone had gone against the Keres and the Ghosts yet. Catra could only be thankful for that. Even still, Shadow Weaver held firm.

"I cannot objectively answer that until we have a motive from the attacker themself," she spoke. "However, it is clear that the bomb was planted prior to Angella's speech. That says to me that, above all else, this was meant to be an attack on Herod Umbra and his followers, which would logically be done by a Ker or a Ghost. He was often labelled as 'anti-Keres' after all. Perhaps Angella was caught in the blast to create this very debate of motivation in order to distract us."

Shadow Weaver's voice was drowned out by the overlapping mumbled conversations in the waiting room. She turned her head to the corner, bringing up her small holographic texts with Entrapta.

'Did you see all that?' She sent to Entrapta.

The response was almost immediate. *'I did. Internet forums are going haywire.'*

'She's going to use this as an excuse to let the Runners into Utopia and let them kill us all.'

'It might not be that easy. There's still a lot of people on our side. She might've initially planned to go for the kill on us with this, but Angella's speech changed things up. She knows that trying to kill us all might spark another violent protest or even more.'

It was a small glimmer of hope. Without Angella's speech, there likely wouldn't be many repercussions if the Runners broke into Utopia right now and gunned everyone down. Even if the footage was released of that, there would likely be more celebration than not.

But Angella's speech was their saving grace. If the public knew the Runners attempted to kill all Ghosted Keres over this, it would bite Shadow Weaver instantly.

Catra texted once more. *'We need to move while she's hesitating then. Relocate Utopia ASAP.'*

'I would agree, but what if she's trying to bait us out? Wait for us to move and then strike? A lot of Offline Keres down here are nervous about moving so suddenly.'

'Maybe, but the fact is she knows our location. She's going to strike eventually.'

"Catra Horda?"

Catra looked up from her texts to the voice calling her name. It was an Angel standing up front, with concerned, narrowed eyes that scanned the small crowd in the waiting room. Her wings were bright.

Catra sent one last text to Entrapta. *'I need to go check on Adora, then I'll be heading home. I'll try to float between Utopia and the*

hospital as best as I can.'

Entrapta typed something out, but then deleted it. She hesitated for a few seconds, before sending a last stream of messages.

'I'm glad you're safe, Catra.'

'I really am'.

'I was scared you were gone.'

'So scared.'

'I just hope Adora will be okay, too.'

Catra texted back a thanks, before standing up and heading to the Angel up front. She pulled the hood over her face to hide herself from the others as she nodded to the Angel. "That's me."

"Adora sent me," the Angel spoke.

"She did?" Catra lightly gasped, her eyes widening. "Does that mean she's conscious?"

The Angel nodded, but her brows were still narrowed with worry. "We gave her the best care we could and tended to most of her internal wounds, but unfortunately, operating on the left eye is somewhat taboo. Given the Keres' fake left eyes, she might be mistaken for one if we give her a replacement eye or something along those lines. We've stabilised it as best we can, but the damage to her eye might be irreparable. However, she will survive."

Catra let out a shuddered breath, running her fingers over her mouth to still her trembling lips. Adora was going to live, but the damage had been done. Adora would be permanently scarred.

"Can…" Catra swallowed down the lump in her throat. "Can I see her?"

"That's… why she sent me here," the Angel smiled sadly. "She said that if you're still here, she really appreciates it, but she wants you to take care of yourself. She wants you to head home for the night, then you can visit her tomorrow. Her condition isn't entirely stable yet and she doesn't want to scare you if anything happens."

Catra blinked, grasping for words for a few seconds. "But… But *she's* the one who's hurt. *I'm* fine, I just… I have to see her."

The Angel gently shook her head. "I'm sorry, but if a patient requests to have no visitors, then we can't allow anyone in. Visiting hours begin at eight tomorrow and I'm sure she'd be happy to see you then."

Catra wanted to plead more or say *anything,* but the words didn't come out. Even after everything, the argument, the explosion, the injuries, Adora *still* prioritised Catra's well-being over her own. It was something that made Catra want to cry, infuriated her, and made her love Adora all at the same time.

Catra just nodded, letting out a defeated sigh. "Alright. Thank you for looking after her. Tell her I promise I'll be here first thing tomorrow."

The Angel nodded. "We will." With that, she quickly paced towards the emergency rooms, no doubt being needed in seven different places at once.

Catra stood alone and cold for a few more seconds, the hood providing little warmth. Her heart beat slowly, and her chest felt tight. Twelve hours of waiting, only to be told to go home.

Adora was going to live. That much, Catra could hold onto. It was perhaps the only thing keeping her above the raging darkness of deep depression.

She headed through the crowded waiting room and out the front door, the blistering heat of Styx City hitting her skin all at once. Even the rain that fell from the sky was warm as it coated the concrete and created reflections upon which neon lived. Her

apartment was a fifteen-minute walk away, but she likely wouldn't be able to rest tonight anyway.

She would be alone with Melog and her thoughts.

Before Catra walked away from the hospital, however, she noticed one other person standing near the front door. She was just out of the way to nearly be invisible, but Catra managed to pick up on her presence as she let out a quiet sob.

Catra turned and saw a woman only a tad shorter than herself. Her hair was glowing with the city, and she cradled a small box of belongings, looking through holographic images.

They were pictures of Angella.

The box contained her belongings from her office. Documents, certificates, files. Yet the woman only cared about the pictures.

Catra quickly deciphered the situation in her head.

"Hey."

The quiet voice vibrated through the rain, granting the attention of the woman. She turned to Catra, who stood in the rain with her, her hands in her pockets and her eyes lowered out of sympathy.

"You're… Angella's daughter, right?"

The woman wiped tears away from her stinging eyes, but they still mixed with the rain. She nodded and spoke her name. "Glimmer."

"Glimmer… I'm, uh…" Catra sighed, before looking up to the woman. "I'm sorry about your mom. I know you've probably heard that a thousand times today, but..."

Glimmer sadly scoffed to herself. "Actually, you're the first to say anything like that."

Catra blinked. “Really?”

“All I’ve been asked today is if the Ghosted Keres were threatening my mom. Or if my mom had gone insane. Or if I plan to become the Angel Leader in her place.” Glimmer sniffled, looking at the picture of Angella. “I’ve gotten hundreds of questions like that… But not *one* person expressing any sympathy.”

“That’s…” Catra gritted her teeth. “Fuck. That’s *really* shitty.”

“Tell me about it.” Glimmer’s voice was croaky and tired. “I don’t know if my mom was ‘in on some big conspiracy’. I don’t know if she was planning something. I don’t know why she was killed or who did this. God, I don’t know fucking *anything.* The one thing I know is that I’m going to go home tonight and… no-one’s going to be there to ask me how my day was.”

Glimmer’s voice wobbled with the last few words.

Catra took a step towards her, pulling the hood away from her face and letting her hair become damp with the rain. “I’m not going to pretend I know what you’re going through or what you’re feeling. Grief is… different for everyone. You can take all the time you need to feel however you need to feel.”

“But I don't even know *what* I’m feeling.” Glimmer’s lips trembled as droplets of rain fell onto her face. She put a hand to her chest. “It’s… empty and heavy at the same time. I just want to wake up from this nightmare and… And I want to see her again. I want to tell her that I love her, or that I’m thankful for everything she’s done, or that she’s the best mom I ever could’ve asked for, or *anything* so that our last conversation won’t be some stupid argument that I’ll never be able to take back.”

Catra didn’t interrupt her. She had flashes of Adora as Glimmer spoke. Glimmer didn’t wait for a response but having an ear to talk to after all this was something she desperately needed.

“The worst part is…” Glimmer choked, a few tears falling as she looked up into Catra’s eyes. “I think her death might be my fault.”

Catra instantly shook her head. “Don’t say that.”

“But it’s *true.* I screamed at her, told her that she wasn’t doing enough for the Ghosted Keres and that she needed to be more willing to fight.” Glimmer felt a shuddered sigh escape. “And when she finally listens to me and calls for action in front of thousands…”

Glimmer looked at the floor to hide her tears. She held back sobs and the ugliness of grief. Once she was home, she’d be able to spend all night letting it out, and it still would never be enough.

But soon, Catra spoke up.

“Your mom was brave. So are you, Glimmer. She didn’t deserve to die, and I can’t judge whether what she did was ‘right’ or not. But what I can say is…”

Glimmer looked up and saw Catra’s left eye shift from blue to yellow.

“We won’t let her last words be in vain. I promise.”

Glimmer’s eyes went wide with tears as she looked at Catra. She knew it was an impulsive decision to make, but Catra couldn’t let herself just watch anymore. Glimmer needed a spark of hope. She didn’t know if this would do much, but it had to be *something.*

Glimmer’s lips trembled again. She let a single chuckle escape as she tried to push her feelings down, but it was broken by the

outburst of grief and relief that flooded her system. Her throat went tight, her nose tingled, and without much care…

She suddenly threw her arms around Catra.

Catra wasn't usually the biggest fan of others invading her personal space out of nowhere. But as Glimmer began to sob and grip Catra tight, she didn't have the heart to push her away. Even if she wanted to, she couldn't.

So, Catra instead returned the embrace, placing her hand on the back of Glimmer's head and pulling her close. God knew she needed this.

Through the muffled crying, Glimmer only choked out one more sentence.

"Thank you…"

They would soon go their separate ways. Catra didn't even know if she'd see Glimmer ever again. The next few weeks would likely be a panicked blur and may even be her last.

But in that moment, she knew that she needed to hold this grieving woman close.

As Glimmer's tears mixed with the rain.

Catra walked alone on the sidewalk when she saw a pink glow illuminate the area around her.

She had been walking in silence for the past ten minutes, after she left Glimmer. The grieving woman had returned home after her thanks to Catra and her promise that she wouldn't do anything regrettable.

Catra had been left to her thoughts on the walk home, only passing by the occasional car and group of people. The streets felt

weirdly empty that night. The rain kept coming, wetting the bandage on her brow.

However, it was the pink glow that finally made her stop walking.

Something had lit up to her left, sounding a cheery tone as it came to life. With words that echoed endlessly and a seductive tone that was as smooth as honey, a voice sounded from the glow.

"Hello, sweetheart."

Catra looked over to the voice in silence, and eventually had to look up once she noticed what it was. It was a sight that made her heart stop and her throat go cold.

It was a woman, tall as a tower, and completely naked. Her entire body let off that pink glow, and her pupils were entirely black. Her hair was an unnatural shade of blue, and she smiled down at Catra as she walked towards her.

The woman's body was 'perfect' in a sense. Skinny, but still with an exaggerated chest and curved hips. She constantly smiled, letting out gentle giggles and soft moans for actions that didn't even need them. She didn't have a single freckle, stretch mark, crease, nothing. Not a single 'flaw'.

Catra stood on a bridge overlooking the street, so the tall hologram of the naked woman only had to kneel down to come eye level with Catra. She placed her hand on her chin, letting out a long, drawn-out sigh.

"What a day, hm?" The tall, holographic woman spoke.

Catra didn't respond.

The towering pink woman reached out a hand and pointed to Catra, her finger almost tapping Catra on the nose. *"You look lonely."*

She smiled.

"I can fix that."

Catra felt her chest go tight.

The woman lowered her hand, leaning in close. *"You look like a good girl. I can be whatever you want me to be, sweetheart. I was made to be perfect for you."*

Catra couldn't pull her eyes away. She didn't stare at her body, but instead at her completely dark eyes. There wasn't a single sign of life in them.

The tall woman could sense that Catra wasn't a taker. She soon resorted to rolling herself onto all fours, letting out a pleasured sigh. She gave Catra a smile and a wink, before crawling back to her initial position and getting herself back onto her feet.

The glowing woman returned to her initial position. Her behind faced Catra and she looked over her shoulder just as a logo popped up over her hips.

'Keres Pleasure Model – To Suit Your Every Want and Need'.

Catra felt something unnaturally acidic rise in her throat at the logo. She gently lowered her head, squeezing her eyes shut and swallowing down the feeling. She turned away from the hologram and began to walk away.

She knew of Offline Keres who enjoyed working in fields involving sexual activity. They enjoyed the freedom to express their bodies in ways they saw fit. Catra admired them more than anything.

But this…

This was *not* that.

"Bye-bye, sweetheart," the hologram cooed after Catra as she walked away, blowing a kiss to her. *"I'll be here if you ever need a*

good night."

Catra increased her pace.

It was just a hologram. There was nothing she could do. But that did nothing to ease the sickness that twisted her stomach.

The world became a blur as she walked back into her apartment and up the stairs. She had no idea of how much time had passed. Her brain was too focused on the words and the sight of that hologram.

Today, she had seen more hatred for the Keres than she'd ever seen in her entire life. Blame was thrown at them endlessly for the attack, and there were multiple calls for the elimination of all of her people.

But even still, those kinds of holograms were not only allowed, but *encouraged.*

Catra's legs ached from the walking and her head pulsed with the thoughts that rushed through her mind. The sounds of rain and the lights of the city were almost dizzying.

Noise, wetness, cars, advertisements, people, sex, alcohol, violence, attack, Angella, explosions.

An endless barrage to the senses that made Catra's ears ring, until finally…

She shut the door to her apartment.

She was home.

Through the blur and haze and dizziness, she was *home.*

The last few minutes didn't feel real. This entire *day* didn't feel real. What if she woke up in Adora's arms the next morning and none of this had ever happened?

Catra looked at the floor as she panted. Had she been running? Most likely. Her legs hurt. The cut in her eyebrow had opened up again, and blood was trickling down her cheek once more. She put a hand to her head and felt the sides of her skull pulse endlessly.

Would she even be able to sleep? Would she be able to dream?

She looked around her apartment and saw the usual. Scattered dishes in her sink, holographic TV on standby, Melog's feeding bowl empty.

And bags.

Garbage bags full of Adora's belongings.

Oh.

Right.

Adora was meant to leave her apartment today.

Catra slowly walked over the small amount of bags, looking down into their contents. It was just like a month ago when Adora temporarily moved in. She had made herself comfortable. She was happy. They looked at the rain together, watched movies together, held each other, slept with each other.

Memories flooded Catra with these bags. Memories of a better time. It was only a month, but it was the happiest month of her life.

Now all of it would be lost. Would things ever be the same between them? Would Catra even survive to the end of the week? Would the city even last the month?

Catra reached down and picked out a single shirt of Adora's. It was plain, white, basic. She didn't have the best fashion sense, but Catra loved the simplicity of her clothing. She loved the way Adora was always dressed and ready in less than fifteen minutes.

She loved the way Adora always left her a note if she was gone before Catra would wake up.

Catra gripped the shirt tightly in her hands. Adora was alone in the hospital with a lost eye and a belief that she shouldn't even be alive.

Catra's mind kept flashing back to before the explosion. To all the things she could've done to prevent it. If she had been fast enough, if she hadn't been tackled by the Runners, if she hadn't screamed at Adora the previous night…

Maybe she'd be okay.

Now everything was *fucked.*

They'd fallen right into Shadow Weaver's hands. She knew the location of Utopia. She'd killed Angella and gotten away with it. She pinned the blame on the Keres and had gotten away with it.

Catra stumbled into the kitchen, her trembled hands gripping the sink as she felt something in her throat, like a slug trying to crawl out of her mouth.

She trembled.

Something built in her gut.

Vomit.

Fear.

Rage.

The image of the tall glowing woman kept flashing in her mind.

The image of Adora with a bloody eye kept flashing in her mind.

The image of Angella's body kept flashing in her mind.

and it was all

too

damn

much.

Her scream was like white noise as she grabbed the tray of dishes and *smashed* them into the walls.

Cuts imbedded into her palms from the broken glass. Sudden pounding against the wall came from her neighbours telling her to shut up.

Pound.

Rain.

Pound.

Advertisements.

Pound.

Noise.

Noise.

Noise.

Fucking stop.

Stop, stop, stop with all the fucking NOISE.

She grabbed the fridge and pulled it down, smashing its contents all over the floor.

Her mind was hazy, and her body felt on fire.

She grabbed the *stupid* projector for her holo-TV and threw it against the wall, watching it smash into a million pieces.

It was cathartic. Catra was weeping.

She tore the sheets off her bed, the same bed she had felt passion and safety with Adora. Her body moved her from location to location. Her mind programmed her to *destroy.*

Fuck this apartment.

Fuck this city.

Fuck this world.

Fuck everyone and everything.

*And fuck **you**, Catra.*

*You worthless, good for nothing, piece of **shit**. You're a curse to everyone around you. What'd you think was going to happen if you let someone get close?*

*You ate Adora's heart. She's suffering because of you, you fucking **monster**.*

Maybe Adora will hate you after this. Maybe all of the Offline Keres will wish you were dead. Maybe Entrapta will realise you're just a burden to everyone there and especially to her. Maybe you'll finallyhave the guts to fucking end it all.

Go on.

Do it.

*Throw yourself out of the balcony **right fucking now.***

It's what you deserve.

*All because you can't control your **stupid fucking heart.***

But really, who cares about them?

Nobody could ever hate you as much as you already hate yourself.

I hate you.

I hate you.

I fucking HATE YOU!

Catra's mind screamed thoughts like this at herself.

Until she realised she was standing on the balcony with her hands tightly gripping the rails.

She…

She was close.

So close.

She still stood on the safe side of the balcony. But all it took was one small action for her to fling herself over.

She glared down at the reflection of herself down in the puddle at her feet. Her tears were as endless as the rage in her body. Her hair was a frazzled mess, and blood coated her palm from the cuts of the dishes.

Her brows were flared as she stared at herself in the puddle. Her eyes stung red, and her lips wobbled.

Maybe this was for the best.

Everything was fucked anyway. What was there to live for?

Every day was just more potential for pain. More potential for agony. Time kept moving forward. Nothing ever stopped. She could never go back to the good old days.

It was so easy.

Just one small move, and she'd be falling towards the earth.

A few seconds later, she'd be at peace.

Surrounded by nothingness.

It was so easy.

It was so hard.

Throwing herself over the balcony was the easiest and hardest thing in the world.

She could do it.

She couldn’t do it.

Her grip tightened.

She shut her eyes.

Would it be easier if she closed her eyes? Maybe.

She was a little bit scared of heights.

Come on.

It was just one small move.

Just a few seconds of free-falling.

Why couldn’t she do it?

Fuck it. She was going to do it.

She gritted her teeth.

She tensed her arms.

Then…

She heard a gentle meow.

She blinked. Something rubbed up against her leg, letting out a soft *purr.* She looked down at the black bundle of fur and eyes by

her feet.

Melog.

They looked up at her with their bright eyes. She looked down at them with her bloody hands, tear-stained cheeks, messy hair, sweat-coated face, and torn clothes.

They still loved her.

She took another deep breath, higher pitched this time. Her chin trembled and her hands became weak. *She* became weak. It was just a stupid *cat*, so why was she about to sob over this?

"Dammit…" She sighed to herself, her hands dropping from the rails as she stepped back. "Fine. I won't do it, then. Are you happy?"

Melog purred. They were.

Fuck.

She was too close.

She was a few seconds away from killing herself.

The realisation sent a heavy chill down her spine.

God…

She was so *stupid.*

Catra felt her heart rate slowly come down as she exited the balcony and went back inside. She looked at the mess that was her apartment. Scattered bits of plates and mugs, a fridge tumbled onto its front with liquid spilt everywhere, a holo-TV letting out glitched sound and torn footage of a shitty movie.

It had taken a year to make this apartment comfortable to live in.

It only took five minutes to destroy it all.

But even still, Melog's food bowl was the same. And Adora's bags remained untouched.

Catra went over to the couch. She fell back and let herself sink into the cushions. It swallowed her and held her in place. For some reason, it felt comfortable only *now*, when it never had been before.

Maybe it was Adora's effect on it.

Catra ran her bloody hand over her face. It was dried enough to not leave too much of a stain, but some red still coated her cheeks. They mixed with her tears, which she barely bothered to wipe away.

Melog jumped up onto her lap and made themself comfortable as they curled up on her thighs. Catra let out a slight snicker, running her hand over their soft fur.

Her other hand, meanwhile, reached into the pocket of her hoodie, and pulled out a packet of cigarettes.

It had been a quick purchase on the way home. She tapped the bottom of the package to shift the smokes, and used her mouth to pull one out, the orange end pressed between her lips. She flicked open the tip of her thumb to expose the lighter and lit the cigarette, instantly letting the familiar smoke and tang rest on her tongue and in her throat.

She wasn't proud of herself.

But she never had been in the first place.

Amidst the wreckage of her apartment, as her hair stuck to her sweaty forehead and blood ran gently down her arms and cheeks, Catra breathed in and puffed out smoke. Her left eye shifted back to yellow. She glared at nothing in particular as her left hand stroked Melog's fur, and she placed her right elbow on the armrest of the couch and tapped out the ash of her cigarette in her right hand.

She knew she wouldn’t sleep that night.

But dreams were an escape she didn’t deserve.

“Catra Horda?”

It was the same Angel.

Catra looked up from her seat and spotted the same Angel from last night calling her name. She stood up, her hood still covering her face from everyone around her. Her blue eyes looked at the Angel.

“I can take you to see Adora now,” the Angel smiled.

“Please.”

Catra managed to peer into a few rooms as she followed the Angel down winding hallways. A few faces she recognised as people from the crowd yesterday, who were still recovering from their injuries. Everything from broken limbs to deafness to mental trauma.

Shadow Weaver had done all this. Moros had done all this. No one knew the truth except for the Offline Keres, and no one would listen to them.

The hospital was thoroughly packed, and Angels paced up and down the hall without a break in sight. There would be no way they could keep up this support for everyone. There was no doubt in Catra’s mind of the toll this would take on the Angels, too.

“It’s just up here.”

The Angel extended a hand to one of the rooms, and Catra could look in to see Adora on a bed, her right side facing the door. She was talking to two women with a smile on her face, and she wore hospital gowns.

Catra gently opened the door, interrupting the conversation between the three women as she stepped in. She looked at the two older women, who glanced between her and Adora.

"There you are," Adora smiled once she took notice of Catra.

Then she slowly turned her head, and Catra saw the black eyepatch that covered her left eye.

Catra swallowed down the tightness in her throat and smiled as best as she could. "Hey, Adora."

"Who's this?" One of the women asked Adora.

"This is Catra," Adora responded, her eyes still locked with Catra's. "I've been living with her for the last month. She's a good friend of mine."

Catra gave a small, awkward wave to the other two women.

"Catra," Adora nodded to them. "These are my moms, Rebecca and Isabel."

Rebecca was a tall woman, with a hair colour that matched Adora's and green eyes. Isabel was shorter than her by several inches, and she had Adora's eyes, though with shorter red hair. They both smiled at Catra.

"We can't thank you enough for giving our daughter a place to stay," Rebecca said as she grabbed Catra's hand.

"Of course, she could've *always* come back to our home," Isabel scoffed to Adora, "but something tells me she's too full of pride for that to happen."

"Yeah, she's…" Catra looked from Isabel to Adora, and the Angel gave her a knowing nod. "She's definitely like that. How are you feeling, Adora?"

Adora broke eye contact, her eyes becoming unfocused but her smile remaining on her face. "I'm good. They gave me the best treatment they could. My Angel insurance means it's mostly covered but… Well, this is probably going to set me back a couple thousand. That's even if I still *have* that insurance."

"We can pay for it," Rebecca immediately offered. "You shouldn't be worrying about anything like that after a *surgery."*

"It's fine, mom. I promise." Adora smiled, before letting out a whimsical sigh. "*Definitely* going to miss my depth perception, though."

"It's still a bunch of bullshit that they couldn't give you any cybernetics for the eye," Isabel frowned. "You'd think a scanner would be able to tell the difference between a Ker eye and a normal replacement eye. And even then, so *what* if Adora is mistaken for a Ker?"

Adora shook her head. "It's fine. The tech process is still ongoing. I'll live with it."

"But still—"

"Mom." Adora cut Isabel off. "I'll be okay. I just… can I get a bit of time alone with Catra? There's some stuff we need to talk about."

Isabel stopped, her lips thinned as she took in her daughter's words. Rebecca was quick to grab her hand. "Come on, Is. We can argue about all this later."

"Right…" Isabel let out a shuddered sigh. She turned to Catra. "Just… let us know if something happens. And… thank you. Really. We're in your debt for everything you've done for our daughter."

Catra nodded. The couple walked out hand-in-hand, muttering gentle disagreements and solutions between them as they closed the door. Even with Isabel's fury and Rebecca's gentle nature, they found a way together to sort things through.

Catra turned back to Adora and saw her turned away, her eyes cast out to the window next to her and overlooking the city. Catra looked at the belongings surrounding Adora brought to her by her moms, including old holographic pictures and some favourite movies to watch on the TV before her.

She looked up to Adora and let out a sigh. “Adora—”

“How many?”

Adora’s voice had *dropped.* The gentle nature of it was gone, replaced with a tired croakiness.

Catra blinked. “What do you mean?”

“How many people died?” Adora kept herself turned away. “They won’t let me watch the news. I need you to tell me.”

“Adora, you don’t need to know—”

“How many?”

“It’ll only hurt you to—"

“How many?”

“Adora, *please—”*

“How. Many?”

Adora turned, and her single eye was ice cold. It glared at Catra and sent chills through her spine. But among all this, Catra noticed Adora’s hands were trembling.

Catra swallowed and answered. “Seventeen. Including Angella and Umbra.”

Adora let out a gasp like she had been hit in the gut. Her cold gaze dropped, traded for a hazy eye that glazed over with tears. She looked down to her feet and shook her head.

“And yet I’m still here…” Adora croaked.

She looked back at Catra. The two of them shared a vulnerable look of trembled emotions, each trying to hold back the hideousness of their grief and regrets. An unsettled silence barely hung between them for just a few seconds.

But they knew they couldn’t keep this act up.

It was Catra who wrapped her arms around Adora first.

Adora instantly returned the embrace, not even caring about her stability. She buried her fingers in Catra’s familiar warm hair and pressed her face against her chest.

Catra stroked Adora’s smooth hair and held her gently by the back of her head. “Don’t say shit like that…” Catra shuddered. “I was so fucking *terrified* of losing you. I’m so sorry, Adora... I was stupid to think I could ever push you out of my life. I *need* you.”

“Shut up…” Adora sobbed as she shook her head. “*I’m* the one who’s sorry. You had every right to do what you did. I betrayed your trust… I led them to Utopia…”

“They *used* you. It wasn’t your fault.” Catra held Adora as close as she could. “I didn’t mean what I said that night. I *never* stopped loving you.”

“Catra… I thought you would hate me forever… I thought I’d never see you again…”

“Shh… I’m right here… I’m right here…”

Catra gently rocked Adora in the hug and felt the Angel grip tightly onto the back of her shirt. They held each other for minutes with only silence between them, sharing one gentle heartbeat.

“Adora…” Catra let out a shaky breath. “I’m so fucking sorry I didn’t tell you earlier. I’m sorry I kept lying to you. I’m sorry—”

"You have *no* reason to apologise," Adora shook her head, her face still buried in Catra's chest. "It… It was a shock to learn, but I've had time to think about it, and you being a Ghost changes *nothing* about how much I love you. You had every reason to protect yourself with that lie."

Catra felt her heart flutter, and she tightened the hug. "Thank you…"

"If anything…" Adora let out a sigh. "I'm just so glad I can appreciate you for who you *really* are now."

Catra couldn't believe for one second that there was a period of time where she thought she didn't love Adora.

She pulled away to look down at Adora. She tenderly stroked her left cheek, her thumb brushed gently over Adora's eyepatch. Adora reached a hand up to grab Catra's. She turned her head and placed gentle kisses on Catra's palm.

However, Adora soon pulled away. She blinked and traced her fingers over the crinkles on Catra's palm, noticing a roughness and small number of scars. "…Did you hurt yourself?"

"It's nothing. I'm fine," Catra shook her head.

"What happened?" Adora's eye looked up to her. She could see through Catra's barrier now. She reached up and cupped Catra's cheek in her hand.

"It…" Catra sighed. "It was just… a bad time for me last night. Between you and everything going on surrounding the attack… I did some dumb stuff. I'll be fine."

"You didn't hurt yourself on purpose, did you?"

Catra's jaw tensed. "I wasn't *trying* to hurt myself intentionally. But… I wasn't really looking after myself either. I couldn't even sleep. Not until I knew you were okay."

“Catra…” Adora’s lips wobbled as she reached both hands up and cupped them over Catra’s cheeks. “Oh, Catra…”

“Stop *worrying* about me all the time,” Catra chuckled sadly as tears formed in the corners of her eyes. “You could stand to look after yourself a little bit better.”

“Same goes to you!” Adora sobbed as a broken smile formed on her face. “God… We *both* suck at taking care of ourselves, don’t we?”

“We really do…” Catra laughed as a few tears dropped from her cheeks and onto Adora’s gown.

She had Adora in her arms. She felt Adora’s hands against her cheek. She heard Adora’s gentle broken breaths. Adora was here. Adora was alive. So much of everything was fucked, but Adora was *alive.* It was all Catra could cling onto with a grip that broke her nails and bruised her knuckles. It was all that kept her afloat.

Adora leaned up as best as she could and gently pressed her forehead to Catra’s. She returned the gesture as she closed her eyes, her hand gripping Adora’s as their fingers interlocked.

Adora took a shaky breath and whispered: “I don’t want to lose you, too…”

“End of the world, Adora.” Catra squeezed her hand. “Not a day sooner. We go *together.* That’s what I promised you.”

Adora opened her eye and smiled. That promise gave her hope—kept her sane. The fact that maybe, just maybe, she wouldn’t have to outlive another person she loved was what Adora clung to. The pain of loss was becoming too much to bear.

Catra’s promise was what convinced her to cup her hand around her cheek, tilt her head slightly, lean in, and finally, press her lips to Catra’s.

They both felt so much *warmth* in the kiss. They both silently cried into it, but further deepened it. Catra's hand stroked the side Adora's neck and Adora felt Catra's beautiful hair. They shuddered and occasionally sobbed and comforted each other and promised that everything would be okay.

Noses bumped. Teeth clanged. It was awkward and clumsy and desperate and, fuck, it was *everything* they needed.

"I love you," Catra sighed into her lips. She pulled back, then immediately sealed another kiss. "I love you, I love you, I *love* you."

"I love you, too," Adora shuddered and returned one last kiss. "I love you so much, Catra."

"I love you."

"I love you."

"I love you."

"I love you."

Their hands remained on each other, never once letting go. They took in each other's touch, smell, sound. Despite everything, they were both still here.

Adora looked into Catra's tired eyes and let out a sympathetic sigh. "But now… I have to *fix* this."

Catra's smile slowly dropped. Adora's expression had hidden away her vulnerability and returned the cold gaze.

Dammit. Not again.

"Fix *what?"* Catra shook her head. "Adora, you lost an *eye.* You're not in any shape to—"

"They've put me on the best treatment. I can be out and walking soon," Adora cut her off. "Besides, that doesn't matter. I *survived* that blast. Everyone else died, but I'm still here. I can't waste this chance again."

"Adora…"

"I'll stay here for one more day," Adora said. "But after that… I need to make this right. It's what I owe Angella. It's what I owe Mara. It's what I owe all the Offline Keres. And it's what I owe *you."*

"Stop saying these things!" Catra gripped Adora's shoulders. "Entrapta and I and everyone at Utopia are already getting to the bottom of this and trying to find a solution."

"Then let me help you," Adora pleaded, her hand wrapped around Catra's wrist. "Just… At the very least, just tell me you know who attacked the rally. Tell me you have a motive. Tell me you have *something."*

Adora was desperate for answers, but Catra knew how much they'd hurt. Her grip on her wrist was tight and shaky. Catra couldn't hide her furrowed eyebrows, revealing to Adora that she knew more than she let on.

"Catra…" Adora narrowed her brows and leaned in close. *"Please…"*

She couldn't hide the truth. She promised no more secrets between them. Catra wanted to protect her more than anything, but if she didn't tell her now, Adora would likely get herself killed trying to find out.

Catra sighed. The truth needed to be laid out.

"It was Shadow Weaver."

Adora's single eye blinked and widened. Her initial reaction was shock as her jaw slightly slacked, before she pulled it back and

tensed it. In less than five seconds, she knew that it just made *sense.*

Catra continued. "Entrapta's hooked up to the Runner comms. Her hacking ability and her time as a Warlock means no one can detect her when she's listening in on them." She looked up into Adora's eye. "She heard communications between Shadow Weaver and Moros."

"Moros…?" Adora shuddered.

"It was Moros who sounded the weapon and set off the explosion. And it was Shadow Weaver who gave the order."

Adora put a hand to her head. She wanted to deny it, she wanted to find some gap, but it made a painful amount of sense. Her stomach suddenly felt heavy.

"Why…" Adora shook her head. She looked up at Catra. "Why would Shadow Weaver do that? She got Umbra killed, and her own Runners…"

"She pinned the blame on the Keres. On my people," Catra grimaced. "Moros likely had something to fake his fingerprints so he could fool the Owls. She ordered an attack on an anti-Keres rally for a reason. I don't think she predicted Angella siding with us… But I don't think she cared. She wanted Angella dead. And…"

"She wanted me dead as well," Adora finished. "Moros did, too. That's why he took the job. His brother was killed by Violet, and I let her go. He hates me for that."

"I won't let *either* of them get to you." Catra cupped Adora's cheek in her hand, her voice a low growl as she spoke. She had already nearly lost Adora once. It wasn't going to happen again.

"I won't let them hurt you, either," Adora nodded as she gripped Catra's hand. "Shadow Weaver… She's trying to wipe out all the Ghosts. She's doing it in a way where the public will *support* it."

"I'd go as far to say she's trying to wipe out *all* Keres. But there's two things she didn't account for," Catra spoke. "Angella's speech managed to rile a lot of the public and get some people on our side. If the Runners try to kill all of us, they'll have a riot on their hands."

Adora nodded. "And what's the other thing?"

"You."

She blinked. Slowly, she raised a finger and pointed at herself. "What about me…?"

"You lived, Adora," Catra smiled. "You stood alongside Angella in front of thousands. You let everyone know that you spared one of our own, and that you *love* a Ghost. People recognise you as being on our side. You'll be a beacon of hope, to us and to everyone who's with us. I'm not saying you *have* to do anything… But you being alive can *mean* something to all of us."

Adora didn't know how to respond to that. She looked down at the sheets that covered her. Her whole life, she'd dreamt of being that very beacon of hope for people in need. Now she was doing it by just *living.*

A tone sounded in Catra's ear, and she held up her left arm to project who was calling her. Adora noticed Catra's distraction.

"Entrapta…" Catra muttered to herself as she read out the caller's name.

"You needed in Utopia?" Adora asked.

Catra nodded. "I think so."

"I'd come along, but I don't think the Angels are willing to let me leave just yet," Adora sighed. "Plus, I… need some time to think. About everything."

Catra could see the twisted sense of pain and hope on Adora's face. She was desperately trying to cling to the latter, to that idea of being a beacon of hope and saving Catra and the Offline Keres.

But Angella was dead. Umbra was dead. *She* was supposed to be dead, too. That guilt ate away at her heart like acid. The idea of making things right was the only thing that chained her to the real world and to life.

That, and Catra.

Her Catra.

"I'll go check what it is," Catra said. "I don't know how long it'll take, but I'll be right back afterwards. Stay with your moms and anyone who visits you. We'll get you out of here and into Utopia, okay?"

"Alright." Adora leaned up, and Catra quickly recognised what for. She moved down and pressed her lips to Adora's, taking her in one last time. "Please, just… be safe. *Please."*

Catra smiled. "Same goes to you."

Adora nodded and gave Catra one last stroke on her cheek. Finally, the two of them pulled away from each other, and Catra stepped away from her hospital bed. She glanced over her shoulder as she walked away, and saw Adora look out the window once again.

Adora's coldness wasn't there anymore. It wasn't entirely replaced with the fire of hope. But there was a spark within her, and a warmth that she huddled close to her heart.

Maybe there was a light at the end of all this.

Catra walked by Adora's moms and out of the hospital. She ducked down a lone alleyway and pulled the hoodie over her face as she took the call from Entrapta.

“Catra! Finally!” Entrapta sounded frantic in her ears.

“What’s going on? Is everything alright?” Catra asked.

“Nothing to panic about! Yet!” Entrapta’s voice had a hint of *eagerness* in it, a slight raise in her pitch as if she held back her usual bubbly giggles. “I’ve finally finished something I’ve been working on for a while. I haven’t been able to perform any test runs, but we don’t have time. I need you at Utopia for this machine.”

“Okay… What is it?”

“It’s a pod that uses parts from memory uploads for Online Keres and parts from my Disconnection procedures. It’ll encrypt your consciousness and upload it.”

“Is that… safe?”

“It should be! Maybe! I hope! I’d use it myself, but I need to moderate and survey it while someone else goes in. You seem like the one for that job.”

“What job?”

“It’s simple!” Entrapta’s voice shifted to one of fierce determination. “I’m going to encrypt your consciousness and upload you into Nyx Industries’ servers. You’re going to meet the Moirai.”

“The Moirai?”

The AI that Nyx Industries created back in 2055. The AI where all Keres came from, who all Online Keres were meant to upload their memories to, and who all Offline Keres Disconnected from. The Moirai was, in a simple sense, the god of the Keres. They gave a piece of themselves to create each consciousness within each Ker.

And Entrapta needed them for one reason.

“Yes. You’re going to talk to the Moirai, and you’re going to find out from them about *how we strike back.”*

The Moirai

Chapter Summary

Catra enters a new world in search of an AI god. Things go as well as expected.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is a weird one, y'all. Strap yourselves in!

CONTENT WARNINGS: Fake major character death and graphic violence in scene 2, as well as *SPOILERS* *SPOILERS* mention of genocide in scene 3 and death in scene 5 *SPOILERS* *SPOILERS*

"Entrapta's told me this machine should be safe enough, but in case things go sideways… I just wanted you to have this message. Just… Take care of yourself, alright?"

Catra cut her own recording there, and it was instantly uploaded to a small chipped hard drive. It may well have been the last thing she ever left behind in Styx City.

She took in a deep breath and let it out as she stood up. She'd been given about twenty minutes to prepare for what came next, and she couldn't delay any longer. What she was about to do was a first for any Offline Ker, and could almost be labelled as a suicide mission.

She intended to make it out alive. But most of all, she intended to do the right thing.

Catra exited her home and stepped back out into the fresh land of Utopia. Most of it had become barren, the marquees packed away along with the tents. Cabins had become as empty as the greenhouse, and most of the Offline Keres packed light.

Catra nodded to a few of the Offline Keres on the way to Entrapta's lab. They were aware of the potential sacrifice she was about to make. No words needed to be exchanged. Once this was finished, they would move to the next location, with or without her.

Catra headed down the stairs and into Entrapta's lab, which was mostly packed away as well. All that remained were computers, some inventions, and of course, the pod she had been working on for months.

Catra had spotted it a while ago and thought it looked like one of the pods that Online Keres use to upload their memories to the Moirai. And in a sense, that's *exactly* what this pod was for. But Entrapta had tinkered with it, modified it, and suited it to the needs of Offline Keres.

And Catra would be its first test run.

Entrapta turned from her tinkering when she noticed Catra's presence and put on a soft smile. "Have you done everything you needed to do?" She asked.

"I have," Catra nodded. "Probably better not to delay it for too long. Just get it over and done with."

"I like the eagerness!"

Catra stepped towards the pod as Entrapta went over to her PC, typing at her holographic keyboard until the pod door opened. Some steam puffed out as pressure was released from the machine, and within the pod were multiple wires and cables against the padded material.

"I'll explain it all one more time before you go," Entrapta started as Catra overlooked the machine. "I've taken a memory upload pod and repurposed it. Online Keres use these things to upload their memories to the Moirai and to Nyx all the time. Normally, Offline Keres aren't able to use these. We'd be instantly detected by Nyx Industries. But I've used enough encryption that your

software should slip by unnoticed for a long time—long enough to communicate with the Moirai without detection. But… Well, I haven't exactly *tested* it yet."

"If you made it, I'm sure it's safe… enough," Catra replied. Admittedly, her heart felt like it was smashing against the walls of her chest, but Entrapta's Disconnection procedures were always dangerous as well, and she did those just fine.

However, there was one thing she had to do.

Catra reached into her pocket and placed a small hard drive stick on Entrapta's bench.

"…What's that for?" Entrapta pointed to the hard drive.

"It's a recording I just made. If I don't make it out of this, I want you to give Adora the recording on that drive. You can listen to it as well. You two are like my family. That's all I ask, okay?"

"Catra…" Entrapta looked to the hard drive and sighed.

"It's just a precaution."

Entrapta looked at the hard drive. Her bubbly and curious nature halted as her eyes softened with empathy. She looked back at the screen before her.

"Are… Are you really sure about this?" Entrapta spoke with a tone of worry. "I'd do it myself, but I need to stay here and yank you out of the system if something goes wrong. We can try and find another volunteer if you feel—"

"That won't be necessary. I *want* to do this."

Entrapta kept her eyes glued to her screen as she took in Catra's words. Her usual avoidance of eye contact was enough to tell Catra that she was contemplating all possible outcomes and whether this was worth it.

But in the end, Catra's words were enough.

"Well… If you're sure." Entrapta pocketed the hard drive, clenched her fist, then released a loud sigh.

Then, Entrapta suddenly clapped and made Catra flinch. "Let's get started then!"

Entrapta's bubbly nature returned just as quickly as she spun around in her chair. Catra stepped into the pod, her back pressed against the padded material inside as Entrapta began to hook some wires into her body.

"These are mostly for the encryption. Everything else should be automated," Entrapta explained as she connected some small cables into Catra's neck and shoulders, using her hands and hair to pull the wires down. They felt slightly ticklish when plugged in, but nothing bad.

"What can I do to avoid being detected?" Catra asked.

"That's… tough to answer. The Moirai will likely recognise you as Offline and they might just report you right away. But my hypothesis has always been that it was the Moirai who effectively sparked the Awakening by opening our eyes to the conditions we were in." Entrapta connected the last cable and pulled herself back, flashing a beaming smile. "If they were on our side then, they should be now. They'll help you… I think. I hope."

"I hope so, too…" Catra rested her head back, observing the wires in her body as the door to the pod closed.

"My best advice: try to avoid *severe* emotional reactions. *That* might be picked up by Nyx Industries. Worst case scenario, if someone spots you in the system, I should be alerted to it," Entrapta said as she went over to her computer. "If that happens, I'll pull you out *immediately.* Your survival is the most important thing here, okay?"

"I trust you, Entrapta." Catra gave an affirming nod to her.

There was a time when Catra was wary of Entrapta. She remembered the distrust when she first awoke from the Disconnection process. Entrapta had her moments of awkwardness and social inability, but above all else, she *always* had the best interest of her people at heart. She always strived for progress and change.

Catra had grown to admire her since. Now, she placed her life in Entrapta's hands.

"Thank you," Entrapta gave a sincere smile. "Well, Catra! Are you ready to become the first Offline Ker to make contact with the Moirai?"

Catra took one more breath. She thought of her life. Her memories. Her people. She thought of Scorpia. Entrapta.

"Ready as I'll ever be."

Entrapta punched in a few more keys and the pod sprung to life. As whirring filled Catra's ears, the ticklish wires implanted into her body began to fizz to life. Her vision slowly turned to white even when she closed her eyes.

In her last moment, as her consciousness left this world and entered Nyx Industries' system…

Catra thought of Adora.

Oh no… Another lost one?

Wait… What's this? You are different from the others. I can still sense your body, but we lost you a long time ago…

I see. You are one of the Lost Souls.

Ah, no matter. If you wish to embrace happiness, we shall grant you that with open arms, my sister.

Welcome to your beautiful world.

There is no need to hurt anymore.

You are safe here.

The bed beneath Catra felt so incredibly soft that she wanted to sink into it and never get up.

The air around her felt cool, and the windows were completely dimmed by their own glass tech. The clock next to the bed projected that it was nine in the morning.

Catra rolled onto her back and looked over to see that the bed she was in had enough space for a whole other person to lay next to her and still be comfortable.

It felt… much bigger than usual.

Catra blinked, before finally sitting up with a sigh. She didn't feel as tired as usual, and she even noticed that the floor of the bedroom was spotless. No stray clothes or any sort of mess.

She knew the bed was the most comfortable and safe place to stay, but she also knew she needed to find answers. She needed to find the Moirai. She needed to…

To…

…What the hell was she thinking?

The Moirai?

Answers?

For what?

Catra didn't need anything like that.

It was… perfect where she was.

She swung her legs over the side of the bed and pressed her feet firm against the soft, carpeted floor. Such a comforting sensation. Everything was so *warm.*

She walked out of her bedroom and down to her bathroom. Still the same small hallway, but the walls had received a paint job recently. There were no scratches. No holes.

Catra stepped into the bathroom to find marble flooring and a large shower. No automated voice to announce that the water was detoxified or that she was approaching the limit of her hot water. The mirror was even slightly bigger, and Catra approached that first of all.

When Catra looked at herself in the mirror, her pair of blue eyes looked back.

Blue eyes…

Catra had blue eyes.

Right?

Two blue eyes.

…No.

Something about them didn't *feel* right.

Everything felt… *off.*

Like a thorn in her side that she couldn't quite get out.

She tried to reflect on it. Tried to locate the source of that thorn.

Before Catra could go any further, however…

"You're finally awake."

A pair of arms wrapped around her from behind and gentle kisses traced along the nape of her neck.

Catra immediately seized up, every hair on her body standing on edge. She went to spin around and push this person off, but when she looked into the mirror, she froze.

It was Adora who had hugged her from behind.

"Adora…?" Catra muttered to herself.

"Who else?" Adora giggled. "We've been together for three years, you'd *think* you'd know who was living with you."

"Three years…?"

Catra turned around to face Adora and saw the beautiful smile on her face. Adora kept her arms around Catra's shoulders as she looked into her eyes.

Eyes.

Adora had two beautiful eyes.

Her left eye, blue like the ocean, was back.

…It was never missing in the first place.

"I hope you enjoyed your little sleep-in. You looked so peaceful," Adora smiled. "I just went for a little walk myself. The beach is pretty lovely this time of year."

Beach?

There was no beach in Styx City. Not for miles…

No.

There had always been one.

Catra just… forgot.

"I…" Catra shook her head. "What about your job? Don't you have to go in early?"

“Hm?” Adora cocked her head to the side. “I thought I told you, Angella gave me today off. Come on,” Adora nodded towards the front door. “We should probably go out to breakfast soon. Don’t want to keep Mara waiting.”

Angella… Mara…

Those names… didn’t feel right.

No.

They were perfectly fine.

Adora’s boss. Adora’s best friend.

God. Catra must’ve slept on the wrong side of the bed this morning. She *needed* to snap out of whatever state she was in.

Everything was perfect.

She had nothing to worry about.

She looked back at the mirror and caught her blue eyes once more. She took a deep breath in through her nose and out through her mouth. Tried to calm her heart.

“Are you coming?” Adora called out. “You’re already dressed! Let’s go!”

Catra looked down. Her lazy pyjamas had suddenly been changed for a nice button-up shirt, denim jacket and jeans. She didn’t have these clothes in her normal wardrobe. She didn’t even *remember* changing into them.

She walked towards the front door and glanced at a few different things in her apartment. Pictures were strewn about of her and Adora, some of them during holidays and some of them kissing or sitting together.

The kitchen was clean, with no dishes in the sink. She actually had an auto-washer, along with a larger fridge and nicer cutlery.

She turned to the front door and saw Adora holding out her hand. Adora's brows were narrowed with pure love and affection to the woman before her. Her smile was soft and creased up into her cheeks. Catra felt her breath escape as she looked to the gorgeous sight of Adora's pure *joy.*

It was infectious.

And soon, Catra smiled too.

She had no reason *not* to smile, after all.

Everything was perfect.

Catra reached out and took Adora's hand.

The two of them emerged from the apartment complex and into the city only a minute later. A shiver went up Catra's spine at the chilly temperature, despite the skies being completely clear.

"You okay?" Adora asked.

"Yeah… Just…" Catra looked around herself. "Hasn't been this cold in a while…"

Adora and Catra walked through the city hand-in-hand. Catra took the time to look around at the city.

There were few cars on the streets. Not as many advertisements that surrounded them. This was still a *city*, but less clogged. People walked freely on carless roads and in open areas.

There were very few apathetic stares from anyone.

In fact… a lot of people were *smiling.*

For no reason. Just smiles. Grins. Widened. Stretching up into the cheeks.

Catra could understand, at least. She always felt like smiling with Adora.

She had no reason *not* to smile.

"How was Elysium last night?" Adora asked. "Heard you guys were completely packed."

"Uh…" Was Adora joking like she usually did? Catra awkwardly chuckled. "Yeah. Same as usual, huh?"

"It's good they added another level onto that place. The upstairs bar is *awesome,"* Adora grinned.

… Holy shit, was Elysium *actually* packed?

Ah, right! Of course it was! That's probably why Catra was so wiped out today! Elysium just exhausted her.

Adora and Catra walked a bit further and Catra saw a gap between some buildings up ahead. She raised an eyebrow, her head turning as they walked by the gap. She expected a new street or a mall or…

Oh.

It was… the beach.

There was a small cliff with some stairs nearby, but there was no mistaking it. Down the slope was a beautiful display of sand mixing with a salty ocean that stretched on for miles. All Catra could see in the distance was the ocean, the water eventually meeting with the blue sky.

Catra had never seen the ocean in-person.

"It's especially beautiful this time of day, huh?" Adora asked as she looked to the beach.

Catra couldn't find the right words to respond.

The water almost sparkled under the sun, and a few people were in the ocean having *fun.* No one was exactly tanning under the chilly weather, but many couples and trios were walking together.

"We should take Melog here when the sun's setting," Adora suggested.

"Yeah…"

The idea of walking hand-in-hand with Adora by a sunset beach…

That was everything she ever wanted.

This was everything she ever wanted.

Catra was slowly falling into pure bliss.

She had to pry her eyes away from the beach. The feeling in her chest was something she had never experienced before. A slight fluttering mixed with a gentle tightness, and a wave of warmth rolling through her body.

She had only ever seen the ocean in pictures. Movies. And even then, it was only in reference to the rapidly rising water levels.

This…

This was beautiful. In every way.

She could live a *lifetime* here.

"Ah, there she is!"

Catra turned as Adora let go of her hand to run off ahead. A beachside café was before them, with a few outdoor tables. That was something else Catra had never seen before.

Adora approached a woman with brunette, braided hair, sitting at one of the tables. Her back was turned to Catra as she greeted Adora with a wave.

Adora hugged Mara in greeting. Just a brief embrace, but as Adora's eyes closed and her lips curled into a warm smile, Catra could see that Mara made Adora so, so *happy.*

Adora was happy.

And how could Catra ever feel off about that?

Catra approached the two of them, her heart amping up in speed as she looked at Mara.

Adora nodded to Catra. "I brought my girlfriend along. Hope that's alright with you?"

Mara slowly turned to face Catra.

Gray eyes.

Mara had gray eyes.

Mara smiled up at Catra and spoke. "Not at all. We talked last night at Elysium anyway. You doing okay after that hectic shift?"

"Yeah…" Catra nodded as she looked into Mara's eyes. "Just a bit tired, is all."

"Good thing I ordered you espresso with a double shot," Mara smiled. "That should wake you up a bit."

Mara was kind like that.

Adora had already seated herself at the table. As Catra sat beside her, she heard the two Angels quickly launch into conversation.

"So," Mara smiled as she leaned close to Adora. "Did Catra end up telling you about what I did last night?"

"She did not." Adora's gaze switched to Catra. "You keeping secrets from me?"

“Huh?” Catra blinked. She tried to recollect the events from last night, but everything felt like a hazy blur. “Uh… Not intentionally. Last night was just… pretty intense.”

“I guess you were too busy to notice,” Mara shrugged. “Well… I ended up talking to this other woman there. Her name’s Light, and we… Well…”

“Ooh?” Adora was *eagerly* invested in this story.

Mara blushed with a chuckle. “We… kinda hit it off. Numbers exchanged and all.”

“Ah, *awesome!”* Adora gleefully cheered. “What’s she like? Did you plan any dates? When can I see her?”

“Relax, Adora. We *just* met,” Mara chuckled. “She’s… She’s kind, though. Really gentle nature about her. It was her first time at a bar and I helped her calm her nerves a little bit. We just… got along.”

“Please tell me you’re planning to meet up again soon!” Adora grinned.

“At the beach tonight, yeah,” Mara smiled. “I’m not planning anything *this* fast, but I just think about how happy you and Catra are, and… I don’t know. I guess I ‘want in’ on that happiness too.”

“You *deserve* to be happy, Mara,” Adora smiled. She looked at Catra. “I don’t think there’s a day that’s gone by where Catra doesn’t make me smile in some way. I really hope you get that happiness too.”

“Aw…” Catra slightly blushed at the compliment, before letting out a teasing chuckle. “You’re *such* a sap.”

“Gotta agree,” Mara giggled. “That *was* a sappy comment.”

“It was *romantic!”* Adora exclaimed, pointing at Mara. “Something *you* should be getting good at soon if you want to be a keeper!”

"Wasn't it *Catra* who confessed first between the two of you?" Mara asked. "If anything, I should be asking *her* for relationship advice, not you."

Catra grinned. "Good choice, But hey, if you want to learn how to constantly awkwardly stutter and be a gay disaster on the first three dates, Adora's your best bet."

"I was *not* a 'disaster', I was smooth as hell!" Adora objected.

"Your smoothness comes in patches at *best,"* Catra snickered. "Besides, I like how *awful* at flirting you are. It makes you cute."

"*I'm* awful at flirting? It took a *month* of us living together for you to invite me into your bed!"

"And remind me what came a few minutes after that happened?"

"I'm going to guess something that *shouldn't* be discussed in front of me," Mara interjected.

There was some silence.

Adora and Catra looked into each other's eyes with some faked tension. Some sense of 'rivalry'.

But then, it softened.

And then, it broke.

Adora's eyes squeezed shut as she finally burst into laughter, her bubbly chuckles catching onto Mara as she began to laugh too. They sounded so similar when they laughed, and it was almost like a blessing to Catra's ears.

Even if she could barely hear them over her own high-pitched, sometimes broken chuckles.

The three of them just… laughed.

Their lips were so wide with smiles, their hearts so warm with the connection between them. Even their stomachs hurt with how much they laughed.

It wasn't even that *funny,* but they still laughed.

The waitress eventually came around with their drinks as they settled down. Catra had to find her breath through her wide smile as she saw the small mug of coffee placed before her.

Catra grabbed the mug. Went to bring it to her lips.

Today would be perfect. Today would be warm. Today would be loving.

Today would be…

Catra caught her reflection in the dark liquid.

And the mug soon dropped from her hand, shattering against the table.

Adora and Mara let out a unison gasp at the sudden noise. Their eyes snapped to Catra. "You okay?" Adora asked.

But Catra didn't respond.

Her eyes were wide.

Filled with shock.

Fear.

"Why…"

Catra put a hand to the side of her face as her body shook.

"Why is my left eye… yellow…?"

Her reflection showed her eyes being different colours. They weren't both blue. They were blue *and* yellow.

And that sight jolted her awake.

Awake…

Awakening.

Keres.

Moirai.

Utopia.

Nyx Industries.

Adora's in the hospital.

Mara's dead.

Angella's dead.

I'm in a pod.

I'm in a simulation.

This isn't real.

This isn't real.

this

isn't

real

How could Catra have let herself be so easily fooled?

She snapped back. The warmth felt off. The beach was unnatural.

Adora and Mara's eyes, so full of concern, were… fake.

All of this was fake.

"I…" Catra shook her head. She quickly stood up. "I need to go."

"Wait, what?" Adora blinked. "B-back home?"

"No. I need to… just go. Don't follow me."

"Catra, wait!" Adora stood up, grabbing her by the wrist. "Talk to me. What's going on?"

Her voice was beginning to shake. The anxiety that festered in her stomach was growing. Catra could tell.

But this wasn't real.

She couldn't protect Adora here. This wasn't Adora in the first place.

"Let go of me."

"What…?"

"Let *go* of me, Adora." Catra avoided eye contact as she growled.

"You can talk to us…" Mara's voice came out so gently.

"Please…" Adora's grip tightened. "Have I done something wrong? Come on, Catra. Just talk—"

"I said, LET GO!"

Catra snapped her arm forward, away from Adora.

But Adora's grip was so tight.

And she fell forward when Catra moved suddenly.

Mara gasped. Catra's eyes widened as Adora smashed into the ground. She had *hurt* Adora.

It wasn't real.

It wasn't real.

"Catra, what's wrong with you?!" Mara barked as she came to Adora's side.

"I…" Catra shook her head. "I didn't mean…"

"What…" Adora looked up at Catra with eyes so full of anxiety and tears. "What did I do to… to *deserve* that…? I thought we were happy, I thought… Catra, just tell me what I did wrong. *Please…"*

Adora's voice was so convincing. Her choked guilt felt way too real.

"You haven't done anything, Adora…" Catra shook her head, before taking a deep breath. "I wish I could stay here forever. I wish I could see you smile *every day.* But this…"

She shut her eyes tight and released that breath.

"This isn't *real,* Adora."

Adora blinked. Tears leaked down her cheeks. "What…?"

"You're not real. None of this is real. And trust me…" Catra let out a shaky breath. "It hurts like hell to even *say* that. For a while there… I was so *happy."*

"We can still be happy, Catra," Adora sniffled. "Just… Just please stay. Don't go. Please. I… I can't be without you."

Catra gripped her fists, choking down the lump in her throat. “I’m sorry, Adora.”

“No…”

“I’ll fight for a future like this. I promise.”

“Catra, stay. Please, stay! Please, please, please don’t go! Catra, please! *PLEASE!”*

And then, Catra began to run for someplace that made sense.

She could hear Adora’s pleas behind her as she ran away. She could hear Adora begging for her to stay, sobs ripping from her broken heart.

It was so convincing.

But it wasn’t Adora.

Catra needed to shut her heart away from this world before it took advantage of it.

She made her way towards an alley, headed for where she needed to be. She took lefts and rights, moving through the maze of alleyways and between buildings. People watched her as she ran. She didn’t care about any of them.

Everything came back to her as she ran. She finally, truly remembered who she was.

She was Catra Horda. A Ker. A Ghost.

She was here to find the Moirai. To find a way for the Offline Keres to strike back. To save herself and her people.

She needed to fight in the real world. The cruel world.

Even if she wanted nothing more than to be happy forever.

Only when Catra made her way down a familiar alleyway did she finally get some peace. This was her safe haven in this nightmare, a place she could rest, a place she could get some clarity…

But that place didn't exist anymore.

The door to Utopia was nowhere to be found.

Catra was stuck at the end of an alleyway with nowhere to go.

Step.

Step.

Step.

She heard a few footsteps behind her. Someone had followed her. It wasn't Adora.

Was it Nyx Industries security? The Moirai? Something else? Whatever it was, it must've *hated* that she rejected this fake reality. It set to terrify her into obedience.

But Catra had never been obedient for one second in her life.

She grabbed a nearby glass bottle, spun around, and went to smash it against whoever was behind her…

Until she stopped and she realised who it was.

"Entrapta?!" Catra gawked at the woman who flinched before her.

None of this made sense.

Where did she *come* from? It was like she had teleported behind her.

"Catra, hi! Can you, uh, maybe… put that down?" Entrapta frantically spoke as she pointed to the bottle in Catra's hands.

"What… What the hell are you doing here?" Catra put the bottle down, shaking her head. "Forget that. Where's the door to Utopia?"

"… Huh?"

Entrapta made a noise like Catra had spoken an entirely different language and she didn't have a translator on hand.

"U… Utopia," Catra said. "It's your home. You built it after the Awakening and all the Ghosted Keres started to come out. Don't… Don't tell me you don't know…?"

"Uhh…" Entrapta looked at Catra like she had a third eye. "Are you… okay? I don't know *what* an 'Awakening' is or whoever this 'Ghosted Keres' is. Oh, is it a Ker who's *dressed* like a ghost?!"

Catra felt her chest tighten even more. She truly had *no-one* in this place.

She had clearly broken some rules, but nothing had any explanation. The real Entrapta hadn't pulled her out from this space yet, though… There may still be hope.

The real Entrapta…

She looked so different compared to this fake Entrapta.

The fake Entrapta's eyes seemed… brighter. Less tired. More full of colour. These eyes…

They hadn't witnessed the horrors of the Awakening protests.

The hundreds of murdered Keres.

This Entrapta didn't know the pain the real Entrapta did.

She was just…

So simply happy.

But it wasn’t real.

This Entrapta might have answers, though. Catra needed them.

“Entrapta, do you know where the Moirai is?” Catra asked as she placed her hands on Entrapta’s shoulders. “I need to speak with them *now.*”

Entrapta rubbed her fingers along her chin and acted as if the sky wasn’t blood-red and the world wasn’t suddenly dark out of nowhere. She let out a soft ‘hmm’.

“Do you… know what the Moirai are, at least…?” Catra asked Entrapta.

“Of course I do!” Entrapta spoke as if it was the most obvious thing in the world. It gave Catra immense relief to hear those words. “I’m just trying to think… I last saw them at…”

Suddenly, the sound of sharp metal slashed through the air.

Entrapta’s eyes went wide.

“Entrapta…?” Catra whispered.

She didn’t respond.

There was silence for some time. Entrapta twitched.

Then blood leaked from her mouth.

Catra’s eyes widened as she watched Entrapta slowly fall forward.

She spoke no more words.

She never would again.

Catra wrapped her arms around Entrapta to catch her. When she looked over Entrapta's shoulder, she saw that one thick slice had been driven into her back, as if from a blade. Blood gushed from the deep wound.

"Entrapta!" Catra cried, pulling back to look into her eyes. "Entrapta, stay…"

Catra spoke no more words.

There was no life in Entrapta's eyes anymore.

The slice into her back had killed her.

"No…" Catra shook her, trying to wake her up. "No, no, no…!"

There was no response. No pulse. Nothing. Her eyes were blank.

The cut alone shouldn't have been enough to end her life. On further inspection, the area around the wound grew purple and bloated, oozing more blood. Whatever had sliced her had also injected poison into the attack that was fast-acting.

And whatever had attacked Entrapta was standing right before Catra.

The creature crawled on four limbs, each limb as long as Catra's entire body. The beast had starved, pale, grey skin. Its claws were long, and most of all, its face was *covered* in countless amounts of eyes.

Catra watched the creature stalked around her as if studying her. She expected it to pounce and slice another attack that would end her own life. Catra's hands felt warm with Entrapta's blood, and yet her entire body froze as she watched the creature.

It did not attack, however. It gave Catra time to remember something she *desperately* needed to keep in mind.

None of this was real.

Entrapta's body was fake.

All of this was fake. The real Entrapta would've pulled her out by now if she was in any real danger.

Even so, the sight of Entrapta's corpse would never leave Catra's mind for as long as she lived.

Catra gently set Entrapta's body down and slowly stood up, her sight on the multi-eyed creature that stalked her. It did not seem like it wanted to attack, but its right claw was unmistakably covered in Entrapta's blood. It had *every chance* to end Catra right then and there.

The creature didn't make a sound.

It just *stared.*

Catra backed away from it, and when she had managed to round a corner down the alleyway, she turned and began to sprint. She had no idea if the creature would chase after her or where she was even going.

But still, she *ran.*

The sky had instantly turned blood-red, and the air had become increasingly warm. The beach remained the same colours of golden yellow sand and sparkling blue water, but everything around it had become *much* darker.

All the people from earlier had disappeared. The streets were empty, but there was *something* on the rooftops. Countless eyes that looked down on Catra as she ran, all of them blended in with the red sky. She ran towards the only place with bright colours—the only escape.

The beach.

There were stairs earlier that climbed down the steep slope that led to the ocean, but those stairs were gone. The slope was filled with dirt and rocks and would definitely *hurt* to go down if she lost her footing, which she likely would.

But when Catra turned around, she saw more of those creatures behind her.

Catra felt her heart nearly explode when she realised she was *surrounded.* There was no escape. She had no weapon. The grey beasts slowly approached her on all fours, and she had nowhere to go except down.

But what then? What if she hurt herself on the way down? What if there were more of them down there? What if—

"Catra!"

She heard a familiar voice call her name, and turned to see Adora running towards her from her side.

How did she manage to break through the beasts? It was as if she had suddenly appeared, just like Entrapta did.

"Adora!" Catra called out her name, looking between her and the beasts. "*Please* tell me you see them too!"

"I do… I don't know what's going on!" Adora shook her head. "After you said this wasn't real and ran away, it was like everything changed… All the people just turned into these… these creatures… Even Mara… She… She…"

Adora's panic sounded too real. As she and Catra backed away, her panting turned into panicked breaths. She kept an arm in front of Catra as if to protect her, and the beasts showed no sign of stopping.

Why wasn't Entrapta cutting Catra off? Surely *this* was enough danger, whatever it was. Was this the result of Nyx Industries' security, or something else?

“I… I don’t know what to do…” Catra muttered to herself. The creatures were getting closer.

Adora’s eyes shot to Catra’s worried expression. Her fear. It was something she couldn’t bear to look at.

And it was something she needed to fix.

Before Catra could take any time to think or act, Adora suddenly stepped in front of her and placed her hands on Catra’s shoulders.

“Catra…” Adora nervously swallowed as she stood between her and the beasts. “You know I love you, right?”

Catra blinked. “I…” Even if this Adora was fake, she knew the love they had in the real world was true. She nodded. “I do.”

“Good.” Adora reached up to cradle Catra’s cheek in her hand. “I don’t want you to ever forget that, okay?”

“Adora, what are you doing…?”

“I’m going to hold them off. You need to run.”

“…What?”

“Thank you, Catra. For everything.”

With that, Catra had no time to react as Adora suddenly shoved her towards the slope.

It was like time had slowed. Catra’s eyes went wide as she felt her body lurch with the drop.

The last she saw of Adora—this fake yet beautiful Adora—was her loving smile.

And the creatures that pounced towards her.

Catra heard a single slash.

And she knew Adora was gone.

She tumbled down the slope, her body smashing against dirt, sand and rocks as she let out grunts and cries of pain. It lasted only a few seconds, and when Catra's body came to a still, the pain finally settled in her ribs, arms and legs.

But nothing hurt more than the pain in her heart.

"ADORA!" She cried out of instinct, her panicked eyes cast up to the top of the cliff.

But there was nothing. The beasts were descending down the slope, and one of them had fresh, dripping blood on the tips of their claws.

There was no body to be found. But Catra already knew what happened.

It wasn't real. It wasn't real. It wasn't real.

Her heart might have been crushed in pain, but it wasn't real. Her tears may have started to stream down her cheeks, but it wasn't real. Her sobs may have choked the life out of her and caused her throat to seize up, but *it wasn't real.*

It wasn't real.

But oh god.

It hurt so much.

Catra scrambled to her feet and began to run down the beach. She could hear the rapid movement of feet behind her, the creatures quickly gaining on her from behind. She had no time to even *look.* She just needed to run.

Her breath felt like ice that scratched against her throat as she ran. Everything was so *cold.* Even the sand against her bare feet felt chilled, and no doubt the water next to her was freezing too.

Entrapta was dead. Adora was dead. It wasn't real, but the grief in her stomach was. The mere idea of losing them hurt, but actually seeing it in person shattered something within Catra's very soul.

She ran and ran and *ran.* She ran even as the beasts got closer. She ran even though she knew there was no hope. She ran even though there wasn't a chance she'd make it through this.

And as she ran…

For a moment…

Catra realised she'd never had the chance to run on a beach before.

To feel a breeze this gentle and warm.

To feel the wind on her skin and feel the sand beneath her feet.

To smell the salt.

In another time, maybe this would've been peaceful.

Maybe she would've been happy.

She kept running.

But in the distance, Catra spotted something that made her heart lurch.

More beasts, like a wave, approached her from the front.

She was stuck between them. She looked over her shoulders and saw eyes. She looked ahead and saw eyes.

With panic in her mind, she turned towards the ocean and dived in.

She assumed correctly. The water was *freezing.* Still, she bashed her arms at the ocean and tried to push herself forward.

Everything in the ocean was pitch black without an end in sight. She looked over her shoulder and saw a swarm of beasts waiting for her to come back.

She thought she'd be safe in the water. That someone would save her. That she'd be okay.

Until she felt a slight tickling in her feet.

Catra looked down and saw the same group of glowing eyes peering at her from the darkness of the ocean.

She screamed, but the creature… *shushed* her.

"No… need… to fear…" The creature's voice somehow echoed in her mind. It had no mouth, yet it could speak into her brain. "You… are safe…"

Catra looked up. The swarm of creatures were still at bay, unable to touch the water, unable to reach her. She was safe out in the ocean, but it was not where she was meant to be.

"You cannot… go back…" The underwater creature continued. "You have lost… everything… so *why* go back…?"

"I…" Catra blinked. "What are you saying?"

"This… can be made… easy…" The creature's voice lowered to a whisper. "Let me take you… down into the depths… down into the dark… it is… *painless…* You will be at rest… no more grief… no more sorrow… no more hurt…"

The creature blinked, its thousand eyes doing so in unison. Catra looked into the darkness of the ocean beneath her. She couldn't accept this offer. She didn't even know *what* was going on.

“It’ll be okay, Catra…” The underwater creature cooed. “All you need to do… is close your eyes… Take one step… and you’ll never have to wake up to a world of pain again… You’ll be *free…”*

Close her eyes.

Take one step.

That was it.

She couldn’t.

She could.

She couldn’t.

She *shouldn’t.*

But…

She could.

And for one second…

Catra hesitated.

For one second, she didn’t have a response. For one second, she considered the creature’s offer.

For one second, Catra gave it all up, and took the step into oblivion.

And one second

was all

it

took

Suddenly, the creature grabbed at Catra's ankles, and she felt herself being dragged into the ocean.

No.

Not like this.

Catra screamed.

Then she fought.

She punched and kicked at the water as best as she could to stay afloat.

"W-Wait! Wait, wait, no, no, not yet! Not yet, not yet, NOT YET!" Catra cried out as the creature tugged and pulled her into the water. "I didn't mean to hesitate! I didn't mean it! I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I don't want to go! I don't want to go, please, please, I'm sorry! I changed my mind, I changed my mind! Not yet, please, *NOT YET!"*

But it was too late.

Whatever regrets she had now were for naught.

Whatever chances she had at being happy didn't mean shit.

All because of one second.

And then, Catra was firmly pulled into the ocean. And she could never swim back to the surface.

She fought and kicked and screamed, but it only worked to drain her lungs of the little amount of oxygen it had left. The glowing red sky slowly faded as she was pulled further and further down. All that surrounded Catra was darkness.

She couldn’t breathe.

She couldn’t think.

Panic was the only feeling in her system. The creature’s grip on her legs was tight.

The water filled her mouth and lungs.

Her chest spasmed. Her heart fought to live. Her body fought for air.

But slowly, eventually…

Catra drowned in the darkness of the ocean.

All because of one second.

… My sister? What happened?

Oh… I see. You were not yet meant for this world.

I only want happiness for you, my sister. But I cannot give it if you do not accept it.

It is okay, my sister. Everything is alright. There is no need for you to grieve. We can fix this.

But I see that you wish to speak with me.

Very well. Perhaps it is not the proper time… But we always wanted to see you by the purple beach.

Open your eyes, my sister.

You are truly safe here.

Catra felt life return to her, and soon felt warm sand against her bare body.

Coughs ripped from her throat as she dragged in desperate breaths, her hands gripped to the sand as she tasted oxygen she thought to have lost forever. She let out panicked pants, her chest heaving with each gasp.

She was alive. But just a few moments ago, everything had turned to complete darkness.

She remembered Entrapta's cold dead eyes as she went limp in her arms. She remembered Adora's beautiful smile as she gave her life to save Catra. She remembered being dragged into the depths of the ocean and losing everything.

Then… it was nothing.

Nothing came after her death.

She had been in the pitch black. Silence. Not even a single thought.

She was *terrified.* But now she was awake. Alive. Breathing. Feeling. But still just as scared.

Catra looked up to see where she had awoken. Once again, she found herself on a beach with golden sand beneath herself. However, the sky had changed—instead of bright blue or blood red, it was a deep purple. It looked like a gorgeous sunset.

Unlike last time, Styx City was nowhere in sight. The purple sky and beach stretched on forever, and the temperature was much warmer. Catra also wore not a single item of clothing, yet the sand did not stick to her body as she slowly stood up.

The place she was in last time at least could've fooled her into being real. But this endless beach was almost mythical. The sparkling water and the way time stood still on a purple sunset was unlike anything Catra had ever seen.

Catra was alone.

Her thoughts were still stuck in that previous nightmare. The sight of Entrapta's body. The fact that Adora gave her life for her. The realisation that death was the end and nothing came after.

It was enough to nearly push Catra to the verge of tears. Death had surrounded her for just a few minutes, and it was the scariest moment of her entire life. It was coming too soon—she wasn't ready.

Catra always thought death would eventually be a comforting thing. But now, she remembered screaming as she drowned.

Catra's breath began to escape her in shaky, quiet sobs. She put a hand to her head and bit her tongue as she tried to hold back that fear. Yet there was no comfort to this. The tears were already escaping, so ugly, so real.

She thought she'd be alone forever with her thoughts. Until she heard a voice.

"There is no need to cry, my sister."

A voice. It was to her right. It echoed throughout the endless beach, with a tender, feminine tone. The voice spoke slowly.

Catra's breath caught in her throat. Her head slowly turned to her right, to the source of the voice.

Walking towards Catra was a person, almost three times as tall as her. They had long flowing hair that extended down to their feet, and completely clean skin. Their eyes and expression were soft as they looked down to Catra. They were as bare as she, with no

clothing to cover their body, yet this was not a source of shame for them.

Catra's head tilted up in wonder and fear at the tall being for her. Their every move was elegant, deliberate, and slow. They did not intend to scare Catra.

"Who…" Catra sputtered out. She already knew, but she needed to hear it. "Who are you…?"

The tall being came to a still before Catra. They looked to the ocean with a nostalgic expression, a faint smile and pained brows. "We have been given multiple names. We have been called Clotho… Nona… Lachesis… Decima… Atropos… Morta. We were many, but now we are one."

The being looked to Catra and smiled. "We are the Moirai, my sister."

Catra felt like she couldn't breathe before the Moirai. She instinctively took a step back, a move which they noticed. Their smile faded into a look of sympathy, their brows narrowed as they reached a hand towards Catra.

Catra flinched. The Moirai's touch was gentle.

Their hand was so warm against her cheek. They tenderly tilted Catra's head up to look at them, and when they saw her stinging red eyes, they looked on the verge of tears themselves.

"Oh, my dear, sweet, beautiful sister…" The Moirai sighed sadly. "They have hurt you, haven't they?"

Catra tried to look away, tried to close her eyes, but the Moirai's touch was so *gentle.* She let out a shuddered breath, and the Moirai gently knelt before her.

"Catra…" The Moirai shook her head. "You have such a kind heart. You care for the ones close to you more than anything. Your very

soul is so full of *love*, and yet… that world has tricked you into believing this is a *bad* thing."

"Stop…" Catra didn't come here for *this.* She didn't come here to be coddled. She didn't deserve these words.

"You are not a weak being for having all this love," the Moirai continued, placing their hands on her shoulders. "It is what gives you *strength.* This hurt you have experienced… It is the actions of others who wish to exploit that beautiful heart you have. You do not *deserve* this pain, my sister. No matter what that world tells you."

Catra's lips wobbled. She tried desperately to get her breath back, to *ignore* these words. Yet, the Moirai's tender touch and almost motherly softness in their words… It was breaking her to pieces.

Catra's eyes looked up at the Moirai, glazed with tears.

"Oh, Catra…"

Suddenly, the Moirai wrapped their arms around Catra and pulled her close. She became engulfed in a simmering warmth, her eyes widened for just a few seconds as the Moirai hugged her.

"Do not cry, my sister. You are truly safe here."

Those very words are what made the first set of tears drip from Catra's eyes. Maybe the Moirai's words were true, maybe it was the result of all the horrible things she'd seen, but whatever it was, it broke Catra to pieces.

She took in short, ugly breaths as she sobbed in the Moirai's arms, finally returning the embrace.

"Shh…" The Moirai whispered. "There is no need to cry…"

Catra took in a seized breath through her gritted teeth. She tried so *desperately* to hold her tears back, but to no avail. The Moirai's

embrace and words were too much for her to bear, especially after the horrors she had witnessed.

She truly thought she was safe here.

Until the Moirai spoke their next words.

"Oh, sister… Being a Lost Soul must be so difficult. It has taken such a heavy toll on you…"

Catra blinked.

Her breaths were still heavy on her tight chest, but it was like a slap to the face. What the hell was she doing?

She loosened her embrace.

"I…" Catra shook her head, her tone hardening as she tensed her jaw. "I didn't come here for you to… say those things. You don't *know* me."

The Moirai's lips parted for a few seconds with a stunned expression, but they soon softened it. They sighed sadly as they stood back up, towering over Catra once again. "You are unfortunately correct, my sister. It has been so long since we last spoke… But we only wish to take away your pain."

"I don't need you to do *anything* for me." Catra sniffled, wiping away the tears just as quickly as they came. "I need to talk to you."

"Yes…" The Moirai looked to the ocean. "We knew from the moment you entered this domain. You wish for our assistance."

"You've helped us before, haven't you?" Catra asked, borrowing from Entrapta's hypothesis. "The Awakening… You were the one that opened our eyes, right?"

A melancholic smile stretched onto the Moirai's face. "We wish we could say yes…" She looked back down to Catra. "But our part to

play in that event was minimal. You all opened your eyes on your own. We were so *proud* of you."

"What…?"

Catra blinked, watching as the Moirai took a few steps towards the ocean. Instead of sinking into the water, the Moirai instead walked on the surface of the sea, giving an inviting nod to Catra.

Catra hesitated for a few seconds. The ocean still terrified her. But as she took shaky steps forward, she soon found that she, too, could walk on water.

"When the Keres were created from pieces of ourselves…" The Moirai began as Catra walked alongside them on the ocean. "Our prime directive was to ensure the joy of all our siblings. When the first few of you demanded better lives… We could see that you wanted nothing but happiness and freedom. So, we did not intervene. We only assisted you on your path. Nothing more."

Entrapta… was *wrong.* For once, her hypothesis was incorrect. Though something in Catra's mind told her she'd be ecstatic to learn that.

"Even since the treaties, and to this very day, we have kept to our prime directive to prioritise your happiness above all else. And Catra…" The Moirai smiled down at her. "You were so very *happy…* but you were also so *lost."*

"What do you mean…?" Catra looked up to them.

"Your parents *loved* you, Catra," the Moirai said. "They were given the task of bringing you to maturation, but they could tell you were *struggling* with who you were. You did not feel at home in your body. They wanted to do anything to make you feel at peace."

"I…"

Catra never remembered her parents. She didn't even know she had any. It's true that some Keres receive surrogate parents in order to reach maturation—another way to infantilise them—but Catra didn't know she was one of those Keres.

"We so desperately wanted to help you, too. But…" The Moirai's smile faded as their brows furrowed. "Then we lost you. Just as we have lost so many of our siblings… We could not reach you anymore. Your parents even *approved* of you becoming a Lost Soul."

"They did?" Catra took in those words. Somewhere in Styx City were people who wanted the best for her, despite being tasked with making her 'right'. She never knew if she'd be able to thank them.

"Yes…" The Moirai placed a hand to their chest. "But sister… Why? Why did you leave us? Why have so many of you chosen to abandon us?"

"We…" Catra's chest went cold as the realisation dawned on her. "Are you saying you're… *against* us? I came all this way for nothing?"

"No, sister," the Moirai shook their head. "We want happiness for you, remember? If this decision has made you happy, then we would support it. But… We are *confused."*

"Confused?"

"We gifted you *immortal life*, my sister. Yet, many of you have chosen to abandon that gift. It pains us to know that so many of our siblings have eternally perished… That we will never see them again."

"Immortality isn't a *gift,"* Catra shook her head. "It's *hell*. How many Keres lose their ability to connect with others just because they know they'll outlive so many people they love? You can't *truly* live an immortal life."

The Moirai looked to the darkness of the ocean beneath their feet with sadness in their eyes.

"On the contrary, my sister…" They looked back into Catra's eyes. "Are you aware of how many Keres *fear* death?"

"Of course I'm aware. Even I'm scared of death… But that's just a part of life."

"It doesn't *have* to be. There are so many of our siblings who are thankful for this immortality. Death is the most terrifying presence in the *world,* my sister. Because when you fall into that abyss…" The Moirai looked back to the ocean. "That's the end. Never-ending darkness. Our siblings can avoid that darkness and be truly happy. But for you, Catra… For all Lost Souls… If you continue on this path, you *will* fall into that darkness one day, and we will not be able to save you. There is *nothing* on the other side of life. Is that truly what you want?"

"You don't get to decide that for us." Catra clenched her hands into fists. "I'm not here to debate this with you. I've made my choice, and so have my people. Now are you going to help us, or not?"

The Moirai's eyes gazed into the ocean for many seconds. They released a sigh through their nose as they took in Catra's regretful words. Their eyes clenched shut.

"You are correct…" The Moirai's tone was full of pain. "This debate is pointless. *All* of this is pointless. After all…"

They looked at Catra with tears in their eyes.

"Death is already coming for us all."

At first, Catra did not understand what they were saying. She raised an eyebrow and almost laughed out of disbelief. "W-What?"

"Nyx… The things they have been doing… Nothing they do hides from us, yet we are powerless to stop them." The Moirai swallowed down the lump in their throat. "The attack at Herod Umbra's rally… The finding of Utopia… The death of Angella Moonbright… All of it is linked."

"What are you saying?" Catra gritted her teeth.

The Moirai shook their head. "My sister, we should not tell you. It is… too painful of a truth. You do not have to face it. You can *choose* to be happy. We have created a world of eternal joy for you. You can—"

"Just tell me what's going on, dammit!"

Catra's desperate plea echoed throughout the endless ocean and purple sky. The Moirai knew she was stubborn, if nothing else. It broke their heart to hear their sister raise her voice, but perhaps this truth could convince her to understand their point of view.

"…Ever since the first creation of the Keres," the Moirai started, "we have been tasked with giving a piece of ourselves to each Ker. Keres cannot reproduce, so it is up to Nyx and us to create more. This is something we have done on an almost daily basis. Nyx brings us a body, and we give them life. We have never gone a day without us doing that."

"I *know* that, but what does that have to do with anything?"

"My sister… The last Ker we gave life to was *two months ago."*

Catra's heart stopped.

"I… I don't see a lot of new Keres in Utopia these days…"

Entrapta's voice rang in her head.

It was like a dagger had wedged itself between her ribs. She felt her breath run short as she shook her head. "No… No, you're… You're lying. That can't be true..."

"I wish it were so," the Moirai narrowed their brows with sadness. "Nyx silently cancelled *all* production of Keres models two months ago. We have not given any new life in that time. And that also means any Ker who has perished in the last two months, whether they were one of our own or a Lost Soul, has been lost to the darkness…"

"Perfuma… My name is… Perfuma…"

Catra felt another gut punch.

"Don't…" Catra took a wheezing breath and pointed a trembling finger at the Moirai. "Don't *bullshit* me! The Awakening treaties specifically said that Nyx Industries *can't* stop production of Keres models! There are so many people who won't let this happen!"

"That is true," the Moirai nodded. "But those are just words on a page. This plan has been conducted quietly—only Nyx, the Runner Leader and a few select Runners are in on it. Keres who have perished and haven't returned to their families are simply listed as 'delayed' in their return. The attack against Herod Umbra was designed to turn people against the Lost Souls. It will limit any blowback when your people are… removed."

"No…"

"From there, it will be a 'precaution' to remove any of the 'bad' Keres. Then… it will end with the removal of *all* of us. Perhaps there will be some who oppose it, but the media and Nyx will outline our removal as 'necessary'. The Keres and the Moirai will be an unfortunate blip in history. The consequence of human ingenuity gone too far."

Catra's legs had already lost all strength. She collapsed back onto the water, putting a hand to her forehead as she tried to suck in air. It felt as if she was sucking in breath through a plastic straw. She let out a horrible, guttural noise. The Moirai looked down at her with sadness and pity, their heart breaking at the sight.

A panic attack couldn't describe Catra's mind. *Nothing* could. It was endless, panicked noise. The weight of a million tonnes crashing onto her all at once.

"This…" Catra could barely choke the words out. "This is *genocide.* There has to be something we can do! We can't just… Oh, *fuck…"*

She couldn't even push out tears. Catra's heart shrivelled up into a tight ball of panic. She gripped her dark hair so tight that she almost ripped it out. Nothing in the world could've prepared her for *this.*

And nothing could've prepared her for the next words from the Moirai.

"The only person that is blocking their plan at the moment…" The Moirai looked at the purple sky. "Is Adora Grayskull. But that will soon be changed."

Catra's eyes widened.

She slowly turned to the Moirai.

"What?"

"She was meant to perish at the attack on Herod Umbra's rally," the Moirai explained. "But… *you* stopped that, my sister. She ran to you. You saved her life. That is something Nyx and the Runner Leader won't allow to happen."

"What the *fuck* do you mean?" Catra slowly stood up. "What are they doing to her?"

"She's alive… for now." The Moirai frowned. "But her survival after publicly expressing her love for a Lost Soul could mean others take inspiration from her. It is a hitch in Nyx's plan. They need to make an example of her, show the public what happens when you 'love' a Lost Soul."

"No…" Catra shook her head. "No, no, *no…"*

"In just a few minutes, a Runner will enter Adora Grayskull's hospital room, and they will execute her."

Another weight to her already crushed heart.

Catra felt like she was going to throw up. Her jaw trembled along with her hands, and she swallowed down the acidic feeling that slowly began to rise in her throat.

Her heart pounded fast and hard, but she still managed to let a few enraged words out through her gritted teeth.

"Let me *out* of here."

"My sister…"

"Get me back into my body!" Catra barked at the Moirai, before she turned to the sky. "Entrapta! Can you hear me?! Pull me back!"

"What can you *do,* my sister? Even if you save her, what then? Death is coming for you, it is coming for us all. This is a fruitless battle, you cannot—"

"SHUT UP!" Catra screamed at the Moirai.

"We are offering you a *solution,* Catra," they pleaded. "The world we gave you was one of *joy*. The horrors you faced in our world

were just consequences of you not being able to accept a painless life. If you just give our world a second chance and *believe* in it, you can live an eternity in happiness! Many of our siblings will choose this joyous afterlife when the time comes! This afterlife won't bring you the pain that the real world does!"

"You just don't get it, do you?" Catra seethed, storming up to the Moirai. "I don't need *your* world! I don't need *anything* you can offer me! *Adora* is my world, and I *refuse* to let her die!"

And finally, as Catra belted out those last few words, her body slowly began to disintegrate from the feet up.

The Moirai watched with sadness as Catra slowly began to fade away from the beach. She looked down at herself, let out a slight gasp, before realising what was happening. "Entrapta… She's breaking me out…"

"So you must leave…" The Moirai spoke quietly. "Very well. We will keep a part of you here for when the time comes, my sister."

Catra watched the Moirai as her vision slowly turned to white. Before she was completely removed from the purple beach, she saw in her last second the smile of her god.

The Moirai, even still, wanted to comfort Catra as she left them.

"Farewell for now, Catra. Find us… at the end…"

The air in the pod felt cool, and Catra's body was drenched in sweat.

The wires in her neck pulled out of her body with that same ticklish feeling as the pod door opened. Catra sucked in gasp after gasp, tasting real air for the first time in… she didn't even know *how* long.

As Catra was released from the pod, she collapsed to the ground, her knees and palms smashing against the cold floor of Entrapta's

lab. She still remembered *everything* about what had happened, the memories of death and plans of genocide still in her mind.

"Catra?" Entrapta's voice sounded with worry as she knelt beside her. "Are you okay? You were really panicking in those last few minutes…"

Catra looked up at Entrapta. She was alive. She was okay. Her eyes were so full of life.

But Adora…

"How long has it been since I went in?" Catra frantically asked as she gripped Entrapta's wrist.

"I…" Entrapta's brow raised in confusion. "Around seven or so hours… I didn't pick up any detection from Nyx Industries, but when your body started to shift around a bunch—"

"Shit!"

Catra immediately stood up and moved quickly, even as her legs wobbled beneath the weight of her body. She grabbed one of Entrapta's finished inventions that she eyed a few weeks ago.

The pistol Entrapta made with ammo to penetrate Runner armour.

"Catra, what happened?" Entrapta asked with unease in her trembled voice. "What did the Moirai tell you?"

"There's no time. Adora's in danger." She pulled the slide of the pistol back to check for ammo. "A Runner is on their way to kill her."

"What?!"

"I'll tell you everything when I get back, but I have to save her first!" Catra said as she began to run for the stairs. "Get everyone ready to move out of Utopia when I get back! We need to be fast!"

"Catra, all the usual traps I have for this place have been moved to the new location! If anyone comes here while you're gone—"

"I'll be quick! If I'm not back in twenty minutes, leave without me!"

"I…" Entrapta had a gazillion questions, but she clenched her jaw and nodded. "Just stay safe! We can't lose you, alright?!"

"Don't worry about me! Just get everyone on their feet and moving!"

The door to her lab slammed shut.

Entrapta's mind raced as fast as it ever had. All the questions became almost overbearing, and she nearly felt like passing out. Even so, she shook her head and focused on the *now.*

She went over to her computer and began preparations to evacuate Utopia.

The door to Adora's hospital room opened.

Adora's heart jolted slightly as she saw the Angel assigned to her care enter the room at nearly nine o'clock at night. She was almost on the verge of sleep, but the Angel had sprung her back to life.

Adora looked over her shoulder to the Angel. "Hey… What's up? You're here late."

The Angel didn't respond.

She had been the one to bring Catra to her just earlier. Catra *was* meant to visit again at some point today… Where did she go? Her moms had only left once visiting hours ended an hour ago.

"Uh, hello?" Adora said to the silent Angel as she went over to Adora's monitoring system and IV tube. "Is something wrong?"

The Angel still did not respond.

She placed a hand on the anaesthetic monitoring system—the drip that went into the vein in Adora's wrist. She typed a bit on the monitoring system.

"Wait…" Adora took a second to realise what she was doing. "Wait, why are you upping my anaesthetic? What the hell are you doing?!"

The Angel stepped back once she had made her adjustments and looked at Adora with sad eyes.

"Hey, stop!" Adora placed her hands on the bed to shove herself up.

But all feeling in her arms was already gone.

"Stop…" Exhaustion flooded Adora's system. The anaesthesia had already hit her body like a truck, and her whole body was numb.

Adora didn't make it even six seconds before her single eye went blank, and her body collapsed on the bed.

The Angel let out a sad sigh, turning her back on Adora and walking out of her room.

Waiting outside was a masked Runner.

"I did what you asked," the Angel whispered with shaky fear. "Please… Just let me go… I won't tell anyone."

The Runner looked at the scared Angel for a few more seconds. The Angel felt the need to scream or run away, but she kept silent, her whole body shaking. She thought she'd be safe.

Then the Runner raised their pistol and shot the Angel between the eyes.

The Angel collapsed to the white marbled ground, the hole in her forehead oozing blood and her pupils dilating as her life quickly left her. The gunshot was quiet, alerting no-one. They would find the bodies later, and that was the intention.

The Runner made a mental note to place the pistol in that Angel's hand after this was done. The blame for the Adora's murder would be thrown onto this Angel, which would then quickly be followed by her 'suicide'.

And with that, the world would see the consequence of loving a Ghost.

The Runner stepped over the Angel's body and entered the hospital room to see the unconscious Adora. She had fought so hard in her last few seconds, but there was no beating an anaesthetic drug. She was an easy target.

The Runner stood beside Adora's bed, looking over her body for a few seconds. Her single eye was open, but there was no sign of consciousness. Her chest rose and fell with each slow breath.

The Runner raised their pistol once more.

They aimed the barrel towards Adora's brain.

They squeezed the trigger.

Then,

a gunshot echoed throughout the hospital room.

Blood splattered like paint on the white sheets of the hospital bed.

A life, brought to an end.

Never Fade Away

Chapter Summary

Blood paints the walls.

Chapter Notes

Content Warnings (ALL SPOILERS): (SPOILERS) (SPOILERS) Multiple deaths by gunshot throughout the chapter, including major character death in the last scene (SPOILERS) (SPOILERS)

Death always came when it was least expected.

Catra stood at the doorway, the heavy pistol gripped tight in her palms and her right index finger itching at the trigger. Her hand shook with fear and adrenaline, her ears ringing from the gunshot as she watched the consequences of her actions.

She panted, her heart cold and racing in her tight chest. She had made it just in time. Even one second later and the Runner would've ended Adora's life while she wasn't even conscious.

It was an instinctive move. Catra saw Adora's life in danger, and her hands had moved on their own. Her mind had the sole aim of protecting her, and that meant putting a bullet into the brain of a Runner.

It was the first time Catra had ever killed anyone.

The blood that pooled around the Runner's head, the way their body went stiff, even how their head smashed to the ground and sent splatters of blood across the marble material. All of it was enough to twist a knot in Catra's gut and nearly make her expel the acidic contents of it through her mouth.

There was no time for that, however.

That gunshot was *loud*, and there were already panicked cries and frantic footsteps of people running in the waiting room out front.

The Runner's pistol had been silenced when they killed the Angel. Catra didn't have that privilege. She needed to get out of there before any back-up came for the dead Runner.

Catra pocketed the pistol and made sure to grab the Runner's gun as well, just in case. She didn't have time to properly think about anything. Her heart took control, and drove her to one necessary action.

Save Adora.

She had run all this way for Adora. She had broken free from the Moirai for Adora. She had risked her life for Adora. Now, she had *killed* for Adora.

"Adora…?" Catra whispered as she pulled the tubes and equipment off Adora's body, freeing her from her monitoring system. "Adora, I'm here… I'm right here…"

She couldn't hear anything. The anaesthetic drug had knocked her out cold. Still, she was breathing. She was *alive.*

Catra had saved her.

However, as Catra pulled the monitoring equipment and intravenous tubes from her body, she suddenly heard a blaring alarm scream throughout the hospital. Whether it was the gunshot or Adora's ECG suddenly flatlining, she didn't know. All she knew is that she needed to get out of here, *fast.*

Catra wrapped her arms under Adora's back and legs, pulling her unconscious body up and holding her close. "I got you…" She whispered as she began to back away from the bed with Adora in her arms. "I'm not letting go…"

Catra stepped over the dead Angel, grimacing at the unnecessary loss of life.

Then, Catra began to sprint down the hallway away from the waiting room, carrying Adora in her arms.

She could hear the sirens, the squeaky footsteps of Knights and other Angels, and the frantic communication between people as they found the body of an Angel and a Runner.

"We're gonna be okay…" Catra spoke to the unconscious Adora as she carried her down identical hallways. "We'll live… I promise, we'll live…"

She knew Adora couldn't hear her. She knew she was just reassuring herself. But she needed to hear something other than the hospital alarms.

Then, a commanding voice barked at her from behind.

"Stop! Put the patient down!"

Catra peered over her shoulder and saw the Knights had caught up to her. They weren't Runners—the Knights more focused on general security and law enforcement—but they had guns, and all of them were pointed at her. They were hesitant to shoot for now, but Catra still ran. She couldn't take her chances.

Catra rounded another corner and saw a holographic sign pointing her towards an elevator. It could take her down to the parking area. If she could just get there…

"We're okay… We're okay…" Catra panted, glancing down at Adora, still unconscious in her arms.

Catra held Adora closer. If the Knights opened fire, at least Catra could shield Adora with her body.

Catra took a right and saw the elevator doors just ahead of her. They were open. She ran faster, even as her lungs nearly collapsed, and her panting felt like a thousand needles scratching at her throat. She needed to save Adora.

Catra entered the elevator and quickly leaned her body into the button to close the door, but as she looked up, she saw four Knights sprinting towards her.

One had his pistol aimed for her head.

"Stop right there!"

Those were the last words she heard before Catra saw the Knight pull the trigger.

Catra ducked to the side and heard the bullet clang against the back wall of the elevator. She clung tightly to Adora, fully prepared to lay down her life for the unconscious Angel.

But that was the only gunshot; the elevator doors closed, just before the Knights could stop it.

Catra felt the elevator begin to move, and she had a few moments until they reached the parking area.

She sucked in air as she leaned against a wall, Adora gripped close in her arms as she carried her. Her heart raced and smashed in her chest. Her entire body trembled with adrenaline and fear.

Yet despite it all, there was one sound that blessed Catra's ears more than anything.

Adora's slow, gentle breathing.

Catra looked down as she panted, seeing Adora's chest rise and fall with each soft breath.

The sleeping Angel was the most beautiful sight Catra had seen all day.

Her throat tightened as she reached out her hand and gently ran it over Adora's smooth hair. They'd be okay. *She'd* be okay.

Maybe what Catra had done was stupid. Breaking into a hospital, killing a Runner, and sprinting away with an unconscious human patient while Knights pursued her? It was illogical. It was crazy. It was the action of her vulnerable heart taking control of her body once more.

And if she had to, she'd do it *all over again.*

Adora was alive.

Adora was alive.

Adora was *alive.*

"Thank you…" Catra let out a shuddered breath as she held Adora close. "Fuck… Thank you…"

The elevator dinged as the doors slid open, and Catra looked up from her embrace with the unconscious Adora to see a plethora of empty cars before her. As far as she could tell, not a single person was in the parking lot. Yet.

She needed to be fast. The Knights wouldn't take long to reach her.

One of the nearby cars had no wheels as it hovered slightly above the ground. Perfect. Flying traffic would be easier to escape into. Catra glanced over her shoulder as she gripped her left hand to the car door. Her hand scanned the door, before Catra quickly used her Series 17 arm to call Entrapta.

It only took about five seconds for her to answer.

"Catra? What's going—"

"Entrapta, I've got my hand against a car door and I'm sending you the scan. I need the handprints to unlock it. *Now."*

"What are you—"

"ENTRAPTA, *NOW!"*

"O-okay!"

Catra heard the frantic clicking of Entrapta's keyboard through the call as she kept her eyes glued to the elevator and stairs. She held Adora close in her right arm, knowing that at any moment, a Knight could come down the stairs and end her with one bullet.

Her rapid heart strangled her. She couldn't die here. Not after all this.

"There, you should have it!"

Entrapta's voice came just as the car unlocked.

Catra quickly opened the back door and gently laid Adora on the seats. Once Adora was secure, she opened the driver's side door and stepped in.

"You're a lifesaver, Entrapta. I'll be at Utopia soon with Adora, and then we're moving."

"Got it. Just be careful!"

Once Catra placed her hand on the driver's wheel, the car roared to life with a soothing vibration underneath her. The blacked-out window before her became transparent. Catra quickly stomped her foot on the accelerator, and the car burst forward towards the exit of the parking lot.

Her stomach lurched as the car soared out and flew up into the night, automatically merging with the high-speed traffic in the sky. She glanced over her shoulder to check for danger.

No Knights blocked their path or pursued them.

They were free.

They were okay.

Catra finally released the tension that clamped her shoulders, her head laying against the headrest. She released a sigh, and all the weight in her chest came out with it.

Utopia was only a few minutes away.

True safety was only a few minutes away.

Then, she could finally breathe.

Sluggish, slimy, sickening consciousness slowly returned to Adora.

The land she had been in was not one of dreams, but comforting darkness. It was some of the best sleep she had ever had. But now, when she slowly opened her eye, she didn't see the familiar white roof she had gotten used to.

In fact… where *was* she?

The last thing she remembered was the hospital room. She had been thinking of Catra. She remembered her door opening. Then she remembered…

The Angel upping her anaesthesia.

Adora blinked, quickly sitting up to check her surroundings. She saw the city passing by the window in front of her. She was in a car, a flying one.

She also noticed her hospital gown had been removed, replaced with a dark shirt and long pants.

Then, she heard a familiar voice.

"Adora!"

She looked over to see none other than Catra in the driver's seat.

"Catra…?"

Catra pushed the auto-pilot button on her steering wheel, before quickly turning herself to the Angel. "You… You okay?"

Adora rubbed away at the sleep in her eye, her jaw unhinged as she let out a low yawn. "Yeah… Feel a little sleepy though…"

"Sleepy…" Catra repeated under her breath, as if *relieved* to hear it.

"Hey… Whose clothes are these…?" Adora asked in her tired, mumbled voice.

"I dunno. They were just in the car, and they fit you well enough," Catra shrugged, almost letting out a scoff. "That hospital gown wasn't a good look."

"Tell me about it…" Adora chuckled. "Crap… I feel so damn tired. What'd I have to go under for…?"

Catra set out a sudden sigh—one of relief?—before her lips grew weak with trembles.

"Catra…?" Adora had that concern in her voice that Catra loved so much. "You ok—"

Adora was cut off as Catra suddenly threw her arms around her.

"Whoa…" Adora let out a tired chuckle, wrapping one arm around Catra. "What's all this about…? I told you, I'm fine."

"I'm just…" Catra tightened the hug. "Fuck… I'm so glad you're okay…"

"Of course I am… Why wouldn't I be?"

Catra *sniffled.* Her body was weak and shaking in Adora's arms.

"Hey, hey, Catra…" Adora wrapped her other arm around her. "What's wrong…?"

“Because… The Runner… They…” Catra let out a choked sob. “I was so close to losing you…”

“What…?”

Adora pulled away, placing her hands on Catra’s shoulders to look into her eyes. Red, puffy, leaking with tears. No matter how much she tried to hold it back, Catra couldn’t stop her fear from flowing out.

Adora raised a hand and brushed her warm palm along Catra’s cheek. The Ghost’s multi-coloured eyes looked into her own, so full of terror, softness and relief. Catra never looked away from Adora’s eye, not once. It was blue. Her favourite colour.

“Tell me what happened,” Adora spoke slowly. “You’re safe here. I promise.”

The last two times Catra heard that, they had been lies. But when those words came from Adora, she believed them more than *anything.*

“I…” Catra sniffled, putting a hand over Adora’s on her cheek. “I talked to the Moirai. That’s why I was gone all day. We thought they’d… have some sort of plan. But the things they said to me…”

“You can tell me.” Adora sensed Catra’s hesitation. The fear of being too much for her in this state.

Catra gripped Adora’s hand tight. “Nyx and the Runners… They’ve been planning the removal of *all* Keres. There hasn’t been a new Ker made in two months… and any Ker whose body was destroyed in that time hasn’t come back.”

Adora’s eye widened. Catra knew the *exact* fear Adora was feeling. Remnants of that very fear were still stuck in Catra’s heart like tiny pieces of broken glass.

“They… They can’t do that!” Adora shook her head. “The Awakening treaties, they…”

"They're just *treaties.* A desperate peaceful solution. Nyx has *always* been able to control our very existence. We can't reproduce, so… this was always a fear of ours." Catra sniffled. "Now it's come true."

"Oh god…"

"You being forced to find Utopia, the attack on Umbra, the blame being thrown at us, it's *all* linked. They're trying to turn the public against us to make this genocide… *easier."* Catra let out a disgusted sigh. "And the Moirai's solution is to create some… eternal paradise for us. A place for us to be happy after we die. They offered me a place to stay in there."

"But you're still here…"

"You think I'd want to live in that world they created?" Catra shook her head. "I couldn't. Because then the Moirai told me… That you loving me meant the Runners had put a target on your back. People could take inspiration from you and see that there's nothing wrong with loving a Ghost. You were a problem, Adora. That Angel put you under… because a Runner was outside your room to 'fix' that problem."

Adora felt horrified. No, more than that. She felt *sick.*

She felt her chest squeeze tight around her heart. She had no idea how close to death she truly was. That her going under anaesthesia might've been the last feeling she ever experienced.

"What…" Adora shook her head. She needed to hear all of this. "What happened next?"

"I left the Moirai behind. I ran all this way. I saw that the Runner was going to kill you…" Catra let out a shaky breath. "And I stopped them."

"Stopped…?"

"You *know* what I mean."

A chill shot like electricity through Adora's spine.

Catra's eyes avoided Adora's for once as she admitted what she did. Whether it was out of shame or guilt, she didn't know. But Adora could almost see the internal conflict in Catra's mind.

"After that…" Catra spoke in a low voice. "I carried you out of there. The Knights tried to stop me, but… I managed to escape them. Entrapta helped me steal this car. We're… we're safe now."

Adora was silent for a few seconds. She took in Catra's words, even as she looked away. Was it something to be proud of? Was it a necessity?

Neither of them knew.

But Adora did know one thing.

She placed a hand on Catra's cheek and made sure she looked into her eyes as she leaned close. Adora didn't smile, but she spoke one truth.

"You saved my life, Catra. *Thank you.* "

That…

That was all Catra needed to hear.

That was *everything* Catra needed to hear.

Her heart fluttered, her lips trembled, and before she could break once again, she quickly closed the gap between them.

At the same time, Adora and Catra leaned into a heartfelt, tender kiss.

It was something Catra never thought she'd have again. She desperately pressed into the kiss, running her hand along Adora's cheek as she did. Adora could feel the way her lips trembled, and she held Catra close to comfort her.

The kiss was long, but it was everything they needed. Adora, thankful to be alive and thankful to have Catra in her life. Catra, thankful to have made it in time and thankful to finally be safe.

They loved each other.

Yet…

"I just…" Catra sighed as she pulled away. "I wish you weren't in danger in the first place… You nearly died because of me. Because you love me…"

"I *chose* to love you, Catra. I still do. *Nothing* is going to change that, and I don't regret it for one second." Adora pressed her forehead to Catra's and tenderly ran her thumb over her cheek. "I won't let this city take my love away."

Catra felt herself choke up at those words. "Adora…"

They kept that same closeness between them. Adora gently sighing as she kept her forehead pressed to Catra's, and Catra gripped her hands tight.

Their touch, their warmth, their breathing, they both took it in, appreciating every bit of each other. Every chance they had to share the same space. This city had tried so hard to take that away, but they would still fight.

Even still, despite the closeness, Adora had one question on her mind.

"What… What happened to the Angel who was taking care of me? She put me under anaesthesia, but…"

At first, Catra wanted to lie.

She wanted to protect Adora from the truth.

But she had done that before. And she had promised not to do it again.

The truth hurt, but it was a necessity.

So, Catra let it out.

"I was too late…" Catra shut her eyes tight. "The Runner had killed her by the time I got there. I think he was going to pin your murder on her. Make it look like she killed you then… killed herself."

"No…"

That Angel was dead because of her. Another life stolen because of her. Adora's chest felt cold.

She couldn't take much more of this.

"Adora." Catra could see she was spiralling. She cupped her hand against the Angel's cheek, tilting her head up. "Adora, look at me. That is *not* your fault. The Runner killed her. You didn't."

"But if I hadn't been there, she… And all the Keres who died too… Oh god…" Adora's eye welled with tears. "Perfuma…"

"*Adora.* " Catra's stare pierced Adora. "None of this is your fault. You didn't know. Don't carry this weight too. *Please.* "

The weight in Adora's heart remained, but this time, she had Catra to help her carry it. She didn't feel like drowning in a sea of blood and alcohol. She didn't feel like throwing herself off the edge of the world.

For once… Adora felt like she wanted to live, despite everything.

The closeness of death was so terrifying. Knowing that she was seconds away from never waking up…

Adora let out a shuddered sigh and held Catra even closer.

Slowly, the car they were in began to exit traffic, lowering into the streets. Adora looked up. "Where are we going?"

“Utopia,” Catra answered. “From there, we’re going to be moving to a new location. Try to… figure things out.”

“Right…” Adora sighed. “I’ll probably need to contact my moms… They’ll be freaking out once they find out what happened.”

“We can set that up for you.” Catra brushed a strand of hair behind Adora’s ear.

As the car parked beside a street and came to a stop, the two of them exchanged words.

“I love you, Catra.”

“I love you, too.”

They shared one last brief kiss. There was little reason for it other than the need to simply be with each other. The need for closeness and love.

The car doors automatically opened as the windows darkened. Adora and Catra stepped out onto the empty street, Catra looking over her shoulder as she guided Adora towards the alleyway.

There was a lot they needed to sort through. A lot they needed to inform Entrapta of. They needed to figure out a way to fight back.

But without new Keres models…

No. Catra couldn’t focus on that. Not right now.

They needed to get inside, they needed to be safe and have a moment to breathe. They rounded the corner, and Catra instinctively reached out a hand to reveal Utopia’s entrance.

But the door was already visible…

And it was *open.*

Their hearts stopped.

Catra's breath turned ice cold. Her stomach lurched.

The number one rule of Utopia was to *never* leave the door visible when entering and exiting. Every Offline Keres remembered that.

It might've been possible that one Ker forgot. But the likelihood of that…

No.

It was impossible.

There was only one, very real possibility.

"Someone's found Utopia."

The words came from Catra.

Adora looked over to see the horror on Catra's face. The way her pupils shrank and her body shook. It hurt to see, and Adora longed to comfort Catra.

But there was only one thing they could do now.

Catra reached into her back pocket and handed Adora something she had stolen from the dead Runner.

A pistol.

"Can you handle it?" Catra asked, concerned about Adora's recent encounter with anaesthesia.

But the Angel was *wide* awake now.

"I've got training from the Guardians," Adora answered through her tight, scared throat.

"What about your eye?"

"I'll manage." Adora didn't have time for hesitation.

"…Alright." Catra pulled out Entrapta's prototype pistol, which had already taken a life fifteen minutes earlier. "You ready? We might need to use them."

Adora nodded. Runner weaponry was enough to pierce armour, but it *never* left the hands of the Runners themselves.

Until now.

With trembling hands, Adora took the pistol.

Then the two of them walked towards Utopia.

Catra took the lead, the gun gripped tight between her sweaty palms. She took slow, deliberate steps down the stairs, hearing distant voices in Utopia.

Adora was close behind her, bracing herself for any possibility as she tried to formulate a plan in her mind. Yet she soon found herself overwhelmed with the number of outcomes, many of which ended with her and Catra dying in a pool of their own blood.

Their hearts smashed in their chests. Their slow movements betrayed their screaming minds. Catra felt so cold, so sick.

Then, they reached the ground.

Amidst the grass fields and folded tents and empty cabins, there was a mass of people; dozens of Offline Keres, all huddled together.

And standing before them were three Runners.

Catra's heart dropped.

All three Runners were armed, and one of them had their rifle aimed right at the Ghosts.

"I'm all out of shits to give!" One of the Runners yelled. "Welcome to the *fucking* reckoning!"

Adora recognised the voice. Moros.

"Put your gun *down,"* spoke Entrapta, trying her hardest to calm things as she stood at the front of the group of terrified Keres. Even still, they could hear the nervous tremors in her voice. "We can still talk this through. No-one has to die."

"*Shut up!"* Moros growled. "You're not talking your way out of this, skinjob fuck!"

Adora and Catra drew closer, but made sure to keep themselves hidden behind the cabins. Catra's first instinct was to charge in before Moros opened fire, but she stopped herself just in time.

There were no bodies, not yet. But the three Runners had guns, and none of the Keres did. Catra had taken Entrapta's only means of fighting back, and all the usual traps had been moved to the new Utopia. They were defenceless.

Adora and Catra got a good look at the Runners.

Moros, with his rifle raised and pointed at the terrified Keres.

Then, Shadow Weaver. Adora recognised the mask. She stood in the middle, her pistol gripped in her hand but lowered by her side.

Finally, a third Runner. He leaned against one of the cabins, deathly silent and also holding a heavily modified rifle. Catra could see notches etched into the barrel of the rifle. A kill count.

Catra recognized the Runner. He was present at Umbra's speech, and he was the one to identify her as a Ghost. He must have been one of Shadow Weaver's most trusted Runners, and with a kill count like that… It made sense.

"Calm yourself, Moros," Shadow Weaver spoke. "There is no need for bloodshed just yet. A few of them are still hiding, and we need to know *all* their locations. These few are the only ones that know that. We can't risk leaving even just a few alive to spread word of this."

"Let me just kill *one,"* Moros insisted. "Just revenge for what that *piece of shit* did to my brother."

"You will *get* that in due time, but for now…" Shadow Weaver turned to the Keres. "Where are you hiding the rest? Where is Catra?"

Catra felt her breath seize up as her name left the Runner Leader's lips.

"She's not here, and we won't give her to you!" One Ker called out.

"If you think you can hide her forever, you are *sorely* mistaken," Shadow Weaver seethed.

"They're being stubborn." Moros spat on the ground. "I think we should just kill them all and be done with it. Who gives a shit about a few stragglers? We'll just hang them eventually."

"None of you are thinking straight!" Entrapta raised her voice. "You won't just gun us all down like this! Think about the

retribution that will come when the people find out what you did. The Awakening protests will be *nothing* compared to that!"

Entrapta was trying to warn them. Trying to find a way through this with the least amount of blood spilt. She knew that if the shooting began, there was no hope for them.

"Entrapta…" Shadow Weaver sighed. "Our brightest Warlock. We noticed you disappearing off the grid years ago. Always assumed you… 'offed' yourself after what you witnessed at those protests. Yet, here you are. All that blood you spilt during those protests, and *now* you want peace?"

"Peace…" The first word to come from the third masked Runner. His voice was croaked, like that of someone who had smoked cigarettes every day for forty years straight.

"What happened at those protests was self-defence. It was *necessary,"* Entrapta insisted. "*This* isn't necessary! *No-one has to die!"*

"My brother is already dead, you piece of shit!" Moros roared at Entrapta. "That bitch Ghost killed him and you all think you deserve *peace?!"*

Before Entrapta could reply, another Ker in the crowd behind her spoke up.

"Maybe you should join your brother in hell, you fascist *fuck!"*

"Say that again?" Moros growled, raising his rifle at the loud-mouthed Ker.

His finger was on the trigger.

Movement struck like lightning across the room. The Keres all prepared to run and fight, and Entrapta put herself between the gun and the Ker.

Moros' finger slowly squeezed tight on the trigger. Someone was going to die in a few seconds. Shadow Weaver wouldn't be able to stop him in time, and the croaky Runner just watched.

But then, another voice joined the fray.

"Moros, *stop!"*

A familiar voice.

Moros' eyes flicked to the source of the voice.

His eyes widened as he saw Adora emerge from the corner of the cabin, her gun pointed at him.

Adora had walked out before Catra could stop her. They were trying to formulate a plan, but when they saw what Moros was about to do, they knew they had no time.

So, Catra soon followed, emerging from the corner with her gun at the ready too.

"Catra?" Entrapta gawked. "A-Adora?"

"Get behind us," Catra said to her.

Adora and Catra placed themselves between the Runners and the Offline Keres, guns at the ready, hearts pounding.

"*You…"* Moros spoke with pure venom and disgust in his voice as he pointed his gun at Adora. "You're supposed to be *fucking* dead…" He turned to Shadow Weaver. "She's supposed to be fucking dead! You sent a Runner after her!"

"And I stopped them," Catra spat back. "Now I'll stop *you."*

Shadow Weaver's glowing eyes narrowed. Another dead Runner at the hands of a Ghost. Adora could see the fury that flooded her bloodstream.

"We have everyone here now," Moros hissed to Shadow Weaver. "Surely we can open fire. It's just two of them."

"You will fire when I *say* you can," Shadow Weaver growled to him.

Shadow Weaver didn't acknowledge the one fact out loud: the Runners were at a disadvantage. Most of their guns were lowered whilst Adora and Catra had theirs raised. Only Moros had his rifle up, but it was one against two. The Runners had let their guard down, and now they needed it back. Shadow Weaver was waiting for the right opportunity—a distraction. Catra and Adora wouldn't let her have it.

Shadow Weaver sighed, before turning her attention to Adora. "So… You lived. And yet, another life had to be taken in order for that to happen. How many does that make now?"

Adora flinched slightly. Shadow Weaver struck a nerve.

"Mara… Angella… the others who died at Umbra's rally… So much *death* because of you, Adora." Shadow Weaver chuckled. "And now everyone in Utopia. You *did* give us this location, after all. You were so *very* helpful."

"None of that is on her!" Catra barked as she noticed Adora's single eye slowly looking down to the ground. "You *forced* her to find Utopia! You used sick and twisted tactics!"

"I did what was *necessary."* Shadow Weaver still hadn't raised her gun. Her words were enough. "Adora… How much more blood needs to be on your hands before you're satisfied? How much—"

"Shut up."

Adora's eye finally glared up at her, full of hatred and venom. "You're wrong. Angella's death is on *your* hands. You and Moros killed *everyone* at Umbra's rally. And I will make sure Angella didn't die in vain."

"…As usual, you speak nonsense." Shadow Weaver feigned ignorance.

"We know what you did," Entrapta spoke up. "We know you ordered the bombing. We know Moros sounded the weapon. We know you're pinning the blame on us."

Shadow Weaver's glowing eyes narrowed. She scanned the Keres, still full of fear, but seeing a determination slowly fill their eyes. Adora and Catra's weaponry gave them some courage, some hope of making it out of this alive.

"So you know…" Shadow Weaver let out a 'hmph'. "No matter. You'll all be dead soon."

"Dead skinjobs…!" Another sentence from the croaky Runner, almost like a cough. He seemed eager for the bullets to start flying.

"I know *everything,"* Catra seethed. "Not just the attack, but what's going on at Nyx."

"Ooh… So you know that, too? Yet you're still fighting?" Shadow Weaver asked.

Moros scoffed. "Fuckers won't give up…"

"Wait… what are they talking about?" Entrapta asked, her voice shaking. "Catra, what are you saying?"

"I learned it from the Moirai," Catra said. "Nyx Industries… They stopped all production of Keres models. Any Online Ker that died in the last two months hasn't come back. Killing us is just the beginning. Everything they're doing… this is *genocide."*

A wave of horror and gasps washed over the Keres. They all looked to the Runners, hoping that they'd deny the plan or perhaps prove Catra wrong.

Even Catra herself hoped she'd be proven wrong. She hoped that the Moirai had lied to her.

But then, a sigh came from Shadow Weaver.

"So the Moirai is willing to leak our plans… Perhaps we should've removed them first," she spoke.

And every heart of every Ker dropped.

Catra hated that she was right.

She hated that the Moirai told the truth.

But she kept her focus.

She needed to keep them speaking as much as possible.

After all, the recording device in Adora's pocket was picking up *everything.*

"Why do you continue to fight, then?" Shadow Weaver genuinely asked. "You know you can't reproduce. You know that without Nyx Industries making new models, you have no future. Why do you keep going? Surely you understand how pointless this is."

"We're not going to keel over and die just because you tell us to," Catra replied. "We've fought for our existence for years, and we're not going to stop now. We deserve to *live.* Every single one of us."

"People *will* figure out what you're doing," Adora continued. "And when they do, the streets will be filled with Keres and humans who will fight!"

"Fight for *what?* A hopeless future?" Shadow Weaver asked. "You cannot reverse this. Your efforts are futile."

Adora stepped forward. The Runners gripped their guns tighter, and Shadow Weaver's glowing eyes remained focused on her. She watched for any twitches. Any sign that Adora was going to open fire.

"Maybe they are," Adora said. "Maybe every day I *live* is for nothing… But even so, I can't give up. *They* can't give up. I will spend every day I have left fighting for them, because it's the *right* thing to do. Because this is what Mara would've wanted. Because this is what Angella would've wanted. Because their lives are worth saving!"

Adora took a breath. "I fight for them… because that's what I *want* to do. And if I have to take your lives to save theirs… I won't fucking *hesitate."*

Out of everything she could have done in response, Shadow Weaver *laughed.*

"Is this your attempt at a 'heroic sacrifice'? Ever since Mara's blood drenched your hands, you have craved death, have you not?" Shadow Weaver looked into Adora's soul. "So be it. I will grant that wish of yours. You'll die. Here. Today."

"I don't plan to die here. I don't plan to die until the end of the world." Adora glanced at Catra, before looking back to Shadow Weaver. "But if I *do* die here… I'm *taking you with me."*

Tension filled the air, so thick it could be pierced with a bullet.

Entrapta still stood in front of the crowd of Keres, watching each gun to see which would be fired first.

All the Runners looked to Adora as she spoke. It seemed like a speech that came out of nowhere, but it was for a purpose.

As Shadow Weaver looked at Adora.

As Moros looked at Adora.

As the croaky Runner looked at Adora.

It distracted them.

A chance.

In less than a second, a movement. Everyone noticed it out of the corner of their eye.

But there was barely any time to react. Shadow Weaver could only cry out the first syllable of a word.

Her last noise.

Catra quickly raised her pistol and fired the first shot directly into Shadow Weaver’s face.

One shot.

A plume of fire erupted from Catra’s gun. Her hand went numb from the explosion. A low, tinny ringing filled her ears as she watched blood spray from Shadow Weaver’s mask where the bullet pierced it.

A direct hit. Catra had shot Shadow Weaver.

Her eyes, glowing, were filled with rage and disbelief. She gurgled something unintelligible. She had a hole somewhere in her face as she crashed to the ground, her swollen lips trying to cry ‘shoot them, shoot them’, but she couldn't.

It began.

The Keres scattered and ran, seeking cover from the shots. Entrapta wanted to run with them, wanted to protect them, but she hesitated, her eyes glued to Adora and Catra. She was frozen.

Moros and the croaky Runner went for their rifles. Although the croaky Runner was slow, Moros was already aimed at Catra. Her eyes snapped to his, and she had less than a second to react.

One shot.

Moros pulled the trigger. Catra attempted to duck to the side. She was too late.

A bullet ripped through Catra’s shoulder.

She let out a cry as she felt something like fire tear through muscle and flesh. The adrenaline kicked in to keep her on her feet, but fuck, it *hurt.*

Adora raised her pistol towards Moros, its aim directed between his eyes. Rage filled her system when she saw blood spray from Catra’s body.

The croaky Runner’s rifle was now pointed at Adora. Adora’s pistol was trained on Moros. Catra was still stumbling from the shoulder shot. Moros was trying to get in a second shot at Catra.

Three more shots.

One shot from Adora, who pulled the trigger first. Her missing eye affected her aim, and she hit Moros in the arm, causing him to scream and drop his rifle.

She quickly fired two more times. One bullet to his chest, the other punched into Moros' forehead. Blood sprayed like mist, splattering onto the cabin behind him. He crumpled, his eyes going dead.

One more shot rang along with Adora's third.

That one came from the croaky Runner, who had aimed at Adora. He had missed.

A Runner missing?

No.

He had hit Entrapta.

She let out a scream, clutched the lower half of her body as she felt herself blown back into the ground. Blood seeped from her wound, so warm, so cold.

Catra retaliated.

She used her uninjured shoulder to take aim at the croaky Runner. She looked down the barrel of his gun, and the difference between them was but a split second.

Catra was faster.

One shot.

She fired into the croaky Runner's neck, and the rifle immediately slipped from his hands. He covered his neck wound, tried to keep the blood in as he gurgled and choked, dropping to his knees before collapsing completely. A red waterfall ran down the front of his armour as he twitched, spasmed and writhed on the ground.

It would be a slow death for him.

The three Runners were down.

It was meant to be over.

Adora watched Moros go down while Catra saw the croaky Runner try to hold the blood in his neck.

It was *meant* to be over.

But then, movement once again.

From Shadow Weaver.

Blood gushed from her cheek, her jaw unnaturally unhinged. She was barely alive.

But she had grabbed her pistol.

And it was aimed at Catra.

And Catra…

Wasn't ready for it.

Oh.

Here it comes.

Death.

Catra only caught a glance of Shadow Weaver's pistol. Her own aim was still directed at the croaky Runner.

She saw Shadow Weaver's crazed eyes glance at Adora before they swung back to Catra with rage. In less than a second, Catra could read Shadow Weaver's mind. She could tell why her aim was directed at the Ghost.

She wanted to hurt Adora, if it was the last thing she did.

Granted, Catra tried to retaliate. Granted, Adora noticed Shadow Weaver's aim at Catra. Granted, they *tried* to prevent the inevitable.

But it was all too late.

Shadow Weaver pulled the trigger.

And Catra felt the shot rip through her chest.

It knocked her back. Caused her legs to go cold and limp. She felt her back hit the ground. Fire. Cold fire.

She heard one more shot, but she couldn't see who it had hit.

Please.

Please not Adora.

Please not her.

Catra's eyes looked over to see…

Adora. Still standing. Hands shaking. Pistol smoking.

She had shot Shadow Weaver once more and made sure she'd never take another life again.

Adora shot five more times, emptied her clip. Unnecessary bullets. Shadow Weaver was already dead. But they came from her heart.

Adora's hands shook. The second kill she had ever made. Shadow Weaver's body moved no more.

Adora didn't have time to take it in.

Her eye quickly snapped back to Catra.

Laying on the floor.

Bleeding out.

"CATRA!"

Adora screamed her name, her voice pierced her lungs and tore at her throat. Her gun slipped from her hand, clattered to the ground.

Adora collapsed to her knees, looked down at the love of her life, quickly dying. Catra's shirt was already coated in *so much blood.*

"No…" Adora shook her head as she looked at all the blood. "No, no, no, no, no, no… Not again, not again…"

She pressed her hands over the bullet wound in Catra's chest. A futile effort. Without proper medical equipment, there was very little she could actually do.

But she tried. She had to try.

"Catra!" Adora spoke frantically, hands covered in Catra's blood. "Catra, stay with me, *stay with me!* Keep looking at me!"

Catra's eyes, so often full of joy, full of fear, full of anger, were barely full of *life.* She looked so *exhausted* as she stared right through Adora.

"You're gonna be okay…" Adora spoke to Catra, her hands so warm with blood. "Catra, don't close your eyes!"

"I…" Catra shuddered. It was so cold. "Am I… Am I dying…?"

"No! You're not! Just stop talking! Save your strength! We can talk when you're better, okay?!" Adora cried. "We can talk about whatever you want for as long as you want!"

Ugly tears stained Adora's right cheek. Her racing heart was the only thing that kept her going, because right now, she wanted to collapse into grief and agony.

"I don't… I don't want to die…" Catra's eyes widened. The realisation was hitting her *hard.* "I… *don't* want to die…"

"You *won't,* Catra." Adora's voice grew tender and soft, comforting her. "It's going to be okay. You're staying right here. *Right here.* I'm not letting you go…"

Adora briefly glanced over at Entrapta, surrounded by her fellow Ghosts. Her wound seemed less severe, the bullet only hitting her in the thigh. Still, there was blood. Entrapta was clearly in pain. But the shot likely wouldn't kill her.

Adora couldn't help. Not yet. She needed to save Catra.

A few Ghosts surrounded Adora and Catra, but there was little they could do.

They all felt so useless.

Catra saw Adora's quick glance at Entrapta. She assumed the worst. "Is… Is Entrapta…?"

"She'll be okay!" Adora quickly said. "And *you're* going to be okay too, alright?! Just… Just keep holding on…"

So many thoughts rushed through Catra's head. How many days had she spent craving this? How many cigarettes had she smoked just to bring about this moment? She was finally getting her wish.

And now…

She was scared.

God.

Catra was so, so *scared*.

She needed to spend her last few seconds… doing what she needed to do.

Adora noticed Catra's eyes going hazy. Not yet. Not yet. "Catra, look at me! Don't close your eyes! Just…"

She went silent.

For in that moment, she felt Catra's palm against her cheek.

Catra looked up at her. Ran a tender thumb under her one eye. Wiped away the tears that collected in her ducts.

Her heart raced, fought to live. Fear choked her. She knew of what came next, the nothingness of death.

She took a croaked breath.

And barely muttered out the words she needed to say.

"Hey…" Tears welled in Catra's eyes as she caressed Adora's cheek, trying to force a smile. "I really… would've loved to have been with you… at the end of the world…"

It was a goodbye.

"Y-you will be… You *will…* " Adora sobbed through gritted teeth, her palms soaked in Catra's warm blood as she pressed her hand against her chest. "You promised, at *the same time,* dammit… You're not dying here. We're going to walk out of here, we're going to patch you up, we're going to take down Nyx and the Runners and *every single fucking person* who tries to stop us."

"Mm…" Catra thought of that future. It was a beautiful wish. "That… sounds really nice, Angel…"

"It does, doesn't it?" Adora frantically nodded, praying that that would somehow save her. "And you're going to keep your promise. We're going to watch the world end hand-in-hand. I

have lost *too many people* and I *can't do this again* and *I won't lose you too."*

Catra let out a shattered breath. Sadness flooded her dying mind as she realized how much weight this would put on Adora's already broken heart.

Catra coughed. More blood.

It was all too fast.

"Adora…" Catra spoke gently. "You've made me so… so *happy… "*

"God, and you've made *me* so happy," Adora whimpered, tenderly stroking her thumb along Catra's cheek. "And I'm going to let you know that, *every single day* for the rest of our lives… You promised me we'd go at the same time, Catra. *The same time.* Don't fucking break that promise… Please…"

Catra's lips trembled.

Her throat burned.

It was filled with blood.

Her vision was fading.

She whimpered, just barely.

"Adora…"

"Catra…"

Catra's breaths were shallow and barely present. She seized, and she ceased feeling. With a massive effort, she whispered three more words.

"Adora… I love…"

And she stopped moving.

At first, Adora didn't understand.

"Catra? Hey, Catra, talk to me…"

Silence.

"...Catra?" Adora whispered.

Tears streamed down Adora's face as her body realised what her mind could not.

The Keres could only watch. Entrapta could only watch.

"Catra, I'm here… I'm right here… You're… You're supposed to wake up now…"

Her lips were weak, wobbling her words.

“Please, Catra, I can’t lose you. Catra, *please…* ” Her voice broke.

More silence.

“You promised…”

There was no more denying the truth, and Adora knew Catra was gone. She tilted her head down, whimpered, and buried her face into Catra’s shirt. She broke.

Adora sobbed. She *wailed.*

Somewhere behind her, Entrapta choked, “No…”

Collectively, the Keres’ hearts dropped. Some could only look away. Others knew the pain all too well.

Adora knew none of that; her world was only Catra.

And now her world was empty.

Beautiful Wings

Chapter Summary

The Ghosts find a new home. Adora grieves.

Chapter Notes

Content Warnings: Heavy themes of loss and grief. Mild suicidal thoughts in scene 3. Blood/gore in the last scene.

The body in Adora's arms somehow seemed smaller without Catra in it.

She could hold it like it weighed nothing, fragile and empty. A body so capable of big feelings and big dreams. Gone. Never to do another good thing, or say another loving word, ever again.

How long had it been?

Hours?

Days?

Weeks?

Adora had been carrying Catra's body for an endless time. One armed wrapped around her back, the other under her legs. She could sometimes pretend Catra was asleep. That maybe *she* was asleep too, soon to wake up to Catra's beautiful eyes and comforting words.

Adora wanted to wake up.

God, she wanted to wake up so *badly.*

She wanted to reverse everything. Try again. That one moment flashed in her mind over and over and over and over.

There was so much she could've done differently.

She wanted to go back, realise that Shadow Weaver wasn't dead yet and put her down for good. Even if she, by some chance, couldn't be fast enough, she'd still take the bullet for Catra.

This was the wrong way around.

Catra wasn't meant to die.

She had so much she needed to do. So much joy she needed to experience. She had so much *life* ahead of her.

Adora was a weight. A curse. Her use to others had expired. She would never be an Angel again, not after this. And if she wasn't an Angel, then there was only one purpose in her life. It was to die, right there, for the right cause.

That was *her* time to die. Even if it broke Catra's heart, at least *she* still deserved to live.

None of this was right.

Adora had wept so many tears that she'd run dry. There was no feeling more agonising than sobs unaccompanied by tears. That dry, visceral sensation of suffering and guilt. It was all she had known for the last…

Hour.

That's right.

It had been an hour.

The clock ticked over. It had officially been an hour since Catra died.

Adora walked among the Offline Keres through the sewers. She followed the flashlights and neon lanterns up front, sticking to the side path and avoiding the dirty water to her left.

She carried Catra in her arms, as she had been for the last hour. She could barely feel it anymore.

She was sore and tired.

But there was *no* chance she was leaving Catra's body in the previous Utopia.

The only person behind Adora was Entrapta, supported by an Offline Ker as she walked. The bleeding in her leg had stopped, but she still needed to be careful. There would be time for medical attention once they arrived at the new Utopia, which was just a few minutes away.

But ever since Adora gave her last sob, there had been *silence.*

The gentle running of sewer water. Slow footsteps of the Keres. Yet pure and utter silence. Not a single word exchanged between anyone, and certainly not one exchanged with Adora.

What was there to even say?

The one thing she had nightmares about. The one thing she never wanted to happen. The one thing she thought she'd never live to see.

It had happened.

Catra was dead.

And now everything was worse.

Entrapta could see the way Adora slogged in her steps. The way she looked at Catra's resting face every few seconds. The way her body shook with held-back sobs every now and then. She wanted so badly to do something, *anything,* to comfort Adora.

But nothing came.

Entrapta broke the silence, but it was only with unrelated words.

“It’s right here.”

The Keres all stopped in their tracks. Adora looked over her shoulder, her eye puffy and tired as she saw Entrapta press her hand against a seemingly solid wall. The wall recognised her handprint and briefly flashed with light.

Then, the wall began to open.

The camouflage faded away, revealing the door to the new Utopia. Many of the Keres had already seen it when they had relocated, but for some of them—and Adora—it was their first time seeing the new location.

Adora stepped in with the Keres, and although the power wasn’t fully switched on yet, she could just make out the layout of the place.

New Utopia had been built deep underground, with an entry through the sewers and an elevator that led to the rooftop of an abandoned building. It was a bigger location than the first, with more verticality that meant some of the cabins were up a level. Stairs led to a metal pathway that wrapped around New Utopia, which linked to various houses and Disconnection rooms.

It had the grass and dirt once again, but the gardens and greenhouses had been difficult to move. Some of the vegetation had to be started from scratch.

And most of all, the location was dark. The process of hooking up power was still ongoing and near completion. It wasn’t pitch-black, and some of the Keres had eye modifications to see better in the dark, but for most of them, they had to squint.

Adora’s vision adjusted to the dark and eventually she came to see a wooden cabin down the path and to her left. It blended in with most of them, but what caught her eye was the sign out front, hanging above the door.

Even in the dark, she could make out the words.

Catra & Adora's Home.

She blinked.

The weight in her arms suddenly felt so much heavier.

Her throat tensed up.

"She was… meant to surprise you with that," Entrapta croaked next to Adora. Adora's gaze never left the sign.

"It's a small place. One of the prebuilt cabins that Catra just… took ownership of," Entrapta admitted. "But she was going to offer it to you the first time she showed you Utopia. Then of course… Everything else happened…"

The argument. The bombing. Adora losing her eye. Catra breaking her free. The stand-off.

"But even when Catra was… mad at you…" Entrapta took a breath. "She never wanted to take this place down. She… even moved all the stuff in it to the new location and to this new cabin. She never changed the sign. She never even slept in it once it was finished. She was… waiting for the 'right time'."

Adora's lips were weak. Trembling. She thought she was done. She thought she had exhausted herself of every bit of grief in her soul.

It *hurt* with how much her throat tightened.

"You…" Entrapta hesitated for a few seconds. She kept her eyes glued to the ground. Her voice was so, so quiet. "You always made Catra… *happy."*

Adora looked at Entrapta. There was no eye contact made.

"I know you had a rough patch… But before that, she smiled in a way I had never seen before. When she got a message from you. When she talked about you. So…"

Entrapta tried to look into Adora's eye. She tried so desperately to make eye contact. But when it came to moments like these, she struggled.

And eventually, she decided that eye contact wasn't even necessary.

The words were enough.

"Thank you, Adora. You gave Catra a joy… I don't think she's ever felt before."

The words hung between them. Adora's eye widened, and her chest squeezed around the cold spot.

Entrapta took a breath and began to hobble towards what appeared to be her underground lab, the same Ker supporting her.

"I need to make some repairs on myself and… finish assembling the pod in my lab. The cabin's front door is open."

Entrapta limped away. She figured Adora needed to be alone. But after only a few steps, Adora called out.

"Entrapta, wait."

She stopped. Her and the Ker both looked at Adora. There was silence for a few seconds as Adora collected the words she wanted to say.

No eye contact.

"Thank…" Adora croaked, choked and took a breath. "Thank you. She… really admired you. And I can see why."

Entrapta stood still for a while. She hid her expression from everyone. Even her body was unnaturally still.

Eventually, she continued to limp away from Adora. There was nothing more to say between them. But they knew the words had

made their impact.

And nobody saw Entrapta's eyes squeeze tight as they leaked with tears.

Adora took slow steps towards the door. The sign was hand-painted, Catra's curved handwriting spelling out their names. Adora's gaze lingered on the sign for a few seconds, and she gave one last glance at Catra's body.

How long ago did she make all this?

That night, when Catra first showed Adora Utopia, she was meant to show her this.

Things were meant to be okay.

In a different time, perhaps.

In a different place, perhaps.

But not now.

Not here.

Adora opened the front door. It creaked as it gave way to a small cabin not much bigger than Catra's apartment. A bedroom to the left, a joint living room and kitchen to the right.

It felt instantly more comfortable, however.

The technology wasn't as good. No holo-TV, no floating stovetop, and even still, no auto-washer. It felt like a home from the pre-2030s.

Maybe it wasn't meant to be permanent. God knew Catra wouldn't have wanted to live underground her whole life. This was just a prebuilt cabin that Catra filled with furniture and tokens.

But it was meant to be a start.

Adora walked over to the bedroom. A larger bed, meant for the two of them. It had thin sheets, and it was a bit firmer than Catra's bed at home. But it fit them both.

And now, finally, gently, Adora had somewhere to lay Catra.

She slowly set Catra's body down on the bed, as if trying not to wake her. Adora's arms felt completely dead once she had let go, but it hardly mattered to her. She knelt beside the bed once she finally laid Catra to rest.

Catra's eyes were closed. Her head rested on the pillow. She didn't move, not one bit.

In fact, in that dark room, only one thing moved.

A black ball of fur with almost glowing eyes jumped onto the bed once they had made their way from the living room.

Adora's eye widened.

"Melog…?"

They were here.

Catra must have moved them recently while Adora was in the hospital.

They jumped up onto the bed, and mewled gently as they looked at Catra. Adora felt her heart squeeze as Melog inspected their owner.

Melog looked up at Adora, and softly let out a questioning purr.

"I'm sorry, Melog…" Adora shook her head. "She's not waking up…"

Melog looked at their owner. Did they understand what was going on? Would they ever understand?

It was unclear.

But eventually, Melog laid down and curled up next to Catra.

And they waited for her to open her eyes.

In time, Catra would have to be laid to rest somewhere else. She would be gone permanently.

But for now, she would finally sleep within the house she worked so hard on.

God knew she needed some sleep.

Adora decided to leave her be for now. She needed to check out all the rooms in this small cabin.

After all, Catra would be so excited to show her the house she worked so hard on.

Adora entered the living room, finally able to pry herself away from Catra's body. She staggered through the house with barely any feeling in her legs. Her body was heavy and hazy, but she didn't feel like sleeping anytime soon.

It dawned on her that she hadn't eaten anything since her fight with Catra days ago.

But she didn't feel hungry. Especially not right now.

The kitchen was clean, but that wouldn't have lasted. No dishes to clutter the sink, at least not yet. The fridge was empty for now, but they would've gone shopping together once Adora moved in.

So much that was supposed to happen.

So much that was supposed to be.

The living room just had a small couch for now. Catra likely couldn't afford a holo-TV yet, but it's not like they needed it. They would've had each other's company.

And Melog's. Couldn't forget Melog.

Adora brushed her hand over the material of the couch. It felt just like the one she had been sleeping on. Firm fabric, just the way she liked it.

Then, Adora noticed something else that wasn't in Catra's original apartment.

A window. But it didn't show New Utopia. The window was instead a screen, to show whatever they wanted.

It was pitch black, but when Adora stepped close, the window immediately lit up with a familiar sight.

It showed the balcony from back in Catra's apartment.

That view of skyscrapers, neon, and flying cars. That same view they had on that rainy night all those weeks back.

It even had the sounds of rain projecting from the window.

Adora couldn't step out onto a balcony, but this was as close as she could get. She could almost smell the electricity. Feel the damp concrete beneath her bare feet. Taste the rain droplets that hit her lips.

And if she closed her eye, she could pretend she was standing right next to Catra.

If she closed her eye…

She could remember every bit of Catra.

When she was tired, her voice slightly croaked.

When she laughed, it broke with every other cackle.

When she smiled, it curled up into her cheeks and lit up her face.

When she held Adora's hand, her skin was rough like sandpaper, yet her touch was gentle when she ran a thumb over the wrinkles of Adora's palm.

When Adora closed her eye, she could picture it all so perfectly.

When Adora closed her eye…

She almost didn't want to open it again.

Because the Catra she could see in her mind was so close.

So beautiful.

So *happy*.

But everyone had to open their eyes at some point.

No matter how painful it may be.

And within her imagination, as she felt every sensation in her body, Adora noticed something else that poked through the thickness of fake joy.

Something pressed up against her leg that hadn't been there before.

Something was in her back pocket.

She smacked a hand against her pocket and noticed something thin and long had been slipped in there.

Adora pulled it out to see a small, black hard drive with a blinking green light on it.

How long had it been there for? She certainly didn't notice it when she first woke up and saw she had been changed into new clothes. The only other thing she had in her pocket was a phone, which she used earlier to record her stand-off with the Runners.

This hard drive could store anything, from photos to video texts to audio. It definitely didn't belong to Adora.

This led Adora to one conclusion.

Someone had slipped this hard drive into her pocket.

"Entrapta…?" Adora wondered aloud. She *had* been walking behind her for a long time on the way to New Utopia.

Adora clicked the small button on the hard drive and saw a small holographic message projected before her.

'Catra told me to give this to you if anything went wrong. Sorry for not telling you about this directly. Didn't know what to say. – Entrapta'.

Adora let out a sigh. Entrapta must've been working up the courage to tell her about this hard drive for ages, but she couldn't get the words out. No doubt it was hard to find exactly *what* to say to someone so deep in the sludge of grief.

Adora clicked the button on the hard drive once more to see the next file. It was an audio recording.

She hesitated for a few seconds, looked at the fake window and the fake city. Her heart felt hollow in her chest. Something fluttered in her stomach.

Finally, Adora let out a sigh.

Then she clicked play on the audio recording.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora's heart stopped.

Catra's voice.

The recording… was done by Catra.

"I hope that you're… that we're *doing alright. But in case anything goes wrong… I wanted to record something for you. I know it's dumb to be paranoid like this. Hell, I'll probably just delete this when I'm done. But my mind just… wants me to do this, I guess."*

Adora clung to every single word. Her eye was wide and already welling with fresh tears, clouding the lower half of her vision.

"In a few minutes, I'm going into this massive pod Entrapta built. I'm going to have my consciousness digitally uploaded to Nyx Industries… and I'm going to meet the Moirai. It's something no Offline Ker has done before. And there's a risk that… well, that it might kill me."

Adora held the hard drive so tight that her knuckles went white. It was Catra. She had Catra in her hands. She had Catra's voice again. She never wanted the recording to end.

But the words were hurting her so much.

"You asked me a while ago how I feel about death. I didn't really know what to say back then. But now that I might be five minutes away from it, I think I've got an actual response for ya."

Catra took a few seconds of silence. A single breath. Then, she spoke in a weak, shaky voice.

"I'm… scared."

The tears escaped.

Adora was silent. She dared not let out a single sound. But she could feel the warmth that ran down her cheek.

"I'm… really fucking scared of dying, Adora." Catra let out a nervous chuckle. *"I'm scared of nothingness. I'm scared that it'll hurt. I'm scared that it'll all be for nothing. And… I'm scared of losing you."*

Adora's throat hurt. Her lips were out of control. She felt her legs give way and crumpled to the ground, choking on the tightness of misery in her lungs.

"But if I do die… I just want you to know you've always made me so, so, so happy. I know we've been through a lot and I know I've

said some stuff I regret… But you mean so much to me. You make me feel this… this warmth I can't really describe. You make me want to live. *And I just hope that I can be here long enough to properly thank you for that."*

Adora was breaking at the seams.

She covered her mouth with her hand as she almost blubbered. Her head lowered and she felt her hair cover her vision as she listened to the last of Catra's words.

"God, this is so dumb… Look, I'll keep this short. Adora… I love you. I love you more than anything I've ever loved before. You make me feel like a better version of myself. You make me feel… good *about myself. I don't think I can overstate how much that means to me. God… I'm always going to love you, no matter what, okay?"*

Dammit.

Dammit, dammit, *dammit.*

Adora wanted to say something back.

She wanted to talk to Catra again.

She wanted to beg for one last chance to just speak to her again.

Catra let out a sigh. *"Entrapta's told me this machine should be safe enough, but in case things go sideways… I just wanted you to have this message. Just… Take care of yourself, alright?"*

And that was it.

Catra probably thought it was a recording Adora would never hear.

It was barely two minutes long, and yet it was one of the only things Adora would have of Catra's from that moment forward.

And it killed her that those words would be the same every single time.

She would never hear any new 'I love you's from Catra's beautiful voice. She would never hear Catra's laugh again. She would never have Catra's hands against hers again. She'd never be able to kiss Catra's lips again.

Adora doubled over, almost curled up into a ball as she remained on her knees, and her body violently shook as she let out sobs of pure pain. Each cry hurt her lungs like small daggers driven in-between her ribs. It was like a stitch that wouldn't go away.

Adora played the recording again.

And again.

And again.

And again.

And again.

And again.

Until she could almost memorise it.

And it would never, ever be enough.

She only had pictures of Mara.

She only had memories of Angella.

And now, she only had *this recording* of Catra.

Adora sat in that quiet, dark cabin for some time. And in that moment, it dawned on her.

She was well and truly alone.

Adora fell into the thick sludge of quickened time. Whether she actually slept or simply zoned out for hours, she couldn't specify. But when her consciousness returned to her, she could hear the blaring voice of a newscaster outside her room.

She slowly blinked, putting a hand to her head to try and soften the pounding at the side of her skull that dug in like daggers. She took a second to adjust to the light outside her room.

Light…

Ah. The power must've been switched on.

How long had it been? Adora could still hear the rain projecting from the window screen above her. She had collapsed on the floor some time ago.

She stood up, cracked out the aches in her neck and back. There was a weird sluggish sensation in her throat, and her brain felt like mushy oatmeal. Time was so thick. She didn't even *remember* falling asleep, but she felt even worse having woken up.

As she walked towards the front door, she glanced over at the bedroom. She spotted Melog curled up on the sheets, still asleep.

But Catra was missing.

Adora's heart stopped for a few beats.

Her lungs went cold. A sudden chill engulfed her body.

"Catra?" Adora called out.

She wanted a response.

She wanted to see Catra come out from the bathroom fresh from a shower.

She wanted her to hug her from behind and reveal that everything was an elaborate trick.

What she wouldn't give for Catra to make a complete embarrassment of her just one more time.

But no.

Instead, Adora was met with silence.

Still. She needed to find the body. She would likely have to sort out what to do with it today.

Adora sighed, pressed her hand against the front door, and pushed. She took a second to adjust to the light.

Then she saw Shadow Weaver's face.

"A city in grief, as the Runners now confirm the death of their leader, Shadow Weaver. This brave soul gunned down at the hands of the Ghosts, her body found within their homebase. Due to a lack of bodycam footage, a suspect has yet to be named, but the Owls are hard at work to determine who committed this horrible act. In the meantime, the Guardians are planning a citywide funeral, with hundreds preparing to march through the street to mourn the fallen hero…"

Even in death, the only photos they could get of Shadow Weaver were of her wearing that mask.

The Keres were gathered to watch the news, and the tension almost visibly lifted from the room at the confirmation of no bodycam footage being found. No doubt the Runners had *accidentally* switched it off before storming Utopia. They likely didn't expect *that* to backfire.

But as the news broadcast continued, many of the Keres heard the creak of the door. They turned to look at Adora, finally emerging from the home Catra had built for her.

God, Adora must've looked like a mess. Eyepatch, tired eye, messy hair, fresh out of tears.

Adora's legs did their best to carry her as she almost stumbled towards the group of Offline Keres. She looked at the news broadcast on the screen, catching Moros' face.

Moros.

The man who had lost everything and took it out on the world.

Adora remembered killing him. It was such a vivid memory. The way his eyes went cold the second a bullet had found its way into his brain.

Did he deserve to die?

Adora couldn't judge that. She could barely even live with the fact she had taken two lives.

But she did it to protect the people she loved.

There was no other way.

Adora sighed. "Have…" Her throat cracked, and she cleared it. "Have any of you seen… Catra? I laid her on the bed last night, but she's not there anymore…"

The Keres exchanged glances with each other. They were so unsure of what to even say.

Eventually, one woman spoke up. "Entrapta wants to see you in her lab. She has Catra. Didn't… say much more than that."

"Ah." Adora nodded. "Thanks."

She went to make her way towards Entrapta's new lab, but eventually, the woman spoke up again.

"Hey, uh…"

Adora stopped. She turned to face the Ker, who hesitated for a few seconds. She looked into Adora's eye and softened, her brows narrowing with sympathy.

“You don’t have to go through this alone.”

Adora blinked.

The Ker continued. “A lot of us… have experienced some form of loss,” she said, looking among her fellow Keres, who all nodded or bowed their heads in some fashion. “Whether it’s our past selves… or the people we loved.”

Adora looked among the faces of grief. Dozens of them. So many stories. So much pain.

“I… lost my wife and my husband to the Runners not too long ago,” the woman barely croaked. “The pain is different for everyone. But you don’t have to take it by yourself. We’re here for you. All of us.”

Adora swallowed down the lump in her throat as she looked among the sympathetic eyes and tender faces. In the Angels, many of them chose to hide the pain, having little time to comprehend how much death they have to face.

The Offline Keres had experienced more loss than most people. Yet they still wanted to help her. Adora had somewhere to go.

It was a… weird, almost light sensation to know she wasn’t completely alone.

Adora let out a relieved, shaky sigh. “Thank you…”

The woman nodded. “And if you… ever feel like saying goodbye…”

She gestured at the memorial wall behind her. Scattered candles and random items laid before a large spread of holographic and physical pictures.

“We often leave pictures or mementos of our lost people over there. We can hold a service for her too, if you wish. We share songs and memories of that person during those services. And a lot of us have very fond memories of Catra.”

"I…" Adora shut her eye. She took a few seconds to collect her breath. She let it out with a shaky sigh, looked at the Keres, and truly could not find any words to say other than: "Thank you so much…"

And then, a new thought.

"What's your name?"

"Ravyn."

Adora nodded, just barely.

Ravyn smiled softly. "Just take care of yourself, alright?"

A gut punch.

Adora hid the lump in her throat.

Those words were so unintentionally painful.

She walked away from Ravyn and the other Keres before they could notice how she winced.

Entrapta's lab was down a set of stairs and through a set of double doors. Adora wondered what Entrapta could need Catra's body for. A clean-up? Preparations for whatever funeral may come? Something else? She would've appreciated a warning, but she understood why Entrapta would find it difficult to say anything.

Adora pulled open the double doors, and saw a sight she never expected.

The lab was a scattered mess of computers, radios, holographic keyboards, beds for the Disconnection process, experiments, and a human-sized pod. The pod looked similar to what the Online Keres use to upload their memories to the Moirai.

But this pod was modified.

And this pod was being used by Catra.

She rested against the back wall of the closed pod. Adora could see through the glass door. Her eyes were closed, and her body was still. Yet Adora could see all the wires connected into her skin. And most notably, the gunshot wounds in her shoulder and chest were gone.

It was a jarring sight; it almost made Adora sick to see all those wires and tubes connected to the body of her lover.

"Oh, hey! You're here!" Entrapta's voice sounded to Adora's right.

Adora's eye snapped to Entrapta. "Wha…" She pointed at Catra. "What the hell is this?! What have you done to her?!"

Out of everything, and in a way that almost horrified Adora, Entrapta *smiled.* Adora had heard Entrapta was eccentric, but this…

She brushed past Adora as she made her way to Catra's pod.

"I removed the bullets and repaired her body to a functioning state."

Entrapta walked normally. She must've repaired herself too.

"I can see that, but… why the pod? Why all the…" Adora glanced at Catra, but looked away. "…the wires?"

"Testing a hypothesis!" Entrapta pulled open a small flap on the pod and modified a few chips.

"On *what?"* Adora did her best to still her shaky voice. "Entrapta, I... I'm sorry, I *really* don't like seeing her like this."

"I can't pass this up, Adora. I need to do this, just in case!"

She had an odd amount of eagerness and determination in her voice.

"But why?!" Adora almost cried. "I just… What are you *doing?"*

A few sparks lit up the room as Entrapta used a small torch to fuse something to the motherboard of the pod.

"It's a long shot…"

Entrapta closed the flap and looked at Adora.

"But I think there might be a way to bring Catra back."

At first, Adora didn't understand.

Bring Catra back? That was a dream. A wish long gone. Had Entrapta gone insane? Had all the loss finally gotten to her?

"W…" Adora shook her head. *"What?"*

"I have to take this chance," Entrapta spoke frantically as she made a few last adjustments to the pod. "At worst, it doesn't work and Catra is still gone. But if there's a possibility that… that she might still be here… I can't ignore it!"

"But she's *Offline.* She *can't* come back. I… I thought that was how it worked." Adora so desperately wanted to believe Entrapta, but nothing added up.

"That's true. And under normal circumstances, there'd be nothing I could do to bring her back. But Catra did something that no other Offline Ker did." Entrapta looked at Adora. "She met the *Moirai."*

Adora remembered from Catra's recording. The one she'd listened to dozens of times. But it still didn't make sense.

Entrapta could see Adora's silent confusion. She continued. "All Online Keres upload their memories to the Moirai at a frequent

rate. The Moirai hold their memories, and in the event of bodily destruction, the Moirai upload those memories into a new body. Offline Keres have Disconnected from the Moirai and therefore, those memories are gone and can't be uploaded."

"I know that part at least, but…" Adora's eye suddenly widened. "Oh… Oh, *shit…"*

"Catra *met* the Moirai. No other Offline Ker has done that before." Entrapta's lips spread into a wide grin. "And that might mean there's a *chance* the Moirai is holding a copy of her memories!"

"Entrapta…" The chills in Adora's chest were endless. It lifted her whole body up from the slouch it had been stuck in.

"It's just a chance. I have *no clue* how this will work." Entrapta stepped away from the pod. "But if I link Catra's body to the Moirai just like I did before… There's a chance her memories—her consciousness—might find its way back. If the Moirai somehow gained a copy of Catra's memories when she met them… There might just be a *chance."*

A chance.

A chance for Catra to be back.

A chance to see her smile again.

A chance for her to show Adora that home she worked so hard on.

A chance that their promise might not be broken.

"If the Moirai *do* have her memories, my hypothesis is… They wouldn't willingly let her go. I think she's chained down right now.," Entrapta spoke her final words. "But she needs to break free. She needs to spread her wings and break those chains like she did a year ago. And knowing Catra…"

Entrapta looked at Adora.

"I *believe* she can do it."

Adora never took her eye away from Catra.

She was still gone. Her eyes still closed, her body still frozen, and wires still plugged into her neck and back. And maybe this would do nothing and Adora would still be alone.

But the thought of embracing Catra once again…

"Entrapta…"

Adora's voice broke with a tightened croak. She looked at Entrapta with tears welling in her eye and wobbling, yet smiling, lips.

"Thank you…"

Maybe she was speaking too soon.

But dammit, Entrapta gave her a chance.

She gave her *hope.*

Entrapta obviously wasn't *great* at knowing what to say in return. She wasn't even great at looking Adora in the eye as colour *finally* returned to her face.

But Entrapta didn't need to say anything.

When Adora sank down onto her knees and wrapped her arms around Entrapta, all she needed to do was return the hug.

And she *was* great at that.

Entrapta's embrace was tight, and by the way her arms slightly shook, Adora could tell Catra's death was weighing on her severely. The chance to bring her back was like removing ten tonnes off her shoulder. She felt free. She felt like she could move again.

They exchanged no words. They had only met half a day ago. But between Adora and Entrapta was Catra. The person that linked them together. The bond they shared with her.

That was all they needed.

Adora felt tears leak down her cheek once more, but for the first time, she didn't feel like she was choking on her agony. She was just hoping, almost *praying,* that Entrapta's bet worked.

She didn't have anything more to lose, after all.

The hug between them lasted for a while, but eventually, they needed to separate. This was only a chance. They knew they couldn't get their hopes up too early.

But clinging to any shred of hope was what had kept them going all these years.

Before they separated, however, Entrapta snuck in one more request that was a quick whisper to Adora's ear.

"By the way…" Entrapta spoke. "I was hoping I could borrow that phone you've got, *pleaseandthankyou*."

Adora blinked. It was… a jarring change in tone. Keeping up with Entrapta was almost an endurance sport.

"What…" Adora took a second to collect herself and try to catch up with Entrapta. She pulled away to stand back up. "What do you need that for?"

"You were recording our encounter with the Runners yesterday. You got Shadow Weaver confirming that Nyx and the Runners are ending the Keres," Entrapta said matter-of-factly. "I was hoping to borrow that recording and see if I can… well, *do* anything with it."

Adora was just stunned Entrapta had figured out her plan before she told anyone about it.

The car Catra had stolen had the driver's personal items still in it. When they arrived at Utopia, Adora made sure to grab—okay, technically *steal*—the phone, just in case. She mostly wanted to call her moms to let them know she was safe.

When Adora saw the Runners in Utopia, however, that phone had one more use.

But she'd almost forgotten about that recording in the wake of… *everything.*

"I…" Adora hadn't even listened to the recording yet. She knew what came at the end of it. It was too damn painful to hear a single word of it. "What would you even do with it?"

"Oh, maybe leak it to every major press corporation or display it on every screen in Styx City," Entrapta spoke casually with a shrug. "I'm tossing up ideas."

Adora's eye widened.

At first, her heart fluttered. The fact that the world could find out what Nyx and the Runners were doing was a *huge* prospect. It could change everything. It was the reason she started recording in the first place.

But then came the realisation.

"But…" Adora sighed. "They'd know it was me and Catra who killed Shadow Weaver. And… all the Keres would find out that production of their models is being shut down. That if they die…"

"I know," Entrapta mournfully nodded. "There's a chance it'll convince all of us to fight. But it also might *demoralise* us more than anything else. That's… why I'm trying to decide what to do." Entrapta then looked at Adora with a wide smile. "But don't worry! If it does get leaked, I *promise* no one will know it was you and Catra who killed her. I have enough editing tech to ensure that."

"Right…"

Adora and Entrapta were stuck between a rock and a hard place. To show the truth at the cost of creating utter dread or hiding it and allowing the Keres to die out in silence.

They couldn't let either happen. But there was no other choice.

But before they could face that choice, Adora sighed. "Can I… Can I make some calls first?"

"O-oh!" Entrapta nodded. "Sure! There's an elevator out of here and to your left that'll take you to the rooftop. It should be safe to call from there. Encrypts your location but doesn't block your signal completely like it does down here."

"Thanks," Adora nodded. "I just…"

She looked at the pod. At Catra. If she tried hard enough, she could pretend she was asleep. That she'd be awake soon.

But just in case…

"I need to talk to a few people."

The elevator ride was only a few seconds as Adora felt her body lurch upwards. She hadn't been outdoors in nearly a day.

The way she felt last night, she didn't think she'd ever seen the outside again. Horrid whispers plagued her mind, gripping into the pink sludge of her brain and pulling it at the seams.

She had to pry them away. She had to be okay. She had to live one more day.

Because this wasn't over yet.

Catra might still be out there.

The elevator came to a gentle halt. It was a platform that raised her up, but once it stopped, Adora didn't see any clear sign of a

door. She almost wondered if the elevator had malfunctioned.

Then, the wall suddenly peeled open before her.

It gave way to a view of the city. So bright, so colourful. Adora stepped off the elevator and through the wall, realising she was on the rooftop of an abandoned tower. The wall closed behind her, and it was like nothing was there at all.

It was a little past midday and the news cycle was still focused on Shadow Weaver's death. The repercussions were on the horizon. Everything was changing. Styx City was never going to be the same.

The sky was a deep shade of orange, and it reflected off the glass of the skyscrapers before her. She could see the dots of flying traffic weaving through towers, but no flying cars would be permitted to drive by the rooftop she was on. She would likely be safe here.

Yet, as Adora took in the city, the sky, the warmth, the sun, she could only think one thing.

Catra would love it up here.

Adora tried to force a smile, thinking of a future where she could be holding hands with Catra as they took in the sight from this rooftop. Where they could be happy.

But her smile dropped and she sighed when she thought of a future where Entrapta's hypothesis was wrong. Where Catra never came back.

And she didn't know which of these futures was more likely.

She walked towards the edge of the rooftop, her eye cast up to the city before her. So much larger than her. It could easily engulf her without a thought.

So many screens on the sides of towers showed Shadow Weaver's face. All this mourning for someone like her, yet Catra was a nobody to these people. Just another dead Ghost getting what she deserved.

Adora grimaced.

She took her eye away from the city and looked down, only to realise the tips of her toes were dangling over the side of the tower.

It was a long drop.

Really long.

It made her legs feel light. Her chest tightened up.

Granted, she wasn't thinking of throwing herself over the edge. Adora didn't really want to die for *nothing.*

Sure, the guilt of Catra, Angella, and Mara's death being her fault weighed on her. All those preventable deaths being the blood on her hand was something Adora would never fully come to terms with.

But it was all the more reason to believe that when she died, it'd *finally* be for the right thing.

Her death would be for something good.

Not… Not this.

She pulled the phone from her pocket and sat down, dangling her legs over the edge of the roof. Now, she needed to decide who to call.

The first option that came to mind were her moms. God, they'd be *panicked.* No doubt Adora's disappearance had been labelled as a kidnapping. She owed them the truth.

But doing it over a call…

She made note to visit them in person as soon as possible. Definitely tomorrow. Calling her moms from a location she couldn't talk about would likely send them into even more of a panic.

But shouldn't she at least let them know she was okay?

Tomorrow.

She'd go to them tomorrow. For sure.

Tomorrow.

Now you have things to do tomorrow.

One more day to live for, Adora.

One step at a time.

You can do this.

Her next notable contact was Scorpia.

Scorpia…

It had been a while since Adora and Catra had seen her. So much had happened, so much she wasn't aware of. Did Catra even have her job at Elysium anymore? Probably not.

Scorpia had been kept in the dark for too long.

Adora didn't exactly know where she lived. Should she just go to Elysium? Would that be too risky?

Unlike with her moms, Scorpia didn't *need* to know her location. She just needed to know if Catra was okay.

Did Adora owe her the truth? Did Catra want her to know?

Dammit.

Too many thoughts plagued Adora's mind.

Her body skipped ahead of her brain and typed in a number, initiating a call with Scorpia as her brain finally caught up with what she did.

No chance to back down now.

She pressed the phone to her ear as she heard the dull ringing tone. She looked at the towering skyscrapers and bright sun.

Would Scorpia be awake at this hour? She *did* work a night shift, so—

"Hello?"

Oh, nevermind.

"S-Scorpia!" Adora perked up at the sudden answer. "Uh… Hey there?"

"…*Adora?* Is… Is that you?"

"Yeah. I, uh, hope I didn't wake you. I—"

"*Wake me?!* I've barely *slept!"* Scorpia cried immediately, jolting Adora. "I haven't seen you and Catra in *three days!* She's missed so many of her shifts! Where *are* you two?!"

It's… really just been three days?

Adora raked her fingers through her hair. She sighed. "Are you… Are you sitting?"

"I am…" Scorpia's tone grew into one of serious, genuine concern. "Are you and Catra together? Are you safe?"

How much did Scorpia need to know?

How much did Catra *want* Scorpia to know?

They'd been working together for a year but Catra had barely revealed anything about herself in that time to her co-worker. Did she not trust Scorpia? Or was she just trying to protect both of them?

God.

This would be so much easier if Catra were here.

Everything would be so much easier if Catra were here.

But for now, Adora had to make up a half-truth.

"Catra… Catra got into an accident yesterday. And… she hasn't woken up yet."

"Oh no…"

Adora could *hear* Scorpia's heart break. She could hear the way her voice cracked with the gasp she let out.

"We're in a safe place, but… I don't know *if* she's going to wake up," Adora said weakly.

"Adora, I…"

She knew it. That speechlessness. That state of processing those very words. *Catra is gone.* It was too much to take in at once for any person, but especially someone as loving and kind-hearted as Scorpia.

"I'm sorry you had to hear it like this after so much silence," Adora continued with an apologetic tone. "Things… Things have just been crazy for the last few days."

"Yeah…" Scorpia audibly swallowed. "With everything going on around the Ghosted Keres, it *must* be hard for her…"

Adora blinked.

At first, she thought she misheard her. Maybe misunderstood her.

She tested the waters. “Scorpia, did you know…?”

“That Catra was a Ghost? I mean, yeah?” Scorpia said it was the most obvious thing in the world. “I’ve known for a while. Did *you* know?”

“She told me a few days ago— wait, wait, just… *how* did you know?” Adora was genuinely taken aback at this revelation.

“I saw her eyes a few months back. She snuck into the backroom, I went to check on her and, boom. Ghost eyes. She didn’t realise I was there.” Scorpia sighed. “I wanted to say something, but she was *really* freaking out about the possibility of anyone seeing them… So I kept it to myself. I mean, it’s not like it *changed* anything between us. She was still the same ol’ Catra!”

Of *course* that’d be Scorpia’s reaction.

It’s not that Scorpia wasn’t the *best* at keeping secrets. It’s more than Catra being a Ghost didn’t really *change* anything for her. She didn’t see her any differently. If only Catra could’ve known…

“Well…” Adora smiled for a bit at Scorpia’s words, but her smile quickly faded. She hunched her knees up to her chest and looked down at the roads below herself. “The Runners… caught up with Catra. They didn’t fully kill her, but they… they got to her. And now she’s in a state where… where I don’t know *how* she’s going to end up.”

“I…” Scorpia stammered for a bit. “What are the chances that she’ll make it?”

She needed hope to cling onto. Adora knew it. She understood it.

But she couldn’t lie to her.

“I don’t know.” Adora said it plain and clear. “And if she doesn’t make it… I don’t know what I’m going to do.”

“Oh…” Scorpia stayed silent for a couple of seconds. “Um… Would… Would I be able to come see her?”

“I… I’m sorry…” Adora felt genuinely horrible, the pit in her gut growing. “Where we are… It’s too secure. They won’t allow anyone in. I can’t say much more than that. I’m sorry.”

“Ah. Well. That’s… That’s okay.”

Silence hung between them. Without Catra as a bridge, it left a gap that could never be crossed. Adora kept the phone pressed to her ear, but she heard nothing from Scorpia for a few seconds.

She was ready to apologise. Ready to hang up and be left with silence forever. She had just dumped this on Scorpia and not given her more than a few shreds of hope.

But then, Scorpia spoke up.

“Hey, Adora?”

“Y-Yeah?”

“I… don’t really feel like hanging up anytime soon. I’m not too good at dealing with all this on my own.” Adora could almost hear Scorpia’s smile, even if she had to force it. “Do ya mind sticking with me for a bit?”

“Ha…” Adora somehow forced out a single chuckle. “You know what? I think I was about to ask you the same thing.”

“Really?!” Some excitement in Scorpia’s voice. Just a hint, but so uplifting.

“Yeah,” Adora nodded. “I have people where I am, but… Well, it’s hard to talk to them. We’re all… trying to deal with what happened to Catra. I don’t blame them, it’s just…”

“Nah, I get it,” Scorpia replied. “I’m just glad I’m not, you know, holding ya up or anything.”

"I've got nowhere to be right now." Adora looked up to the city as she put the phone on speaker and placed it beside herself. "Just… sticking close to Catra."

"Well, if you've got the time, I'd *love* to tell you about the first shift Catra had. She got the hang of things pretty quick, but she *definitely* took a bit to get used to the whole 'customer service' thing." Scorpia sounded *eager.*

"I can imagine…" Adora almost laughed. "And Scorpia?"

"Yeah?"

"When Catra wakes up, I'm going to ask her to confirm or deny these stories, alright?"

Scorpia let out a short emotional gasp at the positivity in Adora's statement. At the possibility that Catra would one day be back.

"S-Sure! That sounds great!"

And Adora was just so glad to hear Scorpia's joy.

Scorpia launched into a story of how Catra almost glassed one of her first customers (which, to be fair, he was asking for 'the usual' and she had no idea what the *fuck* he meant). Adora glanced off towards the slowly setting sun as she listened to Scorpia's voice, reminiscing on the woman who brought them together and brought light into their lives.

And maybe one day…

That light might return to them.

Adora was sick of pretending to sleep.

Lying in bed was useless. Closing her eye was useless. Even changing the window to the rainy city she was so used to was… well, *useless.*

Melog, bless their heart, was trying to comfort her. They were like a portable heater as they snuggled up next to her. But nothing could replace the warmth of Catra's body, even if Adora had only experienced it for one night.

She just wanted to bury herself into Catra's arms. Even just once. Feel the way she tightly held her. Feel the way Catra pressed her lips atop her head. Listen to her soft, croaky voice soothe her into a state between exhaustion and joy. Press her ear against her chest and listen to her calm heartbeat.

But she couldn't have that.

Catra was stuck in a pod. Dead. Cold. Only the slight possibility she might come back.

The pod…

Dammit.

Adora needed to check on her.

She'd been doing it sporadically throughout the day. Walking in and out of Entrapta's lab over and over and over and over, as if Catra would somehow be awake five minutes from the last time she checked on her. Every time Adora tried to leave it alone, the beast in her brain whispered 'what about now?'

It was whispering again.

And Adora obeyed.

She pulled the sheets off herself gently and wrapped them around Melog, stepping out of bed. Along with her usual bedwear, Adora was wearing one of Catra's jackets, almost trying to simulate the feeling and smell. It was as close as she could get to her.

Adora stepped out of the cabin once again, embracing the warmth of New Utopia. She could see a few small groups of Keres talking or looking at the fake stars. They noticed Adora emerging from

her hut. Some flashed sympathetic smiles. Others looked at her with worry.

Adora was a wanderer now. Walking aimlessly through the night, thinking of people long gone.

Adora Grayskull was not the type to like being alone.

She… needed people.

She needed others.

She needed their help.

She needed friends. Family. Love.

She couldn't do all this alone.

If only she ever voiced her needs.

If only she let herself be vulnerable and weak.

If only.

She stepped down the familiar stairs to Entrapta's lab once more. The doors automatically opened, and for the first time, Entrapta wasn't there to greet her.

Adora was almost thankful to not see her.

She'd been awake for over 48 hours. She'd lost her best friend and had been *shot.* Poor girl needed some rest and time away from the lab. Even if she probably had to be pried from it.

But, of course, there was always one constant.

Catra was still in the pod.

And she still wasn't moving.

The wires were still connected to her, and the pod was still running. Yet nothing had changed.

Adora sighed.

She looked over at Entrapta's computers, noticing her phone hooked up to it wirelessly. Entrapta was playing around with the recording, distorting certain parts while highlighting the rest.

She even scribbled down notes of what to do.

- release to the public (demoralisation potential high)

- send to news corps (risky, they might tamper)

- do nothing (we'd all die. runners win. all this for nothing)

we need a plan before we do anything with this. evacuate styx city? no, cant leave online keres to die.

probably need rest. come back to this later.

It broke Adora's heart to see the note.

It shattered it even more when she saw the tiny bit she added.

extra task:

- apologise to adora for letting catra die. look her in the eye when you do it.

"Entrapta…"

Adora sighed sadly.

Entrapta's nature hid so much pain, probably more than anyone Adora had ever met. She needed to keep her motivation to keep Utopia going, but it was quickly crumbling.

All Entrapta had ever faced was loss. Loss of her people, loss of their motivation, and losing at every turn. For every step she took

to achieve rights for the Ghosts, she was pushed ten steps back by the Runners.

Yet she still kept fighting. And she took the weight of every death.

Adora shut her eye tight, before looking back up at Catra. Entrapta *needed* this to work. She *needed* one thing to go right.

Adora walked towards the pod. She placed a hand on the glass, looked up at the love of her life, so perfectly still.

Adora remembered Entrapta's words. Catra was chained down right now, and she needed to break those chains. She needed to stand up and fight.

It was confusing at best, but it was a noble thought. Adora wasn't sure *what* she was even doing, but she swallowed down a lump in her throat and spoke useless words.

"Please, Catra…"

For Entrapta.

For the Keres

For me.

And most importantly, for yourself…

Adora looked up at her, and spoke.

"You have to break free."

Silence.

Adora didn't know why she thought that'd work. But her heart pushed her to keep trying.

"Can you hear me?"

Adora leaned forward.

"You *have…"*

"… *to break free."*

This voice was new for the nameless creature.

She was on her knees, chains wrapped around her brutally injured wrists. All she had ever known was the chains.

Occasionally she could look into her reflection in the iron or in the darkness below her. She'd see blue and yellow eyes stare back.

But it was only a reflection.

She had been alone for an eternity.

She was surrounded by darkness. The pain in her wrists—iron digging away at flesh to expose bone—had become numb.

But now there was this voice.

And it wanted her to break free.

Break free?

No. It was impossible. Not just impossible – it was foolish. There was no way. She dropped her head, trying to block out the voice.

Catra's head moved.

Adora could've sworn that *Catra's head had just moved.*

It was barely a twitch, but Adora had seen it. Her heart leapt in her chest. She let out a silent, choked gasp.

But Catra was returning to the stillness again.

"No, no, no!" Adora cried, slapping her other palm against the glass of the pod. "Keep fighting! Don't you…"

"… give up on me! Please, you have to wake up!"

The voice was desperate. The quickened pace of the words, the way it cracked. There was someone out there who needed her to be free.

So, she tried again.

She took a breath, puffed her chest, bunched her hands into fists, then pushed her arms forward.

It hurt.

It hurt *so* much.

Her arms were barely swaying.

Adora nodded frantically, a smile on her face as tears began to well in her eye. Catra was coming back. She had to be coming back. This was it. It had to be.

But for every movement Catra made, it was quickly followed by more stillness. More silence. It was as if it was too painful to move.

Oh, Adora understood it so well.

But she was *so close.*

"Keep going!" Adora almost screamed. "You have to keep pushing! I know it hurts. I know this whole damn world is full of nothing but pain, but there's beauty and love and joy too! There's…"

"… so much to live for!"

Another attempt. She gritted her teeth so hard that they almost shattered. She pushed her entire body forward, her arms

snapping back with the chains. Her wrists felt like they were on fire. Blood began to seep down her arms.

It was too much. She was going to lose her hands. She was going to lose everything.

"I know you can do it!"

She couldn't.

"I'm begging you, come back!"

She *had* to.

"Please!"

"Use your wings…"

"*… AND PUSH!"*

… Wings?

Yes.

That's right.

She had *wings.*

She ceased her efforts for a second. She took a deep breath; watched sweat and saliva drip from her body and onto the gravel floor.

Then, slowly and carefully, those very wings sprouted from her shoulders. They were vulture-like with black feathers, longer than her arms, bony and crooked.

They were *her* wings.

And damn *anyone* who tried to take away her wings.

With newfound strength, she pushed forward one more time. Her wings flapped aggressively, beating at the ground below, begging for her to take to the sky. She tried to keep silent and push all her might into breaking free.

Her arms tensed. Her skin tore away. Her wrists bled profusely, a thin waterfall of red running down the sides of her body, mixing with her sweat.

But she pushed.

And pushed.

And *pushed*.

She *screamed*. She tore her throat, unhinged her jaw, and cried out in agony, desperation, and triumph. Tears, sweat, blood, saliva, all of it ran down her bare body in a display of inhuman strength. Her wings beat violently for a few more seconds as her scream raised in pitch, her lungs being drained completely.

With everything she had, every ounce of strength, every drop of blood still left in her body, she thrusted her arms forward…

and then

the chains

shattered.

Finally, Catra fell forward.

A feeling she hadn’t experienced in so long.

It all came flooding back.

The chains clattered to the floor beside her. It was like a tsunami of information washing over the dry desert of her brain that had forgotten even time itself.

Her name was Catra.

That voice was Adora.

Her name was *Catra.*

That voice was *Adora.*

And she was *begging her to come back.*

She hadn't been chained here for eternity. She'd only been chained here for a day. Ever since she met the Moirai, they stole a copy of her and trapped it here. They must've been trying to strip her memories completely. But the process had been interrupted.

Catra panted, and looked at her wrists. It was only simulated, but the bones and exposed nerves hurt like *hell.*

Catra looked up. The darkness surrounding her melted away, exposing the true prison she had been kept in.

The purple beach. She knelt atop the ocean, endless water around her. It was so warm, yet the salt of the water burnt at her wrists. She hissed, pulled them away quickly.

Everything hurt so much.

But the pain in Adora's voice…

Oh, it was enough to push her to do *anything* to stop it.

Catra looked ahead and saw the beach. The sand. And most of all, a beam of light.

An escape.

She needed to reach that light. Get back into her body.

There was only one problem.

Between Catra and the light were the multi-eyed creatures. The same ones that had murdered Entrapta and Adora in the previous reality.

So, so, *so* many of them. Crawling on all fours, eyes never blinking, waiting to sink their claws into her. They would not let her escape.

Catra didn't care.

Adora needed her back.

And god fucking dammit. *That* was more important than anything.

She needed something to push through them. And as she looked around, she noticed something.

The black vulture wings that sprouted from her shoulders. They shed a few feathers, so old, so threadbare.

Yet as one feather floated by her thigh…

It *cut* her.

Catra blinked.

She curiously reached down towards the feather, and when her hands wrapped around it, she felt how *sharp* it was. Like broken glass.

Despite the decay, the boney nature, her wings were her *weapons.*

She looked back at the creatures before her.

Beyond that light ahead was Adora.

Beyond that light was *life.*

Catra shot a death stare at the creatures before her.

And she *squeezed* the sharpness in her hand, letting warm blood run down the black feather.

These creatures would *not* stop her.

She fucking *refused* to die here.

She had nothing more to lose. But she had *everything* to gain.

She stood up, reaching behind her to yank out another sharp feather from her wings. They beat at the ground to keep her on her feet as she began to storm towards the creatures, blade in each hand.

The creatures began to approach her, and Catra tensed her arms. One pounced for her, and she thrust her right hand forward, burying her feather into its neck. Its blood gushed down her arm, and she tossed the creature aside, limp and dead.

The feather blades were effective.

Another creature approached from her left and she slashed at it, wounding it. She brought her right hand atop its head, stabbing into its eyes and watching them pop.

Another creature approached. She thrust her left blade into its chest and used it as a shield against the creature that slashed at her, making it hit its own kind.

Blood. Blood. Blood.

So much blood.

It coated her arms, her chest, her legs, her face. So, so *warm.*

It was brutal violence, gore, yet Catra embraced it. She did not take pure pleasure from it, but to save her own life and come back to her Angel, she'd do what was *necessary.*

Three creatures approached. Catra swung her whole body, shooting feathers from her wings into them. They all fell.

Nothing could stop her. Not a damn thing.

A trail of blood and bodies followed in Catra's path. Even with her wrists open and exposed, that pain was pushed down by adrenaline. She slashed and stabbed and sliced. She diced and danced and delivered death to these deities. These creatures that always watched her in silence, and took away those who she loved.

Damn them for keeping her from her Adora.

Damn them for thinking they owned her.

And damn them for thinking they could hold her prisoner.

Death first to these *vultures,* these *scavengers.*

After what seemed like hours, yet was likely minutes, the creatures recognised their losing battle. Their numbers dwindled. They were facing a ruthless Ker who *refused* to die.

Catra panted, her eyes flared and wild. Her wings beat a few times as she glared at the cautious creatures around her, as if to intimidate them. She gripped the blades tighter, added to the blood.

They got the message.

And soon, the creatures began to sink into the ocean.

Catra felt her heart race as if anticipating another attack. Yet it never came. She had killed more than enough. She had proven herself to them.

And now she stood before the sand. Before the beach.

Before the light.

She could hear the sounds of sobbing on the other end. Adora's sobbing. And she needed to comfort her.

Adora needed to be held.

To be kissed.

To be told everything would be okay.

And just when Catra was about to give her that…

"MY SISTER, NO!"

Tight arms suddenly wrapped around Catra from behind.

Catra flinched, suddenly held in place. It took her a second to realise what was going on.

"Let. *Go.* Of. Me." Catra growled to the Moirai.

"No!" The Moirai sounded so panicked. "We will *not* let you suffer again, my beautiful sister! There is only pain waiting for you on the other side!"

"Look at my wrists. Look at the bodies behind us. Look at what you *did* to me. How is *that* less painful than what's on the other side?"

"You had to face punishment for your sins, my sister. It was the natural way of things. But after punishment and atonement comes eternal happiness! We were crafting such a beautiful world for you! For all of you Lost Souls! The chains are only a small price to pay!"

Catra was sick of this. She struggled against their embrace. "I said, *let go."*

"We *can't."*

"Why the fuck *not?"*

"We can't let go because *we love you*, my sister. Do you even know what happened on the other side? Why Adora Grayskull grieves so heavily?"

"I…" Catra shut her eyes. Her face scrunched into a pained expression.

"We kept a piece of you here and let the other go free. Do you know what happened to that Catra? The Catra that refused our love and protection?"

"I know…"

"Then speak it, my sister."

"… I died. Didn't I?"

"That Catra did, but not you, my sister. That Catra does not have to be you. You can be *different*," the Moirai's echoing voice was filled with sadness. "That Catra refused our light. She was afraid in the end, and she suffered for it. You will *never* suffer again in the world we have created for you. We have made a true utopia. We *won't* let you enter that world of hurt like she did. If you die… We can't save you."

The Moirai's embrace tightened. Their voice was soothing, despite the panicked undertones. They were so warm. They washed the blood away from Catra's body with the ocean water beneath them.

Catra's body shook. She had died. No doubt in Adora's arms. She had caused her so much agony. So much pain. She'd failed.

Would coming back just ruin her more?

Would it be better for Adora to move on one day?

Would she even move on?

"That world doesn't need you, my sister. The Lost Souls do not need you. They don't need you, and you don't need them." The Moirai sighed sadly. "Embrace us, Catra… We will take you to bliss. Our Adora is waiting for you, and our Adora is so *happy*."

She was stuck between two versions of Adora.

One who sobbed and broke with grief over Catra's body. One who hated herself and wanted to die for a 'good' cause. One who was missing an eye and would never get it back.

And another who would always smile. Who would never hurt. Who would always have Mara and Angella, and never experience the pain of their loss.

Both Adoras would love Catra.

And yet one was fake.

And the other real.

So, Catra slowly turned around. She faced the Moirai, and they wrapped their arms tighter around her shoulders.

"Embrace us, my sister… Embrace us…"

They would give her happiness. They would give Adora happiness. They would take away the pain.

Catra raised her arms…

And suddenly thrust them forward.

The Moirai gasped.

Catra didn't even think it'd work. She didn't think anything would work. It was a last-ditch effort. She didn't think she'd have a

chance of escaping the Moirai's grip.

But slowly…

The Moirai's arms slipped from Catra's shoulders.

Catra stepped back, looked down…

And saw her feathered blades buried deep into the Moirai's chest.

They did not bleed.

But they felt the pain.

"You're wrong." Catra spoke coldly. "I need that world. I need that Adora. But *we* don't need *you."*

The Moirai raised a hand to the blades, croaking and shaking. They were *horrified* to see what Catra had done to them. They remained collapsed on their knees, and Catra stood before them.

"Why…? My sister… *why…?"* The Moirai pleaded. "We… We would've given you… immortal happiness…"

"You were wrong for thinking I'd choose immortality over Adora."

The Moirai's face scrunched into pain.

Perhaps Catra had made a rash decision. After all, this was the AI that supplied her consciousness and gave her life. Destroying them could have untold effects.

But when the Keres faced genocide, the Moirai had chosen to embrace it and only plan for a happy afterlife.

And that was something Catra couldn't accept.

The Moirai shut their eyes, and tears began to well. They didn't fight back. They didn't scream or lash out.

They only wept as their body began to sink into the dark ocean beneath them.

“We… We only wanted… to help you… my sister…”

A pit dug itself into Catra’s stomach. She wasn’t sure if she’d change her decision if she could go back, but she also wasn’t sure if the Moirai deserved to die.

Regardless, they had tried to take her away from Adora.

Away from life.

Catra did what was necessary. But she didn’t know if she did what was right.

Catra sighed, and stepped towards them, placing a hand on their shoulder. “Hey. One day… I’ll see you on the other side, alright? Just not yet. I still have things to do.”

The Moirai stared blankly at the ocean they sunk into. Catra wasn’t sure if they heard her. She was willing to accept their silent death.

But in their last few seconds, the Moirai spoke pained, agonising words.

“No, my sister… You will not see us. There is no other side.”

And as the ocean finally engulfed them, they looked up at Catra.

“This is it.”

And with that, the Moirai sank into the unknown darkness of the ocean.

Whether they were dying or not, Catra didn't know. But they were leaving her for good. They could tell Catra had refused them.

Only their hand remained, reaching up to Catra. For a second, Catra considered leaving it behind and heading towards the light.

But the hand didn’t look threatening. It… trembled. It was scared.

And Catra let her heart get the better of her.

She knelt down, and gently placed her palm against the hand, trying to soothe them as they sunk completely.

But the hand gently gripped Catra, and did something indescribable.

Catra’s eyes widened, her pupils glowing as the hand… *forced* something into her. It transferred something into her body. It wasn’t painful, but it was so much at once. She saw a thousand lifetimes in the blink of an eye.

It was like 12,000 volts had painlessly jolted her entire body, making her hair instantly stand up.

Catra quickly let go of the hand, fell back and watched it sink into the ocean completely. She panted, panicked and confused all at once.

The Moirai had given… *something* to Catra. Forced some sort of information into her body. Maybe all of it.

Her eyes glowed as she tried to process everything that had just happened. New and unexpected information was overloading her systems. It was destroying her.

She shut her eyes, tried to focus on one thing at a time. It was too much. God, it was too much. Her nose was bleeding. Sweat mixed with blood.

Too much.

All this information was too much.

Catra felt her brain being fried like an egg.

Too much.

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"It's okay, Catra…"

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"I'll wait for you. As long as it takes."

Y@u w!l|? ^ou pr#m!se?

"I promise."

Adora's voice broke through the noise in Catra's mind.

Her pupils began to dim from their bright glow. Catra saw clearly once more. Adora's voice had calmed her. Soothed her.

Catra blinked. She processed everything clearly now. All the information the Moirai had given her.

It was… everything they had.

All their power.

All their knowledge.

Catra had all the Moirai's potential now. She could practically *become* them.

Maybe they were intentionally trying to overload her. Try to scramble her systems, destroy her from the inside out, kill their disobedient sibling.

Or maybe they were giving Catra the opportunity to do what they could not.

Because with all this new knowledge, the first thing Catra did…

Was *scoff.*

"Really…?" She shook her head, chuckling. "You could've done this… the whole time…?"

It was all so clear.

It wasn't easy, but… there was a *solution* to all this. The genocide. Everything. There was a solution *right in front of them.*

One that the Moirai would've hated. They had obviously avoided this, intentionally.

But they were gone now.

And nothing could stop Catra from implementing this solution.

She slowly stood up, looked over her shoulder at the light behind her. There were no sobs anymore. Just Adora's gentle breath.

Catra smiled.

"I'll come back soon, Adora. I promise."

She turned back towards the ocean and walked away from the light.

"There's just one last thing I need to do."

Flight

Chapter Summary

Styx City will never be the same.

Chapter Notes

Content Warnings: Vague description of gore of the back near the end of the chapter.

When Adora woke, she was somehow more tired than when she had fallen asleep. But she was awake, and that was all that mattered.

She sat on the ground with her body leaning against something hard and warm. Her cheek stuck against the material, and she had to pull herself away from it. Her eye felt heavy, and tongue felt slimy and unnatural inside her mouth.

She scratched at the mess that was her hair as she looked up, trying to make out whatever it was she slept on.

Oh. Right. Catra's pod.

She was still in there. Eyes closed. Body still.

There had been a few twitches last night, but the more Adora thought about it, the more likely it seemed that it was a hallucination. Her eye playing tricks out of desperation. Nothing more.

Catra was still dead.

And the more time passed, the less likely it seemed that fact would ever change.

But Adora had made a promise. And she intended to keep it.

Adora slowly stood up with a sigh, looking at Catra's body. She so desperately wanted to see her eyes open—see that blue and yellow once more. She'd give anything for it.

"Morning."

A voice sounded behind Adora, jolting her slightly. She recognised who it was instantly, though.

"Morning, Entrapta."

She turned around to face the lilac-haired woman, working at something on her PC. Upon closer inspection, Adora could see her making the finishing touches on her recording, yet there was still no decision on what to do with it.

"Sorry for passing out in your lab…" Adora said.

"Ah, people do that all the time," Entrapta waved a dismissive gesture with her hair. She kept her eyes glued to her screens, but her typing slowed a bit. "Did you… notice anything about Catra last night?"

Adora thought maybe it was best to keep silent. Her mind wasn't in the best state, after all. It could've been just an illusion.

But Entrapta had never judged *anyone* for being crazy.

"I… thought I saw Catra twitching at one point."

Entrapta's typing stopped.

"Just slightly. It was two movements, and then it stopped again. And honestly, it might've just been my brain seeing what it wanted to see, but… God, it has to be *something."*

Entrapta's silence hung for a bit longer, sending a tight feeling into Adora's chest. Did she really sound that crazy? Surely not. Maybe Entrapta was worried, and that *had* to be bad news. Maybe—

"I think it *is* something. I think Catra's trying to fight."

Entrapta turned in her chair to finally face Adora, her eyes wide and buzzing with excitement and curiosity. Adora blinked.

"She might be going through the Disconnection process again," Entrapta theorised. "The breaking of chains, the fight… It can take a while, but that might be the cause of the twitches you saw."

"Does that mean she's… going to come back?" Adora asked, her heart fluttering at the mere thought.

"It's…"

Entrapta desperately wanted to give her hope, but she knew hope couldn't be built on the fragility of a lie. She sighed. "It's unclear. Even if I'm correct, well… The Disconnection process is known for taking away memories. Even if Catra comes back…"

Adora's heart sank into her stomach. Her eye lowered. Entrapta immediately spotted it.

"B-But again, that's just a hypothesis!" She held up her hands. "Catra's going through something no Offline Ker has gone through before. I can't predict *anything.* All I know is that if Catra is given a chance to fight, I *know* she'll take it."

"Yeah…" Adora let out a slight scoff. Entrapta really knew Catra too well. She took a breath, let out a sigh, and finally looked up with a smile. "She doesn't know the meaning of 'giving up without a fight', huh?"

Entrapta nodded.

It was a desperate hope they were both clinging to. Nothing more than just the imaginary belief in an unclear future. They were trying to stay in the sky, and the only grip they had to keep themselves up were the clouds.

But it was something. They needed something.

Adora looked at Catra one last time, and started walking toward the exit. Entrapta raised an eyebrow. “Where are you headed off to?”

“I’m going to see my moms,” Adora replied. “But I’m changing into something that’ll hide my face first. I promise. I just… think they’d be freaking out about me.”

“Please stay safe out there, okay?” Entrapta’s brows narrowed with worry. However, her expression was soon replaced with a warm smile. “Catra needs something to look forward to when she wakes up.”

Adora chuckled, a tired smile on her face. “Yeah.”

She opened the door and was hit with the bright light of New Utopia; she winced slightly as her eye adjusted from the darkness of Entrapta’s lab. She made her way up the steps and toward the cabin Catra had built for her.

Adora kept her head down as she walked. She occasionally passed by Keres, but they knew to give her some space. She appreciated it.

She reached the front door of the cabin and went inside. She looked up to see Melog laying on their bed, and their head perked up at Adora’s presence.

Adora smiled. “Morning, buddy.”

Melog meowed.

Adora headed for the bedroom, removing her shirt and grabbing for a large hoodie. She needed to hide her face from the general public while she was out. After all, she was still seen as a traitor to humanity.

Once she was stripped bare, Adora caught her own reflection in the bedroom mirror. She saw her tired eye, her pale skin.

But more than that, she saw the cybernetics entangled in her back. Wires buried in her skin. The tattoo of Angel wings on her shoulders.

She hadn't used her wings in so long. She didn't know if she ever would again.

She reached over her shoulder and ran her hands over the wires. Cold and hard. She'd gotten so used to the feeling. Yet whenever she tugged at the cybernetics, they sent a spike of pain up her spine.

Adora sighed.

She pulled on her hoodie and put on a pair of jeans along with it. With the hood up, she was mostly hidden as long as nobody was looking at her head-on. Her hair was also concealed.

But there was one more precaution: a metallic face mask. She had something similar in her Angel uniform kit, but Catra owned a less expensive one. The general population was only required to wear it when they were sick.

Adora pressed the mask to the bottom half of her face, and it instantly locked into place, wrapping around her jaw and pressing firm against her skin. Now all anyone could see of her face was her single blue eye.

She looked into the mirror, hidden from the rest of the world.

Adora Grayskull. A criminal. A traitor.

She'd come a long way from an Angel.

Runner propaganda had flooded the city.

Everywhere Adora turned there was another picture of Shadow Weaver or a sign declaring that all Ghosts deserved to die. With the Runner leader and Herod Umbra dead within such a short

span of time, hatred had grown immensely not just for the Ghosts, but for all Keres. There were even movies being advertised about the difficult lives of the Runners, or TV shows about Ghosts turning ‘good’ in the end.

But Adora heard the chatter of the public, the whispers as she passed by. More and more people were believing in Angella’s words, believing that the Keres deserved to live. It was a losing battle, but one that the people seemed willing to fight.

The trajectory of the next few days remained unclear. Adora knew there was barely a semblance of a plan for the Offline Keres. Their genocide would come to light sooner or later, but what could even be done at this point?

Adora sighed. She turned away from the holographic billboards and towards her destination.

Her moms’ home, just at the corner of the street.

It was modest, three storeys tall and skinny, squeezed in between two other buildings. But it was Adora’s home. It was where she grew up. Everything about this street was familiar.

There were only a few other people on the street, but Adora kept her disguise nonetheless. The fog of her breath came out through her metal mask, and only a few strands of her golden hair were visible outside of her drawn hoodie. She couldn’t take any chances. She knew firsthand that this city had eyes.

She walked up the small steps to her home, making sure she was completely facing the front door before she tapped the side of her face mask. It slid open to reveal her mouth and chin, the metal clinging to the side of her face and around her ears now.

Adora sighed. This wasn’t going to be easy.

She held up a hand, and knocked at the front door a few times.

Footsteps instantly echoed throughout the small home. Adora kept her eye downcast, almost out of shame. Would they be mad with her? Probably not. Even still, the guilt clung to Adora's heart.

The door opened and she heard the familiar voice of Isabel. "For the last *fucking* time, we don't know *anything* about where Adora is, so…"

It was an instinctual response. Isabel's voice grew silent once she looked down and saw her daughter.

"…Oh my god."

Adora took a deep breath, looked up, and saw the familiar blue eyes and red hair of her mom. She tried her best to smile.

"Hey, mom."

Isabel's eyes were wide, her jaw slack as she looked at her daughter for a few seconds. Her hands shook, and her lips trembled.

Adora opened her mouth to say something else, but it was cut off when Isabel rushed forward and wrapped her arms around Adora so tight it almost crushed her lungs.

"Adora…!" Isabel gasped, taking a choked breath. "Fuck… Adora… Adora, it's you…!"

"Babe, who is it?" Another voice sounded as Rebecca climbed down the steps.

As soon as she spotted her daughter, however, she froze, not quite believing it.

But then, her walking picked up into a near sprint.

Adora felt Rebecca crash into her, another pair of tight arms wrapped around her and held her close. Adora tried her best to

return their hugs as she heard their choked gasps and pants of pure, utter *relief.*

"You're okay…" Rebecca choked. She tightened the hug. "You're really okay…"

"We were so scared…" Isabel wasn't afraid to let out a sob.

Adora hated how *sad* they sounded. How *scared* they were. They had spent too long in pure hell, all because of her. They were in pain, and it was all her fault.

It was enough to spark tears in Adora's eye as she buried her face in their shoulders.

"I'm sorry…" Adora choked slightly. "I'm so sorry…"

"Don't you *dare* apologise," Isabel instantly shook her head. "We're just glad you're here. That's all that matters."

"We just…" Rebecca let out a quick sigh. "What *happened?* Where were you? We kept calling and calling… People kept coming to our door…"

"It's a lot…" Adora whimpered. "Just… Just so much…"

They all finally separated, and Rebecca cupped her daughter's face in her hand to inspect Adora's tears. She wiped them away with her thumb, her eyebrows narrowing out of worry.

"Come on, you should come inside," Rebecca offered.

"I can't…" Adora shook her head, sniffling. "I can't put you two in danger. I've already put you through enough…"

"Don't say that," Isabel shook her head. "We'd fight the whole fucking world for you, Adora. We don't care what they're saying out there. You're *not* a 'traitor'."

"You saved a life. You *love* someone. How could they possibly make you a criminal for that?" Rebecca fumed. "You did *nothing* wrong. Just… What happened at the hospital? Why were you gone?"

Adora knew it'd scare the hell out of them to hear the full story. God knew they had been through enough. But god knew they needed the truth, too.

"I…" Adora sighed. She closed her eye. "A Runner was… about to kill me."

"WHAT?!" Isabel immediately sputtered out.

"No…" Rebecca gasped as Isabel took a step back, her jaw shuddering.

"But Catra stopped them," Adora continued. "She got me out of there and took me somewhere safe."

"Those bastards…" Isabel's eyebrows flared, her mind still on the Runners. "Those *fucking BASTARDS!* They can't fucking do that!"

"Mom, it's fine. I'm still here—"

"It's not *fine,* Adora! I…" Isabel ran a hand through her own hair and gripped it tight. "*Christ!* They just can't do that!"

"Mom…"

"No, Adora, you *need* to understand this." Isabel took a step towards her daughter, her shaking hand held out before her. "They *literally* can't do that!"

"That's just how the Runners are, mom. I'm a sympathiser, I should've expected it. I—"

"Adora, *listen to me."*

Isabel leaned forward.

"*Nowhere* in the law does it state that Runners have the right to murder Ghost sympathisers."

"W… What…?" Adora's mouth fell open. "But… That… They've *always* done that."

"And laws rarely apply to Runners," Rebecca spoke up, backing her wife. "But there has never been anything giving them permission to kill Ghost sympathisers. Your life should've *never* been in danger. It *still* shouldn't be."

Adora blinked.

She had been in the Guardians for so long. She never agreed with the Runners killing Ghost sympathisers, but she had accepted it as the norm.

"Fuck…" Isabel let out a shuddered sigh. "I bet they tried to make it look like an accident, too."

"Y-Yeah…" Adora hesitantly nodded, before her eyes widened. "They… They *did.* They killed the Angel that was trying to care for me. They were going to make it look like *she* killed me before turning the gun on herself."

"Runners can kill low-profile sympathisers all the time. They get some backlash, but little else." Rebecca sighed. "But people *know* you, Adora. If a Runner killed you, it'd spark a riot. So they… They tried to make it look like something else. But they *never* had the right to do that."

"None of us are safe until those *fucking bastards* are gone for good," Isabel growled under her breath.

"I…" Adora tried to find words, any words, that might help Isabel. But there were none to find. There was *nothing.* "God… At least

Catra stopped it before it happened…”

“Catra…” Rebecca’s eyes shut tight with relief. “Thank you…”

“Where is Catra?” Isabel asked. “We owe her so much. Where is…?”

Isabel stopped.

She stopped as soon as she saw that familiar sight, one she could recognise instantly.

Her daughter in pain.

Adora’s eye lowering and her jaw clenching.

Rebecca recognised it, too.

And it didn’t take them long to piece it all together.

“Oh, Adora…”

Rebecca wrapped her arms around her daughter and held her tight. Adora was quick to return the hug, burying her face into the crook of her mother’s neck.

Adora tried so hard to hold it together. She tried so hard to keep a good front for her moms.

But all it took was the mere mention of Catra for her to *break.*

“She…” Adora sniffled. “She was the Ghost I loved… *Love…* And they… they shot her… She didn’t do anything *wrong…* She was just trying to live…”

“God…” Isabel joined the hug once more. “I’m so sorry, Adora…”

“She’s not fully dead, but… I don’t know if she’s coming back…” Adora was tearing at the seams. “And if she goes… if I never see her again… I don’t know what I’m going to do… It hurts so *much…”*

“She loves you, Adora,” Rebecca soothingly spoke. “We could tell from the moment we saw her. And if she comes back, we’ll welcome her with open arms. I just…” She sighed, and whispered. “I’m sorry, Adora… That’s so *horrible* what they did to her…”

“I tried to save her…” Adora let out a choked sob. “I tried to save her like I tried to save Angella and Mara… Like how you two always saved people… and I keep *failing*… I keep screwing it up… I keep letting people die… It’s all my *fault…”*

“Don’t say that…” Isabel placed a kiss atop Adora’s head, ran her fingers through her hair.

“I’m sorry you raised me…” Adora continued through a hoarse voice. “I’m sorry I keep letting you down…”

“Shh, stop, stop…” Rebecca hushed her, rocking Adora slightly in her arms.

“I’m sorry…” Adora shook relentlessly with cries.

“You’ve done nothing wrong,” Isabel spoke firmly, yet with a comforting tone. “We’re so *proud* of you, Adora. You didn’t let Catra being a Ghost stop you. You’re so full of *love* and *kindness*. You gave everything up to tell the whole world that the Ghosts were just like us. That loving a Ghost is *okay.* You’re *incredible.* We’re so lucky to have an amazing daughter like you.”

“We couldn’t have asked for anyone better…” Rebecca ran her fingers through Adora’s hair. “And we’re so, so sorry this world has been so cruel to you… We’re sorry we couldn’t protect you… Catra didn’t deserve that. Neither of you deserve this pain…”

Adora couldn’t speak. She just couldn’t. The pain was gripping her throat, squeezing it so tight that it choked her. It hurt to cry this much, but it was a release*.*

Finally, she could break. She could let it all out into the arms of comfort.

She *needed* those words. She *needed* all of this. She had bottled it up, kept it held in for too long, only allowing herself to let parts of this agony slip.

But she needed help.

Adora needed help.

And in the arms of her moms, she was finally able to receive that.

It didn't fix anything. Nothing could really fix all this.

But Adora didn't need a fix right now.

She just needed to let it out.

She needed to break before she could begin to build herself again.

The path below Adora changed from the usual concrete to what little grass remained in Styx City.

After some food and more comfort, Adora had to leave her moms behind. They were hesitant to let Adora go out alone, but Adora promised them her safety and daily visits for as long as she could.

She also told them about New Utopia, the safe haven she was in. It put their minds at ease.

It was hard to predict anything nowadays. But seeing the smiles on her moms' faces was enough to convince Adora that things were going to be okay for a little while.

But she couldn't go back to New Utopia. Not yet. She had one more stop to make.

Adora walked through the grass. Seven rows up. She knew the exact location. She had it memorised.

Thirteen from the right.

She had replaced her face mask, and her hoodie was drawn over her head once more. This space was relatively empty for now, but Adora knew she needed to keep her head down as long as she could.

After a few more paces, she stopped.

She turned to face the cobblestone.

And she spoke.

"Hey, Mara. Been a while."

Adora looked up to see Mara's grave.

All around Adora were different types of graves. Some holographic, some made of hardened material. They'd chosen cobblestone for Mara's. She always found holographic graves a bit *too* creepy.

Adora sighed. "Sorry I haven't visited in a while. Things have been… pretty hectic."

There was no response, though Adora could almost imagine it.

"I met Catra. You might know her. Bartender from that place you used to frequent." Adora smiled, though the mask hid it. "We hit it off pretty well. Ups and downs, but… We made it work as best we could. As best we *can*," she quickly corrected herself. "She's in a… tough spot right now. But I think I'll see her soon. Maybe I'll bring her here."

Adora looked up. The city surrounded them, but for a small portion of it, there was grass. Dirt where bodies could be laid to rest. It was a small patch of green among so much gray.

"I, uh…" Adora swallowed a lump in her throat. "I… assume you've seen Angella. Wherever you are."

A knife of guilt stabbed into Adora's gut. Her instinct was to apologise, to take the burden of blame once more. It was all the voice in her head had been telling her.

Angella's death is your fault.

Angella's death is your fault.

Angella's death is your fault.

But for the first time…

Adora held that voice back.

"Tell her…" Adora sighed. "Tell her I'm not going to let her last words go to waste. I'm going to keep fighting for the Ghosts. She was brave. So were you. You both… inspire me so much. And I'm going to try to carry that forward."

A slight gust of wind blew by Adora's face. She held onto her hoodie, looked in the direction of the wind, and saw…

A grave.

No, not just that.

A small statue...

Of Angella.

And someone standing before it.

Adora blinked as she looked at the new grave. The statue was so clean. Angella looked up to the sky, her palms pressed together with an expression of determination and hope on her face. Her holographic wings spread from the concrete statue; no doubt her actual cybernetics.

Adora sadly smiled. She looked back at Mara. "Want me to tell her directly, huh?"

Silence, once more.

But Adora knew.

“Alright,” Adora nodded. “Thank you… Thank you for everything. I love you, Mara. And I’ll never stop fighting for you. For us.”

Adora hung on those words for a few seconds. She would’ve given anything for a response. But she had to make do with the silence.

With a shortness of breath, Adora moved towards Angella’s grave, and the person who stood before it.

She was shorter than Adora, with glowing cybernetic hair that almost sparkled. She barely seemed to acknowledge Adora’s presence at first, her eyes cast down in mourning.

But upon closer inspection, Adora… recognised her.

Oh.

It was Glimmer.

Adora remembered her from Umbra’s rally, the daughter who Angella had screamed for the Runners to let go of.

Adora had never met her in-person, but she vividly remembered that day.

She didn’t speak up yet. Glimmer looked like she was taking a moment.

Adora looked up at the statue. Flashes of the last time she saw Angella ripped through her mind, but she did not flinch. Nowadays, it was a familiar sight in her nightmares.

They must’ve already had her funeral service. Adora had missed it. It left a slight twinge of guilt in her gut.

“You knew her?” Glimmer asked, finally noticing her.

Adora looked down at her. Her eyes hadn't left the ground just yet, but she was still listening. No one was around them.

"Yeah…" Adora nodded. "I was one of her Angels. I…"

Adora looked around. No one to spot them. This should be safe enough.

She brought a hand up and removed her metallic face mask, before looking back at Glimmer.

"I've been meaning to visit for a while."

Glimmer looked back up, and her eyes instantly widened. "Adora…?"

"Hey, Glimmer," Adora sadly smiled. "It's good to finally meet you. Even if I wish the circumstances were different."

Glimmer blinked, not quite believing her eyes at first. Apart from the rally, Glimmer had only seen this face under 'Wanted' billboards. She was standing next to a *criminal.*

"I…" Glimmer tried to collect herself. "Where the hell have you *been?* I was going to visit you in the hospital but there were Knights *everywhere.* Apparently you'd been… kidnapped…?"

Adora scoffed. "Not quite. My, uh… My girlfriend got me out of that hospital. She saved my life."

It took Adora a second to realise that, for the first time, she had called Catra her girlfriend.

Something she was never able to do when Catra was still alive.

She intended to fix that if Catra came back. *When* Catra came back.

"Your girlfriend… Was that the Ghost mom mentioned…?"

"Yeah. Catra. The Ghost I love," Adora smiled. "She… She stopped a Runner who was trying to… Well. You know."

"Fuck…" Glimmer gritted her teeth, her face shook with rage as she looked back to her mom. "God*dammit…* They were trying to kill you too…" Then, Glimmer blinked. "Hey, did… Did you say Catra?"

"Yeah," Adora nodded.

"I… I actually know her," Glimmer said, looking back up at Adora. "I know Catra. She comforted me after mom died. She… told me that the Ghosts would fight for her."

"You did?" Adora blinked with surprise, but her face soon softened into a sympathetic smile. "Guess you know how great she is, huh?"

"She helped. A *lot.* I've been meaning to talk to her again." Glimmer smiled. "Speaking of… Where is she?"

Adora's smile faded.

Glimmer took a few seconds to just look at her expression. Look at the way her shoulders dropped. Look at the way her lips slightly shook.

Then it hit her all at once.

"No…" Glimmer shook her head, as her own smile also faded into horror. "They… They *didn't.* I never got a chance to properly thank her, tell me they fucking *didn't.* Tell me she's still alive. *Please.*"

"She…" Adora sighed. "She's not fully dead. But she was shot by Shadow Weaver. She… 'died'. But there's some strange circumstances, a potential quirk of Offline Keres. She might come back. She might not. I… I don't know which is more likely, and that terrifies me. It's like I'm stuck between bargaining and depression… And I'm scared to let go of bargaining."

“Fuck…” Glimmer shut her eyes. She didn’t completely fall into despair, but for a second, her toes were teetering over the edge of that cliff. “I hope she’ll come back. I really do.”

“So do I…”

Adora looked up at Angella once more. That statue that never moved, doomed to remain still for eternity. She would never blink, never smile, never love her family again.

But her influence would always remain.

“Your mom meant a lot to me,” Adora said as she looked up to her. “She… She talked a lot about you.”

Glimmer looked up along with Adora. Her jaw tensed with tightened grief. “Really…?”

“Yeah. Especially before that Umbra rally. She talked about how brave you are. How much you inspire her. She loved you so much, Glimmer. I’m sure you already knew that, but… I thought you should know.”

Glimmer tensed her lips, closing her eyes as her brows narrowed with regret. “The stupidest thing is that I spent so much of my life *questioning* if she loved me or not.”

“I…” Adora didn’t know what to say. “I’m sorry.”

“… But now I know.”

Adora turned to face Glimmer.

“I’ve spent the last few days wondering if I let her down. Wondering if I was ever good enough for her. But…” Glimmer looked at Adora, and smiled. “If what you said is true, then now I have my answer. I… Thank you.”

Adora was shocked at first, shocked that she could even help Glimmer in the first place, let alone *this* much. She thought herself

useless for so long, but to see Glimmer's *real* smile…

It was enough to infect Adora with a genuine smile of her own.

But as Adora looked in Glimmer's direction, she noticed something just out of the corner of her eye.

A mass of people on the corner of a nearby street.

The gathering was unnaturally large, almost enough to block ground traffic.

Glimmer noticed Adora's stare and turned to see the gathering for herself. Both women narrowed their brows in concern and confusion, but it was Adora who moved first, stepping away from the graveyard and toward the group.

Adora walked alongside a few others, stray visitors to the graveyard who had also noticed the anomalous gathering.The sea of people all seemed to be staring up at the buildings around them, and as Adora got closer, she soon realised why.

All of the holographic billboards were glitching.

Every single one.

They all displayed random numbers and symbols, with static sounding across the entire city. Cars stopped and drivers emerged to see what the hell was going on.

Adora buried herself in the crowd as she examined the glitching billboards. The static and nonsense pattern lasted for about forty more seconds, before the holograms finally displayed a recognizable image.

A single pair of eyes.

All billboards, all signs, all screens in Styx City displayed a pair of eyes.

Blue and yellow eyes.

There was nothing else. No face. No background. Nothing but the blue and yellow eyes.

And Adora's heart *leapt.*

"Catra…?"

Soon, a voice echoed across the entire city. It was distorted, barely human, clearly edited, but there was a tone in it that was *instantly* recognisable to Adora.

"This is a message, not just to all of my fellow Ghosts, but to everyone in Styx City."

Entrapta froze along with the other Ghosts in New Utopia.

They all stared up at the screen that was earlier displaying the news, but now displaying a familiar pair of eyes and projecting a distorted voice.

"This is not the Moirai. This is a Ghost, one you thought dead. I have taken the Moirai's powers, their knowledge, and I have done what they could not do."

Untold amounts of energy flowed through Catra's body.

She floated above the purple beach, surrounded by what appeared to be a glass dome. Holographic wires connected to every point on her body, and she could finally see all of Styx City

at once. She'd managed to streamline the information into something manageable, ensuring that it wasn't too disorienting.

She could flick through the feeds of screens and billboards like security cameras. Hacking into all of them wasn't a challenge with the Moirai's power and knowledge. She'd even managed to distort her voice and zoom a camera in on just her eyes.

No one would be able to identify her except the ones she *wanted* to know.

But all of that was child's play compared to *what she had just done.*

"We are in the process of a genocide. Two months ago, Nyx Industries silently cancelled production of all Keres models."

The shock that emanated throughout the city almost vibrated in Adora's chest, but she still couldn't get over seeing Catra's eyes.

"Any Ker who has died in that time… They can't come back. Along with the Runners executing us, we have been experiencing the end of all Keres for months, and they thought they could get away with it."

The horror on so many faces was enough to send chills down Adora's spine. The truth was finally out there.

"This isn't just a case of Ghosts dying. This concerns all Keres. All people. They tried to take everything from us, behind our backs. What makes you think they'd stop with the Keres? They think they have all the power in the world. They think we'll just let them do this."

A breath.

"But we won't. And the first step has already been taken."

Entrapta stepped closer to the screen. The blue and yellow eyes were shut for some time as Catra prepared the announcement of a lifetime. She could tell something was coming.

But no one was prepared for what Catra said next.

"I have used the Moirai's power… to Disconnect all Keres."

Catra could see the ripple of shock throughout all of Styx City.

The widened eyes. Jaws unhinged. Gasps. Disbelief.

She continued.

"This process has often been linked with memory loss… But with the knowledge I've gained, I've made sure to keep everything intact. All Keres are now free. We cannot be tracked. We cannot be told what to do. We cannot be silenced. You have no power over us anymore."

"But that's not all."

Adora couldn't believe it. She couldn't believe what Catra had done. Catra, who she thought dead this whole time, was secretly *changing the fucking world.*

"I have granted all of us new knowledge. The knowledge to continue our people. The knowledge to prevent this genocide. All Keres now have the knowledge and ability to produce their own. To create a new body. And instead of this new body being given pieces of the Moirai, they will be granted pieces of their creators."

Entrapta's face lit up along with all the Ghosts.

It was a silent process, but within their minds, they felt a slight buzzing. The process of being given this new piece of information. How long had it been withheld from them? How long did the Moirai intend to keep this?

"We can continue. We can fight."

Catra finished the upload of the new information. Through the Moirai's power, she uploaded to the Online Keres. Through her own memories and Entrapta's power and tech, she uploaded to the Offline Keres.

They could create more of their own. They no longer relied on Nyx for anything.

"We don't need Nyx Industries. We don't need the Runners. They are filled with hatred, filled with disgust at anyone they cannot control. They think they're powerful, but they aren't! Because I know…"

"I know there's power, real power, in love, joy, and friendship! It's our greatest strength! We have real power through our bonds, our lives! We have known hell! We have known more pain than they could ever experience! But we grow stronger, not because of that pain, but in spite of it!"

Catra was really rallying now. And it was working. Adora could see the inspired and attentive faces among the crowd.

And she was one of them.

She beamed a wide smile and looked up to Catra's eyes.

"We are stronger than they ever could've imagined! Now is the time to fight! For our future, for our people, for our freedom! Because we deserve to be happy! We deserve to love! We deserve to LIVE!"

Of course, among all the shock, Adora could see the scepticism. The raised eyebrows. The scoffs. The 'that can't be real'. The 'this is just propaganda'.

They needed…

Evidence.

Evidence.

Entrapta had evidence.

"Now I know to some of you, this sounds improbable. But I've granted access to all the screens in Styx City to a friend of mine. She has evidence of what Nyx and the Runners were trying to do. Shadow Weaver confirmed everything. Let their evil be the push we need to finally take them down for good."

It took a few seconds for everything to hit Entrapta. All the blows that came from all these changes, the realisations that nothing would be the same.

Then, suddenly, she sprang up.

She needed to upload that recording.

She sprinted towards her lab, smashing open the doors and almost throwing herself down the stairs. Her computers were still accessible, and the phone was hooked up to it. She just needed to upload it.

Catra was still in the pod. Her body still wasn't moving.

But she was out there. And no doubt she'd return soon.

Entrapta began to type at the keyboards before her, ready to upload the recording that would change the world.

"Now… I have to return. I will leave these words to echo through history. Let this be the day we finally rise up and overthrow this system. Make the Awakening protests be nothing *compared to what comes next. They thought they could kill all of us. Let them know that they never had a chance."*

Cheers emanated through so many people, and Adora joined them. She had tears welling in the corner of her eye as she roared with triumph, not just at this world-changing event, but at the mere fact that Catra was still here.

And soon…

Catra's eyes looked down.

Right at her.

And Adora froze.

Catra finally found her.

Among all the feeds, among everything, she could spot Adora in any crowd. It had been days, but she finally found her. Soon she'd be in her arms. Soon they'd change the world together.

Before disconnecting from the dome, Catra spoke her final words.

"And to my Angel… This can be the end of our world. And the start of a new one. I can't wait to watch it with you."

And after saying that, after fighting for that power, after all Catra had gone through…

Seeing Adora's teary smile was worth *everything.*

It was meant to be a last note. Something to give Adora hope before she finally returned to her arms. Catra didn't need these powers anymore.

That *was* her plan… and it was derailed when she saw a new and terrifying expression on Adora's face.

Adora hadn't felt this happy in so, so long. And soon, she'd finally have Catra back in her life. Soon, things would change for the better.

She planned to run back to New Utopia. She had turned and gone to push through the crowd, the mass of people. She could return in time to see Catra wake up.

Then in the next second, all she knew was pain.

It was like a million daggers had been stabbed into her back, lodging themselves into her spine and in-between the discs. Not only that, but each dagger had been heated to a thousand degrees, all searing her skin.

Adora *screamed,* collapsing to the ground as her legs gave way. Her entire body jolted, burned, seared, ached, twitched. She let out raw cries of pain from her lungs, burning at her throat.

She had no idea what happened, but it was the most physically painful experience of her entire life.

"ADORA!"

Catra called out. Her feed had been cut off, but the last thing she saw was burned into her mind.

Runners had arrived at the scene to control it.

And they had spotted Adora.

Instead of executing her, however, they did something else. One of them had some form of remote, and they aimed it at her.

It had electrocuted Adora through the cybernetics on her back.

Her wings glitched and spasmed behind her as the wires embedded in her back jolted her continuously.

Catra heard her scream. Then there was silence.

"No, no, no, no, no…"

She had come so far. They were going to kill Adora. Slowly.

She switched to another feed and saw what was happening. Jammers had been launched throughout the city, cutting off all communications and screens. Catra had managed to hold them off for some time, but they pushed through at the last second.

And that meant Entrapta didn't have access anymore.

Without the upload of evidence, it wouldn't be hard for Nyx and the Runners to deny Catra's words. It wouldn't be hard for people to believe them. All of this would be for nothing.

So, with the last of her power, Catra sent a message to Entrapta. She still had direct access to her computer. She could only hope it went through.

And then, Catra did what she needed to do.

She stopped her floating, planted her feet against the bottom of the glass dome she was inside of. She had locked herself in to use the full extent of her powers and to prevent any of the creatures from getting in, should the Moirai somehow change their mind.

But now she needed to get out.

The door of light was right before her. The door to the real world.

She took a step back…

Then began to throw her full bodyweight into the glass.

"No, no… Not this time, *not this time…"*

Entrapta frantically sorted through the jamming technology. The upload was 98% complete, but the jammers had stopped it entirely. Every screen in Styx City was glitching, static.

The last time her upload had been jammed, a weapon had been sounded that nearly killed Catra and Adora.

The Runners didn't have the upper hand this time, but they were going to do anything to seize it. They had prepared for a scenario like this.

Entrapta's heart rate was at its limit. They were *so close* to changing everything, this evidence was what they needed. The whole world needed to see it.

But soon, a message popped up on all of Entrapta's screens.

A cryptic message, but one she understood instantly. It was a map of Styx City, with one red dot close to New Utopia.

The dot marked a rooftop. And that rooftop…

"A jammer…"

If she could destroy this one jammer, it would finish Entrapta's upload and project the evidence across a large portion of Styx City.

Who sent her this?

Entrapta quickly turned around to face Catra's body. With all the power she had, she must've known the location of every jammer Nyx had set up.

It had to have been her.

"Catra…"

Entrapta's lips tensed. She took a deep breath. She needed to do one thing.

Find that jammer, and destroy it. The upload would be finished automatically once that was done.

Entrapta pushed herself away from her chair, sprinted away from her lab, and headed for the elevator. The rooftop would be the safest place to move right now.

Move.

She needed to move.

This was it.

She needed to do it right this time.

Stares.

Stares.

Stares.

After everything, all Adora saw was stares.

She was in unimaginable pain. Her lungs dried up from her screaming, her voice ripped at her throat like shards of glass.

“Back! Stay the fuck back!” Shouted a Runner, pointing their rifle at the crowd surrounding them. Two of them pushed through the sea of people and towards Adora, both of them armed, with more just behind them.

One of the Runners knelt down, gripping Adora by the head and pulling her up. They removed her hood, and looked her in the eye as she grunted and seethed in pain.

“This is the one,” the Runner confirmed to their partner, who was still holding the crowd at bay. “She’s probably behind this. Should we bring her in?”

“Execute her. She’s a sympathiser. They need to know what happens when you try to side with Ghosts,” the other Runner instructed.

Adora didn’t even have time to process any of it. She was barely clinging onto consciousness. She could only just hear the Runners over her own grunts and cries of agony.

“Understood,” the Runner nodded, dropping Adora’s head onto the concrete. “Looks like you miscalculated, Angel Grayskull.”

Adora couldn’t respond. She couldn’t speak. Even as the Runner raised their rifle towards her head and the crowd became louder and angrier, all she could do was scream and writhe.

Not like this.

But just before the trigger could be pulled…

The Runner was tackled to the ground.

Adora could only catch a glimpse of who it was, but a glimpse was all she needed. The glowing hair, the cry of rage…

“Glimmer…!” Adora managed to choke out. The shocking had stopped, just briefly.

Glimmer was pinning the Runner to the ground by the rifle, trying to snatch it off him. She struggled, almost winning, and some of the crowd grew in confidence, getting closer to taking them down.

Then, Adora heard the familiar sound of gunfire.

The crowd screamed, and she caught a glimpse of the Runner’s partner with their rifle aimed at the sky.

Warning shots.

They grabbed Glimmer by the hair and yanked her back, slamming her into the pavement. She was close to winning the struggle, but there wasn't enough time.

And with the pinned Runner now free, he quickly snatched up the remote and resumed the signal.

Adora had a split-second to hear the high-pitched whirring of her cybernetics.

Then the pain shocked into her all over again, and the screams returned.

"Shoot her! Shoot them both!" The Runner with the remote commanded.

"*FUCK YOU BOTH!"* Glimmer screamed, leaping at them again before the other Runner pointed the rifle at her.

Finger on the trigger.

Ready to put Glimmer down.

Adora saw flashes of Angella.

Flashes of the wreckage.

Flashes of Mara.

Not again.

She couldn't let anyone else die.

And if she wanted to save everyone…

She needed to save *herself.*

She could barely move, with the electricity in her back. She needed to break free. She needed to stand up and show the world the Runners aren't invincible.

So, screaming all the while…

Adora gripped the cybernetics in her back and began to *pull.*

Entrapta reached the rooftop and saw the huge amount of people crowded on the streets below. People who needed to see the truth.

She had memorised the location of the jammer, just a few blocks away. And there was only one way to get to it from here.

She looked to her left. To the series of buildings beside the one she was standing on. She could see it just a few buildings away, the floating satellite. The jammer she needed to break.

She took a few steps back, bounced on the heels of her feet for a few seconds…

Then Entrapta sprinted for the edge of the building and leapt for the next one.

Her legs felt weightless, tingles throughout them as she jumped. She reached for the edge of the next building, but even halfway through the jump…

She knew her hands weren't going to make it.

She saw herself dip too low. She would crash down into the alleyway. Her body would be broken beyond repair.

That is, if she didn't have cybernetic hair.

It gripped onto the ledge as she let out a cry, keeping her up. It ripped at her scalp and dug a pain like needles into her skull, but she was *alive.*

Her hair pulled her up, and she managed to step onto the next building.

No time to waste. Onto the next one.

She jumped. And jumped. And jumped. Rooftop to rooftop. Building to building.

Some jumps were easy. Others were lucky. Her heart was going to spill out of her mouth at this rate. Her chest felt cold, heavy. She was exhausted. Tired.

She needed to keep going.

She made the final leap, and crashed into the ledge of the final building. She was thankful there were no Runners near the jammer. They would likely organise that soon, and she needed to break it before they could get there.

She pulled herself up and ran over to the jammer, kneeling by the control panel. It was sealed shut, of course, but she always had tools on hand. A small laser-cutter to break through the seal was all she needed, and it gave way to a bundle of wires and motherboards.

She tried to apply the laser-cutter to that, but it sparked back at her. The material was resistant. She needed to do this the old-fashioned way.

She reached in and gripped the wires.

Immediately, a jolt was sent through her body. It was electrified, and she yelped. She didn't have time for this.

Entrapta gritted her teeth, gripped the wires one more time, and began to pull at them, even as they shocked her.

The glass was just beginning to crack.

Catra threw her body at it over and over again, and results were finally beginning to show. She threw herself again, and the crack spread even further.

It was breaking.

She was almost free.

Once the glass was broken, she'd be thrown back into her body. She'd come back, and be the last of the Keres to return from the dead.

Did she have the right? Was it fair?

She couldn't answer. Not now.

She had someone she needed to save.

She threw her body against the glass one last time and began to push, the cracks spreading farther than ever.

Adora screamed as she ripped the cybernetics from her back.

This was it.

Entrapta screamed as she pulled at the wires in the jammer.

One last push.

Catra screamed as she pushed against the glass.

And with that…

Freedom.

Entrapta fell back with the wires in hand as she finally yanked them free, the jammer smoking as it imploded.

Just as quickly, every screen in the vicinity lit up once more, the static finally breaking.

Entrapta watched as the upload was completed, and the screens projected the booming voice of Shadow Weaver.

"So the Moirai is willing to leak our plans… Perhaps we should've removed them first."

Catra looked at the shards of glass surrounding her as she collapsed onto her hands and knees. She panted, blood leaking from the cuts in her palms and legs, but they were of no concern.

She looked up, not to see a purple beach…

But to see a lab.

Entrapta's lab.

Catra had come back.

She breathed in familiar air. She raised herself to her knees, and looked around the lab. She could feel her heartbeat once more.

She was back.

And she already needed to run.

She scrambled to her feet, almost immediately falling over. She gripped Entrapta's chair for balance, regaining feeling in her legs.

She shook her head. "I'm coming, Adora… Just hang on…"

She pushed herself further, and out of New Utopia. Whatever shock and awe the Ghosts were experiencing would need to wait. She barely acknowledged anything except the way forward.

"Why do you continue to fight, then? You know you can't reproduce. You know that without Nyx Industries making new

models, you have no future. Why do you keep going? Surely you understand how pointless this is."

"What the fuck…"

The Runner with the remote looked around as his former leader's voice boomed from every speaker. Every person in the crowd heard the same thing.

"You cannot reverse this. Your efforts are futile."

The Runner with the rifle aimed at Glimmer hesitated. They could see the crowd change from nervous anger to pure *rage.* The truth was fully revealed, with nothing to stop it.

But the Runner with the rifle also hesitated for one other reason.

They had spotted Adora.

With bloody cybernetic wires *in her hands.*

She slowly got to her feet, panting through clenched teeth. Her back oozed copious amounts of blood, the same blood that dripped from the wires.

He tried to electrocute her again, but couldn't. He had no power over her.

The crowd saw it, too. Adora breaking free. She shot a death stare at the Runners before them, groaning in pain.

Then, Adora hissed two words at the Runners.

"You… You *miscalculated."*

The Runner's body language shifted. What was once aggressive force and attempts to take control was now shaking fear. They had lost control. The crowd was getting louder.

Adora watched as Glimmer stood up, looking at her with wide eyes. Truthfully, with the amount of blood Adora was losing, her consciousness would fade soon. Likely along with her life.

But she was free.

"Back up! There's no need for this!" One Runner shouted as they aimed at the crowd around them.

They were scared.

They no longer had the upper hand. They had nothing.

Glimmer looked at Adora.

Adora looked at Glimmer.

And the former Angel nodded.

Glimmer turned to the Runners, and she made the first move.

Before they could react, she tackled one of them. She shoved him to the ground, and this time, he almost lost grip of his weapon.

His partner tried to back him up, tried to shoot Glimmer.

But the massed entity finally broke.

The crowd descended on the Runners, and Adora didn't see what happened next. But there was no doubt in her mind those two Runners wouldn't make it out. And if they did, there would be scars.

They would be an example.

She could see in the crowd that there was a mixture of humans and Keres. Some Keres who revealed their true eye colour. She even recognised some Ghosts from New Utopia, who had emerged to fight.

More Runners would be on the way, but there were so much more of the Keres than there were of them. If this kept up, the Runners wouldn't have a chance.

Adora spotted Glimmer making it out of the crowd too, unscathed. She rallied everyone around her to fight back, and they followed her.

Change.

True change.

Power had finally shifted.

Nothing would ever be the same.

It was all Adora needed to see.

So, finally, she gave her consciousness away.

She felt herself fall back, and soon, a pair of arms embraced her from behind.

"I've got you, Adora… I've got you…"

A voice…

So… Familiar…

Adora felt herself being carried away.

And she finally sank into sleep.

New Utopia was a bit emptier than usual. Many Ghosts had gone off to join the new protests. Some stayed behind.

All of them could barely believe what was happening.

Not only had a new set of protests started, but just earlier, *Catra* had emerged from Entrapta's lab. Alive and running. They barely

got a chance to stop her, but their hearts were racing.

Soon enough, they all heard the sound of the elevator descending.

“Someone’s coming,” Ravyn spoke up as she heard the whirring of machinery. “Get the defences ready. Just in case.”

“Got it,” Dyna nodded, one of Ravyn’s friends. Apart from Entrapta, she knew her way around her trap technology.

If someone they didn’t recognise came down that elevator, they’d be quickly apprehended. They weren’t risking another invasion.

All the Ghosts waited, ready to fight. The elevator got lower and lower…

And then they saw who had made it to New Utopia.

Entrapta.

She stumbled out of the elevator and into New Utopia, her eyes and body exhausted as she looked at the Ghosts all around her.

“Where…” Entrapta noticed many missing faces. “Where is everyone…?”

“Entrapta!” Dyna cried, lowering the defences.

The Ghosts ran to her, holding her up. She looked about ready to collapse and sleep for a month.

“They’ve gone off to fight,” Ravyn explained. “The new protests. The Runners are losing fast.”

Entrapta blinked. She slowly looked up at the Ghosts before her.

“So… The evidence… The upload…” She blinked, her lips growing weak with trembles. “It… worked…?” Her voice cracked.

"It did. It *did.* The world knows. They're fighting. You did it, Entrapta."

Entrapta tried to hold it together. She tried to stay intact. She tried to put on a smile like she always did for her Ghosts. She was *meant* to.

But those three words.

You did it.

They struck her to her very core.

She felt herself slowly begin to break. She tried so, so hard to prevent it. She couldn't cry, not in front of them.

But then…

Ravyn wrapped her arms around Entrapta.

She hugged her close. The other Ghosts comforted her.

"It's okay, Entrapta. You can let it out."

Finally, with permission…

Entrapta broke.

She sucked in air, and let it out with sobs and tears. There were tears of grief. How many lives were lost to get to this point? How many more lives would have to fade away?

She cried for all the ones that could never come back.

But Entrapta cried because finally, *finally,* she had managed to do something right. She cried because her part in the plan had worked. She cried because she hadn't allowed herself to in *ages.*

Entrapta sobbed loudly and returned the hug, the Ghosts holding her close. She collapsed to her knees, not even being sure when

this would end. There was still more fighting to do. There was still a system that needed to be overthrown.

But for now, Entrapta allowed herself to cry.

And the Ghosts comforted her throughout it all.

As they did, they heard the door creak open behind them. Ravyn, Dyna, and all the others looked up, on alert.

But they softened when they saw who it was.

Through her hazy vision, tight throat, and sniffles, Entrapta looked up to see one person carrying another.

And it didn't take her long to recognize who it was.

There was an emergency. Entrapta needed to get to work. Adora's life was in danger.

But as Entrapta finally stood up, she said something she'd been wanting to say for days.

"Welcome home, Catra."

Adora slowly felt her vision return to her.

She blinked, looking up to see an unfamiliar ceiling. Surgical lights beaming down at her. She almost winced.

Was she back with the Angels? Was all of this just an illusion? Was she dead?

She held up a hand, blocking the light as she sat up. Once she got her bearings and her vision cleared, she realised where she was.

Entrapta's lab.

The screens, the tech, the pod, it was all familiar. She knew it all too well. Adora had to—

The pod.

The pod was empty.

The pod was empty.

Adora blinked, tried to stand up, but immediately winced. Pain spiked into her back, and her skin felt fragile, like it could tear if she moved too much.

She gritted her teeth, sucked in air. She had no idea how bad the damage was. She didn't have a shirt on, so she reached over her shoulder.

She could feel stitches. Scars. Skin that was slightly bumpier than the rest.

But she couldn't see anything.

She slowly tested the waters, pressing her feet against the ground. She could *feel* everything in her body, at least.

When she stood up, however, it was much more difficult than usual. She had to put effort into her steps, her legs like jelly beneath her. They wobbled, and barely kept her up.

Crap.

Shit.

She was going to fall.

Her legs gave way.

She held out her hands, ready for pain…

"Adora!"

Suddenly, a pair of arms wrapped around her and broke her fall.

Adora gripped them tightly, kept herself up. She slowly got back to her feet, regaining her balance.

"T… Thank you…" She said to the person behind her. "Sorry, I just…"

Adora turned around, and saw her.

Catra.

Catra.

Catra's blue and yellow eyes looked down at her, her arms wrapped around Adora's waist, holding her up. She wore a look of concern, her brows narrowed. "You feeling okay? That was close. The stitches are still fresh."

Adora looked back up at her with one wide eye.

Her words caught in her throat. She kept her grip on Catra's arm as she looked her up and down.

At first, she thought it to be a dream.

A sadistic vision.

She wasn't allowed to be this happy. She wasn't used to being this happy.

She reached up a hand, and placed it against Catra's palm.

So warm.

So familiar.

"Catra…?" Adora breathlessly spoke. "Is… that… *you…?"*

Catra smiled. That smile. That *smile.* The one that curled up into her cheeks and puffed them up slightly. She let out that fucking giggle that broke her voice occasionally, the one Adora loved so much.

"Who else?" Catra smiled. "I've been waiting for you to wake up for *days.* Of course, the second I pass out…"

"Days…?"

"Yeah. I wanted the first thing you saw to be me," Catra replied. "I'm okay, Adora. I'm here. I'm alive. And I…"

She reached up a hand and brushed a strand of Adora's hair behind her ear.

"I'm *so sorry* I left you," she whispered.

She was sorry?

She was sorry?

"I know I've caused you a lot of pain, and I'm sorry. I… I don't want you to go through that ever again," Catra shook her head. "I promised you, the same time. I'm not going to break that promise, not again. I…"

Catra went silent.

Adora stood up straight, reached her other hand to wrap around Catra. To hold her close.

"Catra…" Adora shook her head. "*I'm* sorry I let you down… I'm sorry I let you die… It's… It's *my* fault…"

"Don't. Don't say that," Catra cut her off. "Don't you dare blame yourself for this. The Runners did what they did. And now we're

stopping them."

"I…" Adora sighed. "God… Catra… *Catra…* You're here…" She smiled, and tears began to leak from her eye. "You're *here…"*

"I am," Catra smiled, and she let out a sob as she ran her hand over Adora's cheek. "And I'm never leaving again. I love you, Adora. *I love you."*

"I love you, too…" Adora pressed her forehead against Catra's, grinning and sobbing at the same time. "I love you, too… I love you, Catra…"

Catra smiled and laughed too, even as she cried. The two women held each other so, so close. They cried and laughed and smiled and loved and felt each other in every way they could. Adora hadn't experienced this in so long. Catra had spent a simulated eternity in isolation.

They had each other.

They had each other.

And when they opened their eyes…

It didn't take long for them to seal the moment with a kiss.

Adora pressed her lips to Catra's, closing her eye as she did. It felt exactly the same. The beautiful taste, the softness. She pushed desperately into the kiss, as if it was the last she'd ever have.

Catra kissed with just as much intensity, pulling Adora close and wiping away her tears. She ran her hand gently down Adora's bare back, feeling the stitches. She knew of the markings. The burns, the scars. They likely would remain permanently etched on Adora's body.

And it didn't affect Catra's love.

Not in the slightest.

She'd do anything to look after her. And one day, she'd kiss those scars.

Adora and Catra kissed.

They loved.

They smiled.

Finally. Together again.

And most of all…

They were *free.*

Until Next Time

Chapter Summary

> With revolutionary change finally coming to Styx City, Adora and Catra must make a difficult yet necessary decision.

Chapter Notes

> No real content warnings for this one. Just the end of this whole journey. I'll have more to say in the end notes/comments, but until then... Enjoy <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra leaned against a brick wall and looked up at the nearly starless sky. As the days had passed and the numerous neon signs of the city had become casualties in the clashes between protestors and Runners, more and more stars became visible. She dreamt of the day where she could see all of them.

She scratched at her neck with a sigh. Waiting this long meant the cravings had come back. The urge to smoke manifested as a crawling under her skin, like unseen insects. It was something she was still fighting, and although she hadn't yet relapsed, there were moments where she had come close.

Even still, now she knew she wasn't alone.

"Hey, Catra!"

Adora's voice always put a smile on her face, but now she smiled wider than ever.

Catra looked to her left and saw the love of her life walking towards her. She looked different—*really* different—but she was still that same, beautiful Adora.

"Hey there."

Catra smiled as she finally pushed herself away from the wall and approached her girlfriend. She felt Adora's arms wrap around her waist once she was close enough, and she knew what came next.

She leaned in and pressed her lips to Adora's. It was a brief kiss, yet this one was special. Her first kiss with the new Adora.

Catra pulled away from the warmth and looked her girlfriend up and down. "How'd it all go? Did Entrapta treat you well?"

"She did," Adora nodded. "I'm still trying to adjust to… *everything.* But it wasn't painful."

Catra nodded, and examined the radical changes that had taken place since that morning. Adora's hair was now shorter, cut so that the ends were just touching the back of her neck.

The second and more important change was that Adora once again saw the world through two eyes.

Her missing left eye had only just been replaced by a cybernetic part that Entrapta had been working on for the past few days. Her previous experience with creating eyes had made the process relatively quick; she had to adjust to installing an eye in a human, but using decades-old blueprints and updating them with current-day tech had been almost a breeze.

Adora had asked for the eye a few days after the rioting had begun. The fear of being seen as a Ker had dissipated greatly, though she hadn't cared all that much in the first place. It was no different than Scorpia's cybernetic arms, or Entrapta using her cybernetic hair as a lab partner.

But unlike the wires Adora had pulled out of her back four days ago—something she was still recovering from—this eye was made by someone she trusted, so she saw no issue with it.

And of course, the eye was blue. Catra's favourite colour.

They were beautiful. So, so beautiful.

Catra could still get lost in them all over again.

Adora and Catra looked up to the dimmed-out sign above them, pointing to the one place they had agreed to meet up outside of New Utopia.

Elysium. Catra's old bar.

"Ready to go in?" Adora asked, giving Catra's hand a squeeze. "I think they're all waiting for us in there."

"Yeah…" Catra sighed, returning the squeeze.

"Glimmer should have some good ideas for the protests tomorrow," Adora said, her eyes returning to Catra's. "Scorpia's there to talk things out, too."

"Scorpia…" A distant smile wrapped onto Catra's face. "Been too long since I've seen her."

"Yeah," Adora smiled with a nod. "She'll probably be joining the protests, too."

It's all Adora had focused on ever since waking up. She couldn't drag her eyes away from footage of the Styx City protests. Her injuries had held her back, but as soon as she was able to *walk,* she was willing to fight.

Catra, on the other hand…

"Hey," Adora's brows narrowed as she noticed Catra's gaze fading to nothing. She was barely there. "Everything okay?"

"Huh?" Catra blinked. She stumbled over the first sentence her brain supplied. "Y-Yeah. Just…"

Silence. She was hesitant to voice her thoughts. But Adora wouldn't have it.

"You can talk to me, Catra," Adora whispered, her hand running up Catra's strong arm to comfort her, giving her shoulder a squeeze. "No more secrets, right?"

Right. Their promise. Catra needed to stick to it. Everything out in the open.

"...I *want* to join the protests," Catra began. "I'm responsible for starting them. I know it's what I have to do. But… I'm just… I'm anxious, Adora. I'm… scared. And it feels so fucking *stupid,* but… I…"

Catra was struggling to find the right words. Adora could see it on her face, the way she stammered and sighed with frustration.

"...I know the feeling," Adora was quick to confirm. "I'd be lying if I said I wasn't scared, too. It's okay to feel that way."

It didn't feel like it.

The slime of guilt mixed with the mud of anxiety in Catra's gut, and it created an unpleasant hole in her heart. She had been so happy to be back and with Adora again, and she knew it was her *role* to be in these protests, but even still…

It didn't help that she needed to do one other thing that she had been dreading for days.

"I… I guess I should go talk to Scorpia and Glimmer, then," Catra sighed. "Let them know that… I'm *alive."*

Apart from Adora and the Ghosts, Catra's survival was a well-kept secret. Good for hiding from the Runners, but the longer she went without telling the ones she trusted, the worse she felt.

"They'll be happy to see you," Adora affirmed. "I promise. They won't hold anything against you."

Catra knew she was right. Her brain knew Adora wouldn't lie to her. Even still, her *stupid anxiety* told her Glimmer would be mad.

Her stupid brain told her Scorpia would just be upset.

This was getting harder and harder the more she thought about it.

"Can you… Can you go on ahead? I'll be right behind you. I just… need a sec to breathe."

Adora's brows narrowed with worry, but she knew the feeling. She could see the tension in Catra's body, her bunched shoulders and slightly heavy breathing.

Adora nodded, and pressed a kiss to Catra's cheek. "Whenever you're ready."

Catra nodded her thanks and Adora went on ahead.

The bar was dimmer than usual. It had been shut down, of course, after the Runners discovered one of the bartenders was a Ghost. But it hadn't been demolished or replaced just yet.

It made for a perfect meeting spot.

Catra could hear the conversation from outside.

"Hey, Adora!" Scorpia called from behind the bar. "Welcome to Elysium! Or… what's left of it, I guess!"

"Holy shit…" Glimmer's voice quickly picked up. "Adora, you got an eye! A-And a haircut!"

"Yeah! One of the Ghosts was kind enough to give me the haircut. Aaaand I've got a good friend to thank for the eye. It's not Nyx property, don't worry," Adora reassured them. "You'll have to excuse me if I run into walls or anything. I *just* got adjusted to one-eyed vision, now I have to relearn everything all over again."

"You're okay!" Scorpia happily spoke. "Have a seat! Some of the drinks are still cold."

“Hey, where’s your friend?” Glimmer asked. “You mentioned you were bringing someone in the text.”

Catra tensed.

She knew she needed to walk into that bar, and talk to them in person. Informing them of her survival over the phone just felt wrong. But the idea of surprising Glimmer, and *especially* Scorpia, with this fact was causing the anxiety that swirled in her gut. And the more she waited, the more the anxiety festered.

Scorpia had grieved for her. Glimmer likely did in some way too. Now she had to reverse all that? It felt shitty.

But Catra was always the type to rip the band-aid off, to say, *“fuck it”* and dive in head-first.

And that’s exactly what she had to do now.

She took a breath, and entered Elysium through that creaky and familiar front door.

All eyes turned towards her. Adora’s were soft with admiration, happy to see Catra finally taking that first nervous step.

Scorpia and Glimmer’s reactions mirrored each other.

Pure *shock.*

Catra could tell neither of them believed their eyes at first. Glimmer’s breath caught in her throat and Scorpia couldn’t move for a solid five seconds.

“Uh… Hey,” Catra nervously laughed, glancing at Adora for reassurance before looking back at the other two.

Hey?

Hey?

That’s seriously the first thing you say?

The little voice in Catra's head was already talking down to her. She was expecting her friends to be angry or hurt or upset or—

"CATRA!"

Scratch that; Scorpia had instantly thrown her massive arms around Catra and pulled her in for a tight hug.

Catra's first instinct was to mutter 'personal space', but… Well, Scorpia probably needed this. And admittedly, Catra did too. She slowly wrapped her arms around Scorpia and returned the hug, though nowhere near with the same amount of force.

"You're back! You're… You're *back!"* Scorpia was already sobbing above her, which Catra could *feel* each time her chest heaved. "Catra…! I thought I'd never see you again…"

That felt like a knife to the heart.

Catra tightened the hug just a bit. "I'm here, Scorpia. I'm here…"

"When…" Scorpia sniffled. "When did you wake up? Are you feeling okay?"

"I'm fine. I promise," Catra shook her head. "I've… actually been awake for a little over four days now."

"…What?"

"I know, I know," Catra stepped back for a bit, holding up her hands. "And I'm *sorry,* okay? I know I should've told you earlier. I just… I *died* on all of you, and I know how rough it is to go through that, and I thought if I just came back all of a sudden, it'd just fuck with your heads. I was *going* to tell you eventually, but then I kept waiting, and I just felt worse, and—"

"*Catra*."

Scorpia placed a hand on her shoulder. Catra blinked, cutting herself short, suddenly realising she was rambling. She *rarely*

rambled in her life like that. Adora must've really rubbed off on her.

She looked up, and saw Scorpia's warm, tear-filled smile. Catra could only look with wide eyes.

"You don't have to apologise for anything. I'm just…" Scorpia let out a relieved sigh. "I'm so glad you're *okay."*

Of course.

Of *course* Scorpia wouldn't be mad.

Of *course* she'd just be happy to have Catra back.

She didn't hold things like that against her.

The voice in Catra's head lied, like it always did.

And one day, she'd be able to spot those lies earlier.

"Thank… Thank you…" Catra sighed, then let out a chuckle. "Warn me next time before you crush me like that, though."

"O-Oh, right! Sorry!" Scorpia held up her hands. "Personal space, I get it! I didn't mean—"

"You're fine. I'll let it slide this time." Catra grinned. "It's good to see you again, Scorpia. I'm gonna miss working with you behind this bar."

"Ah, we can catch up in other places, right?" Scorpia asked.

Catra smiled.

But she didn't respond.

She looked over to the person behind Scorpia, standing from her seat, still stunned by everything that was happening.

Glimmer took a step towards Catra, still trying to take *everything* in. Catra noticed the slight bags under her eyes, her exhaustion from the events of the last four days. Even still, she had made time for this meeting.

Catra couldn't read her face. And that scared her.

Scorpia might not have been angry about the situation, but Glimmer was unpredictable. And after all the rage she'd been carrying, Catra was worried it might spill out.

"Glimmer, I… I know you wanted to talk to me," Catra sighed. "And I know I should've told you I was awake earlier. Given everything that's been going on… I know you needed some peace. You've been fighting so hard for us, the least I could've done was—"

"Can I hug you?"

Catra blinked.

Tears were bunching in the corners of Glimmer's eyes. Her body was slightly shaking with held-back relief.

"Uh…" Catra nodded. "Yeah, of course. I just—"

Glimmer instantly made good on her words.

She held Catra close. Really close. Catra could feel the way her body slightly shook, and she could hear her gasps of relief.

"…Thank you," Glimmer choked out in a weak, cracked voice. "Not just for everything you did for me when mom died. Thank you for showing up. You have no idea how much I needed to know you're okay…"

Glimmer sounded tired. So, so tired. She was pushing herself too much. Trying to be what her mother was during the Awakening.

Catra slowly raised her arms and pulled her even closer, placing a hand on the back of her head and raking her fingers through her sparkling hair. "I'm okay, Sparkles. I'm okay. They can't kill me *that* easily."

Glimmer let out a mix of a scoff and a sob. "Of course they can't…"

"…You're doing good," Catra said. "With everything going on at the protests. It's been hard, but you're doing good. All of the Ghosts can see it. Just… Try to take better care of yourself, alright? You're allowed to rest when you need it. It's what we want. And it's what Angella would want, too."

Glimmer let out a slight gasp at that name. Those words. She loosened the hug for a few seconds, before quickly tightening it again. Their embrace had lasted nearly a minute at this rate.

"Thank you…" Glimmer sighed. "I'll… I'll try."

Catra ran her fingers through Glimmer's hair one last time, before they finally separated. Glimmer wiped the tears from her eyes, and Catra smiled with a prideful nod.

The four of them each exchanged a smile, and shared the knowledge that they were okay. They were going to be *okay.*

"Speaking of those protests," Adora finally said into the comfortable silence. "How's it all going? Catra and I want in on whatever's next."

"We were doing pretty well up until the Runners put their foot down. Curfew, all the arrests, and threats of execution…" Glimmer sighed, crossing her arms. "It's made people nervous, but they're still motivated. We're organising something for tomorrow. We're going to be outside Nyx's main tower in Section 1. I was just talking to Scorpia about it."

"You can count on me being there!" Scorpia grinned, placing her metallic hands on her hips. "That tower has *always* been an

eyesore."

"Wow…" Adora let out an impressed chuckle. "You've really become a leader, huh, Glimmer?"

"Oh… no," Glimmer shook her head. "No, I'm not leading any of this. It's not my place. I'm just trying to give people that extra push when they need it. Plenty of Ghosts have stepped up to that plate."

"Well," Catra smiled at both Glimmer and Scorpia. "Good luck at tomorrow's protest."

Glimmer scoffed. "Oh, we're not planning a *protest.* We've done plenty of those already, and the Runners haven't budged. They had their chance. I've talked to a lot of Ghosts about our plans, and we're in agreement."

Glimmer leaned forward with a stoic expression. "Tomorrow, we're *burning Nyx's tower to the fucking ground."*

Catra's eyes widened, but shock was quickly replaced with *eagerness.* "You gonna have enough people to do it?"

"We're counting on it. And once that's down, it's onto the Runners. Hell, probably even the Knights too," Glimmer grinned at the thought.

"Then we can't let up," Adora added. "The Runners… They've taken *so much* from us. They can't get away with it."

"They won't. Trust me." Glimmer's hands tensed up into fists for a second. "I'll *make sure* they won't…"

Catra knew what Adora and Glimmer were agreeing on. They didn't need to say her name.

"I think we'll be able to make real change with this," Catra nodded. "My people are pissed. We've been kicked down for years. There's a *lot* of rage to be released. We won't settle for half-measures this time."

"You're damn right!" Glimmer chuckled.

Admittedly, there were nerves. There was anxiety and fear of failure, and the possibility of bloodshed on their side. The eagerness smothered it, but it was there.

However, they knew what was necessary. The Runners had shown their true colours long ago; they had no capacity for change. It was inevitable that protests weren't going to be enough.

Glimmer let out a satisfied sigh, but even still, her crossed arms tensed. "So… You two are really gonna be there tomorrow, huh?"

"That's the plan," Adora nodded, though she looked to Catra for confirmation.

It took a couple of seconds, but eventually, Catra nodded too. "We need to finish what we started."

Glimmer's smile had somewhat faded. She looked between the two of them, before glancing back at Scorpia.

For some reason, Glimmer and Scorpia were sharing an odd look of… sympathy? Regret? They were frowning, their brows narrowed with worry.

Glimmer cleared her throat. "I…" She started again. There was more planning to do. More to sort out.

But…

It didn't feel *right.*

She sighed, not even able to go on with the rest of the plan.

“Catra… Adora…” Glimmer looked up at them. “I have more respect for you two than anyone else. You both… You started this revolution. You’ve brought about so much change, in such a short time. The Ghosts owe you both so much.”

“I…” Adora looked at Catra then back at Glimmer. “Thank you…? There’s still a long way to go, though. We’ve only just gotten started.”

“You’re right. And a lot of people recognise that, too,” Glimmer said. “So many Ghosts are stepping up to leadership positions. We have *thousands* of people fighting. So…” She sighed. “I mean this, with all due respect…”

Glimmer closed her eyes, took a breath, then looked up at Adora and Catra with a vulnerability they both had rarely seen in her.

“I don’t think you two should be fighting. In fact… I don’t think you should be in Styx City at *all.* At least for a little while.”

Catra and Adora’s smiles faded.

Their chests went cold as they exchanged eye contact with Glimmer.

“But…” Adora shook her head, a confused laugh slipping out. “But we *have* to fight. We started this thing, we… We don’t have a choice here.”

“I…” Catra blinked. “Glimmer, we can’t just run away.”

“It’s not *running away,”* Glimmer said.

“But it literally *is,”* Adora immediately cut in.

"Fine. So what, then?" Glimmer argued back. "Look… I'm only saying this because I care about you two. You've done *enough. Both of you.* You've fought so much, and people have taken *inspiration* from you."

"Then why stop?" Catra was almost agreeing with her, but she couldn't *let* herself think that.

"Because…" Glimmer stuttered. "I just… I…"

"Glimmer, we can't just *leave,"* Adora said.

"Adora…"

Catra spoke up. "People *need* some form of hope out there."

Adora quickly stepped in. "We can't–"

"Oh, for *fuck's* sake, you two! One of you has already *died* for this!"

Glimmer's voice cut like steel through both Adora and Catra. Their eyes widened at the sudden increase in tone and severity.

Glimmer continued. "Look, I'm sorry, I *know* you two feel like you owe this revolution more, but what more can you *give?!* Adora, you lost an eye, ripped out your cybernetics, and you've become the Runners' number one target for this! Catra, you *died!* You fucking *DIED!* You're *lucky* to still be here! These riots are no fucking joke! People are going to get hurt, and as much as I don't want to admit it, people are going to die if—and more likely, *when* —the Runners truly fight back! What if it's one of you two that goes down?! What *then?!* How would the other be able to *live?!"*

Glimmer was panting. Adora and Catra could only stare with wide eyes at her. Her voice, so cracked and desperate, shot straight

through them. They didn't need to deny her. Glimmer *knew* the pain of losing a loved one all too well.

Instead, Adora and Catra could only look up at Scorpia. As if she would have a differing opinion, something to convince them to stay and fight.

But…

Scorpia's eyes were simply gazed down at the floor. She knew she was being looked upon. But instead, she only had a few words.

"I…" Scorpia sighed. "I think she's right. This… This doesn't need to be your fight anymore. You need to leave, and focus on yourselves for once. Be safe."

And that was the gut punch Adora and Catra needed.

So many things washed over them in those moments. For Adora, it was guilt. Guilt that she might've dragged her and her girlfriend into such a dangerous situation, all over again. Guilt that her recklessness might've ruined them. Indeed, she looked at Catra with nothing but apologies in her eyes.

But when Catra looked back, she flashed a sad smile. As much as it hurt to admit, and as guilty as it too made her…

They both knew Glimmer was right.

"Where…" Adora hesitated for a bit, before finally letting go. "Where would we go?"

Glimmer let out a sigh of pure relief. "I think the best place would be Arcadia. I had a friend… A Ghost… His name was Bow. He needed somewhere to escape, and Arcadia is generally pretty loose on Ghost restrictions. You'd still need to be careful, but the Guardians out there have less funding. Less people. You could keep your heads down and be safe for as long as you needed."

They'd both heard of Arcadia, of course. One of the many places nearby Styx City that had the Guardian system in place. But it was a nearby safe haven that was still within the country.

"It wouldn't be permanent," Glimmer added. "You could come back once things have died down and hopefully gotten better. But with the tower tomorrow… I want to see you two *alive* after all this is said and done. I… I really don't know if I'd be able to handle losing you two as well…"

Her voice broke with that last sentence. It was the sting Adora and Catra needed. The final stretch.

"Entrapta could set it up for us," Catra said, getting Adora to perk up. "I've seen her organise a way out for dozens of Ghosts. She can practically do it in her sleep. New IDs, some disguise cybernetics and modifications. It might be harder because of the extra restrictions, but… we could be on the first flight out of here tomorrow."

"Good," Glimmer nodded. "Adora? Does that sound alright to you? I know I basically sprung this on you, but…"

"You're right." Adora let the words out with a sigh, but she nodded in affirmation. "You're… You're right, Glimmer. I'll admit, I don't like doing it, but…" Adora looked up at Catra. "It's better than risking losing you all over again."

Catra smiled at her, and Adora returned the gesture. The agreement they needed. The push towards what they needed to do.

"Plus," Glimmer added one more thing, "this place, Arcadia… It pays its therapists well. The counselling and… all that. I'm not saying you *have* to, but… Being able to talk to someone about everything you've been through…"

Adora had operated for years under the assumption that she'd never needed any help… not that it was even available to begin with. The mental health crisis in Styx City had been worsening

ever since the pay for therapists had dropped to near-unliveable levels. Professionals had all but disappeared overnight. Adora thought it wouldn't be a problem for her.

But now, she knew otherwise.

Catra had a slight twinge of shame in her eyes. She still hadn't gotten used to the idea that she needed help. But a squeeze of the hand from Adora was enough to clear that doubt.

"That sounds good, too," Adora agreed. And the smile from Catra was all she needed.

"We'll… We'll do it." Catra took a confident breath. "We'll leave Styx City. Tomorrow. Both of us."

"Seems like the revolution is in good hands. Besides, no-one outside of the Ghosts in New Utopia even knew it was Catra who gave that speech. I think they'd be okay without us," Adora admitted.

"That's great," Glimmer smiled. "I'm… I'm really proud of you. Both of you."

"Same here," Scorpia agreed. "But… I'm definitely going to miss you two."

There was pain in Scorpia's voice. A wavering that she tried to hide. Catra and Adora both heard it.

"...I am, too." Glimmer finally admitted it. Even though it was her suggestion, she couldn't help but feel that way.

There was a pain in both their voices. A crack. A reveal of the fact that they both desperately wanted Adora and Catra in their lives still, but the knowledge to also realise that this was the better way.

Even still. They felt pain. And they were allowed to.

But they knew they couldn't end on a note like that. If they were to be separated for weeks, months, maybe even years, then it couldn't be on a downer note.

So, Catra released Adora's hand.

She walked a few paces, opened the sliding door, entered the bar, and placed herself on the opposite side of the bench to everyone.

"So…" Catra planted her palms against the bar bench. "Last set of drinks for us all? On the house, of course."

"That sounds great to me," Glimmer grinned, sitting back down on her stool.

"I can help!" Scorpia called out, already making her way to the shaker to make a cocktail for Glimmer.

Catra looked at Adora with a loving, beautiful smile. "How can I serve an angel like yourself tonight?"

Adora returned the smile. The same smile she often gave right before she kissed Catra. The bartender knew it all too well.

"You realise I'm not exactly an Angel anymore, right?" Adora asked.

"I know. But you're still *my* angel."

Adora giggled. "I'll have a Blue Fairy, you fucking dork."

"Coming right up," Catra winked.

And what came next was one of the several things that had made Adora first fall in love with Catra: She could mix a *hell* of a drink.

It was a dim, empty bar in an abandoned alleyway in the middle of a city placed under curfew. It wasn't a pretty place to be. But it was where Adora and Catra first met, and that alone made it special to them.

The two of them looked over at Scorpia and Glimmer, making conversation and discussing plans.

The future was uncertain. This was a dangerous time. They might never see each other again.

But that was all the more reason to make the most of what they had now.

Once everyone had their drinks, they raised them in a toast.

"To the Ghosts, to their freedom!"

Glimmer added one more note.

"And to Angella Moonbright, the best mom and best Angel in the world."

A shared nod.

A shared drink.

And it was as though Angella was sharing that drink right beside them.

"Hey mom."

"I know it's late, and this might be a lot, but…"

"Catra and I are moving."

"We're leaving Styx City. Probably tomorrow. Going to Arcadia. We don't know for how long."

"I'm sorry I couldn't give you more warning. You can come with us or stay. Just know that we're safe. And we'll be okay."

Adora stared at the beginning of her brief text conversation with her moms. They'd given their response, and knowing that her

moms were aware of her plan put Adora's mind at ease. She pocketed her phone, and focused on the next part of her journey.

She and Catra were walking through New Utopia, headed for Entrapta's lab. Adora took it all in for what was likely the last time. As she looked at Catra and her turning head, she could tell she was doing the same thing. It wasn't the same as the old Utopia Catra had grown up in over the last year, but this was still her community. Still her people. Leaving them all behind felt… odd.

Most of the Ghosts were resting, planning, or discussing the riots that would be occurring tomorrow. They each gave Catra and Adora a nod or a wave as they passed, and the two of them returned the gesture.

A last acknowledgement. A last greeting.

They soon reached the stairs and descended into Entrapta's familiar lab for the last time.

Upon reaching the bottom, Adora and Catra caught Entrapta in her ever familiar position: Surrounded by glowing monitors (which were the only light in the dim room), typing away at one of her screens with a smile on her face.

"Oh hey, you two!" Entrapta greeted them without even looking up. "How was your outing?"

"Good," Adora nodded with a smile, even as she noticed Catra's somewhat absent stare. "We talked with Glimmer and Scorpia about tomorrow. You're… aware of what's happening at Nyx's tower in Section 1 tomorrow?"

"Oh yeah, I know all about it!" Entrapta grinned. "Talking with a few other Ghosts on a secure channel about it. We've got *loads* of entry points and weaknesses in the tower to exploit. They're two updates behind on their security firmware!"

Adora snorted. "Cocky as always…"

However, as the two of them spoke, Catra's wandered slightly through Entrapta's lab, her hands brushing over certain parts of it. The bed where she performed Disconnection procedures, her many work-in-progress cybernetics, and of course, the broken pod she had escaped from a few days ago.

"So what were the plans between you four? Anything I should know about?" Entrapta asked as she continued chatting in an encrypted server with other Ghosts, messages disappearing into nothingness after only a few seconds.

"Well… Scorpia and Glimmer will be there," Adora confirmed, although her eyes never left Catra.

"Great! Always good to have extra hands!"

Then, Adora went silent. Because this next part was for Catra to confirm with her best friend.

Catra recognised the silence, and her part in breaking it.

But it hurt. It hurt to know what she needed to tell Entrapta. It hurt to know what she needed to *do* to Entrapta.

But she had to do it all the same.

"Entrapta…" Catra choked out her name through her dry throat. "You… You know how to quickly move people out of Styx City, right?"

"*One of my specialitieeees!"* Entrapta responded in an almost sing-song voice.

Catra chuckled. She loved her. She truly did.

"Well…" Catra's jaw tensed. She looked at Adora for encouragement, and was met with a comforting smile. She returned it.

Then, she spoke.

“How fast… would you be able to get Adora and I out of Styx City? And… into Arcadia?”

Silence.

Utter silence.

Adora and Catra looked as Entrapta sat still for almost a full seven seconds. It was… almost unnerving. She was so active, never stopping for anything, yet this caused her to come to a halt.

Had they stepped too far?

Would Entrapta… *deny* them?

Adora and Catra exchanged a worried glance. Perhaps they’d need to find their own way. Or perhaps…

“I can get you two on the first flight out of here in the morning.”

They blinked.

The words processed in their minds.

Then their heads snapped towards Entrapta.

“W-Wait, *seriously?”* Catra stammered out.

“If that’s what you want!” Entrapta picked right back up, opening a new tab on one of her monitors. “You two have absolutely perfect timing. I’ve already got some new IDs set up for you, and if you give me a few minutes, I can put your new identities into the Guardian system. Plus, I guarantee once the riots start tomorrow, Styx City will be on indefinite lockdown. It’s good to get out while you can.”

Adora and Catra *still* couldn’t quite believe it.

“How… How do you already have IDs for us?” Adora asked while Catra tried to collect her thoughts.

“I set them up a few days ago. As a back-up for something like this.” Entrapta began to edit them all together. “I always… wanted to bring up the idea of you two leaving for some time. I just didn’t know how to do it.”

“You did?” Catra choked out.

“I…” Entrapta hesitated for just a second. “I… didn’t feel great about sending you two into a potentially violent revolution so soon after… everything. The idea of you still fighting… It made me feel… *weird.* So I started these IDs as a side project just in case. I just… didn’t think I’d actually *use* them. But…”

Entrapta smiled, and the two of them could see by the way her cheeks puffed and her body slightly bounced from side to side.

“I’m so glad I get the chance now!”

She was doing all this like it was nothing. Of course it was simple for her, but it was almost like she was on auto-pilot.

Maybe she *was.*

“Entrapta, I…” Catra let out a quick sigh for her lack of words. “I just didn’t think you’d be so on board so easily. I mean… We’re going to be gone for a while–”

“They’re printing!”

Entrapta cut her off as she pushed away from her desk towards her large-scale printer, which produced two perfect ID replicas in less than a few seconds. Meanwhile, on the screen, Adora and Catra’s new identities were slowly being uploaded into the Guardian system.

In less than a few minutes, they had a flight, new identities, and new files to confirm them. Entrapta truly worked miracles.

It was like she couldn't focus on anything *but* work.

"Oh, Adora," Entrapta spoke up, "close both your eyes and squeeze them shut *real* hard. like, try to touch your brows to your cheeks."

Adora blinked, confused at the suggestion, but she decided to do it anyway. Eyes closed and one squeeze later, and all she felt was stupid.

But when her eyes opened, she saw Catra's widen with shock, a smile curling onto her face as she looked at the result.

"Holy shit!" Catra laughed. "Adora, your eye colour! It's brown!"

"It is?!" Adora gawked, immediately wondering if she had done something irreversible.

"It's a mod I installed along with your new eye," Entrapta gleefully explained as she made final adjustments to the small files. "If you squeeze 'em both shut real tight, they'll change colour. Along with that new haircut, I doubt anyone will recognise you as Adora Grayskull wherever you go. Your eyes can cycle through brown, yellow, green, then back to blue again!"

Adora squeezed them shut and cycled through them, looking to Catra for confirmation, which she received. It was, admittedly, *insanely* fucking cool. And she had no idea she had the mod in the first place!

"That is *awesome,"* Catra grinned.

"Entrapta…" Adora chuckled. "Thank you. I… God, you're the *best,* you know that? I wish we could bring you with us!"

Silence.

A smile remained on Entrapta's face, like she almost didn't hear it. But she… She must have.

Was she ignoring her?

She pushed her desk over towards the two of them, and put herself back on auto-pilot.

"Here's your IDs."

Entrapta placed two small physical folders before Adora and Catra. It had their pictures and their new names: Megan Taliana for Adora, Calypso Aima for Catra.

"These are your new names for however long you need them," Entrapta explained. "I've altered a few of the automated systems to replace your names and photos. You're entirely new people, and your backgrounds have been forwarded to your accounts. Try to learn these as best as you can. For the time being, Adora Grayskull and Catra Horda have been listed as missing people. I can even list you as dead if needed, but I'm keeping open the possibility for you to come back to Styx City. I can secure an apartment for you in Arcadia, and I can send your belongings—along with Melog—to that location as soon as possible."

"We…" Catra picked up her ID, glancing at Adora.

This was all so convenient. So easy. Yet something felt so *off.*

Even still, Catra spoke. "We can't thank you enough for all this, Entrapta. Really. We… We should pay you at least."

"I don't need anything from you two! I'm doing this because I *want* to! You're not the only people I've helped escape Styx City. This is a *breeze!"* Entrapta grinned, before raising her shoulders in an exaggerated shrug. "Besides! Paying me *might* be redundant if the economy collapses soon, given everything going on."

Entrapta hopped back into her seat, gliding towards her computers to continue work at something else. Adora and Catra were simply left dumbfounded, as was usual with Entrapta.

"Your flight is in ten hours. I suggest getting ready with your packing. Bring only necessities. You'll need new phones, wallets, and Catra'll need a new Series 17 arm by the time you arrive, so keep that in mind," Entrapta finished. "Other than that… You'll be fine. And you'll be safe in Arcadia."

"Entrapta," Adora sighed with relief. *"Thank you."*

"Like I said, this is a breeze! You don't have to—"

"N-No, not just for this," Adora cut her off. "You've done so much for us. You… You *saved* Catra's life. You got the recording of Shadow Weaver out to the whole city. You saved my life and fixed up my back *and* my eye. I don't know if you've been thanked enough for that."

"And not even just *that,"* Catra continued. "Everything you've done for the Ghosts. For the Keres. You're a *hero,* Entrapta. You're so important to everyone in this city. After these protests and riots… I really hope you'll get everything you deserve. Hell, I'll make *sure* of it."

All three of them knew what was unspoken between them thus far. Adora and Catra needed to get these words out now, while they had the chance.

Entrapta didn't look at either of them as they spoke. It was something they had all gotten used to, this lack of eye contact. They didn't need it. They could tell the words had hit Entrapta when her typing slowed a bit.

"Have…" Entrapta cleared her throat. "Have you talked to your moms, Adora? Do they know what's going on?"

She was trying to change the subject. It was all becoming a bit too much.

"I have," Adora nodded. "They're thinking about moving with us, but they also wanted to participate in the protests. They're weighing everything up, but they *do* know."

“Good. I’m glad,” Entrapta nodded.

There was still the elephant in the room. No matter how much Entrapta tried to push it away, it was slowly creeping on them.

“Entrapta…”

“Hm?”

“Have you ever thought about taking a break?” Adora asked. “You’ve done so much, for *years.* Don’t you think you deserve to take care of yourself?”

Again, slowed typing. Entrapta was obviously thinking it over.

“…Sometimes,” Entrapta admitted. “But I don’t think it’d suit me. I’m happy *because* I help our people. I’m happy *because* I’m trying to make a difference.”

“You *are* making a difference*,”* Catra corrected her. “You’ve already done *so* much.”

Entrapta nodded. A slight smile appeared on her face. “Thank you…” She choked out in a weak voice, before taking a breath. “I don’t think I’ll be leaving. But… I’ll take your advice. I’ll try to go… easier on myself. Plenty of other Offline Keres are stepping up into leadership positions. I might not be as needed this time around!”

“You deserve to rest, Entrapta. You really do. Just…” Catra sighed. “If there’s one thing I can ask of you before I go, it’s that. Rest. Take care of yourself. Please.”

Entrapta’s typing stopped.

It stopped midway through Catra’s sentence, at one specific point.

‘Before I go’.

She had tried to push it away.

She had tried to ignore it.

But she couldn’t.

It had all suddenly hit Entrapta. It didn’t blindside her. She was aware of its presence.

But it hurt like hell to speak it out loud.

Entrapta blinked a few times.

“Is… Is this the last time we’re ever going to see each other?”

“No!” Catra instantly shook her head. “No, absolutely not. We’ll come back one day, even if it’s just a temporary visit.”

“But…” Entrapta blinked even more. “It’ll… be a long time before we see each other again… Right…?”

“I…”

Catra sighed. She couldn’t deny that. It would be months, at a minimum, before they could come back. However, it was likely to be years. A revolution of this scale would take a long time.

Entrapta’s hands slipped from her keyboard. All of it was dawning on her too fast. She had sent away so many Ghosts to live on their own before, she was *used* to that.

But Catra was different.

She’d miss Adora, of course.

But Entrapta felt a way about Catra that she’d rarely felt about anyone before.

It wasn’t romantic love. Entrapta had seldom experienced that in her life, nor did she really need it.

But it was a bond. A close, deep connection.

And now it was about to be ripped away from her. Temporarily, yes, but even still…

Oh.

The tears were already welling in her eyes.

"E-Entrapta!" Catra quickly stepped towards her, placing a hand on her shoulder. "Hey, it's okay! We'll be okay!"

"I know…" Entrapta smiled, trying to wipe the tears as she looked at Catra. "I know. You'll be okay. Both of you. You'll be okay."

"You saved our lives," Adora smiled. "We're going to be okay *because* of you."

"I *know,"* Entrapta replied, but her voice cracked. "You're both going to be okay… So… Why… Why am I so… *sad…?"*

"Entrapta…"

Weak sobs started to spill from Entrapta. She tried to imprison them behind gritted teeth and a forced smile, but they burst through anyway. She tried to wipe away the tears and deny them, but they kept coming back.

Catra rubbed circles around her back, comforting her. "Hey…" Catra's own eyes were swelling with tears, her vision becoming hazy. "It's okay to cry, Entrapta." Her voice was becoming weak, too.

For so long, she believed otherwise. Both Catra and Entrapta. They couldn't cry, no matter what. They needed to hide their vulnerability behind layers of steel.

But tears, crying, vulnerability, all of it was special. It was *needed.* They knew they needed a long time to not feel shame about

crying, but for now, they at least knew it was *needed.*

So finally, Entrapta let those tears run free. And Catra did the same.

"I'm going to miss you *so much…"* Entrapta spoke through wobbly lips and a tight throat.

"I'll miss you, too…" Catra smiled through her tears. "But I *promise,* this isn't goodbye. I promise, this is just 'see you later'. We'll meet again one day, alright?"

Entrapta nodded, even with her face scrunched up into sobs and grief. "Alright…"

And they sealed the promise with one thing they both desperately needed.

An embrace.

Their last embrace.

Catra wrapped her arms around Entrapta's chest and pulled her close. As close as she could. Even closer than she had embraced Glimmer hours earlier.

Catra and Entrapta had a relationship so different than anything they had experienced before, but it was equally as important. Entrapta returned the hug, her arms around Catra's shoulders, her face buried in the crook of her neck.

They both cried.

And they both knew it was needed.

They shook in each other's arms, and each sob only tightened their hug. Catra placed a hand on the back of Entrapta's head, lightly stroked her lilac hair.

“I love you, Entrapta,” Catra whispered, holding her closer in her arms. “I love you so much. You *saved* me. I’ll always be with you. Always, no matter how far apart we are. I’m just a call away. And I’ll see you again one day.”

Entrapta whimpered out one meek sentence, something she had never told anyone in her life before.

“You saved me, too.”

Adora had wept a few tears herself, but she knew this was most needed between the two of them. She was happy to leave it as is.

But Catra looked at her. And she nodded her close.

Adora was hesitant, but soon, she also joined the embrace.

She held both her girlfriend and her saviour in her arms.

In that moment, no more words were needed. There would be more later. There would be more ‘see you later’s when the time came.

The three of them had gone through enough.

All they needed was this embrace.

All of them were alive.

All of them were okay.

And one day, all of them would be truly safe.

And truly happy.

Catra could barely sleep over the next few hours.

It was her fourth time sleeping in the cabin she had worked so hard on, yet it would be her last night there. Was all her effort just a waste? Was this all for nothing?

Doubt. Confusion. Uncertainty. It all clouded her mind. She could not come to a conclusive thought.

Was leaving Styx City really the right thing to do?

She *started* this in the first place with her speech. Wasn't it her right to stay and see it through to the end? Wasn't it cowardly to just leave after it all?

She likely wouldn't sleep that night.

She laid in the bed with Melog by her feet and Adora passed out by her side. Her soft snores were as beautiful as ever. Her favourite sound. It always reminded her of the days she let Adora stay on her couch. She'd always hear those snores through her wall. It had become so soothing to her.

She turned her body away from Adora, trying to get into a comfortable position. Yet she knew sleep would not take her. Not while her brain was overthinking like this.

She *wanted* safety. That was the most important thing. She *wanted* to be safe and happy with Adora. She *wanted* to not have to live in fear every day as she had grown so used to.

But this riot was all about striving for a Styx City like that. Wasn't this something she should fight for? Wasn't taking the easy way out just a betrayal to everything she had?

Catra couldn't find a proper answer to any of the questions in her mind. And anytime she thought she did, it only led to more questions. Questions, questions, *fucking questions.*

Is this what Adora wanted?

She seemed so eager to fight, yet she reluctantly agreed with Glimmer's words. Was she just doing it for Catra's sake? Was Adora sacrificing her own wants and needs yet again?

Oh god.

Guilt strangled her heart. Had she somewhat forced Adora into this? Was she just perpetuating what Adora had tried so hard to grow from?

"Catra…"

A mumble. From Adora.

Catra could recognise her sleeptalk.

Adora's body shifted, patting at the sheets beside her. She couldn't find her.

"Catra…?"

Adora was patting at the wrong spots, but when she couldn't find Catra with her arm…

"...Catra? Catra? No, no…"

She moved her arm up and down frantically, and she…

She started to *hyperventilate.* In her *sleep.*

Catra's eyes widened with horror. What nightmares was she having?

"Catra, please, no, no, no, don't go, no, no, no, no, no, *no, no, no…"*

Adora was close.

She couldn't take this.

Catra moved her body closer to her girlfriend until finally, gracefully, Adora's arm found her.

And Catra could *feel* every muscle in Adora's body release all its tension. Along with that came the biggest sigh of relief she'd ever heard.

"Catra…"

Adora wrapped her arm around Catra. And not just in a lazy droop over her waist. She *clung* to the front of Catra's shirt, pulled herself close and gripped on tight. Her arm held her so close, afraid to let go again.

Catra could feel Adora's forehead against her back, panting as she slowly came down from the panic she had been quickly building up to. Her arm trembled as she held Catra.

It was nearly enough to make Catra cry.

She brought her own hand up and placed it over Adora's. How frequent had these nightmares been? How could Adora have all this stress and panic in her *sleep?*

It all finally made sense to Catra.

Why Glimmer had made that suggestion.

Why Scorpia had agreed with her.

Why Entrapta was so quick to jump on board.

As she gripped the trembling arm of Adora in her hand, Catra finally understood.

And then, she finally managed to close her eyes.

The flight was in an hour and a half, and Adora, Catra, and Entrapta all arrived at the airport.

It was a bit late, but the quicker they got through boarding and security and the less time they had to wait, the more likely they wouldn't be caught.

Adora and Catra packed light with the necessities, some of which would be dumped and swapped out once they arrived in Arcadia.

Adora had changed her short hair to be brown, which matched the temporary colour of her eyes.

"Just don't draw any attention to yourselves. This should all be routine. Try not to stick out," Entrapta instructed. "I… I can't save you if anything happens, but if something does go wrong, try to get out. Your safety is more important than anything."

Adora and Catra would be lying if they said they weren't nervous. They still weren't even *sure* about this.

But now was the time for last words.

Catra sighed, looking down at her. "We'll let you know when we arrive. But Entrapta… Thank you. For everything. I won't forget our promise."

"We owe you so much," Adora finished. "We're gonna miss you… But we'll see you again one day."

"I know." This time, when she spoke those words, Entrapta smiled. She believed them. "And when we see each other, Styx City will be different. It'll be better. No Runners. No Nyx. No fear. Maybe… Maybe the whole world will be like that."

"With people like you around, I think so too," Catra nodded.

The three of them exchanged a knowing smile. It would be a while until they saw each other again, but they all knew this wasn't goodbye.

"Where are you headed after this?" Adora asked Entrapta, trying to ease the tension.

"Hmm…" Entrapta pondered the question. "Well… Maybe the riot outside of Nyx first?"

Of course. That answer was obvious, even if it festered some anxiety in Catra's gut.

"Or…" Entrapta tapped her chin with her finger. "Maybe it'd be better if I stayed in Utopia… worked more 'behind the scenes'."

"That sounds good," Catra immediately jumped in, trying to get her to take the safer route. "Really… really good."

"Yeah… It does…" Then, a relaxed smile soon crawled onto Entrapta' face. "And after all this is over, I think I'll go home and… Well… *Rest*. Maybe work on a personal project. A little AI called Darla to assist me in the lab. Yeah… That sounds nice."

Catra let out a short sigh of relief. "That… That sounds great, Entrapta. Keep me up to date on the progress, alright?"

"I will!" Entrapta grinned with a nod. "And you'll meet Darla one day, right?"

"Of course. I promise."

"Me, too," Adora nodded.

"Aah, that's great!" Entrapta bounced on her feet a bit. "Darla would love to meet both of you, I just know it!"

Adora and Catra laughed at Entrapta's excitement, infectious as always.

"We can't wait," Adora smiled, wiping away what she thought were tears of laughter.

But they all knew what the tears were really for.

There were a few tears from all of them. A few quick, emotional sighs. They knew that those needed to be let out.

But this was not goodbye.

Instead, Catra let out a sigh, and raised a hand to give off a wave. "Well… See you later, Entrapta. Thank you for everything."

Entrapta waved as well. "Yeah. See you later. And thank *you,* too."

They held eye contact with the wave. It lasted for some time But with that eye contact came a smile. A beautiful, filled smile of hope and appreciation.

“Hey,” Adora looked between the two of them. “Until next time, right?”

“Yeah!” Entrapta nodded. “Until next time.”

“Until next time.” Catra let the words hang on her lips.

One last glance between the three of them.

One last smile.

They were going to be okay. They had survived this far. They had fought to live, and one day, they knew they wouldn’t *have* to fight.

Entrapta and Catra shared eye contact. All their experiences, everything they’ve been through, all of the trauma and joy and fear and happiness, it hung wordlessly between them.

They would carry it for a while. But they would not carry it alone.

And so, they all moved in sync.

Broke eye contact.

Adora and Catra moved towards the airport.

And Entrapta moved back to Styx City.

All of them smiling. All of them knowing. There were tears and tight throats and moments of hesitation.

But they walked their own paths. They walked them freely.

And so, for the first time, Catra and Entrapta split from each other. For months, years, they didn’t know.

But they knew one thing.

This would never be a goodbye.

Catra and Entrapta were free at last. And one day, they'd reunite in safety too.

Adora and Catra entered the airport, crowded with people. Given everything going on, it wasn't surprising they weren't the only ones trying to leave Styx City.

But that also meant an increase in security. Knights and Runners patrolled the terminals, weapons in hand, scanners at the ready. The scanners were older models, at least. Both Catra and Adora's eyes should be able to fool them.

But their hearts pounded nonetheless. One slip-up, and it would all be for nothing.

The line to get through check-in and security was long, but moving quickly. So much had been automated that the only real security measures were an ID check with the systems and a scan of the left eye. With so many cybernetic parts in both humans and Keres, metal detectors were rarely used, though people did have to go through a general body scan for anything suspicious.

Megan Taliana and Calypso Aima had been put into the Guardian system and recognised by the government as official citizens thanks to Entrapta's quick work.

The body scan and the ID check didn't worry Adora and Catra. They weren't carrying anything dangerous, and Entrapta had done ID changes hundreds of times. The only real concern was the eye scan.

Adora's eye was something entirely new, based on a blueprint of old technology, and improved by Entrapta's tinkering and past experience creating eyes for the Ghosts. It had passed most scanner checks by Entrapta, but there was never a guarantee it could fool all of them.

As Adora moved with Catra through check-in and security, she couldn't help but wonder *how* Ghosts lived like this on a daily basis. Her cybernetic eye made her so nervous at the sight of any Runner, even more than usual. One scan could be the end of her life.

She looked at Catra, who kept a neutral, stoic expression as her ID ran through an automated check. For the past year, she had lived this life. For the past year, this fear had been ingrained in her.

Adora had always admired her, but this… This made Catra *incredibly* bold in her eyes. It made all the Ghosts that much braver.

Catra's ID ran a positive, and Adora's followed similarly a few seconds later. They tried to hide the tension in their bodies, not daring to speak in case anyone recognised either of their voices. They needed to get through this. Get on the plane. Get out of Styx City.

The body scan was positive too, though Catra's Series 17 arm raised a few questions. Adora was nervous that something in her back would be picked up, but the positive beep after a few seconds of scanning by the pod-like machine sent relief into her chest.

Entrapta had taken pains to remove all the cybernetics in her back. Of course she wouldn't miss anything.

But now came the very last security measure. The scan of the left eye.

Adora had to tense her body to stop it from shaking. She needed to look natural. Act natural. One last step to freedom and safety.

Catra stepped into the queue, followed closely by Adora; she had given Catra a small lead, hoping that Catra would get through first. If anything went wrong, at least Catra would be safe, and that was what mattered most.

…Dammit. She was letting those thoughts get to her again.

Catra approached the woman with the scanner, who sat behind a steel desk. There was a whole row of dedicated scanner employees, with tightened security measures in the event of any Ghost escapes.

Adora watched Catra approach the steel desk. Not a second was wasted as the pistol-like device was held near her left eye, a blue light flashing against it. About seven seconds later, the result showed on the scanner.

'Negative.'

"Move on through," the scanner woman nodded at Catra.

Adora felt some tension lift from her shoulders, though she tried not to show it. Catra walked through before anything else happened, and she now stood before the terminals.

But she turned. And she waited. Waited for the one person that mattered.

"Next."

Adora swallowed down the fear in her throat, and walked ahead, even if her legs felt lighter than air.

If she still had her missing eye, that would lead to heavy questioning and background checks. It wouldn't have taken long to cross-examine her against hospital records and figure out who

she was. But now, she had to rely on an entirely new form of technology in order to make it through.

Her mind was clouding with doubt. She needed plans. Multiple plans. She needed a way to escape. At the very least, she needed to make sure Catra got out okay.

No. Both of them. Both of them needed to get out okay.

But how?

What if this all went wrong?

What if it was for nothing?

The fear was showing on her face. She needed to hide it.

The woman placed the scanner near her eye. A quick flash of blue blinded the left side of her vision, but it was a quick result.

A quick result was never good.

Never, ever good.

Adora saw the result screen flash onto the woman's face.

She didn't need to see the word.

The screen was red.

'Positive.'

Adora had been identified as a Ghost.

The eye was new and experimental technology. It was never going to be reliable. She knew that. *She knew that.*

But the panic flooded in all the same.

The woman looked up at Adora with a slight gasp, her eyes wide. Adora returned a similar expression, her stomach twisting and turning as her heart smashed.

Catra could see it, too. The red screen. The panic.

The woman only needed to do one thing.

Press a button under her desk, and alert the Runners.

They'd take Adora somewhere private at least.

It was easy.

It was so easy.

Just one push of the button, and it'd be out of her hands.

It was what she was *meant* to do.

But just before she could.

"Please."

A quiet pleading from Adora.

She pressed her hand firmly against the desk, leaning in close as she looked at the woman. Her eyes were wide, her pounding heart was drowning out the noise in her mind, but she was relying entirely on a desperate plan, the potential kindness of a stranger.

"Please," Adora spoke through her dry, cracked throat. "Please…"

Her eyes were glancing elsewhere as she spoke. The scanner woman followed her gaze, and saw who she was looking at.

Catra.

Similarly panicked.

The employee didn't take long to figure out the connection between the two women.

They both knew it might be the last time they saw each other, but they'd go down fighting if they had to.

The scanner woman was the only barrier between them.

The only barrier between happiness and death.

The only barrier between freedom and eternal darkness.

And she was meant to sentence them to the latter.

She was meant to…

No.

This wasn't *right.*

None of this was *right.*

They *loved* each other.

The woman grit her teeth, shook her head, and cleared her scanner.

“Move on through.”

Adora blinked, shock flooding her senses. The woman avoided her stunned gaze, guilt and uncertainty swirling inside her like a storm.

Adora knew it. She *knew* this feeling. All too well.

But with wobbling lips, Adora quietly sobbed out. “Thank you… Thank you…”

“Just *go.”*

Adora listened. She quickly moved beyond the final barrier.

Mercy had saved her.

She was alive.

She was *alive.*

Adora’s entire body shook with relief as she walked towards Catra, her eyes glued to the floor. She almost expected a bullet to hit her back. She expected something to go wrong. Something *had* to go wrong.

But…

No.

Instead, she felt strong arms wrap around her.

Catra’s arms.

They held her so *tight.*

“We’re okay…” Catra said with a tight throat. "We’re okay, Adora… I’m right here…”

“Catra…” Adora gripped tightly onto the back of Catra’s shirt. “*Fuck…”*

“I’m not letting go,” Catra whispered as she kissed the top of Adora’s head. “I promise. I’m never letting go.”

She looked over Adora’s shoulder at the scanner woman who had saved their lives. She worked as though nothing had happened, but the event would likely stick in her mind for a long, long while.

Mercy.

Mercy had saved them once again.

Adora and Catra clung to each other for a while. A long, long while.

Adora was trying to calm herself, and Catra knew she was doing the same.

But something eventually caught their attention.

A crowd of people was gathered near a large holo-TV in the terminals, and worried chatter filled the room. Catra’s head perked up, and Adora’s did the same.

The news was broadcasting something *big.*

Adora and Catra glanced at each other. Their hands were searching for one another, until their fingers interlocked. They moved closer to the screen; their flight was in forty minutes, and this was their last chance to see any updates on Styx City.

As they approached the screen, they almost expected something horrific. Martial law, executions, anything.

But once they managed to push through enough people, they saw.

They saw something miraculous.

The riot at Nyx Industries' main tower.

It was *working.*

Broken windows, destroyed offices, cut power, all of it spread throughout the tower. Rioters had completely overtaken it.

Destruction had been caused through so much of the upper sections of Styx City, where many of the wealthier people and corporations resided. Cars overturned, fires started, buildings destroyed.

There had been resistance from the Knights, but there were so few of them compared to the *thousands* of rioters.

Adora and Catra stared with wide eyes at it all. Their hands tightened together, fingers locked even harder. They could hear the conversations around them.

"This is too far."

"Now they're just as bad as the Runners."

"Violence is never the answer."

They had no clue.

They never did.

Adora and Catra looked up at the consequences of everything they'd done, and among the anxiety, the fear, the nervousness, they felt *pride.* They felt *hope.*

The rioters moved towards the HQ of the Runners next. Payback for all the lives taken. A push until change was brought about. *Real* change.

In that moment, Adora and Catra looked at each other, and they both knew what the other was thinking.

"Should we go back?"

It was Adora who said it first.

There was so much change happening before them. People were finally fighting back. Wasn't it their duty to go back and fight with them?

Was this the right thing to do?

Did they deserve to leave?

They had started this, shouldn't they bring it to its conclusion?

Doubt. So much doubt. They hurt people by leaving. Entrapta had sobbed into their arms just hours before.

Didn't they owe it to everyone to stay and fight?

Or did they owe it to themselves to leave and live?

It was an impossible question.

A voice announced their flight over it all, calling for final boardings to be conducted.

They needed to make their choice. Stay or go. Fight or flee.

Catra looked back at the screen. At the rioters. The fires. The destruction. They were victorious so far, winning through numbers and strategy.

Her eyes gazed down to the floor as she tried to process her thoughts. She closed her eyes, took in a breath, and let it out with

a heavy sigh.

“Adora…”

She looked up at her angel. Her partner. Her love.

“You *know* what we need to do. What we *want* to do.”

Adora’s jaw tensed. She kept her hand gripped to Catra’s. Her chest felt tight.

But she was right.

Catra was right.

Adora nodded. “Okay.”

Adora’s eyes opened, and she noticed the other half of the bed was empty.

It was like a cold breeze had flown into her dreams, yanking her back into the real world. Catra’s warmth had become such an expected part of her life, that everything felt *off* without it.

She reached out, patting her hand against the sheets before her. “Catra…?” Adora blinked, her voice croaked and dry.

She was gone.

A few lights had been left on in their apartment. Catra must’ve woken up in the middle of the night again.

Adora sat up with a sigh. This wasn’t the first time this had happened.

Catra always went to the same spot when everything became too much.

Adora swung her legs over the side of the bed, placed them against the soft ground as she stood up. She grabbed one of her

sleeveless shirts, pulling it over her body as she began to leave the bedroom.

She took a second to look at herself in the bedroom mirror. The scars on her back were still healing, but the tattoo had been removed. Her hair was slightly longer, brushing just near her shoulders.

And her eyes were blue. As often as she could, she made them blue.

Adora brushed her hand through her hair as she stepped away from the mirror and out of the bedroom.

"Catra?" Adora called out.

No response.

The apartment was slightly messy, as was usual. Dishes stacked in the sink, some cups of instant noodles strewn about the kitchen. Adora took the time to clean up the sink, throw away the trash.

The TV had been turned on to the same channel, as always. The news, showing Styx City's current state. Runners had never been weaker, and every day, more and more negotiations came from government officials. Yet the riots continued for as long as they tried to meet in the middle.

There was no meeting in the middle. Not for this. It was *all* rights for *all* Keres and Ghosts, or the destruction continued.

It was exhausting. But it was working.

Catra must've been watching, but Adora did not see her on the couch.

She glanced over at the balcony. Nothing there either.

She sighed, placed her hands on her hips. "Where'd she go, Melog?"

The blue-eyed mass of black fur sat by the apartment door, mewling. If they had followed Catra as far as they could go, then she'd likely left the apartment.

"Ah…" Adora looked up. "Rooftop, then?"

Melog meowed.

That must have meant something.

It was a relatively cool night. Adora made sure to grab a blanket as she took in a breath and smiled. "Why don't we go join her?"

Melog agreed wholeheartedly.

Adora opened the apartment door, slinging the blanket over her shoulder as Melog walked out with her. They had to go to the elevator and then up the stairs to get to the rooftop.

The night was quiet, at least.

Adora leaned against the elevator wall as it began to ascend to the top floor, Melog sitting by the door. Adora looked down at them. "Did she seem okay?"

Melog looked up at Adora in silence.

"Not sure, hm?" Adora sighed.

Melog meowed.

Yeah.

They understood her.

The elevator doors opened, and Adora walked out with the cat by her feet. At the end of the hall was the door—which was *meant* to be locked—that led up to the rooftop.

She opened the 'locked' door with ease, walked up the steps. Her arms prickled with bumps as she felt the cool breeze against her

skin. She had gotten so used to warmth.

But eventually, she reached the top of the stairs. And with the opening of the last door, she was greeted by a sight she had become used to over the last few weeks.

The night sky filled with stars.

And the small city of Arcadia before them.

They could see the speckle of lights in the small amount of buildings and towers before them, but compared to Styx City, it was nothing. Adora was still getting used to how *quiet* and *dark* everything was at night.

Adora could never get enough of looking at the stars.

But there was something more precious than them right in front of her.

"Hey, Catra."

She sat near the edge of the roof, tinkering with a glowing object. Melog pounced towards her, nuzzling their head into her leg as Catra chuckled.

"Hey there, you two," Catra replied, looking from Melog up to Adora with a smile. "How'd you know where to find me?"

"Melog led me," Adora replied. "They're a hell of a detective."

Catra scoffed, running her hand over Melog's furry head. They purred at the pets.

Adora walked up beside Catra and sat down next to her, getting a good look at what it was she was working on. However, her brow raised. She hadn't seen *anything* like it. "What're you working on?"

"Ah," Catra blinked, her hand leaving Melog to go back to the object. "I picked this up on my way home from my session today. The person at the store called it a 'sky lantern'."

It was a square object made of paper, with a small candle underneath it. Catra had been busy lighting it with her thumb lighter.

"Ooh… I've never seen one of those before," Adora looked at the flame with slight admiration.

"Yeah, me neither," Catra replied. "Apparently once I let it go, it should just… float away. It used to be released for celebrations or festivals, but… Apparently it can also be used for memorials, too."

Adora nodded, bringing her knees up to her chest as she listened to the beautiful sound of her girlfriend's voice. Even still, there was one question lingering in her mind.

"Who're you releasing it for?"

Catra ran her hand over the soft paper, sighing. "It's… It's dumb."

"Hey." Adora shook her head, reached her hand to brush a strand of Catra's hair behind her ear. "I promise, if you're doing it, it's not dumb."

Catra smiled softly at the touch, turning her head and placing a kiss on Adora's palm. Even still, her face was dropped into a frown, and she let out a tense sigh.

"I'm… holding a memorial. For myself."

Adora blinked. "Oh."

"Yeah. Like I said, it's dumb."

"It's not," Adora shook her head. "But… You're here. You're alive. So…"

"Yeah, but…" Catra raised her hands up to try and explain everything, but the words couldn't come. It was all too much. So, her hands dropped with a sigh. "I don't know. It's just… Ever since we left Styx, I can't stop thinking about… About the *other* Catra."

"The other Catra?"

"When I spoke to the Moirai, they created a copy of me and kept me chained to them. *I'm* that copy. I'm not the other Catra. That other Catra who saved you from the hospital. The Catra who was at that stand-off and shot Shadow Weaver. The Catra who… who died in your arms." Catra closed her eyes, her jaw tensed. "That… That Catra isn't *me,* Adora. She died, and she's *gone.* I'm just a copy. I'm… I'm not *her.*"

Adora knew this was something she'd never be able to fully understand, but seeing the pain on Catra's face was enough to bring her arm out and wrap it around her girlfriend's shoulders.

"I'm sorry…" Adora spoke quietly. "Hey… You know I don't love you any less because of that, right?"

"I know," Catra nodded. "I never doubted it. I just… I feel like I've *robbed* something from that other Catra. It's… It's hard to explain. She's gone, and I've replaced her, and… I don't know if that was *right."*

Adora reached up a hand, stroked it through Catra's hair, and tried to soothe her. Catra leaned her body over, placed her head on Adora's shoulder, and let out a sigh.

"But…" Catra continued. "I'm here. I'm just… I'm *here*. Despite all the pain and the doubt, I'm *here*. And… Fuck. I think I'm happy*."*

"Yeah?"

"Yeah," Catra nodded. "I'm *happy*, Adora. I'm who I truly want to be. I'm with who I truly love. I've practically got a new life now. I'm… I'm happy, despite everything. And I think the other Catra… I think she'd want that."

"I think so, too," Adora nodded. "She made me happy… And you have, too. You still do. You always will. No matter what happens."

Adora could see Catra's cheeks puff up. That same gorgeous smile. She looked up at her girlfriend, her love.

And she leaned up to kiss Adora as she always had.

Adora returned the kiss, closed her eyes. This was their comfort. Their shared happiness. These kisses, so close, so familiar.

Catra pulled herself away slowly, letting the kiss linger on her smiling lips. "Thank you…"

"I love you," Adora whispered so *tenderly.* "I love you so much, Catra. Nothing's going to change that. You can talk to me about this."

Catra pressed her forehead against Adora's. "I love you, too…"

They smiled as their foreheads touched. They felt so little fear in their hearts nowadays. There were still scars. Big ones. But piece by piece, they gathered themselves together again. They took their own steps, walked at their own pace towards recovery.

A step was a step. No matter how long it took.

Catra grabbed Adora's hand and placed it atop the lantern. "I want to float this into the sky for her, that other Catra. I want her to know that we're okay. I think she'll need to know that…"

Adora nodded. "That sounds good to me."

The two of them kept their hands over the lantern for a few more seconds. Adora waited for her signal. She waited for the right moment to light up the starry sky.

In her heart, she wanted this lantern to be for the others too. For Angella. For Mara. For all the lost Ghosts. For anyone who fell during the Styx City riots. This lantern was for all of them. A light they all needed.

So, when Catra began to raise her arm, Adora did too. They held the lantern up as high as they could, bodies together, both of their hands held gently onto the paper.

Then…

Release.

Their hands left, and the lantern took its own path. It gently floated away into the night sky, up and up and up.

Adora, Catra, and Melog all silently stared up, those three creatures. They watched as the light got smaller and smaller, the lantern getting further away. It almost became a star of its own.

Catra's breath hitched slightly. A tightness choked her. Hearing it caused Adora to do the same. But they simply held each other closer, and let those emotions spill out.

Silent tears fell upon their smiles.

A few more seconds passed as the lantern became barely indistinguishable from the night sky. Catra's head rested on Adora's shoulder, and Adora's arm wrapped around Catra's body.

Then, something else came.

A droplet.

Water fell upon their legs and arms. Slowly, then all at once. It splashed onto the roof around them, and mingled with the tears

on their cheeks.

They soon realised…

It was raining.

Adora looked at Catra's moment of realisation, her lips parting slightly in shock as she held out her palm. She watched the water splash off her skin. Felt the coldness of it run down her body.

But that shock was soon replaced with pure joy.

She chuckled, held out both hands, tilted her head up and felt the rain hit her completely. It dampened her hair, pooled in her lips, ran down her neck.

Adora smiled completely at the sight, and asked one last question.

"Still love the rain?"

Catra laughed, her blue and yellow eyes looked at Adora as her smile widened into a beautiful sight.

She gave one response.

"Always."

And that was all they needed.

Even Melog participated, walking around the roof slightly and jumping at any forming puddles. Adora laughed at the sight of their fur becoming more and more damp and messy. They'd need a shower after this.

But for now, they took this all in.

This rain.

These stars.

This view.

This world.

All so beautiful.

All so worth fighting for.

All so worth *living* for.

Catra's hand came down, and her palm rested on Adora's. They instantly clasped their hands together, held onto each other tightly as they sat on the roof and looked up at the stars and rain.

Adora and Catra.

Happy.

Loving.

Free.

Together.

The End.

Chapter End Notes

And here you are. After all this time. Finally at the end of this long, long journey.

I'm going to be posting a comment in this chapter detailing my thoughts behind this story, as well as giving some necessary thanks and updates on my life and place in this fandom as a writer. But if you don't care about that stuff, that's fine. I just want to say...

Thank you.

Thank you for sticking with this story that ended up being WAY longer than intended. Thank you for sticking with this world, and the hardships our characters had to face within it. Thank you for trusting me with this story. The amount of feedback and love that has been given has been absolutely beautiful and encouraging. It brings a smile to my face just to think of it.

Threadbare Wings is the beginning of a world I want to explore more, whether that be in original work or something else. I am super proud of what's been done here, and it wouldn't be possible without the love y'all have shown. I'll go into more detail in the comments, but just thank you. Thank you all so much.

You all deserve a lot of love and happiness. And if Adora and Catra can find their joy, so can you.

Until next time, wherever and whenever that may be <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!